# MASS GAP OF FOUR-DIMENSIONAL LATTICE YANG–MILLS THEORY FOR EVERY COMPACT SIMPLE GROUP

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ABSTRACT. *We prove that four-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory with any compact simple gauge group has a unique infinite-volume state, exponential clustering and an explicit transfer-matrix gap at couplings past the curvature limit of the ungauged measure, up to* $\beta_W = 0.345$ *for* SU(2) *and* $\beta_W = 0.76$ *for* SU(3)*, in a gauge that fixes one link of every plaquette. We prove that a Dobrushin–Shlosman estimate in one cube of fixed physical size, or any exponential decay of renormalised correlations in physical units, gives a mass gap for every continuum limit. The cube estimate is open along the continuum tuning; for* SU($N$) *it needs cubes of side at least of order* $(\beta_W/\log\beta_W)^{1/4}$*. For block averages, a cut-off of Bałaban's average composes across all scales on fields of small curvature for every compact group, and under the* SU(2) *Wilson measure the large fields form clusters of vanishing physical size.*

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## 1. Introduction

Wilson's lattice gauge theory [77] assigns an element $Q_e$ of a compact group $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ to every link $e$ of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ and weighs a configuration by $\exp(N\beta \sum_p \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p)$, where $Q_p$ is the ordered product of the four link variables around the plaquette $p$.[1] At small $|\beta|$ the theory is under control: it has a unique infinite-volume state, correlations decay exponentially, and the transfer matrix has a gap [64, 68].[2] The question is how far into the coupling range such statements can be proved with explicit constants, since the problem of the continuum limit [47] begins where strong coupling ends and Bałaban's weak-coupling analysis [5, 6, 7] takes over.

Two methods give explicit ranges. The Bakry–Émery method [3, 4] of Shen, Zhu and Zhu [69] bounds the Hessian of the action; in [14] we showed that the sharp bound is $4d = 16$ and that no curvature argument for the ungauged measure goes beyond $|\beta| < 1/32$. The Dobrushin method [29, 30][3] bounds the influence of each link on the conditional law of another; for SU(2) the single-link conditional law is a von Mises–Fisher law on the three-sphere, the sharp Kantorovich modulus[4] of that family is one quarter [14] (Theorem I.4 in Appendix I), and every link has eighteen partners, which gives $\beta_W < 2/9$ and nothing beyond, because the coefficients are attained.

Both limits come from the same count. A link of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ lies in six plaquettes and shares each with three other links. Gauge invariance makes part of this redundant: in a box, the variables on a forest of links can be set to the identity without changing any gauge-invariant expectation [26].[5] The forest we use is a field of straight lines with one line through every site, chosen so that every plaquette contains exactly one fixed link. Then every free link has

[1] This is the normalisation of Shen, Zhu and Zhu [69] and of our earlier paper [14]. The conventional inverse coupling is $\beta_W = N^2\beta$, so the weight is $\exp(\frac{\beta_W}{N}\sum_p \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p)$; for SU(2), identified with the unit quaternions, $\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p = \operatorname{Re} Q_p$ and $\beta_W = 4\beta$. Standard accounts of the lattice theory are the books of Montvay and Münster [61] and of Gattringer and Lang [37]; the Hamiltonian version is due to Kogut and Susskind [51].

[2] Strong-coupling results of this kind go back to Osterwalder and Seiler [64], who proved exponential clustering and a gap by a convergent expansion, and to Seiler's monograph [68]; the general framework for lattice gauge fields and their continuum limits is that of Brydges, Fröhlich and Seiler [21]. More recent work treats the strong-coupling regime by probabilistic methods: the survey of Chatterjee [24], his large-$N$ solution of SO($N$) lattice gauge theory at strong coupling [25] and its planar extension by Basu and Ganguly [10], the Langevin dynamics of Shen, Zhu and Zhu [69], and the area law in an enlarged region by Cao, Nissim and Sheffield [23]. For finite gauge groups Adhikari and Cao proved correlation decay at weak coupling [1]. In two dimensions the continuum Yang–Mills measure has been constructed by Gross, King and Sengupta [40], Driver [32] and Lévy [52]; in four dimensions Bałaban's renormalisation group, as expounded by Dimock [28], gives ultraviolet stability in finite volume, and Magnen, Rivasseau and Sénéor constructed the theory with an infrared cutoff [57]. None of these results gives a mass gap in physical units.

[3] Dobrushin's theorem: if the conditional law of each variable given all others moves, in Kantorovich distance, by at most $C_{xy}$ times the distance by which the variable at $y$ moves, and $\sup_x \sum_y C_{xy} < 1$, then the Gibbs measure is unique and correlations decay at the rate given by the Neumann series of the matrix $C$. Dobrushin and Shlosman [31] replaced single variables by finite boxes, which is the form used in Section 10.

[4] The Kantorovich distance between two probability measures on a metric space is the least expected distance over their couplings, equivalently the largest difference of their integrals over 1-Lipschitz functions [75]. The modulus of a family of laws indexed by a metric space is the best Lipschitz constant of the map from the index to the law in that distance.

[5] Creutz used a maximal tree to remove the gauge freedom completely; the temporal gauge, with all links in one direction fixed, is the special case of a family of straight lines. In a maximal tree almost every link is fixed in some region and none in others, so the number of partners of a free link is not uniform, and the temporal gauge leaves fourteen partners per link. The point here is a pattern that fixes exactly one link in every plaquette.

exactly twelve free partners, two in each of its plaquettes (Lemma 2.2), and both methods improve.

**Theorem 1.1** (SU(2))**.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ and $0 \le \beta_W < \frac{1}{3}$. For every gauge-invariant local observable $O$ the expectations $W_\Lambda(O)$ in boxes with free boundary converge, along every sequence of boxes that exhausts $\mathbb{Z}^4$, to a limit $\omega(O)$ that does not depend on the sequence. The state $\omega$ is invariant under translations and the hypercubic group and reflection positive;*[6] *truncated correlations of Lipschitz observables decay at every rate below $-\log(3\beta_W)$; and the transfer matrix has spectral gap*

$$m \ge -\log(3\beta_W) > 0.$$

*For $-\frac{1}{3} < \beta_W < 0$ all statements except reflection positivity and the gap hold.*

The step behind Theorem 1.1 is short once the line field is in place. The number $\frac{1}{3}$ is also the end of the road for this kind of argument.

**Theorem 1.2** (Ceiling)**.** *Let $F'$ be any set of links of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ without cycles, and give two distinct links outside $F'$ that share a plaquette the coefficient $|\beta|$, the largest single-link Kantorovich coefficient of* $\mathrm{SU}(2)$*. Then the weighted Dobrushin condition with these coefficients fails for $\beta_W \ge \frac{1}{3}$. For the line field the coefficients are attained, so no single-link Kantorovich argument in that gauge reaches $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$.*

The ceiling concerns coefficients between single links. Take instead as a block the three free links of one plaquette. The free links of the line field split into such triples with period two (Lemma 5.1), the coupling inside the block plaquette is no longer paid for, and each link keeps ten outside partners. The price is the sensitivity of a law on three spheres instead of one, which we bound analytically by integrating out the middle link of the block.

**Theorem 1.3** (SU(2) with plaquette blocks)**.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ and $0 \le \beta_W \le 0.345$. The number $\alpha(\beta_W)$ of (5.3) is increasing, $\alpha(\frac{1}{3}) \le 0.9561$ and $\alpha(0.345) \le 0.9973$. The conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold with decay at every rate below $-\frac{1}{2}\log\alpha(\beta_W)$ and a transfer-matrix gap*

$$m \ge -\tfrac{1}{2}\log\alpha(\beta_W) > 0;$$

*at $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$ this gives $m \ge 0.0224$. For $-0.345 \le \beta_W < 0$ all statements except reflection positivity and the gap hold.*

At small coupling the rate of Theorem 1.1 is the better one, so both bounds stand side by side; Theorem 1.3 matters past $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$, where the gap of Theorem 1.1 has closed.

The curvature method gains as well, and for every $N$. Let $\operatorname{Hess} S_0$ be the Hessian of $\sum_p \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p$ on $G^E$ and $F$ the set of fixed links.

**Theorem 1.4** (Curvature in the gauge)**.** *For every $N$, every field $Q$ and every tangent vector $v = (X_e Q_e)$ with $X_e = 0$ for $e \in F$,*

$$|\operatorname{Hess} S_0(v,v)| \le \tfrac{29}{2}|v|^2,$$

*against the sharp constant* 16 *without gauge fixing. Consequently, for $G = \mathrm{SU}(N)$ and $|\beta| < \frac{1}{29}$, or $G = \mathrm{SO}(N)$, $N \ge 3$, and $|\beta| < \frac{N-2}{58N}$, the conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold with the rate and gap of Theorem 1.5. For* $\mathrm{SU}(3)$ *this is $\beta_W < \frac{9}{29} = 0.310$.*

The constant $\frac{29}{2}$ is a statement about $\mathrm{U}(N)$, so it holds on every closed subgroup, and the curvature of the group does the rest. This gives the theorem for every compact simple gauge group, the exceptional groups included, with an explicit gap. Let $\rho : G \to \mathrm{U}(N)$ be a faithful unitary representation of a compact connected Lie group $G$, weigh a configuration by

[6] That is, $\omega(\vartheta(\bar{F})F) \ge 0$ for every $F$ depending on the links on one side of a lattice hyperplane, $\vartheta$ being the reflection in it. It gives the Hilbert space and the transfer matrix of Osterwalder and Schrader [62, 63] and of Osterwalder and Seiler [64], reconstructed in Appendix F.

TABLE 1. Least Ricci curvature $\kappa_G = h^\vee/(2\ell_\rho)$ of the compact simple groups in a faithful representation $\rho$ of least dimension $N$, and the range of Theorem 1.5 for the conventional inverse coupling $\beta_W = N^2\beta$.

| Group | $\rho$ | $h^\vee$ | $\ell_\rho$ | $\kappa_G$ | $\beta_W <$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, $N \geq 2$ | $\mathbb{C}^N$ | $N$ | 1 | $\frac{N}{2}$ | $\frac{N^2}{29}$ |
| $\mathrm{SO}(N)$, $N \geq 5$ | $\mathbb{R}^N$ | $N-2$ | 2 | $\frac{N-2}{4}$ | $\frac{N(N-2)}{58}$ |
| $\mathrm{SO}(3)$ | $\mathbb{R}^3$ | 2 | 4 | $\frac{1}{4}$ | $\frac{3}{58}$ |
| $\mathrm{Sp}(n)$, $n \geq 2$ | $\mathbb{C}^{2n}$ | $n+1$ | 1 | $\frac{n+1}{2}$ | $\frac{2n(n+1)}{29}$ |
| $G_2$ | 7 | 4 | 2 | 1 | $\frac{14}{29}$ |
| $F_4$ | 26 | 9 | 6 | $\frac{3}{4}$ | $\frac{39}{29}$ |
| $E_6$ | 27 | 12 | 6 | 1 | $\frac{54}{29}$ |
| $E_7$ | 56 | 18 | 12 | $\frac{3}{4}$ | $\frac{84}{29}$ |
| $E_8$ | 248 | 30 | 60 | $\frac{1}{4}$ | $\frac{124}{29}$ |

$\exp(N\beta\sum_p \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\,\rho(Q_p))$, and let $\kappa_G$ be the least Ricci[7] curvature of $G$ for the bi-invariant metric $\langle X, Y\rangle = -\,\mathrm{Tr}(\rho(X)\rho(Y))$; we identify $G$ with $\rho(G) \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$.

**Theorem 1.5** (Every compact simple group)**.** *Suppose that the Lie algebra of $G$ is semisimple, so that $\kappa_G > 0$, and that*

$$N|\beta| < \tfrac{2}{29}\,\kappa_G.$$

*Then the conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold, for $\beta < 0$ all of them except reflection positivity and the gap, with decay at every rate below*

$$m_G(\beta) = \operatorname{arccosh}\Big(1 + \frac{1}{12}\Big(\frac{\kappa_G}{N|\beta|} - \frac{29}{2}\Big)\Big) > 0$$

*and a transfer-matrix gap $m \geq m_G(\beta)$. For a simple $G$, $\kappa_G = h^\vee/(2\ell_\rho)$, where $h^\vee$ is the dual Coxeter number and $\ell_\rho$ the Dynkin index of $\rho$; Table 1 lists the values.*

For $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, $\kappa_G = \frac{N}{2}$, and for $\mathrm{SO}(N)$, $\kappa_G = \frac{N-2}{4}$, so Theorem 1.5 contains the ranges of Theorem 1.4 and supplies their rate.[8] For small $|\beta|$ the existence of a gap is classical for every compact group, with no explicit range [64, Thm. 3.6]; what is new is an explicit range for every group, past the range $N|\beta| < \kappa_G/16$ that the Hessian bound 16 gives without gauge fixing, and an explicit gap. As $\beta \to 0$ the gap grows like $\log \frac{\kappa_G}{6N|\beta|}$.

No Bakry–Émery argument for the ungauged measure can pass $|\beta| = \frac{1}{32}$ [14, Thm. C]; the gauge fixing changes the measure, not the metric, which is why it can. For $\mathrm{SU}(2)$ the curvature range $\beta_W < \frac{4}{29}$ lies inside that of Theorem 1.1, and no curvature argument for the gauge-fixed $\mathrm{SU}(2)$ measure passes $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$: when one active link $e$ is $-1$ and all others are 1, the six plaquettes through $e$ have variable $-1$, and along a geodesic through $Q_e$ the Hessian of $-\frac{\beta_W}{2}\sum_p \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\,Q_p$ is $-6\beta_W$ times the metric of the unit sphere $S^3$, whose Ricci curvature is 2, so the Bakry–Émery tensor is negative there once $\beta_W > \frac{1}{3}$. For $\mathrm{SU}(3)$ the Dobrushin route goes much further.

[7] For a bi-invariant metric on a compact Lie group the Ricci curvature is $-\frac{1}{4}\,\mathrm{Tr}((\mathrm{ad}\,X)^2)$ in the direction of $X$. It is positive for every $X \neq 0$ exactly when the Lie algebra is semisimple, and $\kappa_G$ is its minimum over unit vectors.

[8] The dual Coxeter number is $h^\vee = N$ for $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, $N-2$ for $\mathrm{SO}(N)$, $n+1$ for $\mathrm{Sp}(n)$, $4, 9, 12, 18, 30$ for $G_2, F_4, E_6, E_7, E_8$, and the Dynkin index of a representation is normalised to one on the defining representation of $\mathrm{SU}(N)$ [49, Ch. 6]. The identity $\kappa_G = h^\vee/(2\ell_\rho)$ is the statement that the Ricci tensor of a compact simple group with a bi-invariant metric is one quarter of the negative Killing form, $\mathrm{Ric}(X, X) = -\frac{1}{4}B(X, X)$ [60], together with $B(X, X) = 2h^\vee\,\mathrm{Tr}(\rho(X)^2)/\ell_\rho$. Lower Ricci bounds of the same kind, for special holonomy and for Riemannian submersions, are studied in [18, 38].

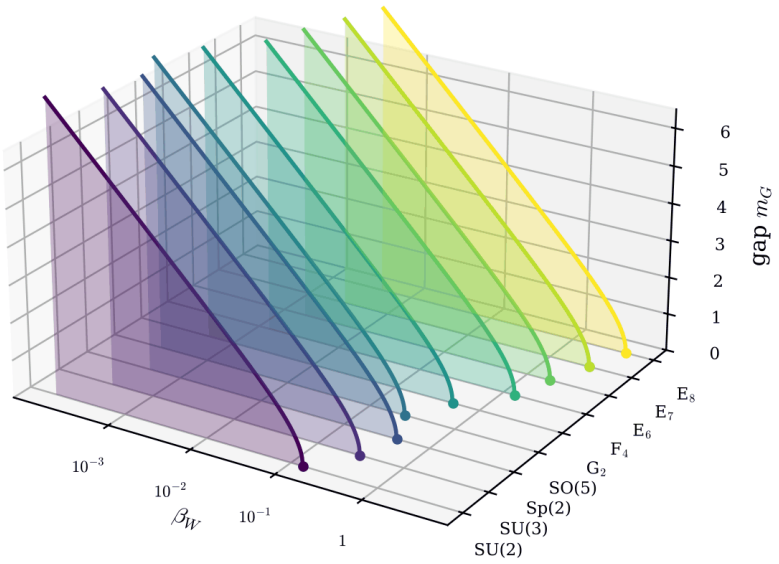



FIGURE 1. The gap $m_G(\beta)$ of Theorem 1.5 as a function of $\beta_W = N^2\beta$ on a logarithmic scale, for nine groups in the representations of Table 1. Each curve ends at the edge $\beta_W = 2N\kappa_G/29$ of the range, marked by a dot, where the gap tends to zero; as $\beta_W \to 0$ it grows like $\log(\kappa_G/(6N|\beta|))$. The curves differ only by the factor $N\kappa_G$, since $m_G$ depends on $N|\beta|/\kappa_G$ alone.

**Theorem 1.6** (SU(3))**.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(3)$ and $0 \le \beta_W \le \frac{3}{4}$. Then the conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold, with decay at every rate below $-\log(1.33319\,\beta_W)$ and a transfer-matrix gap*

$$m \ge -\log(1.33319\,\beta_W) > 0.$$

The proof of Theorem 1.6 bounds the Kantorovich modulus of the one-link measure $\nu_b(dU) \propto e^{\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(Ub)}dU$ on SU(3) uniformly over staple sums $b$. Its analytic part is a lower bound for the spectral gap of $\nu_b$ through Bochner's formula with a cross term (Lemma 7.3), a corrector chosen box by box among polynomials of degree two in the matrix entries (Lemma 7.4), the reduction of $b$ to diagonal matrices (Lemma 7.5), the character expansion of the moments of $\nu_b$ (Lemma 7.6) and an interpolation inequality on boxes of staple sums (Lemma 7.7). The remaining step evaluates the resulting bound on 2341 boxes with rigorous error bounds; the theorem rests on that computation, which is described in full in Section 7.7 and Appendix E.

The plaquette blocks of Theorem 1.3 work for SU(3) as well. They use the same modulus of the one-link measure, but only through the three links of a block, so they need $\Lambda(2\beta_W)$ small and not $2r\Lambda(r) < 1$: near the end of Theorem 1.6 they give a much larger gap, and they go past it.

**Theorem 1.7** (SU(3) with plaquette blocks)**.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(3)$ and $0 \le \beta_W \le \frac{19}{25} = 0.76$. Then $\alpha_3(\beta_W) < 1$ for the number of (8.2), with $\alpha_3(0.72) \le 0.9182$, $\alpha_3(\frac{3}{4}) \le 0.9653$ and $\alpha_3(0.76) \le 0.99950$. The conclusions of Theorem 1.1 hold with decay at every rate below $-\frac{1}{2}\log\alpha_3(\beta_W)$ and a transfer-matrix gap*

$$m \ge -\tfrac{1}{2}\log\alpha_3(\beta_W) > 0;$$

*at $\beta_W = \frac{3}{4}$ this gives $m \ge 0.0177$, against $1.1 \cdot 10^{-4}$ from Theorem 1.6, and at $\beta_W = 0.76$, where Theorem 1.6 no longer applies, $m \ge 2.5 \cdot 10^{-4}$.*

TABLE 2. Explicit ranges of uniqueness, decay and a transfer-matrix gap for four-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory. The first three rows hold for the ungauged measure; the last three are the results of this paper.

| Method | SU(2), $\beta_W$ | SU(3), $\beta_W$ |
|---|---|---|
| Curvature, Shen–Zhu–Zhu [69] | $< \frac{1}{12}$ | $< \frac{3}{16}$ |
| Curvature, sharp [14] | $< \frac{1}{8}$ | $< \frac{9}{32}$ |
| Dobrushin, sharp quarter [14] | $< \frac{2}{9}$ | |
| Curvature, forest gauge | $< \frac{4}{29}$ | $< \frac{9}{29}$ |
| Dobrushin, forest gauge | $< \frac{1}{3}$ | $\leq \frac{3}{4}$ |
| Plaquette blocks, forest gauge | $\leq 0.345$ | $\leq 0.76$ |

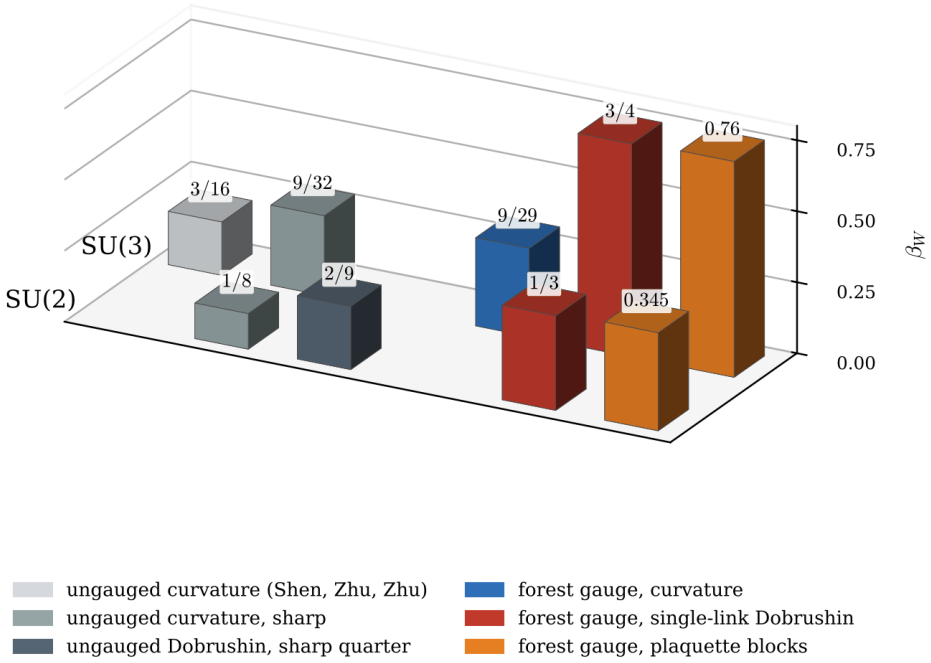



FIGURE 2. Ranges of Table 2. The height of each bar is the largest inverse coupling $\beta_W$ covered by the method. Grey bars are methods for the ungauged measure; blue, red and orange bars use the forest gauge. For SU(2) the red bar ends at the ceiling of Theorem 1.2 and the orange bar, plaquette blocks, passes it (Theorem 1.3); for SU(3) the red bar is Theorem 1.6 and the orange bar, plaquette blocks, gives a larger gap there and passes it (Theorem 1.7).

All seven theorems are statements at fixed lattice spacing. They do not touch the continuum limit, the crossover to Bałaban's regime, or a gap in physical units, which together are the Clay problem; Section 9 says where each method stops and what remains of the four open problems of [14]. The obstruction proved in [15], that a lattice gap uniform in lattice units forces trivial continuum two-point functions, applies to all of them.

*The continuum step.* Section 10 goes past that obstruction in one respect, through three implications, each proved.

(I1) A Dobrushin–Shlosman condition on one cube of fixed physical size, uniform along the continuum tuning, gives a mass gap in physical units for every continuum limit

(Theorems 10.2 and 10.4), and so does exponential decay with constants of the renormalised correlations of a spanning set of observables (Theorem 10.5); this holds also for observables smoothed by the spatial gradient flow (Proposition 10.6).

(I2) The flowed observables, renormalised by one condition at a single physical separation, have reflection positive continuum limits along subsequences, and such a limit is nontrivial exactly when one ratio of lattice two-point functions stays away from zero (Theorem 10.7); that ratio is bounded above and below by ratios of correlations of one slice field at fixed physical separations (Proposition 10.10).

(I3) Tree bounds on the truncated correlations give all the higher Schwinger functions as reflection positive distributions, imply the ratio bound, and carry the conditional mass gap to every polynomial in the smeared fields (Theorem 10.15); for a smooth packet they give the ratio with an explicit rate and a reference vector of finite energy (Proposition 10.19).

*What is open.* The inputs of (I1)–(I3), namely the cube condition along the tuning, the slice ratio in four dimensions and the tree bounds, are not proved, and so the nontrivial existence of the continuum limit and the gap in physical units remain open. Figure 3 shows how the proved statements, the implications and the open inputs fit together.

Section 11 measures the open inputs. The cube condition holds at strong coupling, fails at every fixed cube size at weak coupling, forces the gauge-fixed variables to be disordered on the scale of the cube, and cannot be reached from estimates on single lines of links; for $\mathrm{SU}(N)$ it needs cubes of side at least of order $(\beta_W/\log\beta_W)^{1/4}$ (Propositions 11.15 and 11.16). For a Gaussian field it holds at a fixed physical scale when the field has a mass and fails exactly, at every size, when it is massless (Proposition 11.2); it also fails for the quadratic approximation of the forest gauge itself (Proposition 11.3). The order-two cases of the tree bounds force the lattice gap below a fixed multiple of the lattice spacing, so no strong coupling expansion gives them (Proposition 10.18). The slice ratio holds in two dimensions, where it is the exact solution of lattice gauge theory (Remark 10.12), and fails for a field whose mass is fixed in lattice units; for the free field, conditioning an energy packet on averages over blocks leaves a fixed fraction of its ordinary variance at every lattice spacing, so a reduction to block averages has to be measured in the reflected norm (Proposition 10.13).

*Block averages.* Section 12 poses the cube condition for block averages in a gauge whose fixed links are trees inside blocks of side two. Its quadratic approximation then holds at every coupling once the cube is large (Theorem 12.7), and integrating out one scale reduces it to a cube condition for the averages, which carry at least the coarse quadratic form at every scale (Corollary 12.10 and Proposition 12.8); the averages along the lines of the forest gauge, by contrast, leave one class of lines invisible and fail at every size (Proposition 12.1). For the group-valued links, the straight path between block roots gives a coarse link whose fibres satisfy a coercivity bound for every compact group and every field (Theorem 12.13), but this map does not compose across scales (Proposition 12.16), and for every compact connected group no continuous covariant block map treats the positions of a block alike (Proposition 12.17). A cut-off of Bałaban's averaging operation is continuous, covariant and coercive for every field and agrees with the block averages to first order; it breaks the symmetry only at large fields, as it must, and its constants are those of one step (Theorem 12.19). On fields with values in a maximal torus whose curvature stays small at every scale it composes, with the energy nonincreasing and the thin paths contracted (Theorem 12.21), and for every compact group it composes on fields whose curvatures at the successive scales have a small sum (Theorem 12.25). Under the SU(2) Wilson measure the plaquettes that are not small lie in clusters whose physical size tends to zero in probability, and the cut-off acts only next to them (Theorem 12.27, Corollaries 12.28 and 12.29); such plaquettes are nevertheless present along the one-loop tuning (Proposition 12.30). Whether

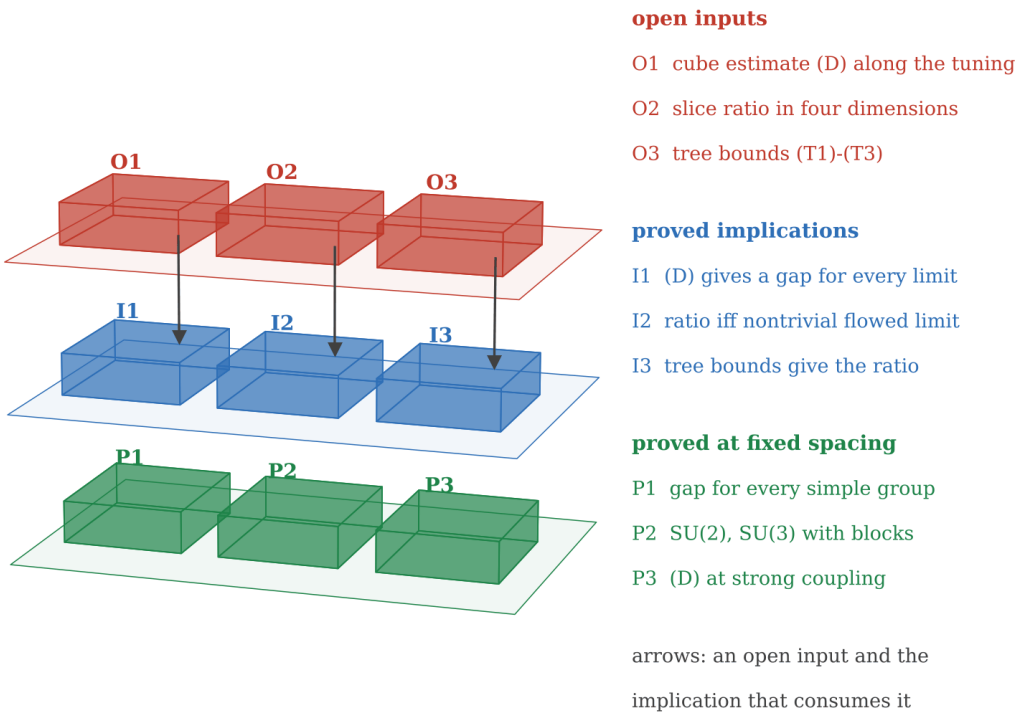



FIGURE 3. The logical structure of the paper. Green: theorems at fixed lattice spacing (P1 the gap for every compact simple group, Theorem 1.5, P2 the plaquette blocks for SU(2) and SU(3), P3 the cube condition at strong coupling). Blue: the proved implications (I1)–(I3) of the continuum step. Red: their inputs, none of which is proved along the continuum tuning. Each arrow joins an open input to the implication that consumes it; no implication feeds its own input.

some block map is coercive for all fields and composes across scales, through these clusters, is open.

*Plan.* Section 2 constructs the line field. Section 3 shows that a Dobrushin bound for the gauge-fixed specification gives the full conclusion of Theorem 1.1. Sections 4, 5, 6, 7 and 8 prove Theorems 1.1–1.7, and Section 9 measures what is left. Section 10 proves (I1)–(I3), Section 11 states and measures their open inputs, and Section 12 poses the cube condition for block averages, composes the cut-off average across scales at small fields and locates the large fields under the Wilson measure. The appendices contain the residue table of the line field, the comparison lemma and its version for blocks, the blocks of the local Hessian inequality, the details of the certified computation, the reconstruction of the transfer matrix with the equivalence of a gap and exponential clustering (Appendix F), the facts on spectral measures and on the character expansion that the continuum step uses (Appendices G and H), and a complete proof of the sharp quarter for the single-link law of SU(2) (Appendices I–K), so that the paper does not depend on our earlier one for any step.

## 2. THE LINE FIELD

Write $e_0, \dots, e_3$ for the unit vectors of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ and $(x, \mu)$ for the link from $x$ to $x + e_\mu$. A *direction field* is a map $\sigma : \mathbb{Z}^4 \to \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$; its links are $F = \{(x, \sigma(x)) : x \in \mathbb{Z}^4\}$. At each site put $\pi_x(\mu) = \sigma(x + e_\mu)$. The plaquette at $x$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ has the links $(x, \mu)$, $(x + e_\mu, \nu)$, $(x + e_\nu, \mu)$, $(x, \nu)$, so it contains

$$[\sigma(x) \in \{\mu, \nu\}] + [\pi_x(\mu) = \nu] + [\pi_x(\nu) = \mu] \tag{2.1}$$

links of $F$.

**Lemma 2.1.** *Every plaquette of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ contains exactly one link of $F$ if and only if, at every site $x$, $\pi_x$ fixes $\sigma(x)$ and permutes the other three directions cyclically.*

*Proof.* Fix $x$, let $s = \sigma(x)$ and let $R$ be the set of the other three directions. For a plane $\{s, \nu\}$ the count (2.1) is $1 + [\pi_x(s) = \nu] + [\pi_x(\nu) = s]$; it equals one for all $\nu \in R$ exactly when $\pi_x(s) = s$ and $\pi_x(\nu) \neq s$ for $\nu \in R$, that is, when $\pi_x$ fixes $s$ and maps $R$ into $R$. For a plane $\{\mu, \nu\} \subset R$ the count is $[\pi_x(\mu) = \nu] + [\pi_x(\nu) = \mu]$. Draw an arrow $\mu \to \pi_x(\mu)$ for every $\mu \in R$ with $\pi_x(\mu) \in R \setminus \{\mu\}$. Each vertex of $R$ has at most one outgoing arrow, and the condition says that each of the three pairs of $R$ carries exactly one arrow. Three arrows on three vertices with out-degree at most one give out-degree exactly one everywhere, and a tournament on three vertices with all out-degrees one is a directed three-cycle. □

From now on $\sigma$ is the field of period two given in Table 3 of Appendix A, read from $x$ modulo two. The table lists $\pi_x$ at each of the sixteen residue classes; in each row $\pi_x$ fixes $\sigma(x)$ and is a three-cycle on the rest, so every plaquette contains exactly one link of $F$ by Lemma 2.1.[9]

**Lemma 2.2.** (i) *$F$ is a disjoint union of bi-infinite straight lines, one through every site: every site has exactly one outgoing and one incoming link of $F$, and both point in the direction $\sigma(x)$.*

(ii) *For every box $\Lambda$ (a product of four finite intervals, with the links and plaquettes it contains), $F \cap E(\Lambda)$ is a disjoint union of segments, hence a forest.*

(iii) *A link $e = (x, \mu) \notin F$ lies in six plaquettes. Four of them contain a link of $F$ that shares an end point with $e$, and these lie in the planes $\{\mu, \sigma(x)\}$ and $\{\mu, \pi_x(\mu)\}$. In the other two, which lie in the remaining plane $\{\mu, \rho\}$, the link of $F$ is opposite to $e$.*

(iv) *Every link outside $F$ shares a plaquette with exactly twelve other links outside $F$, two in each of its plaquettes.*

*Proof.* (i) Since $\pi_x$ fixes $\sigma(x)$, $\sigma(x+e_{\sigma(x)}) = \sigma(x)$. Because $\sigma$ has period two, $x - e_\mu \equiv x + e_\mu$, so also $\sigma(x - e_{\sigma(x)}) = \sigma(x)$, and the link $(x - e_{\sigma(x)}, \sigma(x))$ is in $F$. Conversely, if $(x - e_\nu, \nu) \in F$, then $\sigma(x - e_\nu) = \nu$, and straightness at $x - e_\nu$ gives $\sigma(x) = \nu$. So the incoming link is unique and continues the outgoing one.

(ii) A line meets a box in a segment, and distinct lines are disjoint.

(iii) The plaquettes of $e$ are, for each $\nu \neq \mu$, the one at $x$ and the one at $x - e_\nu$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$. A link of $F$ sharing an end point with $e$ is the outgoing or the incoming link of $F$ at $x$ or at $x + e_\mu$. At $x$ both point in the direction $s = \sigma(x) \neq \mu$, and they lie in the plaquettes at $x$ and at $x - e_s$ in the plane $\{\mu, s\}$. At $x + e_\mu$ both point in the direction $t = \pi_x(\mu)$, which lies in $R \setminus \{\mu\}$ because $\pi_x$ is a three-cycle on $R$, and they lie in the plaquettes at $x$ and at $x - e_t$ in the plane $\{\mu, t\}$. These four plaquettes are distinct because $s \neq t$. Each plaquette contains exactly one link of $F$, so in the two plaquettes of the third plane $\{\mu, \rho\}$ the link of $F$ is a link of direction $\mu$ or $\rho$ not touching $e$; the links of direction $\rho$ in such a plaquette touch $e$, so it is the opposite link.

(iv) Each of the six plaquettes contains $e$, one link of $F$ and two other links, and two distinct links share at most one plaquette. □

[9] There are exactly eight period-two direction fields with this property, all equivalent to $\sigma$ under the symmetries of the lattice. A field with one fixed link at every site and one in every plaquette exists only in four dimensions: a link lies in $2(d-1)$ plaquettes and a site carries $d(d-1)/2$ of them, and $2(d-1) = d(d-1)/2$ forces $d = 4$. The statements of this section are also checked in the Lean certificate of the archive.

(a) the line field in the slice $x_3 = 0$ (b) one plaquette in the gauge

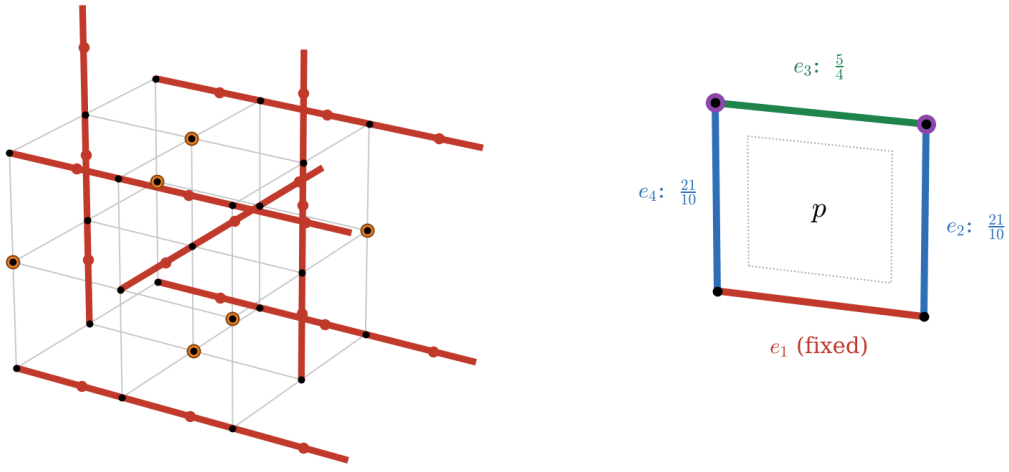



FIGURE 4. (a) The line field in the slice $x_3 = 0$ of a box of side three. Thick red segments are the links of $F$ in the directions $0, 1, 2$, with a dot marking the direction of travel; an orange ring marks a site whose line leaves the slice in direction 3. Every line is straight (Lemma 2.2(i)), and the segments that leave the box are its boundary stubs. (b) One plaquette with its fixed link $e_1$. The weights are those of the local inequality of Lemma 6.2 for the three free links: $\frac{21}{10}$ on the two links adjacent to $e_1$ and $\frac{5}{4}$ on the opposite one. The two purple corners are the ones that enter the corner form (6.3) once $Y_1 = 0$.

## 3. Gauge fixing and the free-boundary state

Let $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ be compact with Haar measure $dU$, and let $\Lambda$ be a box. The Wilson measure with free boundary is

$$W_\Lambda(dQ) = \frac{1}{Z_\Lambda} \exp\Big(N\beta \sum_{p \in P(\Lambda)} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p\Big) \prod_{e \in E(\Lambda)} dQ_e.$$

The measure is invariant under the gauge transformations $Q_{(x,y)} \mapsto g_x Q_{(x,y)} g_y^{-1}$ with $g \in G^\Lambda$. Call the links outside $F$ *active* and write $A$ for their set. For a function $O$ of the links, $O^F$ is $O$ with every link of $F$ set to the identity.

**Lemma 3.1** (Gauge fixing)**.** *Let $\mu_\Lambda^F$ be the probability measure on $G^{A \cap E(\Lambda)}$ whose density with respect to Haar measure is proportional to $\exp(N\beta \sum_{p \in P(\Lambda)} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F)$. For every gauge-invariant $O$ on $G^{E(\Lambda)}$,*

$$W_\Lambda(O) = \mu_\Lambda^F(O^F).$$

*Proof.* Each segment of $F \cap E(\Lambda)$ is a path $x_0, x_1, \dots, x_k$ along one direction. Given the variables on $F$, put $g_{x_0} = 1$ and $g_{x_{i+1}} = g_{x_i} Q_{(x_i, x_{i+1})}$ on every segment. The transformed field has $Q_e^g = 1$ on $F \cap E(\Lambda)$, and for fixed values on $F$ the map $Q_A \mapsto Q_A^g$ is a product of left and right translations, which preserves Haar measure. Gauge invariance of the action and of $O$ and the change of variables give the claim. □

No leftover holonomy appears because $F \cap E(\Lambda)$ is a forest. The measures $\mu_\Lambda^F$ are finite-volume versions of the specification $\gamma^F$ on $G^A$: for $e \in A$, $\gamma_e^F$ resamples $Q_e$ from the law with density proportional to $\exp(N\beta \sum_{p \ni e} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F)$ given all other active links. No infinite-volume gauge transformation is performed; $\gamma^F$ is a specification in its own right. Fix a metric $\delta$ on $G$ of diameter $D$ that is bi-invariant (for SU(2) the chordal metric on $S^3$,

$D = 2$; for SU($N$) the Hilbert–Schmidt distance). The Kantorovich coefficient of $e'$ on $e$ is

$$C_{ee'} = \sup \frac{W_1(\gamma_e^F(\cdot \mid Q), \gamma_e^F(\cdot \mid Q'))}{\delta(Q_{e'}, Q'_{e'})},$$

the supremum over pairs of configurations that differ only at $e'$. It vanishes unless $e$ and $e'$ share a plaquette.

**Proposition 3.2.** *Suppose that every row and every column of $(C_{ee'})$ sums to at most $\alpha < 1$. Then:*

(i) *$\gamma^F$ has exactly one Gibbs measure $\mu_F$;*
(ii) *for every gauge-invariant local $O$ the limit $\omega(O) = \lim W_\Lambda(O)$ exists along every sequence of boxes exhausting $\mathbb{Z}^4$ and equals $\mu_F(O^F)$;*
(iii) *$\omega$ is invariant under translations and the hypercubic group;*
(iv) *if $\beta \geq 0$, $\omega$ is reflection positive for reflections in hyperplanes through sites and in hyperplanes bisecting links;*
(v) *for gauge-invariant local $O, O'$ with $O$ Lipschitz in each link, $|\operatorname{Cov}_\omega(O, O')| \leq C_{O,O'} e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(O,O')}$ for every $\lambda < -\log \alpha$;*
(vi) *if $\beta \geq 0$, the transfer matrix of $\omega$ has spectral gap at least $-\log \alpha$.*

*Proof.* (i) Gibbs measures exist by compactness, and the comparison lemma of Appendix B with $S = \emptyset$ shows that any two coincide.

(ii) Extend $\mu_\Lambda^F$ by Haar measure on the active links outside $\Lambda$, and let $S$ be the set of active links with a plaquette outside $P(\Lambda)$; this includes every active link outside $E(\Lambda)$. For an active link $e \notin S$ all six plaquettes of $e$ lie in $P(\Lambda)$, so the conditional law of $Q_e$ under the extended measure is $\gamma_e^F$. Let $T$ be the support of $O^F$ and $\lambda < -\log \alpha$. The comparison lemma with weights $e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(\cdot, T)}$ gives

$$|\mu_\Lambda^F(O^F) - \mu_F(O^F)| \leq L \frac{\theta D}{1 - \theta} \sum_{z \in S} e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(z,T)},$$

with $\theta = \alpha e^\lambda < 1$ and $L$ a Lipschitz constant of $O^F$; the sum is at most $C_T R^3 e^{-\lambda R}$ when $R$ is the distance from $T$ to the complement of $\Lambda$. For $O$ continuous but not Lipschitz, approximate uniformly. Lemma 3.1 gives $W_\Lambda(O) = \mu_\Lambda^F(O^F)$.

(iii) $W_\Lambda(\tau_v O) = W_{\Lambda - v}(O)$, and the boxes $\Lambda - v$ also exhaust $\mathbb{Z}^4$; by (ii) the limit does not depend on the sequence. The line field is a device for computing $W_\Lambda$ and is never shifted. The same argument applies to the hypercubic group.

(iv) For $\beta \geq 0$ the measure $W_\Lambda$ is reflection positive for every box symmetric under the reflection [64], and reflection positivity passes to the limit along such boxes, which is $\omega$ by (ii).

(v) $\operatorname{Cov}_\omega(O, O') = \operatorname{Cov}_{\mu_F}(O^F, O'^F)$, and setting the links of $F$ to the identity keeps the Lipschitz property. The bound is Corollary B.2.

(vi) Let $\vartheta$ be a time reflection and $\tau_t$ a time translation. For gauge-invariant local $O$ that are Lipschitz in each link, (v) gives $|\omega(\vartheta(\bar{O})\tau_t O) - |\omega(O)|^2| \leq C_O e^{-\lambda t}$. On the support of $O$ these functions are dense in the gauge-invariant part of $L^2(\omega)$: gauge-invariant functions are functions on the compact quotient of $G^E$ by the gauge group, Lipschitz functions for the quotient metric are dense in $L^2$ of every finite measure on it, and they lift to gauge-invariant Lipschitz functions. By Proposition F.1 the spectrum of the transfer matrix on the complement of the vacuum lies in $[0, e^{-\lambda}]$, for every $\lambda < -\log \alpha$. □

The proposition replaces the torus limits and the uniqueness of the ungauged Gibbs measure used in [14, Thm. F] by the free-boundary limit, which has all the properties the reconstruction of the transfer matrix needs.[10]

[10] On a torus the line field closes up into cycles, and the holonomies along them cannot be removed by a gauge transformation; the argument never uses a torus. The state $\omega$ is defined only on gauge-invariant observables, which is all that the Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction [62, 63, 64] uses.

## 4. SU(2) up to one third

*Proof of Theorem 1.1.* Identify SU(2) with the unit quaternions and use the chordal metric. For an active link $e$ and a plaquette $p \ni e$, the staple $s_p$ is the product of the other three link variables in the order that makes $\mathrm{Re}(Q_e s_p) = \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p$, with links of $F$ equal to one. Since $N\beta \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p = 4\beta\langle Q_e, \bar{s}_p\rangle$ in $\mathbb{R}^4$, the conditional law of $Q_e$ is the von Mises–Fisher law $\nu_b(dx) \propto e^{\langle x,b\rangle}dx$ on $S^3$ with $b = 4\beta\sum_{p\ni e}\bar{s}_p$. Changing a partner $e'$ by $\delta$ in the chordal metric changes one staple by an isometric image of that displacement, so $b$ moves by $4|\beta|\delta$, and the sharp quarter (Theorem I.4), $W_1(\nu_b,\nu_{b'}) \le \frac{1}{4}|b-b'|$, gives $C_{ee'} \le |\beta|$. By Lemma 2.2(iv) every row and column has twelve nonzero entries, so $\alpha \le 12|\beta| = 3|\beta_W|$. Proposition 3.2 applies for $|\beta_W| < \frac{1}{3}$. □

*Proof of Theorem 1.2.* For the line field, every staple of an active link contains two active links, so the six staples can be chosen with sum zero while the staple through a given partner $e'$ moves freely. At $b = 0$ the derivative of $\nu_b$ in the direction $h$ has Kantorovich norm $\frac{1}{4}|h|$ by Lemma I.3(i), so $C_{ee'} = |\beta|$ exactly, and every row sum is $12|\beta| = 3|\beta_W|$.

Now let $F'$ be any forest and $C'$ the matrix of the statement. Suppose a positive weight $w$ satisfies $C'w \le \alpha w$. For a box $\Lambda_n$ of side $n$ let $C_n$ be the principal submatrix on the active links of $E(\Lambda_n)$; then $C_n w \le \alpha w$ on these links, and the Collatz–Wielandt inequality for nonnegative matrices gives $\rho(C_n) \le \alpha$. Since $C_n$ is symmetric, $\rho(C_n)$ is at least the mean row sum. The box has $4n^4 - O(n^3)$ links and $n^4$ sites, and a forest has fewer links than sites, so the number $a$ of active links is at least $3n^4 - O(n^3)$. Let $a_p$ be the number of active links of the plaquette $p$; the box has $P = 6n^4 - O(n^3)$ plaquettes and $\sum_p a_p = 6a - O(n^3)$. Two links share at most one plaquette, so the row sums add up to $|\beta|\sum_p a_p(a_p-1)$, and by convexity

$$\frac{|\beta|}{a}\sum_p a_p(a_p-1) \ge \frac{|\beta|P}{a}\,\bar{a}(\bar{a}-1) = 6|\beta|(\bar{a}-1) - o(1),$$

with $\bar{a} = \sum_p a_p/P = 6a/P - o(1) \ge 3 - o(1)$. Hence $\alpha \ge 12|\beta| - o(1)$ for every $n$, and $\alpha \ge 12|\beta| = 3|\beta_W|$. □

Without gauge fixing the same count gives eighteen partners and the ceiling $\beta_W = \frac{2}{9}$ of [14, Prop. 13]; the temporal gauge, a family of lines in one direction, leaves fourteen. The line field is optimal among forests: twelve is the mean number of partners forced by the number of free links, and it is attained at every link.

## 5. SU(2) past one third: plaquette blocks

Throughout this section $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ is the group of unit quaternions with the chordal metric $|x-y|$, $\bar{x}$ is the conjugate, $\langle x,y\rangle = \mathrm{Re}(x\bar{y})$ is the inner product of $\mathbb{R}^4$, and $dx$ is the normalised Haar measure on $S^3$. Left and right multiplication by unit quaternions and conjugation are isometries, and $\mathrm{Re}(xyz) = \mathrm{Re}(yzx) = \langle y, \bar{z}\bar{x}\rangle$. Put

$$Z_0(c) = \int_{S^3} e^{\langle c,x\rangle}dx = \sum_{j\ge 0}\frac{(|c|^2/4)^j}{j!\,(j+1)!}, \qquad c \in \mathbb{R}^4,$$

let $\nu_c(dx) \propto e^{\langle c,x\rangle}dx$ be the von Mises–Fisher law, and write $g = \log Z_0$, so that $\nabla g(c)$ is the mean and $\operatorname{Hess} g(c)$ the covariance of $\nu_c$.

5.1. **The blocks.** Let $\mathcal{B}$ be the set of plaquettes at $x$ in the plane $\{0,1\}$ with $x_0 \equiv x_1$ and in the plane $\{2,3\}$ with $x_2 \equiv x_3$, congruences modulo two (Table 4 of Appendix C lists them modulo $2\mathbb{Z}^4$, and Figure 5 draws them). A *block plaquette* is a plaquette of $\mathcal{B}$, and its *block* is the set of its three active links.

**Lemma 5.1.** *The set $\mathcal{B}$ is invariant under translations by $2\mathbb{Z}^4$ and:*

(i) *the blocks partition the active links;*
(ii) *every plaquette $p \notin \mathcal{B}$ meets three distinct blocks, one in each of its active links;*

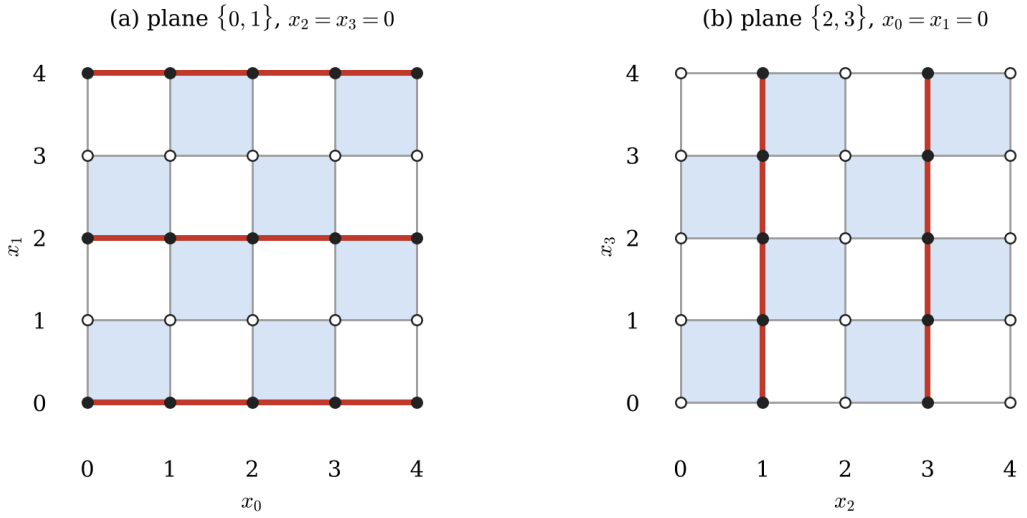



FIGURE 5. Block plaquettes, shaded, in (a) a plane $\{0,1\}$ and (b) a plane $\{2,3\}$: the plaquettes at $x$ with $x_0 \equiv x_1$, respectively $x_2 \equiv x_3$, modulo two. Red links belong to the line field $F$; a filled dot marks a site whose line runs in the plane, an open dot one whose line leaves it. The shaded squares form a checkerboard, so every link of the plane borders exactly one of them, and every square contains exactly one red link (Lemma 2.1); hence each block plaquette carries three active links and the blocks partition the active links (Lemma 5.1(i)).

(iii) *every active link lies in exactly five plaquettes outside $\mathcal{B}$, so it shares a plaquette outside $\mathcal{B}$ with exactly ten active links, none of them in its own block;*
(iv) *if an active link $j$ and a link of a block $B$ lie in a common plaquette outside $\mathcal{B}$, then every link of $B$ has its midpoint within distance 2 of the midpoint of $j$.*

*Proof.* Invariance under $2\mathbb{Z}^4$ is clear from the congruences. We use one fact throughout: two distinct links lie in at most one common plaquette, since they span it.

Every link lies in exactly one plaquette of $\mathcal{B}$. Indeed, a link $(y,\mu)$ with $\mu \in \{0,1\}$ lies in no plaquette of the plane $\{2,3\}$, and in exactly two of the plane $\{0,1\}$, those at $y$ and at $y - e_\nu$, where $\nu$ is the other element of $\{0,1\}$. The base points $y$ and $y - e_\nu$ differ only in the coordinate $\nu$, so $y_0 - y_1$ has opposite parities at the two, and exactly one of them satisfies $x_0 \equiv x_1$. The directions $2,3$ are treated in the same way. Every plaquette of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ contains exactly one link of $F$ (Lemma 2.1), so a block plaquette contains three active links, and every active link lies in exactly one block. This is (i).

(ii) Let $p \notin \mathcal{B}$ have active links $e_1, e_2, e_3$, and let $q_i$ be the block plaquette of $e_i$. Then $q_i \neq p$, so $q_i \cap p = \{e_i\}$ by the fact above. If $q_i = q_k$ with $i \neq k$, then $e_i, e_k$ lie in the two distinct plaquettes $p$ and $q_i$, which is impossible. So the three blocks are distinct, and each meets $p$ in one link.

(iii) An active link $e$ lies in six plaquettes (Lemma 2.2), and by (i) exactly one of them is in $\mathcal{B}$. Each of the other five contains two further active links. These ten links are distinct, because a link other than $e$ shares at most one plaquette with $e$, and none lies in the block of $e$, because a link $f$ of that block sharing the plaquette $p \notin \mathcal{B}$ with $e$ would put $e, f$ in the two distinct plaquettes $p$ and the block plaquette of $e$.

(iv) Let $f \in B$ share the plaquette $p \notin \mathcal{B}$ with $j$. Two links of one unit square have midpoints at distance $2^{-1/2}$ or $1$, so the midpoint of $j$ is within distance 1 of that of $f$, and the midpoint of $f$ is within distance 1 of that of every link of its block plaquette. The triangle inequality gives the bound 2. □

Fix a block plaquette $p$ with active links $e_1, e_2, e_3$. Reading the plaquette product cyclically and deleting its fixed link, $\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p = \operatorname{Re}(y_1 y_2 y_3)$, where $y_i$ is $Q_{e_i}$ or $Q_{e_i}^{-1}$. Every other plaquette containing $e_i$ meets the block only in $e_i$ by Lemma 5.1(ii) and contributes $4\beta\langle y_i, \bar{s}\rangle$ to the exponent, where $s$ is the staple of $y_i$ in it. Hence the conditional law of the block given all other active links is

$$\mu_b(dy) \propto \exp\Big(\sum_{i=1}^{3}\langle y_i, b_i\rangle + 4\beta \operatorname{Re}(y_1 y_2 y_3)\Big)\, dy_1\, dy_2\, dy_3, \tag{5.1}$$

with $b_i$ the sum of $4\beta\bar{s}$ over the five staples, so that $|b_i| \le 20|\beta|$. Inversion is an isometry of $S^3$ and preserves Haar measure, so we may work with $y$ instead of $Q$. On $(S^3)^3$ we use the metric $d(y, y') = \sum_i |y_i - y_i'|$.

5.2. **The sensitivity of one block.** Let $\lambda_*$ and $\tau$ be a lower and an upper bound for the eigenvalues of $\operatorname{Hess} g(c)$ on the ball $|c| \le 24|\beta|$, and $M$ an upper bound there for the norm of the third derivative $D^3 g(c)$ as a trilinear form. Put

$$\begin{aligned} w &= 8\beta^2(\tau - \lambda_*), \qquad s = \tfrac{1}{4} + (e^w - 1)e^w\sqrt{\tau}, \\ C &= 20|\beta|(4|\beta|\tau s + 16\beta^2 M), \qquad K = \frac{(1+|\beta|)\, s}{1 - C}, \end{aligned} \tag{5.2}$$

assuming $C < 1$.

**Lemma 5.2.** *Let $\nu$ be a probability measure and $\lambda = e^R\nu/\nu(e^R)$ with $\operatorname{osc} R \le \omega$. For bounded $f, h$,*

$$\operatorname{Cov}_\lambda(f,h) \le \operatorname{Cov}_\nu(f,h) + (e^\omega - 1)e^\omega \operatorname{sd}_\nu(f)\operatorname{sd}_\nu(h).$$

*Proof.* We may assume $0 \le R \le \omega$. The density $\rho = e^R/\nu(e^R)$ lies in $[e^{-\omega}, e^\omega]$, so $\delta = \|\rho - 1\|_\infty \le e^\omega - 1$. With $\tilde{f} = f - \nu f$ and $\tilde{h} = h - \nu h$,

$$\begin{aligned} \operatorname{Cov}_\lambda(f,h) - \operatorname{Cov}_\nu(f,h) &= \nu\big((\rho-1)\tilde{f}\tilde{h}\big) \\ &\quad - \nu\big((\rho-1)\tilde{f}\big)\,\nu\big((\rho-1)\tilde{h}\big), \end{aligned}$$

and the right side is at most $(\delta + \delta^2)\operatorname{sd}_\nu(f)\operatorname{sd}_\nu(h)$ by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality. □

**Lemma 5.3.** *Let $\beta \ge 0$, $a, c_0 \in \mathbb{R}^4$ with $|a|, |c_0| \le 20\beta$, and*

$$\kappa(dx) \propto \exp\big(\langle x, a\rangle + g(c_0 + 4\beta\bar{x})\big)dx \quad \text{on } S^3.$$

*For every 1-Lipschitz $f$ and every $h \in \mathbb{R}^4$:*

(i) $\operatorname{Cov}_\kappa(f, \langle x, h\rangle) \le s|h|$;

(ii) *if $c_0$ moves in the direction $k$, then $|\frac{d}{dt}\kappa(f)| \le (4\beta\tau s + 16\beta^2 M)|k|$.*

*Proof.* (i) Taylor's formula at $c_0$ gives $g(c_0 + 4\beta u) = g(c_0) + 4\beta\langle \nabla g(c_0), u\rangle + R(u)$ with $R(u) = 8\beta^2 \operatorname{Hess} g(\xi)(u,u)$ for some $\xi$ on the segment, $|\xi| \le 24\beta$. For $u = \bar{x}$ of norm one, $R(\bar{x}) \in [8\beta^2\lambda_*, 8\beta^2\tau]$, so $\operatorname{osc} R \le w$. Since $\langle \nabla g(c_0), \bar{x}\rangle = \langle x, \overline{\nabla g(c_0)}\rangle$, $\kappa$ is the tilt $e^R\nu/\nu(e^R)$ of $\nu = \nu_c$ with $c = a + 4\beta\overline{\nabla g(c_0)}$. The sharp quarter, Theorem I.4, gives $\operatorname{Cov}_\nu(f, \langle x, h\rangle) = \frac{d}{dt}\nu_{c+th}(f) \le \frac{1}{4}|h|$. A 1-Lipschitz function on a set of diameter two has $\operatorname{sd} \le 1$, and $\operatorname{sd}_\nu\langle x, h\rangle \le \sqrt{\tau}|h|$ because $|c| \le |a| + 4\beta \le 24\beta$. Lemma 5.2 gives (i).

(ii) The derivative is $\operatorname{Cov}_\kappa(f, \langle \nabla g(c_0 + 4\beta\bar{x}), k\rangle)$. Write $\nabla g(c_0 + 4\beta u) = \nabla g(c_0) + 4\beta \operatorname{Hess} g(c_0)u + N(u)$. The constant term does not contribute. The linear term is $\langle x, h\rangle$ with $h = 4\beta\overline{\operatorname{Hess} g(c_0)k}$, $|h| \le 4\beta\tau|k|$, and contributes at most $4\beta\tau s|k|$ by (i). For $|u|, |u'| \le 1$, $\|\operatorname{Hess} g(c_0 + 4\beta v) - \operatorname{Hess} g(c_0)\| \le 4\beta M|v| \le 4\beta M$ on the segment between them, so $|N(u) - N(u')| \le 16\beta^2 M|u - u'|$; the function $\langle N(\bar{x}), k\rangle$ is therefore $16\beta^2 M|k|$-Lipschitz, its standard deviation is at most that constant, and its covariance with $f$ is at most $16\beta^2 M|k|$. □

**Lemma 5.4.** *Let $C < 1$. If $b$ and $b'$ satisfy $|b_i|, |b'_i| \le 20|\beta|$ and differ only in one coordinate $b_i$, then*

$$W_1(\mu_b, \mu_{b'}) \le K\,|b_i - b'_i|$$

*in the metric $d$.*

*Proof.* The map $y_1 \mapsto -y_1$ turns $\mu_b$ for $\beta$ into the law for $-\beta$ with $b_1$ replaced by $-b_1$ and is an isometry, so we may take $\beta \ge 0$; the cyclic symmetry of $\operatorname{Re}(y_1y_2y_3)$ lets us take $i = 1$. Let $f$ be 1-Lipschitz for $d$ and $\varepsilon = |b_1 - b'_1|$.

*The middle link.* Given $y_1, y_3$, the law of $y_2$ is $\nu_c$ with $c = b_2 + 4\beta\,\overline{y_3y_1}$, which does not involve $b_1$. Changing $y_1$ by $\eta$ moves $c$ by $4\beta\eta$, and the sharp quarter moves $\nu_c$ by at most $\beta\eta$ in $W_1$. Hence $F(y_1, y_3) = \mathbb{E}[f \mid y_1, y_3]$ is $(1+\beta)$-Lipschitz in each variable, and $\mu_b(f) = \mu_b^{13}(F)$, where $\mu_b^{13}$ is the law of $(y_1, y_3)$:

$$\mu_b^{13} \propto e^{\langle y_1, b_1\rangle + \langle y_3, b_3\rangle} Z_0\big(b_2 + 4\beta\,\overline{y_3y_1}\big).$$

Since $|b_2 + 4\beta\overline{y_3y_1}| = |b_2y_3 + 4\beta\bar{y}_1| = |y_1b_2 + 4\beta\bar{y}_3|$, its conditional laws are

$$\kappa_1(dy_1 \mid y_3) \propto e^{\langle y_1, b_1\rangle + g(b_2y_3 + 4\beta\bar{y}_1)}dy_1,$$
$$\kappa_3(dy_3 \mid y_1) \propto e^{\langle y_3, b_3\rangle + g(y_1b_2 + 4\beta\bar{y}_3)}dy_3,$$

both of the form of Lemma 5.3, with $|c_0| = |b_2|$.

*Two sites.* Integrating Lemma 5.3(i) along the segment from $b_1$ to $b'_1$ gives $W_1(\kappa_1, \kappa'_1) \le s\varepsilon$ for the same $y_3$. Moving $y_3$ to $y'_3$ moves $c_0 = b_2y_3$ along a segment of length $|b_2||y_3 - y'_3| \le 20\beta|y_3 - y'_3|$ inside the ball $|c_0| \le 20\beta$, so Lemma 5.3(ii) gives $W_1(\kappa_1(\cdot \mid y_3), \kappa_1(\cdot \mid y'_3)) \le C|y_3 - y'_3|$, and the same for $\kappa_3$, which does not depend on $b_1$. Let $\pi$ be a coupling of $\mu_b^{13}$ and $\mu_{b'}^{13}$ minimising $d_1 + d_3$, $d_k = \mathbb{E}_\pi|y_k - y'_k|$. Replacing $(y_1, y'_1)$ by an optimal coupling of $\kappa_1(\cdot \mid y_3)$ and $\kappa'_1(\cdot \mid y'_3)$ keeps a coupling, so minimality gives $d_1 \le s\varepsilon + Cd_3$; in the same way $d_3 \le Cd_1$. Hence $d_1 \le s\varepsilon/(1 - C^2)$ and

$$|\mu_b(f) - \mu_{b'}(f)| \le (1+\beta)(d_1 + d_3) \le \frac{(1+\beta)s}{1 - C}\,\varepsilon = K\varepsilon. \qquad \square$$

5.3. **The constants.**

**Lemma 5.5.** *Write $g(c) = \varphi(|c|^2)$ and $r = |c|$. For $c \ne 0$ the eigenvalues of* Hess $g(c)$ *are $2\varphi'(r^2)$, three times, and $2\varphi'(r^2) + 4r^2\varphi''(r^2)$, and the norm of $D^3g(c)$ is*

$$\max\Big(|A + \Gamma|, \tfrac{2}{3}|A|\Big), \qquad A = 12r\varphi''(r^2), \quad \Gamma = 8r^3\varphi'''(r^2).$$

*On the ball $r \le 2.07$ every eigenvalue of* Hess $g$ *lies between* 0.158491 *and* 0.25000001*, and the norm of $D^3g$ is at most* 0.0615586*.*

*Proof.* Differentiating $\varphi(|c|^2)$ gives $D^2g(v, v) = 2\varphi'|v|^2 + 4\varphi''\langle c, v\rangle^2$ and $D^3g(v, v, v) = 12\varphi''\langle c, v\rangle|v|^2 + 8\varphi'''\langle c, v\rangle^3$. For $|v| = 1$ and $t = \langle c/r, v\rangle \in [-1, 1]$ the cubic form is $At + \Gamma t^3$, whose largest absolute value is attained at $t = \pm 1$ or at an interior critical point, where it equals $\frac{2}{3}|A||t| \le \frac{2}{3}|A|$; by Banach's theorem [8] the supremum of a symmetric trilinear form on the diagonal of the unit sphere is its norm. The numerical bounds are obtained in ball arithmetic [48] from the series of $Z_0$, truncated after forty terms with a proved bound on the tail, on $2 \cdot 10^4$ subintervals of $[0, 2.07]$; the program is described in Appendix C. $\square$

5.4. **The proof of Theorem 1.3.** Let $\gamma^{\mathcal{B}}$ be the block specification: for a block $B$, $\gamma_B^{\mathcal{B}}$ resamples the three links of $B$ from (5.1). It comes from the same interaction as $\gamma^F$, so the two specifications have the same Gibbs measures. Define the block coefficients

$$C_{Bj} = \sup \frac{W_1(\gamma_B^{\mathcal{B}}(\cdot \mid Q), \gamma_B^{\mathcal{B}}(\cdot \mid Q'))}{|Q_j - Q'_j|}$$

for an active link $j \notin B$, the supremum over pairs of configurations that differ only at $j$, with $W_1$ for the metric $d$.

**Proposition 5.6.** *Suppose that* $\sum_B C_{Bj} \le \alpha < 1$ *for every active link* $j$. *Then the conclusions (i)–(vi) of Proposition 3.2 hold with* $-\frac{1}{2}\log\alpha$ *in place of* $-\log\alpha$.

*Proof.* The proof of Proposition 3.2 goes through with Lemma B.3 of Appendix B in place of Lemma B.1, and with the set $S$ of part (ii), and the support of $H$ in Corollary B.2, enlarged to the union of the blocks that meet it. The enlargement multiplies the size of these sets by at most three and moves them by at most one, which changes only the constants. □

*Proof of Theorem 1.3.* Let $|\beta| \le 0.345/4$ and take the constants of Lemma 5.5, whose ball $r \le 2.07$ contains $|c| \le 24|\beta|$. With these fixed constants every quantity in (5.2) is increasing in $|\beta|$, and so is

$$\alpha(\beta_W) = 40|\beta|K. \tag{5.3}$$

Changing an active link $j$ by $\eta$ changes one staple of each of its ten partners outside its block by an isometric image of the displacement, so the field $b_i$ of each such partner $i$ moves by at most $4|\beta|\eta$, and Lemma 5.4, applied once for each of these ten fields, gives $\sum_B C_{Bj} \le 40|\beta|K$. Evaluating (5.2) in ball arithmetic at $\beta_W = 0.345$ gives $w \le 0.0054459$, $s \le 0.252746$, $C \le 0.050243$, $K \le 0.289069$ and $\alpha \le 0.99729$; at $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$ it gives $\alpha \le 0.95602$. Proposition 5.6 applies. □

*Remark* 5.7. Most of the range is kept. A second bound for the same sensitivity, which keeps the law of the middle link instead of linearising it, evaluated in floating point on a quadrature grid and maximised over the fields $b$ by a random search followed by the Nelder–Mead method, gives 0.2783 at $\beta_W = 0.34$, against 0.2881 from Lemma 5.4, and $40|\beta|$ times it crosses one near $\beta_W = 0.357$. That computation is not certified and is not used in the proof. Past this point the gain from integrating out one link is spent, and larger blocks are needed, such as the free links of a cube of the line field, whose sensitivity no longer reduces to two sites.

## 6. Curvature in the gauge

In this section $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ is a closed connected subgroup with Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$ and the inner product $\langle X, Y\rangle = -\operatorname{Tr}(XY)$; the bound of Theorem 1.4 is proved first for $\mathrm{U}(N)$. A tangent vector at a field $Q$ is $v = (X_e Q_e)$, $|v|^2 = \sum_e |X_e|^2$. For the plaquette at $x$ in the plane $\mu < \nu$ number its links $e_1 = (x, \mu)$, $e_2 = (x + e_\mu, \nu)$, $e_3 = (x + e_\nu, \mu)$, $e_4 = (x, \nu)$, transport their vectors to $x$,

$$Y_1 = X_{e_1}, \quad Y_2 = Q_{e_1} X_{e_2} Q_{e_1}^*, \quad Y_3 = Q_{e_4} X_{e_3} Q_{e_4}^*, \quad Y_4 = X_{e_4}, \tag{6.1}$$

and write $W = Q_p$. The second derivative of $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p$ along the geodesic $Q_e(t) = e^{tX_e}Q_e$ is

$$\begin{aligned} f_p = {} & \sum_{i=1}^{4} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_i^2 W) + 2\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_1 Y_2 W) + 2\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_3 Y_4 W) \\ & - 2 \sum_{i\in\{1,2\},\, j\in\{3,4\}} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_i W Y_j), \end{aligned} \tag{6.2}$$

so that $\operatorname{Hess} S_0(v, v) = \sum_p f_p$. To see this, write $Q_p = Q_{e_1} Q_{e_2} Q_{e_3}^* Q_{e_4}^*$. Since $Q_{e_1} e^{tX_{e_2}} = e^{tY_2} Q_{e_1}$ and $e^{-tX_{e_3}} Q_{e_4}^* = Q_{e_4}^* e^{-tY_3}$, the plaquette variable along the geodesic is $Q_p(t) = e^{tY_1} e^{tY_2} W e^{-tY_3} e^{-tY_4}$. Differentiating twice at $t = 0$ gives the four squares, the two products of neighbouring factors and the four products across $W$, and the squares and the product $WY_3Y_4$ are moved cyclically under the trace. The corner form of $p$ is

$$c_p = 2\langle Y_1, Y_4\rangle - 2\langle Y_1, Y_2\rangle + 2\langle Y_2, WY_3W^*\rangle - 2\langle Y_3, Y_4\rangle. \tag{6.3}$$

It collects the inner products of the transported vectors of two links that meet at a right angle at a corner of $p$.

**Lemma 6.1.** *On $\mathbb{Z}^4$, or on a box with free boundary, for every field $Q$ and every square-summable $X$,*

$$\sum_y \Big[ |D_y X|^2 + \sum_\mu \big| X_{y,\mu} + Q^*_{y-e_\mu,\mu} X_{y-e_\mu,\mu} Q_{y-e_\mu,\mu} \big|^2 \Big] = 4|X|^2 + \sum_p c_p,$$

*where $D_y X = \sum_\mu [X_{y,\mu} - Q^*_{y-e_\mu,\mu} X_{y-e_\mu,\mu} Q_{y-e_\mu,\mu}]$ is the covariant divergence and terms with a link outside the box are omitted.*

*Proof.* At a site $y$ write $o_\mu$ for the vector of the outgoing link in direction $\mu$ and $i_\mu$ for the transported vector of the incoming one, so that $D_y X = \sum_\mu (o_\mu - i_\mu)$. Every link is outgoing at one end and incoming at the other, so the squares $|o_\mu|^2 + |i_\mu|^2$, which appear once in $|D_y X|^2$ and once in $|o_\mu + i_\mu|^2$, add up to $4|X|^2$. The collinear cross term $-2\langle o_\mu, i_\mu\rangle$ of $|D_y X|^2$ cancels the term $+2\langle o_\mu, i_\mu\rangle$ of $|o_\mu + i_\mu|^2$. The remaining cross terms of $|D_y X|^2$ pair two perpendicular ends at $y$, and each such pair is a corner of exactly one plaquette, with the sign and the transport of (6.3) (this is the proof of [14, Lemma 1]). In a box two perpendicular ends at $y$ span a plaquette of the box, because a box is a product of intervals. □

**Lemma 6.2.** *Let $k \in \{1,2,3,4\}$, let $k \pm 1 \pmod 4$ be the positions adjacent to $k$ and $k+2$ the opposite one. For every $N$, every $W \in \mathrm{U}(N)$ and all $Y_1, \dots, Y_4 \in \mathfrak{u}(N)$ with $Y_k = 0$,*

$$\pm f_p + \tfrac{9}{10} c_p \le \tfrac{21}{10} \big( |Y_{k-1}|^2 + |Y_{k+1}|^2 \big) + \tfrac{5}{4} |Y_{k+2}|^2.$$

*Proof.* Replacing $W$ by $-W$ changes the sign of $f_p$ and fixes $c_p$, so the sign $+$ suffices. Conjugation by a unitary matrix preserves both sides, so we may take $W = \mathrm{diag}(w_a)$. The form $\mathcal{F} = \mathrm{RHS} - f_p - \frac{9}{10} c_p$ then splits into a block for each diagonal position $a$, in the real variables $y_i = -i(Y_i)_{aa}$, and a block for each pair $a \neq b$, in the complex variables $z_i = (Y_i)_{ab}$, since $(Y_i)_{ba} = -\bar{z}_i$. Appendix D shows that every block is positive definite. □

*Proof of the bound in Theorem 1.4.* Every plaquette has exactly one link of $F$, and $X$ vanishes on it. By Lemma 2.2(iii) each active link is adjacent to the fixed link in four of its plaquettes and opposite to it in two. Summing Lemma 6.2 over the plaquettes,

$$\sum_p (\pm f_p + \tfrac{9}{10} c_p) \le (4 \cdot \tfrac{21}{10} + 2 \cdot \tfrac{5}{4}) |X|^2 = \tfrac{109}{10} |X|^2.$$

By Lemma 6.1, $\frac{9}{10} \sum_p c_p = \frac{9}{10} \Sigma - \frac{36}{10} |X|^2$, where $\Sigma \ge 0$ is the left side of the lemma. Hence

$$\pm \operatorname{Hess} S_0(v,v) + \tfrac{9}{10} \Sigma \le (\tfrac{109}{10} + \tfrac{36}{10}) |X|^2 = \tfrac{29}{2} |X|^2.$$

In a box, links near the boundary lie in fewer plaquettes and receive less. □

The factor $\frac{9}{10}$ is chosen so that the corners are paid by the divergence identity at the price $\frac{36}{10}$ while the local blocks stay positive; Lemma 6.1 is the divergence identity of [14, Lemma 1] with the collinear term written as a square, so nothing is lost by Cauchy–Schwarz.

The two lemmas concern vectors in $\mathfrak{u}(N)$ and fields in $\mathrm{U}(N)$, so the bound holds without change on every closed subgroup $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$, the vectors $X_e$ ranging over its Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$. It is also the Hessian of $S_0$ on $G^E$: the metric is bi-invariant, the geodesics of $G$ through $Q_e$ are the curves $e^{tX} Q_e$ with $X \in \mathfrak{g}$, which are geodesics of $\mathrm{U}(N)$, and the Hessian is read off from second derivatives along geodesics.

**Lemma 6.3.** *Let $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ be closed and connected with simple Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$, let $\mathfrak{t} \subset \mathfrak{g}$ be a maximal abelian subalgebra, and write the eigenvalues of $\operatorname{ad} H$ on $\mathfrak{g} \otimes \mathbb{C}$ and of $H$ on $\mathbb{C}^N$, for $H \in \mathfrak{t}$, as $i\alpha(H)$ and $i\mu(H)$, with $\alpha$ running over the roots and $\mu$ over the weights of $\mathbb{C}^N$ counted with multiplicity. Then $\mathrm{Ric}_G = \kappa_G \langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ with*

$$\kappa_G = \frac{\sum_\alpha \alpha(H)^2}{4 \sum_\mu \mu(H)^2} \qquad (0 \neq H \in \mathfrak{t}).$$

*Proof.* For a bi-invariant metric the curvature is $R(X,Y)Z = -\frac{1}{4}[[X,Y],Z]$ on left-invariant fields [60, Sect. 7], so for an orthonormal basis $(E_i)$ of $\mathfrak{g}$,

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{Ric}(X,X) &= \sum_i \langle R(E_i,X)X, E_i\rangle \\ &= \tfrac{1}{4}\sum_i |[X,E_i]|^2 = -\tfrac{1}{4}\operatorname{Tr}(\operatorname{ad} X)^2,\end{aligned}$$

since $\operatorname{ad} X$ is skew. The Killing form $B(X,Y) = \operatorname{Tr}(\operatorname{ad} X \operatorname{ad} Y)$ and $\langle\cdot,\cdot\rangle$ are invariant under the adjoint action, and $\mathfrak{g}$ is simple, so $B = -4\kappa\langle\cdot,\cdot\rangle$ for a constant $\kappa$ and $\operatorname{Ric} = \kappa\langle\cdot,\cdot\rangle$. On $H \in \mathfrak{t}$ the two forms are $B(H,H) = -\sum_\alpha \alpha(H)^2$ and $\langle H,H\rangle = -\operatorname{Tr} H^2 = \sum_\mu \mu(H)^2$. □

Table 1 evaluates the ratio of Lemma 6.3 for every compact simple Lie algebra and a faithful representation of least dimension, on the root systems of [46, Sect. 12.1]; the weights of the representations of dimensions 27 and 56 of $E_6$ and $E_7$ are the roots of $E_8$ with prescribed inner products with a subsystem $A_2$, respectively $A_1$, projected to its orthogonal complement, by the decompositions $248 = (78,1)+(27,3)+(\overline{27},\bar{3})+(1,8)$ and $248 = (133,1)+(56,2)+(1,3)$ [70]. Taking for $H$ the coroot $\theta^\vee$ of the highest root gives $\sum_\alpha \alpha(\theta^\vee)^2 = 4h^\vee$ and $\sum_\mu \mu(\theta^\vee)^2 = 2\ell_\rho$, so $\kappa_G = h^\vee/(2\ell_\rho)$, with the Dynkin index normalised to one on the defining representation of $\mathrm{SU}(N)$. The ratio depends on $\mathfrak{g}$ and $\rho$ only, so it is the same for every compact group with Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$, simply connected or not.

**Lemma 6.4.** *Let $e \neq e'$ be two links of a plaquette $p$, and write*

$$\operatorname{Hess}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p(v,v) = \sum_{e,e'\in p} H^p_{ee'}(X_e, X_{e'})$$

*with bilinear forms satisfying $H^p_{ee'}(a,b) = H^p_{e'e}(b,a)$. Then $|H^p_{ee'}(a,b)| \le |a|\,|b|$ for all $a,b \in \mathfrak{u}(N)$ and every field.*

*Proof.* By (6.2) the terms of $f_p$ that mix two positions $i \neq j$ are $2\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_1Y_2W)$, $2\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_3Y_4W)$ and $-2\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Y_iWY_j)$, so $H^p_{ee'}$ is $\pm\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(abW)$ or $\pm\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(aWb)$ after an isometric transport of $a$ and $b$, and $|\operatorname{Tr}(abW)| \le \|a\|_{\mathrm{HS}}\|bW\|_{\mathrm{HS}} = |a|\,|b|$. □

**Corollary 6.5.** *Let $G \subset \mathrm{U}(N)$ be closed and connected with semisimple Lie algebra and $N|\beta| < \frac{2}{29}\kappa_G$. For every box the measure $\mu^F_\Lambda$ satisfies the Bakry–Émery condition with $K = \kappa_G - \frac{29}{2}N|\beta| > 0$, uniformly in the box, and hence a logarithmic Sobolev inequality with constant $2/K$ and a Poincaré inequality with constant $1/K$.*

*Proof.* The set $\{Q_F = 1\}$ is a product factor, so its Ricci curvature is at least $\kappa_G$ on every link, and the Hessian of the restricted action is the restriction of $N\beta\operatorname{Hess} S_0$ to $X_F = 0$. Apply the bound and [4, Cor. 5.7.2]. □

6.1. **Decay with an explicit rate.** Let $A'$ be a finite set of active links and $P'$ a finite set of plaquettes whose active links lie in $A'$. An action $S = \sum_{p\in P'} c_p \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q^F_p$ with $0 \le c_p \le 1$ is *admissible* if $|\operatorname{Hess} S(v,v)| \le \frac{29}{2}|v|^2$ for all $v$ tangent to $G^{A'}$. Two links lie in at most one common plaquette, so by Lemma 6.4 and Lemma 2.2(iv) the mixed blocks of its Hessian satisfy $|\operatorname{Hess} S_{ee'}(a,b)| \le |a|\,|b|$, and each link has at most twelve partners. The action $S_\Lambda = \sum_{p\in P(\Lambda)} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q^F_p$ of a box is admissible by the bound proved above, and so is every convex combination of two admissible actions. Let $\mu$ be the probability measure on $G^{A'}$ with density proportional to $e^{N\beta S}$ with respect to Haar measure, let $L = \Delta + N\beta\langle\nabla S, \nabla\cdot\rangle$ be its Langevin generator, which is self-adjoint in $L^2(\mu)$, and $P_t = e^{tL}$. Write $\nabla_e$ for the gradient in the factor of the link $e$, and for weights $w : A' \to (0,\infty)$ put $\Gamma^w(f) = \sum_e w_e|\nabla_e f|^2$; $\Gamma$ is the case $w \equiv 1$.

**Lemma 6.6.** *Let $\lambda \ge 0$ and $w_e = e^{\lambda d_e}$, where $|d_e - d_{e'}| \le 1$ whenever $e$ and $e'$ share a plaquette, and put*

$$K_\lambda = \kappa_G - N|\beta|\Big(\tfrac{29}{2} + 12\big(\cosh\tfrac{\lambda}{2} - 1\big)\Big).$$

*Then* $\Gamma^w(P_t f) \le e^{-2K_\lambda t} P_t \Gamma^w(f)$ *for every smooth* $f$ *and* $t \ge 0$.

*Proof.* Put $V = -N\beta S$. On the product manifold $M = G^{A'}$ the projection to the tangent space of one factor is parallel, the rough Laplacian commutes with it, and the Ricci tensor is block diagonal. Hence the Bochner–Weitzenböck formula $\nabla\Delta g = \Delta\nabla g + \mathrm{Ric}(\nabla g)$, applied factor by factor, together with the derivative of the drift, gives for smooth $g$

$$\begin{aligned}\tfrac12 L\Gamma^w(g) - \Gamma^w(g, Lg) &= \sum_e w_e\big(|\nabla\nabla_e g|^2 + \mathrm{Ric}_G(\nabla_e g, \nabla_e g)\big)\\ &\quad + \sum_{e,e'} w_e \,\mathrm{Hess}\, V_{ee'}(\nabla_e g, \nabla_{e'} g),\end{aligned}$$

where $\Gamma^w(g,h)$ is the polarised form.[11] Put $u_e = \nabla_e g$ and $v_e = \sqrt{w_e}\, u_e$. By the symmetry of $\mathrm{Hess}\, V$,

$$\begin{aligned}\sum_{e,e'} w_e \,\mathrm{Hess}\, V_{ee'}(u_e, u_{e'}) &= \mathrm{Hess}\, V(v,v)\\ &\quad + \sum_{e\neq e'} \Big(\cosh\tfrac{\lambda(d_e - d_{e'})}{2} - 1\Big)\,\mathrm{Hess}\, V_{ee'}(v_e, v_{e'}),\end{aligned}$$

because $\frac{w_e + w_{e'}}{2\sqrt{w_e w_{e'}}} = \cosh\frac{\lambda(d_e - d_{e'})}{2}$. The first term is at least $-\frac{29}{2}N|\beta|\,|v|^2$. In the second only partners contribute, each with a coefficient at most $\cosh\frac{\lambda}{2} - 1$ and a block of norm at most $N|\beta|$, and $2|v_e|\,|v_{e'}| \le |v_e|^2 + |v_{e'}|^2$ with twelve partners per link bounds it by $12(\cosh\frac{\lambda}{2} - 1)N|\beta|\,|v|^2$. Since $\mathrm{Ric}_G \ge \kappa_G$ and $|v|^2 = \Gamma^w(g)$,

$$\tfrac12 L\Gamma^w(g) - \Gamma^w(g, Lg) \ge K_\lambda \Gamma^w(g).$$

For fixed $t$ let $\varphi(s) = P_s\Gamma^w(P_{t-s}f)$, $0 \le s \le t$. Then $\varphi'(s) = P_s\big(L\Gamma^w(g_s) - 2\Gamma^w(g_s, Lg_s)\big) \ge 2K_\lambda\varphi(s)$ with $g_s = P_{t-s}f$, and $\varphi(0) \le e^{-2K_\lambda t}\varphi(t)$ is the claim. □

**Lemma 6.7.** *Suppose* $K_\lambda > 0$. *Let* $f$ *and* $g$ *be smooth functions on* $G^{A'}$ *that depend only on the links of* $A_f$ *and of* $B_g$, *and let* $D$ *be the least number of steps from* $A_f$ *to* $B_g$ *in the graph on* $A'$ *whose edges join links that share a plaquette. Then*

$$|\,\mathrm{Cov}_\mu(f,g)| \le \frac{e^{-\lambda D/2}}{K_\lambda}\,\|\nabla f\|_\infty \sum_{e\in B_g} \|\nabla_e g\|_\infty,$$

*where* $\|\nabla f\|_\infty^2 = \sup\sum_e |\nabla_e f|^2$.

*Proof.* Since $K_0 \ge K_\lambda > 0$, Lemma 6.6 with $\lambda = 0$ gives $\Gamma(P_t f) \le e^{-2K_0 t}\|\nabla f\|_\infty^2$, so $P_t f$ converges uniformly to a constant, which is $\mu(f)$ by invariance, $M$ being connected. Since $\frac{d}{dt}\mu(gP_t f) = \mu(gLP_t f) = -\mu(\Gamma(g, P_t f))$,

$$\mathrm{Cov}_\mu(f,g) = \int_0^\infty \mu\big(\Gamma(P_t f, g)\big)\,dt.$$

Let $d_e$ be the smaller of $D$ and the graph distance from $e$ to $A_f$, so that $|d_e - d_{e'}| \le 1$ for partners, $w_e = 1$ on $A_f$, $w_e = e^{\lambda D}$ on $B_g$, and $\Gamma^w(f) \le \|\nabla f\|_\infty^2$. For $e \in B_g$, Lemma 6.6 gives $|\nabla_e P_t f|^2 \le w_e^{-1}\Gamma^w(P_t f) \le e^{-\lambda D}e^{-2K_\lambda t}\|\nabla f\|_\infty^2$. Hence $|\Gamma(P_t f, g)| \le e^{-\lambda D/2}e^{-K_\lambda t}\|\nabla f\|_\infty \sum_{e\in B_g}\|\nabla_e g\|_\infty$, and integration in $t$ gives the bound. □

*Proof of Theorem 1.5.* Let $\lambda^* > 0$ solve $K_{\lambda^*} = 0$, so that $\frac{\lambda^*}{2} = m_G(\beta)$, and let $0 < \lambda < \lambda^*$; then $K_\lambda > 0$.

[11] For $w \equiv 1$ this is Bochner's identity $\Gamma_2 = |\nabla^2 g|^2 + (\mathrm{Ric} + \mathrm{Hess}\, V)(\nabla g, \nabla g)$; the weights enter only through the factor index, which the connection, the Laplacian and the Ricci tensor preserve, so only the off-diagonal blocks of $\mathrm{Hess}\, V$ see them.

*Decay in boxes.* Lemma 6.7 with $S = S_\Lambda$ gives

$$|\operatorname{Cov}_{\mu^F_\Lambda}(f,g)| \le C_{f,g} e^{-\lambda D/2},$$

uniformly in the box.

*Limit.* For boxes $\Lambda \subset \Lambda'$ let $S_s = (1-s)S_\Lambda + sS_{\Lambda'}$ on the active links of $\Lambda'$, $s \in [0,1]$, and $\mu_s$ the corresponding measure; $S_s$ is admissible, $\mu_0$ is $\mu^F_\Lambda$ times Haar measure on the active links outside $\Lambda$, and $\mu_1 = \mu^F_{\Lambda'}$. For smooth $f$ of the active links of $\Lambda$,

$$\frac{d}{ds}\mu_s(f) = N\beta \sum_{p \in P(\Lambda')\setminus P(\Lambda)} \operatorname{Cov}_{\mu_s}(f, \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q^F_p),$$

and $|\nabla_e \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p| \le \|Q_p\|_{\mathrm{HS}} = \sqrt{N}$. A step in the graph of Lemma 6.7 moves a link by at most one lattice unit, so a plaquette at graph distance $k$ from the support $T$ of $f$ lies within distance $k+1$ of $T$, there are at most $C_T(k+1)^4$ of them, and every plaquette outside $P(\Lambda)$ is at graph distance at least $R-1$, $R$ the distance from $T$ to the complement of $\Lambda$. Lemma 6.7 gives

$$|\mu^F_{\Lambda'}(f) - \mu^F_\Lambda(f)| \le C_f R^4 e^{-\lambda R/2}.$$

The limit therefore exists along every increasing sequence of boxes, and two sequences are compared through their intersections, which are boxes. Continuous gauge-invariant $O$ are uniform limits of smooth gauge-invariant ones, for instance of $e^{\tau\Delta}O$, since the heat semigroup of $G^E$ commutes with left and right translations; with Lemma 3.1 the limit $\omega(O)$ of $W_\Lambda(O)$ exists for all of them.

*Properties.* Invariance and, for $\beta \ge 0$, reflection positivity follow as in Proposition 3.2(iii)–(iv). For Lipschitz $O$ the functions $e^{\tau\Delta}O$ are smooth with the same Lipschitz constant, since $\mathrm{Ric}_G \ge 0$ [4, Sect. 3.3], so the bound of the first step passes to $\omega$ and to Lipschitz observables. Two links of one plaquette have time coordinates that differ by at most one, so observables at time separation $t$ are at graph distance at least $t-c$, and truncated correlations decay at every rate below $m_G(\beta)$. The gap follows from Proposition F.1 as in Proposition 3.2(vi). □

*Proof of the rest of Theorem 1.4.* By Lemma 6.3 and Table 1, $\kappa_{\mathrm{SU}(N)} = \frac{N}{2}$ and $\kappa_{\mathrm{SO}(N)} = \frac{N-2}{4}$; for SO(4), whose Lie algebra is $\mathfrak{so}(3)\oplus\mathfrak{so}(3)$ acting on $\mathbb{R}^4\otimes\mathbb{C} = \mathbb{C}^2\otimes\mathbb{C}^2$, each ideal gives $\frac12$ by the same computation. The conditions of Theorem 1.4 are those of Theorem 1.5. □

*Remark* 6.8. Let $h_F$ be the supremum of $\pm\operatorname{Hess} S_0$ on the gauge-fixed directions, so that uniform curvature reaches $|\beta| < 1/(2h_F)$ and no further. At the identity field $-\operatorname{Hess} S_0$ restricted to $X_F = 0$ has the eigenvalue $9+\sqrt{17} = 13.123$ on the torus of side two, so $9+\sqrt{17} \le h_F \le \frac{29}{2}$. A gradient search over SU(2) fields of periods two, four and six gives $h_F = 13.97401$, attained by an abelian field; certificates made of plaquette forms and vertex forms on the period-two cell cannot go below 14.384. With this gauge the curvature method stops between $|\beta| = \frac{1}{29}$ and $\frac{1}{26.25}$.

## 7. SU(3) up to 3/4

In this section $G = \mathrm{SU}(3)$, $\beta \ge 0$ and $\beta_W = 9\beta$. The distance on SU(3) is $d(U,V) = \|U-V\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$, which is at most the geodesic distance for $\langle X, Y\rangle = -\operatorname{Tr}(XY)$; $K = \operatorname{conv}\mathrm{SU}(3)$; $A(M) = \frac12(M - M^*)$ and $P$ removes the trace. With this inner product $\mathrm{Ric} = \frac32$, the Casimir of the fundamental representation is $\lambda_F = \frac83$ and that of the adjoint representation is 6.

### 7.1. Reduction to one link.

The conditional law of an active link is

$$\nu_b(dU) \propto e^{\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)} dU, \qquad b = N\beta \sum_{p \ni e} S_p,$$

where $S_p$ is the staple of $e$ in $p$, a product of SU(3) matrices and identities, or its adjoint. Six staples give $b \in rK$ with $r = 6N\beta = 2\beta_W$. For a matrix $h$ put $\varphi_h(U) = \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Uh)$ and

$$L_h(b) = \sup\{\operatorname{Cov}_{\nu_b}(g, \varphi_h) : g \text{ 1-Lipschitz for } d\},$$
$$\Lambda(r) = \sup_{b \in rK} \sup_{\|h\|_{\mathrm{HS}}=1} L_h(b).$$

Changing a partner $e'$ changes one staple by a matrix of norm $d(Q_{e'}, Q'_{e'})$. Along the segment $b_t$ from $b$ to $b'$, which stays in $rK$, $\frac{d}{dt}\nu_{b_t}(g) = \operatorname{Cov}_{\nu_{b_t}}(g, \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(U(b' - b)))$, so $W_1(\nu_b, \nu_{b'}) \le N\beta\Lambda(r)\, d(Q_{e'}, Q'_{e'})$. With twelve partners per link,

$$\alpha \le 12N\beta\Lambda(r) = 2r\Lambda(r) = 4\beta_W\Lambda(2\beta_W). \tag{7.1}$$

Since $K$ is convex and contains 0, the mean of $I, \omega I, \omega^2 I$ with $\omega^3 = 1$, $r'K \subset rK$ for $r' \le r$ and $\Lambda$ is nondecreasing.

### 7.2. **Gradients and one-forms.**

**Lemma 7.1.** *In the left trivialisation, $\nabla\varphi_c(U) = -PA(cU)$; if $V = \varphi_b$ then* $\operatorname{Hess} V(X, X) = \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(UX^2 b)$*; and $\Delta\varphi_c = -\lambda_F\varphi_c$.*

*Proof.* $\frac{d}{dt}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ue^{tX}c)|_{t=0} = \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(cUX) = -\langle PA(cU), X\rangle$ for $X \in \mathfrak{su}(3)$. On a group with a bi-invariant metric $\nabla_X X = 0$ for left-invariant $X$, so the Hessian is the second derivative along $e^{tX}$. The function $\varphi_c$ is a matrix coefficient of the fundamental representation, on which the Casimir acts by $\lambda_F$. □

**Lemma 7.2.** *The bottom of the spectrum of the rough Laplacian $\nabla^*\nabla$ on $L^2$ one-forms of* SU(3) *is $\mu_0 = \frac{7}{6}$.*

*Proof.* Trivialise one-forms on the left, so that a one-form is a function $f : \mathrm{SU}(3) \to \mathfrak{su}(3)$. For an orthonormal basis $X_a$ acting as left-invariant vector fields, $\nabla_{X_a} Y = \frac{1}{2}[X_a, Y]$ and $\nabla_{X_a} X_a = 0$, so $\nabla^*\nabla = -\sum_a (\rho(X_a) + \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{ad} X_a)^2$. On the isotypic part $V_\pi \otimes V_\pi^* \otimes \mathfrak{su}(3)$ of $L^2 \otimes \mathfrak{su}(3)$ put $A_a = \rho_\pi(X_a)$, $B_a = \operatorname{ad} X_a$ and $T_a = A_a + B_a$, the action on the tensor product. Since $A_a$ and $B_a$ commute, $A_a + \frac{1}{2}B_a = \frac{1}{2}(A_a + T_a)$ and $A_aT_a + T_aA_a = A_a^2 + T_a^2 - B_a^2$, so on a component $\sigma \subset \pi \otimes \mathrm{ad}$

$$\nabla^*\nabla = \tfrac{1}{2}(C_\pi + C_\sigma) - \tfrac{1}{4}C_{\mathrm{ad}} = \tfrac{1}{2}(C_\pi + C_\sigma) - \tfrac{3}{2},$$

with $C(p, q) = \frac{2}{3}(p^2 + q^2 + pq + 3p + 3q)$ for the representation of highest weight $(p, q)$ [34]. The components of $(p, q) \otimes (1, 1)$ are $(p+1, q+1)$, $(p+2, q-1)$, $(p-1, q+2)$, $(p+1, q-2)$, $(p-2, q+1)$, $(p-1, q-1)$ and $(p, q)$, the last with multiplicity two, one or zero as both, one or none of $p, q$ are positive, and only those with nonnegative labels occur. For $\pi = (0, 0)$ the only component is $(1, 1)$, with value $\frac{3}{2}$. For $\pi = (1, 0)$ the components are $(2, 1)$, $(0, 2)$, $(1, 0)$, with values $\frac{31}{6}$, $\frac{19}{6}$, $\frac{7}{6}$, and $(0, 1)$ is conjugate. For $p + q \ge 2$ the smallest values occur at $(p-1, q-1)$, $(p, q)$, $(p-2, q+1)$ or $(p+1, q-2)$, and each is at least $\frac{1}{3}(2(p^2 + q^2 + pq) + 3(p + q) - 3) - \frac{3}{2} \ge \frac{3}{2}$. □

### 7.3. **The gap of the one-link measure.**

**Lemma 7.3.** *For $b \in rK$ the spectral gap of $L = \Delta + \langle\nabla V, \nabla\cdot\rangle$, $V = \varphi_b$, on $L^2(\nu_b)$ is at least*

$$\gamma(r) = \tfrac{39}{64}\mu_0 + \tfrac{3}{2} - \tfrac{r}{2} = \tfrac{283}{128} - \tfrac{r}{2}.$$

*Proof.* Let $-Lf = \lambda f$ with $\lambda > 0$, $\omega = df$ and $\eta = e^{V/2}\omega$; norms are in $L^2(dU)$. Bochner's formula integrated against $\nu_b$ gives $\lambda\nu_b|\omega|^2 = \nu_b|\nabla\omega|^2 + \nu_b((\mathrm{Ric} - \operatorname{Hess} V)(\omega, \omega))$, and since $e^{V/2}\nabla\omega = \nabla\eta - \frac{1}{2}dV \otimes \eta$,

$$\lambda\|\eta\|^2 = \|\nabla\eta - \tfrac{1}{2}dV \otimes \eta\|^2 + \int (\mathrm{Ric} - \operatorname{Hess} V)(\eta, \eta). \tag{7.2}$$

Put $\mathcal{A} = \nabla\eta$ and $\mathcal{B} = \frac{1}{2}dV \otimes \eta$. Then

$$\langle \mathcal{A}, \mathcal{B}\rangle = \tfrac{1}{4}\int \langle \nabla V, \nabla|\eta|^2\rangle = \tfrac{\lambda_F}{4}\int V|\eta|^2,$$

because $-\Delta V = \lambda_F V$. Writing $\|\mathcal{A}-\mathcal{B}\|^2 = \|\frac{5}{8}\mathcal{A}-\mathcal{B}\|^2 + \frac{39}{64}\|\mathcal{A}\|^2 - \frac{3}{4}\langle\mathcal{A},\mathcal{B}\rangle$ and dropping the first term,

$$\|\mathcal{A}-\mathcal{B}\|^2 \geq \tfrac{39}{64}\mu_0\|\eta\|^2 - \tfrac{1}{2}\int V|\eta|^2$$

by Lemma 7.2. With $\mathrm{Ric} = \frac{3}{2}$, (7.2) gives $\lambda\|\eta\|^2 \geq (\frac{39}{64}\mu_0 + \frac{3}{2})\|\eta\|^2 - \int(\mathrm{Hess}\, V(\eta,\eta) + \frac{1}{2}V|\eta|^2)$, and the claim follows from the pointwise bound

$$\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(MX^2) + \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\,M \leq \tfrac{r}{2}|X|^2, \qquad M = bU \in rK, \tag{7.3}$$

since $\mathrm{Hess}\, V(X,X) = \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(MX^2)$ and $V = \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\,M$. The maximum over $|X| = 1$ of the left side is convex in $M$, so it suffices to take $M = rW$ with $W \in \mathrm{SU}(3)$ and, after a conjugation, $W = \mathrm{diag}(e^{i\theta_k})$ with $\sum_k \theta_k = 0$; put $c_k = \cos\theta_k$. Write $X = iH$ with $H$ Hermitian, traceless, $\mathrm{Tr}\,H^2 = 1$, with diagonal $d_k$ and entries $H_{jk}$. Then

$$\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(WX^2) = -\sum_k c_k d_k^2 - \sum_{j<k}(c_j + c_k)|H_{jk}|^2,$$

with $\sum_k d_k^2 + 2\sum_{j<k}|H_{jk}|^2 = 1$, so the maximum is the larger of $q_{\mathrm{off}} = \max_{j<k} -\frac{1}{2}(c_j + c_k)$ and $q_{\mathrm{diag}} = \max\{-\sum c_k d_k^2 : \sum d_k = 0,\ \sum d_k^2 = 1\}$. If $l$ is the third index, $q_{\mathrm{off}} + \frac{1}{2}\sum_k c_k = \frac{1}{2}c_l \leq \frac{1}{2}$. The value $q_{\mathrm{diag}}$ is minus the smaller eigenvalue of $\mathrm{diag}(c)$ compressed to the plane $\sum d_k = 0$; the eigenvalues of the compression solve $\sum_k (c_k - \mu)^{-1} = 0$, that is $3\mu^2 - 2e_1\mu + e_2 = 0$ with $e_1, e_2$ the elementary symmetric functions of the $c_k$, so $q_{\mathrm{diag}} = \frac{1}{3}(\sqrt{e_1^2 - 3e_2} - e_1)$. The inequality $q_{\mathrm{diag}} + \frac{1}{2}e_1 \leq \frac{1}{2}$ is $\sqrt{e_1^2 - 3e_2} \leq \frac{1}{2}(3 - e_1)$, that is $e_1^2 - 4e_2 + 2e_1 - 3 \leq 0$. When $\sum\theta_k = 0$, $\sum c_k^2 = 1 + 2c_1c_2c_3$, and with this identity the left side equals $-2(1-c_1)(1-c_2)(1-c_3) \leq 0$. □

The weight $\frac{5}{8}$ is the one that gives the coefficient $\frac{1}{2}$ of $V$, and (7.3) is an equality at $W = I$. At $r = \frac{3}{2}$, $\gamma = \frac{187}{128}$.[12]

### 7.4. **A corrector of degree two.**

**Lemma 7.4.** *For $b \in rK$, $\|h\| = 1$ and every smooth real function $u$ on* $\mathrm{SU}(3)$,

$$L_h(b) \leq \sqrt{\nu_b|\nabla u|^2} + \sqrt{\mathrm{Var}_{\nu_b}(\varphi_h + Lu)/\gamma(r)}.$$

*Proof.* Let $-L\psi = \varphi_h - \nu_b\varphi_h$. For a 1-Lipschitz $g$, $|\nabla g| \leq 1$ almost everywhere, because $d$ is at most the geodesic distance, so $\mathrm{Cov}(g,\varphi_h) = \nu_b\langle\nabla g, \nabla\psi\rangle \leq \nu_b|\nabla\psi|$. Write $\psi = u + \chi$. Since $\nu_b(Lu) = 0$, $\chi$ solves $-L\chi = X - \nu_b X$ with $X = \varphi_h + Lu$, and

$$\nu_b|\nabla\chi|^2 = \mathrm{Cov}(\chi, X) \leq \sqrt{\mathrm{Var}\,\chi\ \mathrm{Var}\,X} \leq \sqrt{\nu_b|\nabla\chi|^2\,\mathrm{Var}\,X/\gamma}$$

by Lemma 7.3. Hence $\nu_b|\nabla\chi|^2 \leq \mathrm{Var}\,X/\gamma$, and $\nu_b|\nabla\psi| \leq \sqrt{\nu_b|\nabla u|^2} + \sqrt{\nu_b|\nabla\chi|^2}$. □

The best $u$ is $\psi$ itself, and then the second term vanishes. With $u = s\varphi_h$, Lemma 7.1 gives $\varphi_h + Lu = (1 - s\lambda_F)\varphi_h + s\Gamma$ with $\Gamma = \langle\nabla V, \nabla\varphi_h\rangle$; the choice $s = 1/\lambda_F$ removes $\varphi_h$ and leaves the drift. This blended corrector reaches $\beta_W = \frac{45}{64}$ and stops near 0.715 (Section 9). We take $u$ in a space of polynomials of degree two.

Let $\mathcal{P}_2$ be the real vector space of real polynomials of degree one or two in the entries $u_{ij}$ of $U$ and $\bar{u}_{ij}$ of $\bar{U}$. It has dimension 189: a basis $(B_k)$ consists of $\frac{1}{2}(m + \bar{m})$ and $\frac{1}{2i}(m - \bar{m})$ for each pair $\{m, \bar{m}\}$ of conjugate monomials with $m \neq \bar{m}$, and $m$ itself when $m = \bar{m}$.

[12] The direct Bochner bound, with Minkowski's inequality in place of the cross term, gives $(\sqrt{\mu_0} - \frac{g}{2}r)^2 + \frac{3}{2} - r$ with $g^2 = \max_W \|PA(W)\|^2 = 2.0655$; it is exact at $b = 0$, where the gap is $\frac{8}{3}$, but falls below $\gamma$ for $r > 0.24$ and vanishes before $r = 1$.

Identify $h \in \mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$ with $\mathbb{R}^{18}$ through the real and imaginary parts of its entries. For a real $189 \times 18$ matrix $C$ put

$$q_h = \sum_{k} \sum_{m=1}^{18} C_{km} h_m B_k \in \mathcal{P}_2,$$

linear in $h$. For diagonal $b = \operatorname{diag}(a_1, a_2, x_3 + iy_3)$ we have $V = \sum_k b_k \varphi_{F_k}$ with $(b_k) = (a_1, a_2, x_3, y_3)$ and $F = (e_{11}, e_{22}, e_{33}, ie_{33})$, so

$$X_h = \varphi_h + L q_h = \varphi_h + \Delta q_h + \sum_k b_k \langle \nabla \varphi_{F_k}, \nabla q_h \rangle \tag{7.4}$$

is a polynomial of degree at most three, affine in $b$, while $\nabla q_h$ does not depend on $b$. The squares of these functions have degree at most six, so the quadratic forms $h \mapsto \nu_b |\nabla q_h|^2$ and $h \mapsto \nu_b[(X_h - \kappa)^2]$ are combinations of moments of $\nu_b$ of degree at most six.

To compute $\Delta$ and $\langle \nabla f, \nabla g \rangle$ exactly we use the basis of $\mathfrak{su}(3)$

$$e_{jk} - e_{kj}, \quad i(e_{jk} + e_{kj}) \ (j < k), \quad i(e_{11} - e_{22}), \quad i(e_{11} + e_{22} - 2e_{33}),$$

acting as left-invariant fields $X_a f(U) = \frac{d}{dt} f(U e^{t X_a})|_{t=0}$, with weights $w_a = \frac{1}{2}$ for the first seven and $\frac{1}{6}$ for the last. Then $\sum_a w_a X_a \otimes X_a$ is the Casimir tensor of $\langle X, Y \rangle = -\operatorname{Tr}(XY)$, so

$$\langle \nabla f, \nabla g \rangle = \sum_a w_a \, X_a f \, X_a g, \qquad \Delta = \sum_a w_a X_a^2.$$

The fields map monomials to combinations of monomials of the same degree with coefficients in $\mathbb{Z}[i]$; for instance $\Delta \varphi_h = -\frac{8}{3} \varphi_h$, as in Lemma 7.1.

### 7.5. **Orbits of staple sums.**

**Lemma 7.5.** *Let $V, W \in \mathrm{SU}(3)$.*

(i) *$L_h(VbW) = L_{V^{-1} h W^{-1}}(b)$ and $L_h(\bar{b}) = L_{\bar{h}}(b)$.*
(ii) *Every $b \in \mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$ is in the orbit of some $\operatorname{diag}(a_1, a_2, z_3)$ with $a_1 \geq a_2 \geq |z_3|$ and $\operatorname{Im} z_3 \geq 0$.*
(iii) *A diagonal matrix lies in $K$ if and only if it lies in the convex hull of the diagonal torus $T$ of $\mathrm{SU}(3)$.*

*Proof.* (i) If $U$ has law $\nu_{VbW}$ then $WUV$ has law $\nu_b$; the map preserves $d$ and Haar measure, and $\varphi_h(U) = \varphi_{V^{-1} h W^{-1}}(WUV)$. For $\bar{b}$ use $U \mapsto \bar{U}$. (ii) Take a singular value decomposition $b = V_1 \Sigma W_1$ and move the determinants of $V_1, W_1$ into the last entry; a complex conjugation makes $\operatorname{Im} z_3 \geq 0$. (iii) Let $c$ be diagonal with nonzero entries of distinct moduli and let $U$ maximise $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(cU)$ on $\mathrm{SU}(3)$. The derivative along $\mathfrak{su}(3)$ vanishes, so the anti-Hermitian part of $cU$ is a multiple $i\lambda I$ of the identity and $cU = H + i\lambda I$ with $H$ Hermitian. Then $H^2 + \lambda^2 I = cc^*$ is diagonal with distinct entries, $H$ commutes with it and is diagonal, and $U \in T$. Hence $\max_{\mathrm{SU}(3)} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(cU) = \max_T \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(ct)$ for such $c$, and by continuity for every diagonal $c$. A diagonal matrix outside $\operatorname{conv} T$ is separated from it by such a functional, which then separates it from $K$. □

Since every $b \in rK$ has operator norm at most $r$,

$$\Lambda(r) = \sup\Big\{ \sup_{\|h\|=1} L_h(b) : b \in \mathcal{R}_r \Big\},$$

where $\mathcal{R}_r$ is the set of $\operatorname{diag}(a_1, a_2, x_3 + iy_3) \in r \operatorname{conv} T$ with $a_1 \geq a_2 \geq |x_3 + iy_3|$ and $y_3 \geq 0$, a subset of the box $[0, r]^2 \times [-r, r] \times [0, r]$ in the coordinates $(a_1, a_2, x_3, y_3)$.

7.6. **Exact moments and interpolation.**

**Lemma 7.6.** *For $D, D' \in \mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$ let $\mathbb{E}_H$ be the Haar mean on* $\mathrm{SU}(3)$ *and*

$$Z(D,D') = \mathbb{E}_H \exp\big(\tfrac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(UD) + \tfrac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(\bar{U}D')\big).$$

*Then*

$$Z(D,D') = \sum_{p\ge q\ge 0} \frac{s_{(p,q)}(DD'^{\top})\, G_{p,q}(\det D)\, G_{p,q}(\det D')}{d_{p,q}},$$

*with $G_{p,q}(z) = \sum_{k\ge 0} c_{(p+k,q+k,k)} z^k$, $c_\lambda = 2^{-|\lambda|}/\prod \mathrm{hooks}(\lambda)$, $d_{p,q} = \frac{1}{2}(p-q+1)(q+1)(p+2)$ and $s_{(p,q)}$ the Schur polynomial. The moments of degree $j$ in $U$ and $k$ in $\bar{U}$ are $\mathbb{E}_H[u^\alpha \bar{u}^\beta e^{\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)}] = 2^{|\alpha|+|\beta|}\partial_D^\alpha \partial_{D'}^\beta Z(b,\bar{b})$, the entry $u_{ij}$ pairing with $D_{ji}$.*

*Proof.* We use $(\operatorname{Tr} X)^n = \sum_{\lambda\vdash n} f^\lambda s_\lambda(X)$, where $f^\lambda$ is the number of standard tableaux of shape $\lambda$, given by the hook length formula [71, Cor. 7.21.6]. Expanding the exponential gives

$$e^{\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} X} = \sum_{n\ge 0} \frac{(\operatorname{Tr} X)^n}{2^n n!} = \sum_\lambda c_\lambda s_\lambda(X),$$

the sum over partitions with at most three parts. For $U \in \mathrm{SU}(3)$ one has $s_{\lambda+(k,k,k)}(UD) = (\det D)^k s_\lambda(UD)$, so

$$e^{\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(UD)} = \sum_{p\ge q} G_{p,q}(\det D)\, \chi_{p,q}(UD),$$

where $\chi_{p,q}$ is the irreducible character of highest weight $(p,q,0)$ and $d_{p,q}$ its dimension. Since $\bar{U} = (U^{-1})^\top$, we have $\chi_{p,q}(\bar{U}D') = \chi_{p,q}(U^{-1}D'^{\top})$, and Schur orthogonality [22, Ch. 2],

$$\mathbb{E}_H\big[\chi_\rho(UA)\chi_{\rho'}(U^{-1}B)\big] = \delta_{\rho\rho'}\frac{\chi_\rho(AB)}{d_\rho},$$

gives the expansion. The bound below gives absolute convergence. Finally $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub) = \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub) + \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr}(\bar{U}\bar{b})$. □

The computation keeps $p \le 34$ and $k \le 11$. Every omitted partition has more than 34 boxes, and since $|s_\lambda(X)| \le \dim(\lambda)\|X\|^{|\lambda|}$ and $\sum_{\lambda\vdash n} f^\lambda \dim\lambda = 3^n$ by Schur–Weyl duality, the omitted part of each factor is at most $\sum_{n>34}(\frac{3}{2}\|D\|)^n/n!$; Cauchy's estimate on a polydisc around $b$ turns this into a bound for every derivative (Appendix E).

**Lemma 7.7** (Interpolation on a box)**.** *Let $Q = \prod_k [l_k, l_k + w_k]$ in the coordinates $(a_1, a_2, x_3, y_3)$, with corners $b_i$ and multilinear weights $\omega_i(b) \ge 0$, $\sum_i \omega_i(b) = 1$, and let $\varsigma = w_1^2 + w_2^2 + \max(w_3^2, w_4^2)$. For $b \in Q$:*

(i) *$Z(b) \ge e^{-\varsigma/8}\sum_i \omega_i(b) Z(b_i)$;*
(ii) *$\nu_b(f) \le e^{\varsigma/8}\max_i \nu_{b_i}(f)$ for every $f \ge 0$ that does not depend on $b$;*
(iii) *if $Y_b = (\mathcal{A} + \sum_k (b_k - \beta_k)\mathcal{B}_k)^2$ with functions $\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{B}_k$ of $U$ and a fixed point $\beta$, then*

$$\nu_b(Y_b) \le e^{\varsigma/8}\Big(\max_i \nu_{b_i}(Y_{b_i}) + \sum_k \frac{w_k^2}{4}\,\frac{\max_i Z(b_i)\nu_{b_i}(\mathcal{B}_k^2)}{\min_i Z(b_i)}\Big).$$

*Proof.* Write $E(b) = e^{\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)} = \prod_k e^{c_k b_k}$, where

$$c = (\operatorname{Re} u_{11}, \operatorname{Re} u_{22}, \operatorname{Re} u_{33}, -\operatorname{Im} u_{33}),$$

so that $|c_k| \le 1$ and $c_3^2 + c_4^2 \le 1$. In each coordinate the chord of $e^{c_k x}$ over $[l_k, l_k + w_k]$ lies above the function and, by Hoeffding's lemma [45] for a two-point variable, below $e^{c_k x} e^{c_k^2 w_k^2/8}$. Multiplying,

$$E(b) \le \sum_i \omega_i(b) E(b_i) \le E(b)\, e^{\sum_k c_k^2 w_k^2/8} \le E(b)\, e^{\varsigma/8}. \tag{7.5}$$

Integrating the right inequality gives (i), and (ii) follows from the left one and (i). For (iii) let $\mathcal{F}(b) = Y_b E(b)$ and $I_k$ the linear interpolation in the $k$-th coordinate, so that $\mathcal{F} - I_1 I_2 I_3 I_4 \mathcal{F} = \sum_k I_1 \cdots I_{k-1}(\mathcal{F} - I_k \mathcal{F})$. Along the $k$-th coordinate $\mathcal{F}$ is $\ell^2 e^{c_k x}$ times a positive factor, with $\ell$ affine of slope $\mathcal{B}_k$, and $\partial_k^2 \mathcal{F} = ((c_k \ell + 2\mathcal{B}_k)^2 - 2\mathcal{B}_k^2)E \geq -2\mathcal{B}_k^2 E$. With the Green kernel of the interval, whose integral is at most $w_k^2/8$,

$$\mathcal{F} - I_k \mathcal{F} \leq 2\mathcal{B}_k^2 \int G\, E \leq \tfrac{w_k^2}{4} \mathcal{B}_k^2 \sum_i \omega_i^{(k)} E(b_i)$$

by the left inequality of (7.5), with weights $\omega_i^{(k)} \geq 0$ of sum one that do not depend on $U$. The operators $I_j$ have nonnegative weights of sum one; integrate over $U$ and divide by $Z(b)$, bounded below by (i). □

7.7. **The cover and the theorem.** Fix a box $Q$ and a matrix $C$. For any constant $\kappa$, $\operatorname{Var}(X_h) \leq \nu_b[(X_h - \kappa)^2]$; take $\kappa = \langle \kappa(b), h \rangle$ with $\kappa(b)$ affine in $b$, fitted to the means at the corners. By (7.4), $X_h - \kappa = \mathcal{A} + \sum_k (b_k - \beta_k)\mathcal{B}_k$ with $\beta$ the centre of $Q$ and $\mathcal{B}_k = \langle \nabla \varphi_{F_k}, \nabla q_h \rangle - \langle \partial_k \kappa, h \rangle$, and Lemmas 7.4 and 7.7 give, for all $b \in Q \cap \mathcal{R}_r$,

$$\begin{aligned} \sup_h L_h(b) \leq{}& \sqrt{e^{\varsigma/8} \max_i \lambda_A(b_i)} \\ &+ \sqrt{\frac{e^{\varsigma/8}}{\gamma(r)} \Big( \max_i \lambda_V(b_i) + \frac{e_N}{\min_i Z(b_i)} \Big)}, \end{aligned} \tag{7.6}$$

where $e_N = \sum_k \frac{w_k^2}{4} \max_i Z(b_i) \lambda_k(b_i)$ and $\lambda_A$, $\lambda_V$, $\lambda_k$ are the largest eigenvalues of the quadratic forms $h \mapsto \nu_{b_i} |\nabla q_h|^2$, $h \mapsto \nu_{b_i}[(X_h - \kappa)^2]$ at $b = b_i$, and $h \mapsto \nu_{b_i}[\mathcal{B}_k^2]$ on $\mathbb{R}^{18}$. Their entries are moments of $\nu_{b_i}$ of degree at most six, computed with rigorous error bounds (Appendix E); each largest eigenvalue is bounded above by an $LDL^\top$ factorisation of $tI$ minus the computed form with certified positive pivots, plus the norm of its error matrix by Weyl's inequality [43, 48].

The matrix $C$ is chosen in each box in floating point. At the mean of the corner moments and at $b = \beta$, Lemma 7.4 for $u = q_h$ is a quadratic problem in $C$: for $\theta > 0$ we minimise the trace of $\nu |\nabla q|^2 + \theta \operatorname{Var}(X)/\gamma$ over the 18 coordinate directions $h$, a least-squares problem of size 189, keep the $\theta$ on a geometric grid of 48 values from 0.05 to 80 that gives the smallest bound, and round $C$ to multiples of $2^{-30}$. Any choice gives a valid bound.

A box is discarded when it contains no point with $a_1 \geq a_2 \geq |z_3|$, or when a linear functional $\ell(b) = \operatorname{Re} \operatorname{Tr}(c^* b)$ satisfies $\min_Q \ell > r \max_T \ell$, which separates it from $r \operatorname{conv} T$ and hence, by Lemma 7.5(iii), from $\mathcal{R}_r$.

**Proposition 7.8.** *$2r\Lambda(r) \leq 0.999887$ at $r = \frac{3}{2}$.*

*Proof.* The box $[0, r]^2 \times [-r, r] \times [0, r]$ is cut into 8192 boxes of side $r/8$. Of these, 841 survive the two tests, and 581 satisfy $2rB_Q < 1$ for the right side $B_Q$ of (7.6), with $\gamma(r) = \frac{187}{128}$. Each of the other 260 is cut into sixteen boxes of side $r/16$; 1760 of these survive the tests, and all satisfy $2rB_Q < 1$. The 2341 certified boxes cover $\mathcal{R}_r$. The largest bound is 0.999887, on the box $[1.3125, 1.5] \times [0.9375, 1.125] \times [0.5625, 0.75] \times [0, 0.1875]$, and the median is 0.983. Figure 6 shows the cover, and Appendix E the error analysis. □

The same cover at a larger $r$ bounds $\Lambda(r)$ where $2r\Lambda(r)$ is no longer below one; the plaquette blocks of Section 8 use that bound.

**Proposition 7.9.** *$2r\Lambda(r) \leq 1.029967$ at $r = \frac{38}{25}$.*

*Proof.* As in the proof of Proposition 7.8, with $\gamma(r) = \frac{4643}{3200}$ and the threshold $2rB_Q < 1.03$: of the 8192 boxes of side $r/8$, 784 survive the two tests and 690 satisfy the threshold; each of the other 94 is cut into sixteen boxes of side $r/16$, of which 373 survive the tests, and all satisfy it. The 1063 certified boxes cover $\mathcal{R}_r$, and the largest bound is 1.029967. □

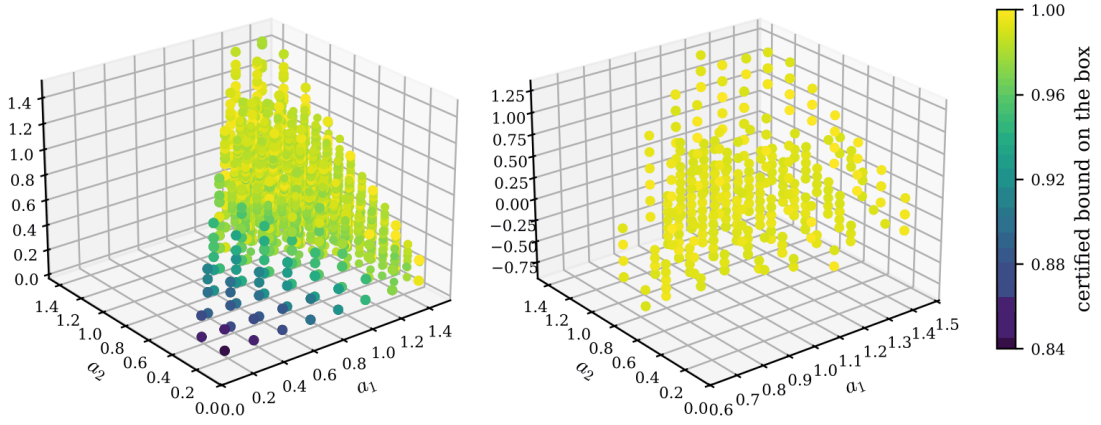



FIGURE 6. The 2341 certified boxes at $r = \frac{3}{2}$, plotted at their centres in the coordinates $(a_1, a_2)$ of the staple sum $\mathrm{diag}(a_1, a_2, x_3 + iy_3)$, coloured by the certified bound on $2r \sup_h L_h$ over the box; the larger points are the boxes of side $r/8$. (a) All boxes, with height $|x_3 + iy_3|$. (b) The 419 boxes with bound above 0.99, with height $x_3$; the largest bounds sit in the interior of $\mathcal{R}_r$, not at its extreme points.

*Proof of Theorem 1.6.* Proposition 7.8 gives

$$\Lambda\big(\tfrac{3}{2}\big) \le \frac{0.999887}{3} < 0.333296.$$

For $\beta_W \le \frac{3}{4}$ we have $2\beta_W \le \frac{3}{2}$, and (7.1) with the monotonicity of $\Lambda$ gives

$$\alpha \le 4\beta_W \Lambda\big(\tfrac{3}{2}\big) < 1.333183\,\beta_W \le \tfrac{3}{4} \cdot 1.333183 < 1.$$

Proposition 3.2 applies with the Hilbert–Schmidt metric. □

## 8. SU(3) WITH PLAQUETTE BLOCKS

In this section $G = \mathrm{SU}(3)$, $\beta \ge 0$, $\beta_W = 9\beta$, $N\beta = \beta_W/3$, and the notation is that of Section 7: $d$ is the Hilbert–Schmidt distance, $K = \mathrm{conv}\,\mathrm{SU}(3)$, $\nu_c(dU) \propto e^{\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(Uc)}dU$, $\varphi_h(U) = \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(Uh)$ and $\Lambda(r)$ is the modulus of (7.1). Put $Z(c) = \int e^{\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(Uc)}dU$ and $g = \log Z$ on $\mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$, viewed as $\mathbb{R}^{18}$ with the inner product $\langle x, y\rangle = \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(xy^*)$. The gradient of $g$ at $c$ is the conjugate mean $m(c)^*$, $m(c) = \nu_c(U) \in K$, and $\mathrm{Hess}\, g(c)(h,h) = \mathrm{Var}_{\nu_c}(\varphi_h)$. Since $Z(VcW) = Z(c)$ for $V, W \in \mathrm{SU}(3)$, the same holds for $g$.

The blocks are those of Lemma 5.1, which concerns the line field only and holds for every group. For a block plaquette with active links $e_1, e_2, e_3$, $\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\,Q_p = \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(y_1y_2y_3)$ with $y_i = Q_{e_i}$ or $Q_{e_i}^{-1}$, and the conditional law of the block is

$$\mu_b(dy) \propto \exp\Big(\sum_i \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(y_i b_i) + N\beta\,\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}(y_1y_2y_3)\Big)dy, \tag{8.1}$$

where $b_i$ is $N\beta$ times the sum of the five staples of $y_i$ outside the block plaquette, so $b_i \in 5N\beta K$ and $\|b_i\|_{\mathrm{op}} \le 5N\beta$. On $\mathrm{SU}(3)^3$ we use $d(y, y') = \sum_i \|y_i - y_i'\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$.

8.1. **The sensitivity of one block.** Let $r = 2\beta_W = 6N\beta$. Let $\lambda_*$ and $\tau$ be a lower and an upper bound for the eigenvalues of $\operatorname{Hess} g$ on $rK$, $M$ an upper bound on $rK$ for $|D^3 g(c)(u,v,v)|$ over unit vectors $u, v$, and $\gamma = \gamma(r)$ the gap of Lemma 7.3. Put

$$w = \tfrac{3}{2}(N\beta)^2(\tau - \lambda_*), \qquad s = \Lambda(r) + (e^w - 1)e^w\sqrt{\tau/\gamma},$$
$$C = 5(N\beta)^2\Big(\tau s + \frac{\sqrt{3}\,N\beta\,M\,e^w}{\gamma}\Big), \tag{8.2}$$
$$K_3 = \frac{(1 + N\beta\Lambda(r))\,s}{1 - C}, \qquad \alpha_3 = 10N\beta K_3,$$

assuming $C < 1$.

**Lemma 8.1.** *Let $a, c_0 \in 5N\beta K$ and*

$$\kappa(dx) \propto \exp\big(\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(xa) + g(c_0 + N\beta x)\big)dx \quad \text{on } \mathrm{SU}(3).$$

*For every 1-Lipschitz $f$ and every $h \in \mathbb{C}^{3\times 3}$:*

(i) $\operatorname{Cov}_\kappa(f, \varphi_h) \le s\|h\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$;

(ii) *if $c_0$ moves in the direction $k$ inside $5N\beta K$, then*

$$\big|\tfrac{d}{dt}\kappa(f)\big| \le N\beta(\tau s + \sqrt{3}N\beta M e^w/\gamma)\|k\|_{\mathrm{HS}}.$$

*Proof.* (i) The segment from $c_0$ to $c_0 + N\beta x$ lies in $6N\beta K = rK$, and Taylor's formula gives

$$g(c_0 + N\beta x) = g(c_0) + N\beta \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(x\, m(c_0)) + R(x)$$

with $R(x) = \frac{1}{2}(N\beta)^2 \operatorname{Hess} g(\xi)(x,x)$. Since $\|x\|_{\mathrm{HS}}^2 = 3$, $R \in [\frac{3}{2}(N\beta)^2\lambda_*, \frac{3}{2}(N\beta)^2\tau]$ and $\operatorname{osc} R \le w$. Hence $\kappa$ is the tilt $e^R\nu/\nu(e^R)$ of $\nu = \nu_{c'}$ with $c' = a + N\beta m(c_0) \in rK$. By definition of $\Lambda$, $\operatorname{Cov}_\nu(f, \varphi_h) \le \Lambda(r)\|h\|$. The function $f$ is 1-Lipschitz for the geodesic distance, which dominates $d$, so $\operatorname{sd}_\nu f \le \gamma^{-1/2}$ by Lemma 7.3, and $\operatorname{sd}_\nu \varphi_h \le \sqrt{\tau}\|h\|$. Lemma 5.2 gives (i).

(ii) The derivative is $\operatorname{Cov}_\kappa(f, \langle \nabla g(c_0 + N\beta x), k\rangle)$. Write $\nabla g(c_0 + N\beta u) = \nabla g(c_0) + N\beta \operatorname{Hess} g(c_0)u + N(u)$. The linear term is $\varphi_h$ with $\|h\| \le N\beta\tau\|k\|$ and contributes at most $N\beta\tau s\|k\|$ by (i). On the segment from $c_0$ the Hessian moves by at most $N\beta M\|u\| \le \sqrt{3}N\beta M$, so $x \mapsto \langle N(x), k\rangle$ is $\sqrt{3}(N\beta)^2 M\|k\|$-Lipschitz for $d$. The law $\kappa$ is a tilt of $\nu$ by a function of oscillation at most $w$, so its spectral gap is at least $e^{-w}\gamma$ by the Holley–Stroock lemma [44], and the covariance of two Lipschitz functions under $\kappa$ is at most $e^w/\gamma$ times the product of their constants. □

**Lemma 8.2.** *Let $C < 1$. If $b, b'$ have all fields in $5N\beta K$ and differ only in $b_i$, then $W_1(\mu_b, \mu_{b'}) \le K_3\|b_i - b_i'\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$ for the metric $d$.*

*Proof.* By the cyclic symmetry of $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(y_1y_2y_3)$ we may take $i = 1$. Given $y_1, y_3$, the law of $y_2$ is $\nu_c$ with $c = b_2 + N\beta y_3 y_1 \in rK$. Changing $y_1$ by $\eta$ in $d$ moves $c$ by $N\beta\eta$ and $\nu_c$ by at most $N\beta\Lambda(r)\eta$ in $W_1$, as in (7.1); so $F(y_1, y_3) = \mathbb{E}[f \mid y_1, y_3]$ is $(1 + N\beta\Lambda(r))$-Lipschitz in each variable. The law of $(y_1, y_3)$ is proportional to $e^{\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(y_1b_1) + \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(y_3b_3)}Z(b_2 + N\beta y_3 y_1)$, and $Z(b_2 + N\beta y_3 y_1) = Z(y_3^{-1}b_2 + N\beta y_1) = Z(b_2y_1^{-1} + N\beta y_3)$, so its two conditional laws have the form of Lemma 8.1, with $c_0 = y_3^{-1}b_2$ and $c_0 = b_2y_1^{-1}$. Moving $y_3$ to $y_3'$ moves $y_3^{-1}b_2$ along a segment in $5N\beta K$ of length at most $\|b_2\|_{\mathrm{op}}\|y_3 - y_3'\| \le 5N\beta\|y_3 - y_3'\|$. The coupling argument of Lemma 5.4 now gives $d_1 \le s\varepsilon + Cd_3$, $d_3 \le Cd_1$ and $|\mu_b(f) - \mu_{b'}(f)| \le (1 + N\beta\Lambda(r))(d_1 + d_3) \le K_3\varepsilon$. □

8.2. **The constants and the proof of Theorem 1.7.**

**Lemma 8.3.** *At $r = \frac{3}{2}$ every eigenvalue of $\operatorname{Hess} g$ on $rK$ lies in $[0.056015, 0.247316]$, and $|D^3 g(c)(u,v,v)| \le 0.182126$ for $c \in rK$ and unit vectors $u, v$. At $r = \frac{38}{25}$ the same holds with $[0.054978, 0.248280]$ and $0.183546$.*

*Proof.* For $V, W \in \mathrm{SU}(3)$, $g(VcW) = g(c)$ and $x \mapsto VxW$ is an isometry, so the eigenvalues of $\operatorname{Hess} g$ and the norm of $D^3 g$ are constant on the orbits, and by Lemma 7.5 it suffices to bound them on $\mathcal{R}_r$. The derivatives of $g$ are the cumulants of $\varphi$ under $\nu_c$. Cut the box $[0,r]^2 \times [-r,r] \times [0,r]$ into boxes of side $r/8$ and keep the 841 (784 at $r = \frac{38}{25}$) that survive the two tests of Section 7.7. On each box $Q$ we compute, with rigorous error bounds, the moments of $\varphi$ of degree at most three at the sixteen corners $b_i$ and at the centre $b_0$, and put $k = m(b_0)$, the mean of $\varphi$ at the centre.

*Upper bound.* For $b \in Q$ and every $h$, $\operatorname{Var}_{\nu_b}(\varphi_h) \le \nu_b[(\varphi_h - \langle k, h\rangle)^2] \le e^{\varsigma/8} \max_i \nu_{b_i}[(\varphi_h - \langle k, h\rangle)^2]$ by Lemma 7.7(ii).

*Lower bound.* Integrating the right inequality of (7.5) against $f \ge 0$ and dividing by $Z(b) \le \sum_i \omega_i Z(b_i)$, the left one, gives $\nu_b(f) \ge e^{-\varsigma/8} \min_i \nu_{b_i}(f)$. With $f = (\varphi_h - \nu_b\varphi_h)^2$ this gives $\operatorname{Var}_{\nu_b}(\varphi_h) \ge e^{-\varsigma/8} \min_i \operatorname{Var}_{\nu_{b_i}}(\varphi_h)$.

*Third cumulant.* Put $\delta = m(b) - k$. The mean value theorem and the upper bound give $\|\delta\| \le \tau\rho + e$, with $\rho$ the largest distance from $b_0$ in $Q$ and $e$ the error of the computed mean. Expanding the central moment about $k$,

$$\begin{aligned} D^3 g(b)(u,v,v) = T_b(u,v,v) - \delta_u \operatorname{Var}(\varphi_v) \\ - 2\delta_v \operatorname{Cov}(\varphi_u, \varphi_v) - \delta_u \delta_v^2, \end{aligned}$$

with $T_b = \nu_b[(\varphi - k)^{\otimes 3}]$, $\delta_u = \langle \delta, u\rangle$ and the moments under $\nu_b$. For a function $G$ of either sign, writing $G = G^+ - G^-$ and applying the two bounds above to $G^\pm$ gives $|\nu_b(G)| \le (\max_i |\nu_{b_i}(G)| + \varepsilon \max_i \nu_{b_i}|G|)/(1-\varepsilon)$ with $\varepsilon = 1 - e^{-\varsigma/8}$. For $G = (\varphi_u - k_u)(\varphi_v - k_v)^2$ we use $|\nu_{b_i}(G)| \le \|T_{b_i}\|$, the largest singular value of the $18 \times 324$ unfolding of $T_{b_i}$, and $\nu_{b_i}|G| \le 2\sqrt{3}\, \nu_{b_i}[(\varphi_v - k_v)^2]$, since $\|U - k\|_{\mathrm{HS}} \le 2\sqrt{3}$. The largest eigenvalues and singular values are bounded as in Section 7.7, and the maxima over these boxes are the numbers stated (Appendix C). □

*Proof of Theorem 1.7.* Let first $\beta_W \le \frac{3}{4}$, so that $r = 2\beta_W \le \frac{3}{2}$. Every field met in Lemmas 8.1 and 8.2 lies in $\frac{3}{2}K$, so the constants of Lemma 8.3 at $\frac{3}{2}$, $\Lambda(\frac{3}{2}) \le \frac{0.999887}{3}$ from Proposition 7.8 and $\gamma = \gamma(\frac{3}{2}) = \frac{187}{128}$ apply; with these fixed constants every quantity in (8.2) is increasing in $\beta_W$. For $\frac{3}{4} < \beta_W \le \frac{19}{25}$ the fields lie in $\frac{38}{25}K$, and the constants of Lemma 8.3 at $\frac{38}{25}$, $\Lambda(\frac{38}{25}) \le \frac{1.029967}{3.04}$ from Proposition 7.9 and $\gamma(\frac{38}{25}) = \frac{4643}{3200}$ apply in the same way. Changing an active link $j$ by $\eta$ changes one staple of each of its ten partners outside its block by a matrix of norm $\eta$, so the field $b_i$ of each such partner moves by $N\beta\eta$, and Lemma 8.2 gives $\sum_B C_{Bj} \le 10N\beta K_3 = \alpha_3(\beta_W)$. In ball arithmetic, at $\beta_W = \frac{3}{4}$, $w \le 0.017935$, $s \le 0.34088$, $C \le 0.043520$, $K_3 \le 0.38609$ and $\alpha_3 \le 0.96521$; at $\beta_W = 0.72$, $\alpha_3 \le 0.91815$; at $\beta_W = 0.76$, with the second set of constants, $w \le 0.018609$, $s \le 0.34673$, $C \le 0.045770$, $K_3 \le 0.39454$ and $\alpha_3 \le 0.99950$. Proposition 5.6, whose proof does not use the group, applies with the Hilbert–Schmidt metric. □

*Remark* 8.4. Theorem 1.6 ends where $2r\Lambda(r)$ reaches one. The blocks remove the factor $\frac{12}{10}$ of the single-link sum and keep most of it after paying for the three links: at $\beta_W = \frac{3}{4}$ the gap bound rises from $1.1 \cdot 10^{-4}$ to 0.0177, and the block bound is the better one for $\beta_W \ge 0.715$. Before the corrections for the three links their sum is $\frac{10}{12}$ of the single-link sum $2r\Lambda(r)$, so it can stay below one while $2r\Lambda(r)$ is slightly above one; Proposition 7.9 certifies $2r\Lambda(r) \le 1.03$ at $r = 1.52$, which is enough at $\beta_W = 0.76$, with little room. Evaluated in floating point with the constants of a scan of $\mathcal{R}_r$, the block sum stays below one up to $\beta_W \approx 0.78$; that computation is not certified and is not used.

## 9. Where the methods stop

SU(2). Theorem 1.2 closes the single-link route in every forest gauge at $\beta_W = \frac{1}{3}$. Blocks of several links, where the influence of a boundary link on a whole block is bounded at once, in the spirit of the Dobrushin–Shlosman criterion [31], pass it: plaquette blocks reach

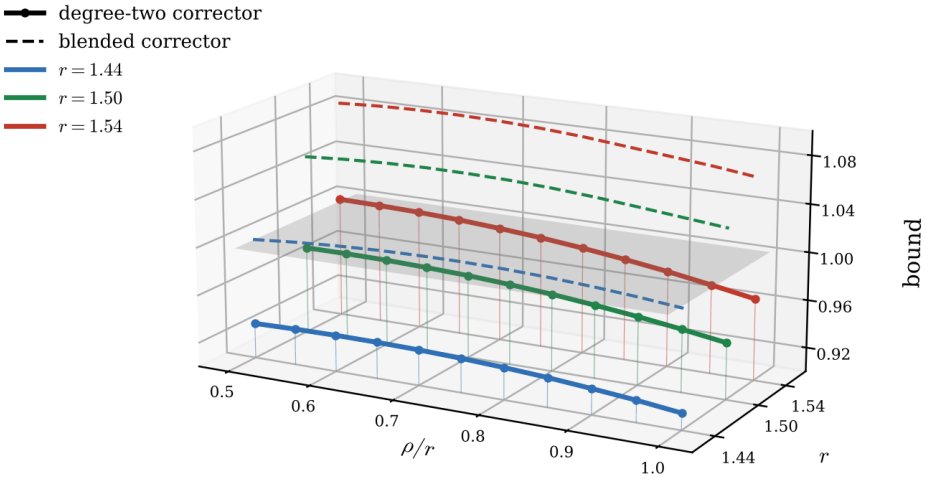



FIGURE 7. The floating-point value of $2r \sup_h$ of the bound of Lemma 7.4 on the face $b = \mathrm{diag}(r, \rho, \rho)$, as a function of $\rho/r$, for $r = 1.44$, 1.50 and 1.54: dashed with the corrector $u = s\varphi_h$ for the best $s$, solid with $u = q_h$ of degree two for the best $C$. The grey plane is the Dobrushin threshold one. The first corrector is above it already at $r = 1.44$; the second stays below it at $r = 1.50$, where Proposition 7.8 certifies the bound on all of $\mathcal{R}_r$, and crosses it by $r = 1.54$.

$\beta_W = 0.345$ (Theorem 1.3), and the sharper floating-point bound of Remark 5.7 stops near 0.357. Larger blocks are the next step.

*Curvature.* Remark 6.8 locates the end of the curvature method in this gauge between $|\beta| = \frac{1}{29}$ and $\frac{1}{26.25}$.

SU(3). The route of Section 7 bounds the $H^{-1}(\nu_b)$ norm of $\varphi_h - \nu_b\varphi_h$, which is at least $L_h(b)$, and needs it uniformly on $rK$. Its Galerkin values (polynomials of degree two) at matrices of $rK$ give $2r$ times the norm equal to 0.79 at $r = 1.25$, 0.89 at $r = 1.4$, 0.97 at $r = 1.5$ and 1.009 at $r = 1.55$, so the route stops at or below $\beta_W \approx 0.77$ even with exact constants. With $u = s\varphi_h$, Lemma 7.4 stops earlier: in floating point its largest values on $\mathcal{R}_r$ lie on the face $\mathrm{diag}(r, \rho, \rho)$ with $\rho$ between $0.75r$ and $0.8r$, and $2r$ times the bound is 0.9458 at $r = 1.36$, 0.9767 at $r = 1.40$ and 1.0080 at $r = 1.44$, so this corrector ends near $\beta_W \approx 0.715$. With $u = q_h$ of degree two the largest values on the same face are 0.9305 at $r = 1.44$, 0.9729 at $r = 1.50$ and 1.0018 at $r = 1.54$ (Figure 7), close to the Galerkin values. Lemma 7.3 therefore costs little at these couplings, and most of the distance between the floating-point value at $r = 1.5$ and the certified 0.999887 of Proposition 7.8 is the interpolation over boxes. Between $\beta_W = \frac{3}{4}$ and 0.77 there is room only for smaller boxes. The plaquette blocks of Theorem 1.7 use $\Lambda(2\beta_W)$ as well, with a little more room: they reach 0.76 with the certified cover of Proposition 7.9 and near 0.78 in floating point (Remark 8.4); past that one needs larger blocks, whose sensitivity does not go through the one-link modulus.

*Other groups.* For groups other than SU(2) and SU(3) only the curvature route is carried out here (Theorem 1.5), and it stops where the bound $\frac{29}{2}$ uses up the curvature of $G$, at $N|\beta| = \frac{2}{29}\kappa_G$. The Dobrushin route needs a bound for the Kantorovich modulus of the one-link measure of each group, which is not attempted here.

*The four open problems.* Our earlier paper [14] listed four problems between the strong-coupling results and the Clay problem [47]: (1) uniqueness and a gap at intermediate fixed coupling; (2) the crossover from strong coupling to Bałaban's weak-coupling regime; (3) the

continuum limit with the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms; and (4) a gap in physical units. The present paper moves the boundary of (1): for SU(2) from $\beta_W = \frac{2}{9}$ to 0.345, for SU(3) from $\frac{9}{32}$ to 0.76, with a gap at $\frac{3}{4}$ of 0.0177 in lattice units, and for every compact simple group, the exceptional groups included, past the curvature ceiling of the ungauged measure, with an explicit gap. It does not close (1); the region between these values and the scaling region, near $\beta_W \approx 2.2$ for SU(2) and $\beta_W \approx 6$ for SU(3), is open, and with it problem (2). Problems (3) and (4) are not solved here. Every bound proved here is uniform in lattice units, so by [15] none of them can by itself produce a continuum mass gap; that requires control of the gap in physical units along the renormalisation group flow [5, 17].[13]

*The continuum problem.* Two general facts limit what can be imported into problems (3) and (4) above from constructions of continuum measures. Both concern a random distribution $F$ on $\mathbb{R}^d$, a Borel probability measure on the tempered distributions with finite moments, and the growth condition

$$\mathbb{E}\, e^{F(\chi)} \le e^{C(\|\chi\|_1 + \|\chi\|_2^2)} \qquad \text{for all real } \chi \in \mathcal{S}(\mathbb{R}^d), \tag{9.1}$$

which is the growth condition of the regularity axiom of Glimm and Jaffe at $p = 2$ [39, Sect. 6.1, (6.1.5)]. It is the hypothesis under which reflection positivity across coordinate and diagonal hyperplanes is shown in [73] to give rotation invariance of the Schwinger functions, a step proposed there for the continuum limit of lattice gauge theories.

**Proposition 9.1.** *Let $F$ satisfy (9.1), and suppose that its connected two-point function is, off the diagonal, a locally integrable function $S_2(x,y)$ with $S_2(x,y) \ge c|x-y|^{-2\Delta}\big(\log \frac{1}{|x-y|}\big)^{-k}$ for $0 < |x-y| \le r_0$, where $c > 0$, $k \ge 0$ and $2\Delta > d$. Then $F$ does not exist: no random distribution has both properties.*

*Proof.* Applying (9.1) to $\chi$ and $-\chi$ and using $\cosh x \ge 1 + \frac{x^2}{2}$ gives $\mathbb{E}F(\chi)^2 \le 2(e^{C(\|\chi\|_1+\|\chi\|_2^2)} - 1)$. Fix nonnegative $\varphi, \psi \in C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R}^d)$, not zero, with supports in a ball of radius $\frac{R}{2}$ and at distance $\delta > 0$ from each other, and put $\varphi_\varepsilon(x) = \varepsilon^{-d/2}\varphi(x/\varepsilon)$, and likewise $\psi_\varepsilon$. Then $\|\varphi_\varepsilon\|_2 = \|\varphi\|_2$ and $\|\varphi_\varepsilon\|_1 = \varepsilon^{d/2}\|\varphi\|_1 \le \|\varphi\|_1$ for $\varepsilon \le 1$, so the covariance of $F(\varphi_\varepsilon)$ and $F(\psi_\varepsilon)$ is bounded uniformly in $\varepsilon$ by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality. On the other hand the supports of $\varphi_\varepsilon$ and $\psi_\varepsilon$ are disjoint, and for $u, v$ in the supports $\varepsilon\delta \le |\varepsilon u - \varepsilon v| \le \varepsilon R$. For $\varepsilon R \le r_0$ and $\varepsilon R < 1$ the lower bound for $S_2$ therefore gives

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{Cov}(F(\varphi_\varepsilon), F(\psi_\varepsilon)) &= \varepsilon^d \iint \varphi(u)\psi(v) S_2(\varepsilon u, \varepsilon v)\, du\, dv \\ &\ge c\, R^{-2\Delta} \varepsilon^{d-2\Delta} \Big(\log \frac{1}{\varepsilon\delta}\Big)^{-k} \|\varphi\|_1 \|\psi\|_1,\end{aligned}$$

which tends to infinity as $\varepsilon \to 0$. □

The action density $\operatorname{Tr} F_{\mu\nu}F_{\mu\nu}$ has dimension $\Delta = 4$ in four dimensions. A two-sided short-distance law of the form $|x-y|^{-8}$ times the fourth power of the running coupling, which is what asymptotic freedom[14] predicts and what the conditional construction of [74] states for the smeared action density, has $2\Delta = 8 > 4$ and $k = 2$; so that field cannot satisfy (9.1), and rotation invariance for it has to come from another source, as in [74], where it is reduced to a separate infrared hypothesis. In three dimensions the free part of the action density already has $2\Delta = 6 > 3$. Condition (9.1) suits fields of dimension at

[13] Every one of these approaches needs an input at physical length scales. Renormalisation group approaches to the ultraviolet behaviour of gauge and gravitational theories, of which [5, 28] are the rigorous ones for Yang–Mills theory, have also been proposed for the effective dimension of spacetime [66] and for completions of quantum gravity [11, 16]; they do not bear on the infrared estimates needed here.

[14] For SU($N$) the renormalisation group gives, with $b_0 = 11N/(48\pi^2)$ and the invariant scale $\Lambda$,

$$g(a)^{-2} = 2b_0 \log \tfrac{1}{a\Lambda} + O\big(\log\log \tfrac{1}{a\Lambda}\big),$$

so the inverse coupling $\beta_W = 2N/g(a)^2$ grows like $\frac{11N^2}{12\pi^2} \log \frac{1}{a\Lambda}$ along the continuum tuning.

most $\frac{d}{2}$, such as the field strength of the free Maxwell field, whose covariance is bounded in momentum space.

Positivity, symmetry and regularity do not produce a gap by themselves.

**Proposition 9.2.** *On $\mathbb{R}^4$ let $F$ be the centred Gaussian random distribution with covariance*

$$\widehat{C}(p) = \int_0^1 \frac{m^2}{|p|^2 + m^2}\, dm.$$

*Then $F$ is invariant under all Euclidean motions, reflection positive, satisfies (9.1) with $C = \frac{1}{2}$, and its Osterwalder–Schrader Hamiltonian has no gap above the vacuum.*

*Proof.* Since $0 \le \widehat{C} \le 1$, $\mathbb{E}e^{F(\chi)} = e^{\frac{1}{2}\langle \chi, C\chi\rangle} \le e^{\frac{1}{2}\|\chi\|_2^2}$, with the unitary Fourier transform. Invariance is clear. The covariance is the integral over $m \in (0,1)$, with the weight $m^2 dm$, of the covariances of free fields of mass $m$, each of which is reflection positive [39, Sect. 6.2]; a positive combination of reflection positive covariances is reflection positive, and so is the Gaussian measure with such a covariance [39, Sect. 6.2]. For $\chi(t,\mathbf{x}) = h(t)g(\mathbf{x})$ with $h \ge 0$ supported in $t > 0$, not zero, and $\hat{g}(0) \ne 0$, the vector $v = F(\chi)$ is orthogonal to the vacuum, and after the Fourier transform in $\mathbf{x}$,

$$\langle v, e^{-sH} v\rangle = \int_0^1 m^2\, dm \int \frac{|\hat{g}(\mathbf{k})|^2}{2\omega} e^{-\omega s} \times \Big(\int_0^\infty h(t) e^{-\omega t} dt\Big)^2 d\mathbf{k},$$

with $\omega = \sqrt{|\mathbf{k}|^2 + m^2}$ and constants absorbed in $\hat{g}$. If $H$ had a gap $m_0 > 0$, the left side would be at most $e^{-m_0 s}\|v\|^2$. For $0 < \eta < m_0$ the part of the integral with $m, |\mathbf{k}| \le \eta/2$ is at least $c_\eta e^{-\eta s}$ with $c_\eta > 0$, a contradiction as $s \to \infty$. □

The Gaussian field of Proposition 9.2 is not a gauge theory; it shows only that an infrared estimate, such as a bound $\langle v_a, T_a^{\lfloor t/a\rfloor} v_a\rangle \le C_v e^{-m_* t}$ uniform in the spacing $a$ along the continuum tuning, has to be proved in addition to the axioms. The lattice bounds of this paper are of this form only with $m_*$ proportional to $1/a$, and by [15] such bounds give trivial limits. The routes we know to a continuum gap therefore all stop at the same two estimates: the construction of the infinite-volume continuum measure past Bałaban's small-field analysis [5, 7], which the conditional construction of [74] assumes clause by clause and which yields there a non-negative Hamiltonian without any statement on its spectrum, and a decay estimate in physical units at large scales. The finite-size criterion described in [74, Sect. 9.4] reduces a gap to a threshold condition on one box, uniformly in the cutoff; as stated there, the condition fails in every small box and would have to be checked at large scales, which the construction does not reach.

## 10. The continuum step at one physical scale

The bounds of the preceding sections hold at fixed coupling and give a gap that is at least a fixed number in lattice units, and [15] shows that no such bound can produce a continuum gap. This section replaces the single-link condition of Proposition 3.2 by a condition on one cube of $n^4$ sites, averaged over its translates in the manner of Dobrushin and Shlosman [31], and proves that the condition gives a gap of order $1/n$ in lattice units. If it holds with $n$ proportional to $1/a$, that is, in a cube of fixed physical size, the gap survives in physical units and passes to every continuum limit (Theorem 10.4). The two statements that remain unproved, the cube estimate and the existence of the limit, are stated in Section 11.

10.1. **Averaged cubes.** For a finite set $V \subset A$ let $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q)$ be the probability measure on $G^V$ with density proportional to $\exp\big(N\beta \sum_{p \cap V \ne \emptyset} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F\big)$ with respect to Haar measure,

(a) averaged cubes, $n = 4$ (b) one physical scale

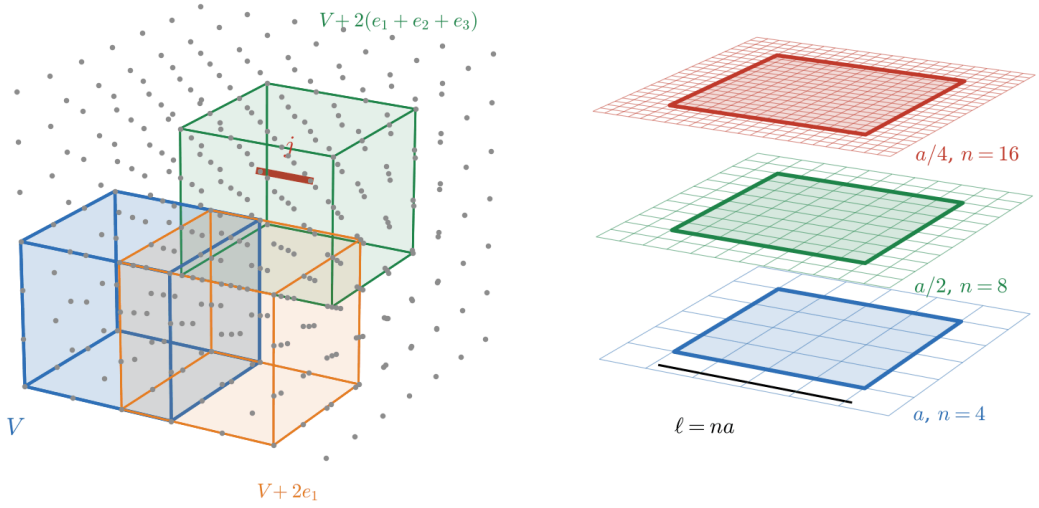



FIGURE 8. (a) The cube $V$ of side $n = 4$ and two of its translates by $2\mathbb{Z}^4$, drawn in three of the four dimensions. A link $j$ outside $V$ enters $K_c$ through every translate whose boundary it touches, and $D(n, \alpha)$ compares that total with the $N_n = (n/2)^4$ translates that contain $j$. (b) The cube of Theorem 10.4: its physical side $\ell = na$ is held fixed while the spacing is halved, so $n$ doubles at each step and the lattice gap $\log(1/\alpha)/(2n)$ is of order $a/\ell$.

the links outside $V$ being those of $Q$. Its conditional law of $Q_e$, $e \in V$, given the other links of $V$ is $\gamma_e^F$. Write $d_V(Q_V, Q'_V) = \sum_{i \in V} \delta(Q_i, Q'_i)$ and, for $j \in A \setminus V$,

$$C_{V,j} = \sup \frac{W_1^{d_V}\left(\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q), \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q')\right)}{\delta(Q_j, Q'_j)},$$

the supremum over pairs that differ only at $j$; $W_1^{d_V}$ is the Kantorovich distance for $d_V$. The coefficient vanishes unless $j$ shares a plaquette with a link of $V$.

Let $n \geq 2$ be even and let $V$ be the set of active links $(x, \mu)$ with $x \in [0, n)^4$. The direction field has period two, so the translations by $2\mathbb{Z}^4$ preserve $F$, $A$ and $\gamma^F$, and the translates $V_x = V + x$, $x \in 2\mathbb{Z}^4$, satisfy $C_{V_x, j+x} = C_{V,j}$. Every active link lies in exactly $N_n = (n/2)^4$ of them. A *class* is an orbit of $2\mathbb{Z}^4$ on $A$, that is, a residue of the base point modulo two together with a direction; there are at most 64 classes. For a class $c$ put

$$K_c = \sum_{j \in c \setminus V} C_{V,j}.$$

**Definition 10.1.** For $0 < \alpha < 1$, the condition $D(n, \alpha)$ at the coupling $\beta$ is $K_c \leq \alpha N_n$ for every class $c$.

Since $\sum_{x \in 2\mathbb{Z}^4,\, j \notin V_x} C_{V_x, j} = \sum_x C_{V, j-x}[j - x \notin V] = K_{c(j)}$ for the class $c(j)$ of $j$, the condition says that the total influence of a link on the translates that do not contain it is at most the fraction $\alpha$ of the number of translates that do. Figure 8 shows the cubes.

For $n = 2$ it is a bound on blocks of 48 links. Distances between links are those of their midpoints; a link of $V$ and a link sharing a plaquette with $V$ are at distance at most $\rho_n = 2n$, and $c_n$ denotes the number of active links within distance $\rho_n$ of a given one.

**Theorem 10.2.** *Let $\beta \geq 0$ and suppose that $D(n, \alpha)$ holds. Then statements* (i)–(iv) *of Proposition 3.2 hold,* (v) *holds for every $\lambda < \log(1/\alpha)/\rho_n$, and the transfer matrix of $\omega$ has spectral gap at least $\log(1/\alpha)/(2n)$.*

*Proof.* The proof of Proposition 3.2 uses the coefficients $C_{ee'}$ only through Lemma B.1 and Corollary B.2. Lemma B.4 of Appendix B gives the same conclusions under $D(n,\alpha)$, for every $\lambda > 0$ with $\alpha e^{\lambda\rho_n} < 1$, with the constant $\theta D/(1-\theta)$ replaced by $D(1+c_n e^{\lambda\rho_n})/(1-\theta)$ and $\theta = \alpha e^{\lambda\rho_n}$. The measures used there are invariant under every $\gamma_{V_x}$ with $V_x$ disjoint from the exceptional set: a Gibbs measure of $\gamma^F$ and its conditional measures given the links of a finite set by Lemma B.4(a), and the extended finite-volume measure of part (ii) because every plaquette that meets such a $V_x$ lies in $P(\Lambda)$. Part (vi) then follows from Proposition F.1 as before, with every $\lambda < \log(1/\alpha)/(2n)$. □

10.2. **The continuum limit.** Let $a_k = 2^{-k}a_0$ and let $\beta_k \geq 0$ be couplings, typically with $\beta_k \to \infty$. Suppose that the lattice states $\omega_k$ at $\beta_k$ exist as in Proposition 3.2, with transfer matrices $\mathbb{T}_k$ on the reconstructed spaces $\mathcal{H}_k$ and vacua $\Omega_k$ (Appendix F). Let $\mathcal{T}$ be a complex vector space of test functions on $\mathbb{R}^4$ supported in $\{t > 0\}$ and, for each $k$, let $f \mapsto O_k(f)$ be a linear map from $\mathcal{T}$ to gauge-invariant local observables supported in positive lattice times; the example to keep in mind is $O_k(f) = Z_k \sum_x a_k^4 f(a_k x)\Phi(x)$ for a local gauge-invariant field $\Phi$, a renormalisation constant $Z_k$ and $\Phi(x)$ the translate of $\Phi$ to $x$. Write $\vartheta$ for the time reflection and $\tau_t$ for the time translation by $t$ lattice steps.

**Definition 10.3.** A *continuum limit* of $(\omega_k, O_k)$ is a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$ with a unit vector $\Omega$, a self-adjoint operator $H \geq 0$ with $H\Omega = 0$, and a linear map $f \mapsto \psi(f)$ from $\mathcal{T}$ to $\mathcal{H}$ with dense range, such that for all $f, g \in \mathcal{T}$ and all dyadic $\tau \geq 0$,

$$\langle \psi(f), e^{-\tau H}\psi(g)\rangle = \lim_{k\to\infty} \omega_k\big(\vartheta(\overline{O_k(f)})\, \tau_{\tau/a_k} O_k(g)\big),$$
$$\langle \Omega, \psi(f)\rangle = \lim_{k\to\infty} \omega_k\big(O_k(f)\big),$$

the limits taken over the $k$ for which $\tau/a_k$ is an integer. It is *nontrivial* if $\mathcal{H} \neq \mathbb{C}\Omega$.

The Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction [62, 63] produces such a limit from convergent renormalised Schwinger functions that satisfy the axioms; the definition records only what the next theorem uses.

**Theorem 10.4.** *Suppose that there are $\alpha < 1$, $\ell > 0$ and even $n_k$ with $n_k a_k \leq \ell$ such that $D(n_k, \alpha)$ holds at $\beta_k$ for every $k$. Then every continuum limit of $(\omega_k, O_k)$ satisfies*

$$\sigma(H) \subset \{0\} \cup [m_*, \infty), \qquad m_* = \frac{\log(1/\alpha)}{2\ell},$$

*and $0$ is a simple eigenvalue. If the limit is nontrivial, $\sigma(H) \cap [m_*, \infty) \neq \emptyset$, so $H$ has a mass gap of at least $m_*$.*

*Proof.* By Theorem 10.2 the state $\omega_k$ exists and $\mathbb{T}_k$ has gap at least $\log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k)$ on the complement of $\Omega_k$. Let $f \in \mathcal{T}$, put $O = O_k(f)$ and $\varphi_k = \Psi_O - \omega_k(O)\Omega_k$. In the reconstruction of Appendix F, $\langle \Psi_F, \mathbb{T}_k^t \Psi_H\rangle = \omega_k(\vartheta(\bar{F})\tau_t H)$, so $\langle \Omega_k, \Psi_O\rangle = \omega_k(O)$, and $\mathbb{T}_k\Omega_k = \Omega_k$; hence, for integers $t \geq 0$,

$$\begin{aligned}\langle \varphi_k, \mathbb{T}_k^t \varphi_k\rangle &= \omega_k\big(\vartheta(\bar{O})\, \tau_t O\big) - |\omega_k(O)|^2 \\ &\leq e^{-t\log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k)}\, \|\varphi_k\|^2.\end{aligned}$$

Take $\tau \geq 0$ dyadic and $k$ large, so that $t = \tau/a_k$ is an integer; then $t/(2n_k) = \tau/(2n_k a_k) \geq \tau/(2\ell)$, and the right side is at most $e^{-m_*\tau}\|\varphi_k\|^2$. Both sides converge by Definition 10.3. With $\varphi = \psi(f) - \langle \Omega, \psi(f)\rangle\Omega$ and $e^{-\tau H}\Omega = \Omega$ the limit reads

$$\langle \varphi, e^{-\tau H}\varphi\rangle \leq e^{-m_*\tau}\|\varphi\|^2.$$

The maps $f \mapsto O_k(f)$ and $f \mapsto \psi(f)$ are linear, so the vectors $\varphi$ form a linear subspace, and it is dense in $\Omega^\perp$ because the range of $\psi$ is dense. The inequality extends to $\Omega^\perp$ by continuity, and from dyadic $\tau$ to all $\tau \geq 0$ by the strong continuity of $e^{-\tau H}$. For $\varphi \in \Omega^\perp$ with spectral measure $\mu_\varphi$ of $H$ this says $\int e^{-\tau E} d\mu_\varphi(E) \leq e^{-m_*\tau}\mu_\varphi([0,\infty))$ for all $\tau \geq 0$; if $\mu_\varphi([0, m_* - \eta]) > 0$ for some $\eta > 0$, the left side is at least $\mu_\varphi([0, m_* - \eta])e^{-(m_*-\eta)\tau}$, which

exceeds the right side for large $\tau$. So $\mu_\varphi$ lives on $[m_*, \infty)$ for every $\varphi \in \Omega^\perp$, which gives both claims about 0, and the spectrum on $\Omega^\perp \neq \{0\}$ lies in $[m_*, \infty)$ and is not empty. □

The proof uses $D(n_k, \alpha)$ only through the decay of the two-point functions, and the same argument accepts any decay with constants that depend on the observable.

**Theorem 10.5.** *Let $m_0 > 0$ and let $\mathcal{T}_0$ span $\mathcal{T}$. Suppose that for each $f \in \mathcal{T}_0$ there are $C_f < \infty$, $\tau_f \geq 0$ and $k_f$ such that*

$$\begin{aligned} C_k^f(\tau) &= \omega_k\big(\vartheta(\overline{O_k(f)})\, \tau_{\tau/a_k} O_k(f)\big) - |\omega_k(O_k(f))|^2 \\ &\leq C_f e^{-m_0 \tau} \end{aligned}$$

*for all $k \geq k_f$ and all dyadic $\tau \geq \tau_f$ with $\tau/a_k \in \mathbb{Z}$. Then every continuum limit of $(\omega_k, O_k)$ satisfies $\sigma(H) \subset \{0\} \cup [m_0, \infty)$, and 0 is a simple eigenvalue. If the limit is nontrivial, $H$ has a mass gap of at least $m_0$.*

*Proof.* For $f \in \mathcal{T}$ put $\varphi(f) = \psi(f) - \langle \Omega, \psi(f) \rangle \Omega$, which is linear in $f$. Since $e^{-\tau H}$ is self-adjoint and fixes $\Omega$, Definition 10.3 gives $\langle \varphi(f), e^{-\tau H} \varphi(f) \rangle = \lim_k C_k^f(\tau)$. For $f \in \mathcal{T}_0$ let $\mu$ be the spectral measure of $H$ at $\varphi(f)$. Then $\int e^{-\tau E} d\mu(E) \leq C_f e^{-m_0 \tau}$ for dyadic $\tau \geq \tau_f$. If $\mu([0, m_0 - \eta]) > 0$ for some $\eta \in (0, m_0)$, the left side is at least $\mu([0, m_0 - \eta]) e^{-(m_0 - \eta)\tau}$, which is impossible for large $\tau$. Hence the spectral projection $E_{[0, m_0)}$ of $H$ vanishes on $\varphi(\mathcal{T}_0)$. By linearity it vanishes on $\varphi(\mathcal{T})$, and since its kernel is closed, it vanishes on the closure of $\varphi(\mathcal{T})$, which is $\Omega^\perp$ because $\psi(\mathcal{T})$ is dense. So $E_{[0, m_0)} = \langle \Omega, \cdot \rangle\, \Omega$, which gives both claims. □

Theorem 10.4 is the case $m_0 = m_*$, $\tau_f = 0$ and $C_f = \sup_{k \geq k_f} \|\varphi_k\|^2$, which is finite because $\|\varphi_k\|^2 = C_k^f(0)$ converges. Theorem 10.5 needs neither a lattice gap nor the gauge of this paper. It applies to the output of a cluster expansion of any coarse effective theory, provided the expansion bounds the correlations of a spanning set of renormalised observables in physical units.

Theorem 10.4 bypasses the obstruction of [15]: under the hypothesis the lattice gap is at least $\log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k)$, of order $a_k/\ell$ in lattice units, which tends to zero, and only its value in physical units is bounded below. In the language of [15] the hypothesis implies the gap part (R2) of Hypothesis R, with $m = m_*$, and the conclusion holds for every continuum limit without a separate assumption on the gap.

10.3. **Smoothed observables.** The observables $O_k(f)$ of Definition 10.3 need not be local. The renormalised fields that one expects to converge are smoothed by the gradient flow of the Wilson action [55][15]; at positive flow time their correlation functions are finite to all orders of perturbation theory once the coupling is renormalised [56]. Flow in all four directions mixes the two sides of the reflection plane, but the spatial flow of [67, Sec. II.B] does not: it flows the links of each time slice under the Wilson action of that slice and leaves the temporal links alone.

Fix a bi-invariant Riemannian metric on $G$. For a configuration $U$ of all links of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ (for the states of this paper, the links of $F$ equal to 1), let $\Phi_s(U)$, $s \in \mathbb{R}$, solve

$$\frac{d}{ds} U_e = -\nabla_e \sum_{p \ni e,\ p \text{ spatial}} (N - \operatorname{Re} \operatorname{Tr} U_p)$$

for every spatial link $e$, the sum running over the four plaquettes of the time slice of $e$ that contain it, with the temporal links held fixed and $\nabla_e$ the gradient in the variable $U_e$.

[15] The flow moves the gauge field along the negative gradient of the Wilson action. At positive flow time the flowed fields are smooth on the scale of the square root of the flow time, and in perturbation theory their gauge-invariant composite fields need no further renormalisation [55, 56].

**Proposition 10.6.** (i) *$\Phi_s$ is defined on every configuration of the infinite lattice, $\Phi_s \circ \Phi_{s'} = \Phi_{s+s'}$, and $\Phi_s$ commutes with gauge transformations, with spatial and temporal translations and with the reflections in time. The link $\Phi_s(U)_e$ depends only on the spatial links of the time slice of $e$, and there are constants $\kappa, c$ depending only on $G$ such that, if $\Phi_s^R$ denotes the flow of the links of that slice within distance $R$ of $e$ with all other links held fixed,*

$$\delta\big(\Phi_s(U)_e, \Phi_s^R(U)_e\big) \le D\, e^{\kappa|s|}\, \frac{(c|s|)^{R+1}}{(R+1)!}$$

*for every configuration $U$.*

(ii) *Let $\omega$ be a state as in Appendix F and $O$ a bounded gauge-invariant function of finitely many links at times in $[t_0, t_1]$, continuous in them. Then $O \circ \Phi_s$ is a bounded gauge-invariant function of the links at times in $[t_0, t_1]$ and a uniform limit of gauge-invariant local functions at those times.*

(iii) *Theorem 10.4 holds with $O_k(f)$ replaced by $O_k(f) \circ \Phi_{s_k}$ for any $s_k \in \mathbb{R}$, in particular for $s_k = \tau/a_k^2$ at a fixed flow time $\tau$ in physical units.*

(iv) *The image measure $(\Phi_s)_*\omega$ is reflection positive, and its transfer matrix is unitarily equivalent to that of $\omega$, the unitary fixing the vacuum.*

*Proof.* (i) Embed $G$ in a matrix algebra. The right side of the equation is a smooth function of the links of the four plaquettes containing $e$, tangent to $G$ at $U_e$, so on the Banach space of bounded assignments of matrices to the spatial links it is a vector field that is bounded and Lipschitz on a neighbourhood of the configurations with values in $G$, with a Lipschitz constant that does not depend on the volume because every link meets finitely many others. The Picard–Lindelöf theorem gives a unique local solution; it stays on $G$ because the field is tangent there, and since the field is bounded on $G$ the solution exists for all $s$; uniqueness gives the group law. The action of a time slice and the metric are invariant under gauge transformations, translations and the reflections, so the flow commutes with them by uniqueness. Since the equation of a spatial link involves only links of its own slice, so does the solution. For the comparison, let $d_{e'}(s)$ be the distance between the two flows at a link $e'$ of the slice. Smoothness on the compact group gives constants $\kappa_0, c_1$ with $d_{e'}(s) \le \int_0^{|s|} (\kappa_0 d_{e'} + c_1 \sum_{e'' \sim e'} d_{e''})$ for $e'$ within distance $R$ of $e$, where $e'' \sim e'$ means that the two links share a spatial plaquette (twelve neighbours), while $d_{e'} \le D$ beyond. Iterating the integral form of this inequality, a term that reaches the links beyond distance $R$ needs at least $R+1$ steps of $\sim$, and $\sum_{k>R} x^k/k! \le e^x x^{R+1}/(R+1)!$; this gives the bound with $c = 12c_1$ and $\kappa = \kappa_0 + c$.

(ii) The truncated flow $\Phi_s^R$ commutes with gauge transformations for the same reason as $\Phi_s$, so $O \circ \Phi_s^R$ is a gauge-invariant function of finitely many links at times in $[t_0, t_1]$. By (i) and the uniform continuity of $O$, it converges to $O \circ \Phi_s$ uniformly as $R \to \infty$.

(iii) The proof of Theorem 10.4 uses $O_k(f)$ only through the vectors $\Psi_{O_k(f)}$ and the identity $\langle \Psi_F, \mathbb{T}^t \Psi_H \rangle = \omega(\vartheta(\bar{F}) \tau_t H)$. By (ii) and the footnote in Appendix F, both extend to uniform limits of local functions at positive times, and $f \mapsto O_k(f) \circ \Phi_{s_k}$ is linear.

(iv) By (i), $\Phi_s$ and $\Phi_{-s}$ preserve the functions of the links at positive times and commute with $\vartheta$ and $\tau_t$. Hence $(\Phi_s)_*\omega\big(\vartheta(\bar{F})\tau_t H\big) = \omega\big(\vartheta(\overline{F \circ \Phi_s})\, \tau_t(H \circ \Phi_s)\big)$, which for $t = 0$ and $H = F$ is nonnegative, and $F \mapsto F \circ \Phi_s$ induces an isometry between the reconstructed spaces that intertwines the transfer matrices and fixes the vacuum; $\Phi_{-s}$ gives its inverse. □

Part (iv) says that smoothing changes the variables and not the theory: it neither creates nor removes a gap. Its use is in the choice of the observables. With $O_k(f)$ the spatially flowed fields at a fixed physical flow time, for instance $Z_k \sum_x a_k^4 f(a_k x)(\mathcal{E}_\tau(x) - \omega_k(\mathcal{E}_\tau(x)))$ with $\mathcal{E}_\tau(x)$ the flowed action density of the slice, statement (E) asks for the convergence of correlation functions that are known to be finite in perturbation theory [56], and Theorem 10.4 applies to them. Theorem 10.7 below constructs their continuum limits along subsequences; their nontriviality is not proved here.

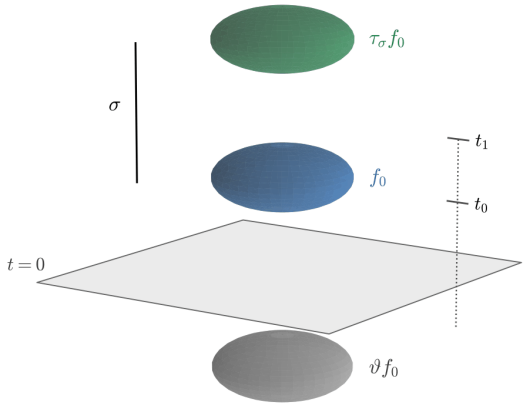



FIGURE 9. The packet $f_0$ of Theorem 10.7, supported in the time window $[t_0, t_1]$ above the reflection plane $t = 0$, its reflection $\vartheta f_0$ and its translate $\tau_\sigma f_0$ by $\sigma$ in time. The correlation $C_k(\sigma)$ pairs the reflected packet with the translated one; $C_k(0)$ is the reflected norm that renormalises the packet.

10.4. **Renormalised flowed observables.** The spatially flowed fields can be renormalised by one condition at a single physical separation, and their correlation functions then have continuum limits along subsequences without further assumptions. What remains open is whether such a limit is trivial, and that question reduces to one ratio of lattice two-point functions.

Fix a bounded gauge-invariant function $\Phi$ of finitely many spatial links of the slice $\{x_0 = 0\}$, continuous in them, a flow time $\tau > 0$ in physical units, and a nonzero test function $f_0 \in C_c(\mathbb{R}^4)$ supported in $\{t > 0\}$. Put $s_k = \tau/a_k^2$, write $\Phi_x$ for the translate of $\Phi$ to $x \in \mathbb{Z}^4$, and let

$$A_k = \sum_{x \in \mathbb{Z}^4} a_k^4 f_0(a_k x)(\Phi_x \circ \Phi_{s_k} - \omega_k(\Phi_x \circ \Phi_{s_k})),$$

$$C_k(\sigma) = \omega_k(\vartheta(\bar{A}_k)\, \tau_{\sigma/a_k} A_k)$$

for dyadic $\sigma \geq 0$ (the sum is finite, and $\sigma/a_k$ is an integer for large $k$). By reflection positivity $C_k(0) \geq 0$; assume $C_k(0) > 0$ and set $Z_k = C_k(0)^{-1/2}$. Let $\mathcal{D}$ be the set of points $y = (t, y') \in \mathbb{R}^4$ with dyadic coordinates (in units of $a_0$) and $t > 0$, and for $y \in \mathcal{D}$ and $k$ with $y/a_k \in \mathbb{Z}^4$ let $A_k^y$ be the translate of $A_k$ by $y/a_k$.

**Theorem 10.7.** (i) *For $y, y' \in \mathcal{D}$ and every $k$ with $y/a_k, y'/a_k \in \mathbb{Z}^4$,*

$$Z_k^2 \left|\omega_k(\vartheta(\bar{A}_k^y) A_k^{y'})\right| \leq 1.$$

(ii) *Every sequence of $k$ has a subsequence along which $K(y, y') = \lim Z_k^2\, \omega_k(\vartheta(\bar{A}_k^y) A_k^{y'})$ exists for all $y, y' \in \mathcal{D}$ and $\rho(\sigma) = \lim C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0)$ exists for all dyadic $\sigma > 0$. Along it there is a probability measure $\mu$ on $[0, \infty]$ with*

$$\rho(\sigma) = \int_{[0,\infty]} e^{-\sigma E}\, d\mu(E) \qquad (\sigma > 0),$$

*the integrand being $0$ at $E = \infty$.*

(iii) *Along such a subsequence, let $\mathcal{T}$ be spanned by the translates $f_0(\cdot - y)$, $y \in \mathcal{D}$, and one more function $f_* \in C_c(\mathbb{R}^4)$ supported in $\{t > 0\}$ outside their span, and let $O_k$ be the*

*linear map with* $O_k(f_0(\cdot - y)) = Z_k A_k^y$ *and* $O_k(f_*) = 1$. *Then* $(\omega_k, O_k)$ *has a continuum limit in the sense of Definition 10.3, on which the dyadic spatial translations act by unitary operators commuting with* $H$.

(iv) *This limit is nontrivial if and only if* $\mu([0,\infty)) > 0$, *if and only if* $\rho(\sigma) > 0$ *for one dyadic* $\sigma > 0$, *and then* $\rho(\sigma) > 0$ *for all of them. Consequently a nontrivial limit exists along some subsequence if and only if* $\limsup_k C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0) > 0$ *for some dyadic* $\sigma > 0$.

(v) *If the hypothesis of Theorem 10.4 holds, then* $\mu$ *is carried by* $[m_*, \infty]$ *and* $\rho(\sigma) \le e^{-m_*\sigma}$.

*Proof.* By Proposition 10.6(ii) each $\Phi_x \circ \Phi_{s_k}$, and hence each $A_k^y$, is a uniform limit of gauge-invariant local functions at times $\ge 1$, so the reconstruction of Appendix F applies to them (its footnote). Write $\Psi_k = Z_k \Psi_{A_k}$. Since $\langle \Omega_k, \Psi_{A_k}\rangle = \omega_k(A_k) = 0$ and $\|\Psi_k\|^2 = Z_k^2 C_k(0) = 1$, $\Psi_k$ is a unit vector orthogonal to $\Omega_k$. The relation $\langle \Psi_F, \mathbb{T}_k^t \Psi_H\rangle = \omega_k(\vartheta(\bar F)\tau_t H)$ for all $F$ gives $\Psi_{\tau_t H} = \mathbb{T}_k^t \Psi_H$. Spatial translations commute with $\vartheta$ and with $\tau_t$ and leave $\omega_k$ invariant, so they act on the reconstructed space by unitaries $U_k(x)$ that commute with $\mathbb{T}_k$. Hence, for $y = (t, y')$,

$$Z_k \Psi_{A_k^y} = U_k(y'/a_k)\, \mathbb{T}_k^{t/a_k} \Psi_k .$$

(i) The left side of the inequality is $|\langle Z_k \Psi_{A_k^y}, Z_k \Psi_{A_k^{y'}}\rangle| \le 1$, because $\|U_k\| = 1$ and $0 \le \mathbb{T}_k \le 1$.

(ii) The set $\mathcal{D} \times \mathcal{D}$ is countable and the numbers are bounded by (i), so a diagonal subsequence gives all the limits $K$; the limits $\rho(\sigma)$ are among them, since $C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0) = \langle \Psi_k, \mathbb{T}_k^{\sigma/a_k} \Psi_k\rangle$ is the value of $K$ at $y = y' = (\sigma/2, 0)$. Let $\nu_k$ be the spectral measure (Lemma G.1) of $\mathbb{T}_k$ at $\Psi_k$, a probability measure on $[0,1]$, and $\mu_k$ its image under $\lambda \mapsto -a_k^{-1} \log \lambda \in [0,\infty]$. Then $C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0) = \int e^{-\sigma E} d\mu_k(E)$. The space $[0,\infty]$ is compact, so a further subsequence has $\mu_k \to \mu$ weakly (Lemma G.2), and $E \mapsto e^{-\sigma E}$ is continuous on $[0,\infty]$ for $\sigma > 0$.

(iii) A finite combination $\sum_j c_j f_0(\cdot - y_j)$ with distinct $y_j$ that vanishes has Fourier transform $\hat f_0(p) \sum_j c_j e^{-ip\cdot y_j} = 0$; since $\hat f_0$ is analytic and not zero, the exponential sum vanishes on an open set and every $c_j$ is zero. So the translates are linearly independent and $O_k$ is well defined. On the space $V$ of finite sums $v = \sum_y c_y \delta_y$ over $\mathcal{D}$ put $B(v,w) = \sum \bar c_y c'_{y'} K(y,y')$. It is the limit of $\langle v_k, w_k\rangle$ with $v_k = \sum_y c_y Z_k \Psi_{A_k^y}$, hence positive semidefinite; let $\mathcal{H}_0$ be the completion of $V$ modulo its null space. For dyadic $\sigma \ge 0$ and dyadic spatial $x$ define $T(\sigma)\delta_y = \delta_{y+(\sigma,0)}$ and $U(x)\delta_y = \delta_{y+(0,x)}$. At level $k$ these are $\mathbb{T}_k^{\sigma/a_k}$ and $U_k(x/a_k)$, so in the limit $B(T(\sigma)v, w) = B(v, T(\sigma)w)$, $B(T(\sigma)v, T(\sigma)v) \le B(v,v)$, $B(v, T(\sigma)v) \ge 0$, and $U(x)$ preserves $B$. Thus $T(\sigma)$ extends to commuting positive contractions on $\mathcal{H}_0$ with $T(\sigma)T(\sigma') = T(\sigma+\sigma')$, and $U(x)$ to unitaries commuting with them. For dyadic $\sigma > 0$ the kernel of $T(\sigma) = T(\sigma/2)^2$ equals that of $T(\sigma/2)$, so all these kernels coincide; and every $\delta_y$ with $y = (t, y')$ equals $T(t/2)\delta_{(t/2, y')}$, a vector in the range of a positive operator and so orthogonal to its kernel. Hence each $T(\sigma)$ is injective on $\mathcal{H}_0$, and $H_0 = -\log T(1)$ is a self-adjoint operator with $H_0 \ge 0$ and $e^{-\sigma H_0} = T(\sigma)$ for dyadic $\sigma$, by the uniqueness of positive roots. Put $\mathcal{H} = \mathbb{C}\Omega \oplus \mathcal{H}_0$, $H = 0 \oplus H_0$, $\psi(f_0(\cdot - y)) = \delta_y$ and $\psi(f_*) = \Omega$. The range of $\psi$ is dense, and the identities of Definition 10.3 hold: for two translates they are the limits defining $K$, with $\tau_{\sigma/a_k} A_k^{y'} = A_k^{y'+(\sigma,0)}$; and for $f_*$ they read $\omega_k(1) = 1$ and $\omega_k(\vartheta(\bar A_k^y)) = \omega_k(\tau_{\sigma/a_k} A_k^y) = 0$.

(iv) The limit is nontrivial exactly when $\mathcal{H}_0 \ne 0$, that is when $\|\delta_y\|^2 = K(y,y) = \rho(2t)$ is positive for some $y = (t, y')$. By (ii) and Lemma G.3(b), $\rho(\sigma) > 0$ for one $\sigma > 0$ if and only if $\mu([0,\infty)) > 0$, and then $\rho(\sigma) > 0$ for every $\sigma > 0$. For the last statement choose a subsequence along which $C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0)$ tends to its lim sup, and refine it by (ii).

(v) Under that hypothesis the proof of Theorem 10.4 gives $\nu_k([0, e^{-\log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k)}]) = 1$ because $\Psi_k \perp \Omega_k$, so $\mu_k$ is carried by $[\log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k a_k), \infty] \subset [m_*, \infty]$, and so is the weak limit $\mu$. □

The measure $\mu$ is the spectral measure of the renormalised flowed field in the limit: its part on $[0,\infty)$ is what survives as a state of the continuum theory, and its atom at $\infty$ is the weight that the field puts on energies that diverge in physical units. The theorem constructs the renormalised continuum observables and their reconstruction for every tuning, and it reduces their nontriviality to the lattice inequality

$$\limsup_{k\to\infty} \frac{C_k(\sigma)}{C_k(0)} > 0$$

for one physical separation $\sigma$: the flowed two-point function of the smeared packet at a fixed physical distance must not become negligible against its reflected norm $C_k(0)$. If the lattice gap stayed above some $m > 0$ in lattice units, the ratio would be at most $e^{-m\sigma/a_k}$ and the limit would be trivial, so the inequality is a condition on the tuning $\beta_k \to \infty$; it is not proved here. Nor are the independence of the limit from the subsequence, Euclidean invariance, or bounds on products of more than two renormalised fields, for which (i) gives nothing because $Z_k$ may diverge (Theorem 10.15 reduces them to tree bounds); (E) requires all of these.

The denominator $C_k(0)$ is the reflected norm of the packet smeared by $f_0$, not a coincidence limit of point fields, and the distinction matters. For the free massless scalar field in four dimensions with spatial momenta cut off at $\Lambda$, the covariance at spatial separation 0 is $(1-(1+\Lambda t)e^{-\Lambda t})/(4\pi^2 t^2)$ at time $t>0$ and $\Lambda^2/(8\pi^2)$ at coincidence, so its ratio $2(1-(1+\Lambda t)e^{-\Lambda t})/(\Lambda t)^2$ tends to zero as $\Lambda\to\infty$, although the limiting field is the nontrivial Gaussian field; for packets smeared by $f_0$ the reflected norms of that field have finite positive limits and the ratio stays positive. The criterion of Theorem 10.7(iv) is about the smeared packets $A_k$ only.

When the ratio is bounded below, renormalising at the separation $\sigma$ instead of 0 removes the escape to infinite energy altogether, and one slab of the transfer matrix gives a sufficient condition for the bound. Write $\mu_k$ for the measures in the proof of Theorem 10.7.

**Proposition 10.8.** (i) *Suppose $C_k(\sigma) \geq c\, C_k(0)$ for a dyadic $\sigma > 0$, a $c > 0$ and every $k$ of a sequence. Let $\mu'_k$ be the spectral measure, in energies $E = -a_k^{-1}\log\lambda$, of the unit vector $C_k(\sigma)^{-1/2}\Psi_{A'_k}$ with $A'_k = \tau_{\sigma/2a_k}A_k$. Then $\mu'_k$ is a probability measure on $[0,\infty)$,*

$$\mu'_k([\Lambda,\infty)) \leq c^{-1}e^{-\sigma\Lambda}, \qquad \int E^m\, d\mu'_k \leq c^{-1}\Big(\frac{m}{e\sigma}\Big)^m,$$

*and $t \mapsto C_k(\sigma+t)/C_k(\sigma)$ is Lipschitz on $[0,\infty)$ with constant $(e\sigma c)^{-1}$. A subsequence of the $\mu'_k$ converges weakly to a probability measure on $[0,\infty)$ with the same bounds.*

(ii) *Suppose $\langle\Psi_k,(1-\mathbb{T}_k)\Psi_k\rangle \leq Ca_k$ for a constant $C$ and every $k$ of a sequence. Then $C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0) \geq e^{-2C\sigma}$ whenever $Ca_k \leq \frac12$ and $\sigma/a_k$ is an integer, and $\mu_k([\Lambda,\infty]) \leq C(a_k+\Lambda^{-1})$ for every $\Lambda > 0$.*

*Proof.* (i) We have $\Psi_{A'_k} = \mathbb{T}_k^{\sigma/2a_k}\Psi_{A_k}$, so the measure $\mu'_k$ is $e^{-\sigma E}d\mu_k(E)$ divided by its mass $C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0) \geq c$, and $e^{-\sigma E}$ vanishes at $E=\infty$. For $E \geq \Lambda$ we have $e^{-\sigma E} \leq e^{-\sigma\Lambda}$, and $E^m e^{-\sigma E} \leq (m/e\sigma)^m$ for all $E \geq 0$. The ratio in question is the integral of $e^{-tE}$ against $\mu'_k$, and the inequality $|e^{-tE}-e^{-sE}| \leq |t-s|E$ with the moment bound for $m=1$ gives the Lipschitz bound. The tail bound makes the sequence tight on $[0,\infty)$, so Prokhorov's theorem gives the weak limit, and the bounds pass to it because $\{E>\Lambda\}$ is open and $E^m$ is a monotone limit of bounded continuous functions.

(ii) Let $\nu_k$ be the spectral measure of $\mathbb{T}_k$ at $\Psi_k$ on $[0,1]$, a probability measure, and $n = \sigma/a_k$. By Jensen's inequality for the convex function $\lambda^n$,

$$\frac{C_k(\sigma)}{C_k(0)} = \int \lambda^n d\nu_k \geq \Big(\int \lambda\, d\nu_k\Big)^n \geq (1-Ca_k)^n \geq e^{-2Ca_k n},$$

since $\log(1-x) \geq -2x$ on $[0,\frac12]$. Moreover $Ca_k \geq \int(1-e^{-a_kE})d\mu_k \geq (1-e^{-a_k\Lambda})\mu_k([\Lambda,\infty])$, and $1-e^{-x} \geq x/(1+x)$. □

Part (ii) asks for an upper bound on a one-slab Dirichlet form, the opposite direction to a mass gap, which bounds such forms from below. In the box of Proposition 10.9, with $g$ smooth, the time smearing supplies the factor $a_k$ up to one ratio: in the notation of its proof, $\mathbb{T}_k = A$ and $\Psi_{A_k} = \sum_n w_n \mathbb{T}_k^n u$ with $w_n = a_k g(a_k n)$ and $u = a_k^3 F^c \psi_0$, and the identity $(1-\mathbb{T}_k)\Psi_{A_k} = \sum_n (w_n - w_{n-1})\mathbb{T}_k^n u$ gives $\langle \Psi_k, (1-\mathbb{T}_k)\Psi_k\rangle \le a_k \|g'\|_{L^1}\|u\|/\|\Psi_{A_k}\|$, so the hypothesis of (ii) holds when the vector $u$ of a single slice stays comparable to the time-smeared packet. That comparison is not proved; Proposition 10.10 below bounds the ratio without it.

A one-slab bound of this kind also limits the mass that $D(n_k, \alpha)$ can supply. Let $e^{-m_k}$ be the norm of $\mathbb{T}_k$ on $\Omega_k^\perp$. If a unit vector $\varphi_k \perp \Omega_k$ has $\langle \varphi_k, (1-\mathbb{T}_k)\varphi_k\rangle \le \kappa a_k < 1$, then the spectral measure of $\mathbb{T}_k$ at $\varphi_k$ lives on $[0, e^{-m_k}]$, so $1 - e^{-m_k} \le \kappa a_k$ and $m_k \le -\log(1-\kappa a_k)$. If in addition $D(n_k, \alpha)$ holds with $n_k a_k \le \ell$, Theorem 10.2 gives $m_k \ge \log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k) \ge a_k \log(1/\alpha)/(2\ell)$, and therefore

$$\frac{\log(1/\alpha)}{2\ell} \le \frac{-\log(1-\kappa a_k)}{a_k} = \kappa + O(a_k).$$

So the physical mass $m_*$ of Theorem 10.4 is at most the constant $\kappa$ of any one-slab bound. The two hypotheses are compatible because both are statements in physical units. The one-slab bound forces $m_k \to 0$, so it cannot come from an expansion whose convergence gives a lattice gap bounded below in lattice units.

In a periodic spatial box the assumption $C_k(0) > 0$ is a theorem. Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(N)$ with its defining representation, and replace $\mathbb{Z}^4$ by $\mathbb{Z} \times (\mathbb{Z}/L_k\mathbb{Z})^3$ with $L_k \ge 3$ and $\omega_k$ by the infinite-time Wilson state of the box. The proof of Theorem 10.7 uses only reflection positivity and the transfer matrix once the spatial translations are dropped, and parts (i)–(iv) hold in the box with $\mathcal{D}$ replaced by its points $(t, 0)$, the time translates of $f_0$ being independent by the same Fourier argument in $t$.

**Proposition 10.9.** *In the box, let $f_0(t,x) = g(t)h(x)$ with $g, h \ge 0$, and let $\Phi = \sum_{i<j}(N - \mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\, Q_{ij})$ be the energy of the three spatial plaquettes at the origin. If $g(a_k n)h(a_k x) > 0$ for some $n \ge 1$ and some $x$, then $C_k(0) > 0$.*

*Proof.* Lüscher proved that the transfer matrix is strictly positive [54]; we recall the argument because the proof uses it in this form.

*The one-link kernel.* Write $\chi$ for the character of the defining representation and $b = \beta_W > 0$. Then

$$e^{\frac{b}{N}\mathrm{Re}\,\chi} = \sum_{m \ge 0} \frac{(b/2N)^m}{m!}(\chi + \bar\chi)^m,$$

and $(\chi + \bar\chi)^m$ is the character of $(\rho \oplus \bar\rho)^{\otimes m}$. Every irreducible representation $\sigma$ occurs in one of these tensor powers: their matrix coefficients span the algebra of polynomials in the entries of $q$ and $\bar q$, which contains the constants and separates points, so it is dense in $C(G)$ by the Stone–Weierstrass theorem, while the matrix coefficients of a $\sigma$ that never occurred would be orthogonal to it by Schur orthogonality. So the coefficient of every irreducible character in $e^{\frac{b}{N}\mathrm{Re}\,\chi}$ is positive, and convolution with this function acts on each isotypic part of $L^2(G)$ by a positive scalar.

*The transfer matrix.* In the temporal gauge the transfer matrix of the box acts on the gauge-invariant part of $L^2(G^E)$, $E$ the spatial links of one slice, as $MKM$, where $K$ is the tensor product over $E$ of the convolutions above and $M$ is multiplication by the exponential of half the spatial plaquette weight [54, 64]. Both commute with gauge transformations, $K$ is positive and injective by the first step, and $M$ is positive and invertible, so $\langle v, MKMv\rangle = \langle Mv, KMv\rangle > 0$ for $v \ne 0$. Its kernel is a continuous positive function, and $K$ is compact, so its largest eigenvalue $\lambda_0$ is simple with an eigenfunction $\psi_0 > 0$, and with $A = MKM/\lambda_0$, a function $F$ of the slice at time $n \ge 0$ has $\Psi_F = A^n F\psi_0$ in the reconstruction, $\Omega$ being $\psi_0$.

*Conclusion.* Let $F = \sum_x h(a_k x)\,\Phi_x \circ \Phi_{s_k}$ and $F^c = F - \omega_k(F)$. Then $\Psi_{A_k} = a_k^4\, p(A) F^c \psi_0$ with $p(z) = \sum_{n\ge 1} g(a_k n) z^n$, a polynomial with nonnegative coefficients, not all zero, so $p > 0$ on $(0,1]$ and $p(A)$ is injective. The function $\sum_x h(a_k x)\Phi_x$ vanishes at the configuration with every link 1 and is positive at one with a single nontrivial link at a site where $h(a_k x) > 0$; the flow $\Phi_{s_k}$ is a bijection, so $F$ is not constant, and as $F$ is continuous and $\psi_0 > 0$, $F^c\psi_0 \neq 0$. Hence $C_k(0) = \|\Psi_{A_k}\|^2 > 0$. □

The proposition removes the one assumption of Theorem 10.7 in a box; it says nothing about the ratio of part (iv), on which nontriviality depends.

The ratio of Theorem 10.7(iv) can be compared with correlations of a single slice field. Suppose that $f_0(t,x) = g(t)h(x)$ with $g \ge 0$ supported in $[t_0, t_1]$, $t_0 < t_1$ positive and dyadic, let

$$U_k = \sum_{x\in\mathbb{Z}^3} a_k^3 h(a_k x)\big(\Phi_{(0,x)} \circ \Phi_{s_k} - \omega_k(\Phi_{(0,x)} \circ \Phi_{s_k})\big)$$

be the centred field of the slice at time 0, smeared in space only, and put $u_k = \Psi_{U_k}$ and

$$D_k(r) = \langle u_k, \mathbb{T}_k^{r/a_k} u_k\rangle = \omega_k(\vartheta(\bar U_k)\,\tau_{r/a_k} U_k)$$

for $r \in a_k\mathbb{Z}$, $r \ge 0$. Let $n_0 = \lceil t_0/a_k\rceil$ and $n_1 = \lfloor t_1/a_k\rfloor$.

**Proposition 10.10.** *Assume $C_k(0) > 0$, and let $\sigma \ge 0$ with $\sigma/a_k \in \mathbb{Z}$.*

(i) *$D_k(r) > 0$ for every $r$, and*

$$\frac{D_k(2a_k n_1 + \sigma)}{D_k(2a_k n_0)} \le \frac{C_k(\sigma)}{C_k(0)} \le \frac{D_k(2a_k n_0 + \sigma)}{D_k(2a_k n_1)}.$$

(ii) *$\log D_k$ and $\log C_k$ are convex and nonincreasing on $a_k\mathbb{Z}_{\ge 0}$. If $D_k(r') \ge c\, D_k(r)$ with $r < r'$ and $c \le 1$, then $D_k(\beta) \ge c^{\max(1,(\beta-\alpha)/(r'-r))} D_k(\alpha)$ whenever $r \le \alpha < \beta$; if $C_k(\sigma) \ge c\, C_k(0)$ with $\sigma > 0$, then $C_k(\sigma') \ge c^{\sigma'/\sigma} C_k(0)$ for $\sigma' \ge \sigma$.*

(iii) *Let $k$ run through a sequence. If $D_k(r') \ge c\, D_k(r)$ for dyadic $0 < r < r'$ with $r \le 2t_0$, a $c \in (0,1]$ and every large $k$, then for every dyadic $\sigma \ge 0$ and every large $k$*

$$C_k(\sigma) \ge c^{\max(1,(2t_1 - 2t_0 + \sigma)/(r'-r))}\, C_k(0).$$

*Conversely, if $C_k(\sigma) \ge c\, C_k(0)$ for a dyadic $\sigma > 0$ and every $k$, then $D_k(2t_0 + \sigma') \ge c^{\sigma'/\sigma} D_k(2t_1)$ for every dyadic $\sigma' \ge \sigma$ with $\sigma' > 2(t_1 - t_0)$ and every large $k$.*

*Proof.* For a function $F$ of the slice at time 0 and an integer $n \ge 0$ we have $\Psi_{\tau_n F} = \mathbb{T}_k^n \Psi_F$, since both have inner product $\omega_k(\vartheta(\bar G)\tau_n F)$ with every $\Psi_G$. By time translation invariance of $\omega_k$, $A_k = \sum_n w_n \tau_n U_k$ with $w_n = a_k g(a_k n) \ge 0$, and $w_n = 0$ unless $n_0 \le n \le n_1$; so $\Psi_{A_k} = \sum_n w_n \mathbb{T}_k^n u_k$. Let $\nu$ be the spectral measure of $\mathbb{T}_k$ at $u_k$, on $[0,1]$, and $W(\lambda) = \sum_n w_n \lambda^n$. Then

$$C_k(\sigma) = \int W(\lambda)^2 \lambda^{\sigma/a_k}\, d\nu(\lambda), \qquad D_k(r) = \int \lambda^{r/a_k}\, d\nu(\lambda).$$

(i) Since $t_0 > 0$, $n_0 \ge 1$ and $W(0) = 0$; so $C_k(0) > 0$ forces $\nu((0,1]) > 0$, and then $D_k(r) > 0$. For $0 \le \lambda \le 1$, $\|w\|_1 \lambda^{n_1} \le W(\lambda) \le \|w\|_1 \lambda^{n_0}$; inserting these bounds in $C_k(\sigma)$ and $C_k(0)$ gives the two inequalities.

(ii) Convexity of $j \mapsto \log \int \lambda^j\, d\rho$ for a positive measure $\rho$ on $[0,1]$ is Hölder's inequality, and the integrals decrease in $j$ because $\lambda \le 1$; take $\rho = \nu$ and $\rho = W^2\nu$. If $\beta \le r'$, monotonicity gives $D_k(\beta) \ge D_k(r') \ge cD_k(r) \ge cD_k(\alpha)$. If $\beta > r'$, the difference quotients of the convex function $\log D_k$ increase in both end points, so $(\log D_k(\beta) - \log D_k(\alpha))/(\beta-\alpha) \ge (\log D_k(r') - \log D_k(r))/(r'-r) \ge \log c/(r'-r)$. The statement on $C_k$ is the same comparison of quotients on $[0,\sigma]$ and $[0,\sigma']$.

(iii) For large $k$ the times $2t_0$, $2t_1$ are multiples of $a_k$, and $2a_k n_0 \ge 2t_0$, $2a_k n_1 \le 2t_1$. Since $D_k$ is nonincreasing, (i) gives

$$\frac{D_k(2t_1 + \sigma)}{D_k(2t_0)} \le \frac{C_k(\sigma)}{C_k(0)} \le \frac{D_k(2t_0 + \sigma)}{D_k(2t_1)}.$$

The first claim is the left inequality with (ii) for $\alpha = 2t_0 \geq r$ and $\beta = 2t_1 + \sigma$. For the second, (ii) gives $C_k(\sigma') \geq c^{\sigma'/\sigma} C_k(0)$, and the right inequality at $\sigma'$ gives the claim, the two times being ordered because $\sigma' > 2(t_1 - t_0)$. □

So for the packet $g \otimes h$ the open input of Theorem 10.7(iv) follows from an inequality between two correlations of one slice field,

$$\liminf_k D_k(r')/D_k(r) > 0 \quad \text{for one pair } 0 < r < r' \text{ with } r \leq 2t_0,$$

and by (iii) a uniform bound for one packet gives one for every packet $g' \otimes h$ with $g'$ supported in $[t_1, \infty)$. The condition $r \leq 2t_0$ cannot be dropped: a bound at a later pair says nothing about an earlier packet, as $D_k(r) = (1 - 4^{-k})2^{-kr} + 4^{-k}2^{-r}$ shows, with $D_k(4)/D_k(3) \to \frac{1}{2}$ and $D_k(2)/D_k(1) \to 0$. A bound at a later pair does apply to the packet shifted forward in time, renormalised by its own reflected norm. The left inequality of (i) bounds the ratio without the comparison of $u$ with the packet that was needed after Proposition 10.8(ii). Every bound on such ratios proved in this paper, at strong coupling or through Theorem 10.4, is an upper bound of the form $e^{-m(r'-r)/a_k}$; the inequality above is the opposite one and says that the slice field does not put its weight on energies that diverge in physical units. Reflection positivity and positivity of the transfer matrix do not give it, since a lattice theory with a fixed mass in lattice units has both and its ratio tends to zero. It holds for the free field.

*Remark* 10.11. Let $D_k$ be defined as above for the massless free lattice field on $a_k\mathbb{Z}^4$ in place of $\Phi$, with $h \in C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R}^3)$ and the lattice heat flow for a physical time $t_f > 0$ in place of the gradient flow. With $\hat{p}^2 = \sum_i (2a_k^{-1}\sin(a_k p_i/2))^2$, $\cosh(a_k\omega) = 1 + a_k^2\hat{p}^2/2$ and $\hat{h}_k(p) = \sum_x a_k^3 h(a_k x) e^{-ia_k p\cdot x}$,

$$D_k(r) = \int_{[-\pi/a_k, \pi/a_k]^3} |\hat{h}_k(p)|^2 e^{-2t_f\hat{p}^2} \frac{e^{-r\omega}}{2a_k^{-1}\sinh(a_k\omega)} \frac{d^3p}{(2\pi)^3}.$$

On the Brillouin zone $\hat{p} \geq 2|p|/\pi$ and $a_k^2\hat{p}^2/2 \leq 6$; as $\operatorname{arccosh}(1+y)/\sqrt{2y}$ decreases on $(0, 6]$, $a_k\omega \geq \kappa a_k\hat{p}$ with $\kappa = \operatorname{arccosh} 7/\sqrt{12} > 0.76$, and $a_k^{-1}\sinh(a_k\omega) \geq \omega$. Since $|\hat{h}_k|$ is bounded uniformly in $k$, the integrands are dominated by a multiple of $e^{-8t_f|p|^2/\pi^2}/|p|$, which is integrable on $\mathbb{R}^3$, and they converge pointwise to $|\hat{h}(p)|^2 e^{-2t_f|p|^2} e^{-r|p|}/(2|p|)$. By dominated convergence $D_k(r')/D_k(r)$ tends to the corresponding positive ratio of continuum integrals; for $h = e^{-|x|^2}$, $t_f = 0.05$, $r = \frac{1}{2}$ and $r' = 1$ it is 0.6337.

*Remark* 10.12. The inequality also holds along the right tuning in two-dimensional $\mathrm{SU}(N)$ lattice gauge theory, which is interacting and nonabelian but has no propagating gluons. Take the lattice $a_k\mathbb{Z} \times a_k\mathbb{Z}_{L_k}$ with $a_k L_k = \ell$ fixed, the weight $\prod_p \exp(\frac{\beta_k}{N} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} U_p)$ with $\beta_k = 2N/(g^2 a_k^2)$, and the temporal gauge. A gauge-invariant function of the links of one slice depends only on the conjugacy class of their holonomy $V$ around the circle; this includes every spatially flowed and spatially smeared slice field, since the flow is gauge covariant. Let $w_\beta$ be the probability density proportional to $e^{\frac{\beta}{N}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} U}$ with respect to Haar measure and, for an irreducible representation $\lambda$ of dimension $d_\lambda$ and character $\chi_\lambda$, $\hat{c}_\lambda(\beta) = d_\lambda^{-1}\int \chi_\lambda w_\beta \, dU$. Between two slices put $W_x = V_x' V_x^{-1}$; the $W_x$ are independent with density $w_{\beta_k}$, which is invariant under conjugation and inversion, and

$$V_1' \cdots V_L' = W_1 \, (V_1 W_2 V_1^{-1}) \cdots \\ \cdots (V_1 \cdots V_{L-1} W_L (V_1 \cdots V_{L-1})^{-1}) \, V_1 \cdots V_L,$$

so the new holonomy is $QV$ with $Q$ distributed as the $L_k$-fold convolution of $w_{\beta_k}$, independent of $V$. By Schur's lemma (Lemma H.1) the transfer matrix acts on class functions by $\chi_\lambda \mapsto \hat{c}_\lambda(\beta_k)^{L_k}\chi_\lambda$. The coefficients are real, since $w_\beta$ is invariant under $U \mapsto \bar{U}$, nonnegative, since the exponential of $\frac{\beta}{2N}(\chi_{\mathrm{F}} + \bar{\chi}_{\mathrm{F}})$ is a sum of characters with nonnegative coefficients,

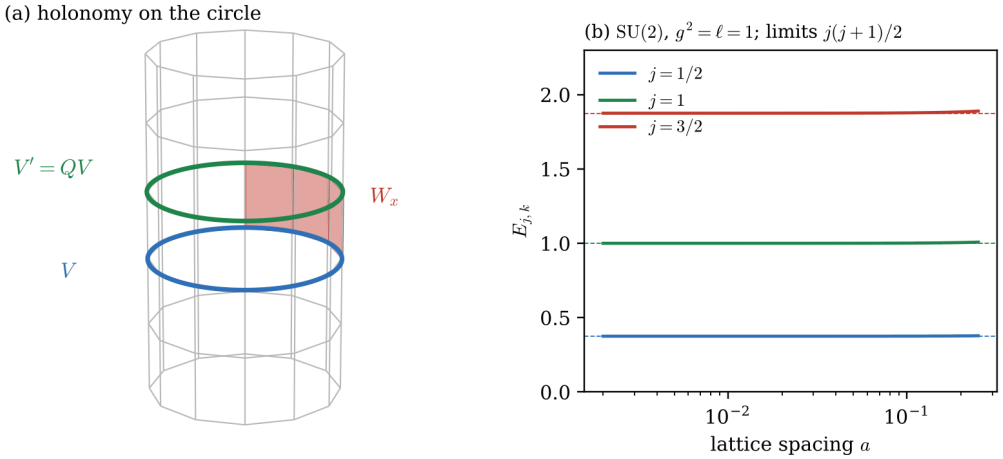



FIGURE 10. Two-dimensional SU($N$) (Remark 10.12). (a) The lattice $a_k\mathbb{Z} \times a_k\mathbb{Z}_{L_k}$ drawn as a cylinder: the holonomy $V$ of one slice, the holonomy $V' = QV$ of the next, and the plaquette variables $W_x$ between them. (b) The energies $E_{j,k} = -(\ell/a_k^2)\log \hat{c}_j(\beta_k)$ of SU(2) for $g^2 = \ell = 1$, with $\hat{c}_j(\beta) = I_{2j+1}(\beta)/I_1(\beta)$, against the lattice spacing; the dashed lines are the limits $j(j+1)/2$.

and below 1 for $\lambda \neq 0$. For a class function $f$ with $\int f\, dU = 0$ and isotypic components of norms $|\hat{f}_\lambda|$, the slice correlation is therefore

$$D_k(r) = \sum_{\lambda \neq 0} |\hat{f}_\lambda|^2 e^{-rE_{\lambda,k}}, \qquad E_{\lambda,k} = -\frac{\ell}{a_k^2}\log \hat{c}_\lambda(\beta_k).$$

Laplace's method[16] at the unique maximum $U = 1$ of $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} U$, with $U = e^X$, $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} e^X = N + \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} X^2 + O(|X|^4)$, $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} X^3 = 0$, $\operatorname{Tr}\rho_\lambda(X) = 0$ and $\sum_a \rho_\lambda(T_a)^2 = -2C_2(\lambda)$ for an orthonormal basis of $\mathfrak{su}(N)$ in the norm $-\operatorname{Tr} X^2$, gives $\hat{c}_\lambda(\beta) = 1 - NC_2(\lambda)/\beta + O(\beta^{-2})$, with the Casimir normalised by $C_2 = (N^2-1)/(2N)$ on the fundamental representation (Lemma H.2). Hence $E_{\lambda,k} \to g^2\ell C_2(\lambda)/2$, and since $D_k(r) \leq \|f\|^2$,

$$\liminf_k \frac{D_k(r')}{D_k(r)} \geq \frac{|\hat{f}_\mu|^2}{\|f\|^2} e^{-r'g^2\ell C_2(\mu)/2} > 0$$

for every $\mu \neq 0$ with $\hat{f}_\mu \neq 0$; for $f = \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} V$ the ratio is exactly $e^{-(r'-r)E_{\mathrm{F},k}} \to e^{-(r'-r)g^2\ell(N^2-1)/(4N)}$. This is the exact solution of two-dimensional lattice gauge theory, whose continuum limit is the measure of [40, 32, 52], written as the inequality. In two dimensions $g^2$ has the dimension of a mass squared and there is no ultraviolet problem, so the argument has no four-dimensional analogue. Nor does the spatial flow give the inequality by itself: it damps the spectral weight at large spatial momentum and leaves the weight at zero spatial momentum unchanged. For the free lattice field of Remark 10.11 with a mass $M_k$ and the same flow, every energy is at least $m_k = a_k^{-1}\operatorname{arccosh}(1 + a_k^2M_k^2/2)$, so $D_k(r') \leq e^{-m_k(r'-r)}D_k(r)$, which tends to zero relative to $D_k(r)$ when $a_kM_k$ is fixed.

A route to the slice ratio in four dimensions replaces the packet by its conditional expectations given averages of the field over blocks of increasing size and controls the error of each step. The free field shows in which norm such errors can be small. In the ordinary $L^2$ norm the first step already fails: conditioning on the averages over blocks of side two leaves a fixed fraction of the variance of an energy packet, at every lattice spacing.

[16] For a smooth function with a unique nondegenerate maximum, $\int e^{\beta\varphi}h$ has an expansion in powers of $\beta^{-1}$ whose coefficients are Gaussian moments at the maximum; Lemma H.2 carries it out here.

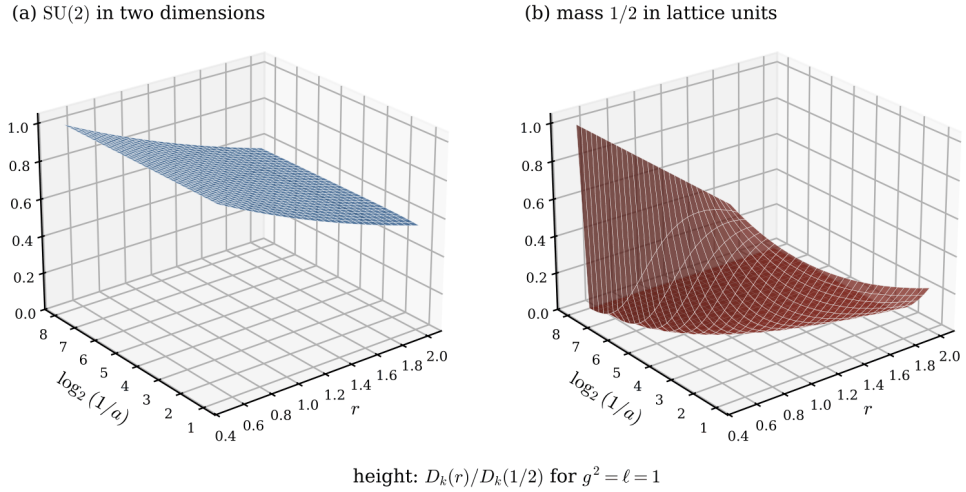



FIGURE 11. The ratio $D_k(r)/D_k(\frac{1}{2})$ over the separation $r$ and the lattice spacing $a_k$. (a) Two-dimensional SU(2) with $f = \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} V$ and $g^2 = \ell = 1$, where the ratio is $e^{-(r-1/2)E_{1/2,k}}$ and converges as $a_k \to 0$. (b) The term $e^{-(r-1/2)m_k}$ of the lowest energy $m_k$ of a free field with mass $\frac{1}{2}$ in lattice units, which bounds the ratio from above and tends to zero at every $r > \frac{1}{2}$.

**Proposition 10.13.** *Let $d \geq 2$, let $\Lambda$ be a periodic box in $\mathbb{Z}^d$ with even sides, let $\mu > 0$, and let $\phi$ be the Gaussian field on $\Lambda$ with density proportional to $\exp\bigl(-\frac{1}{2}\sum_{x,\nu}(\nabla_\nu\phi(x))^2 - \frac{\mu^2}{2}\sum_x \phi(x)^2\bigr)$, where $\nabla_\nu\phi(x) = \phi(x+e_\nu) - \phi(x)$. Let $\mathcal{Z}$ be a set of blocks $B = 2z + \{0,1\}^d$, let $\mathfrak{B}$ be the $\sigma$-algebra generated by the averages of $\phi$ over the blocks in $\mathcal{Z}$, let $f \geq 0$ on $\Lambda$, and let*

$$F = \sum_{x\in\Lambda} f(x) \sum_{\nu=1}^{d} {:}(\nabla_\nu\phi(x))^2{:},$$

*where ${:}X^2{:} = X^2 - \mathbb{E}X^2$. For $B = 2z + \{0,1\}^d$ put $x_B = 2z$, $y_B = 2z + e_1 + e_2$ and*

$$\alpha_B = \frac{1}{4} \sum_{w\in\{x_B, y_B\}} \Bigl(d\, f(w) + \sum_{\nu=1}^{d} f(w - e_\nu)\Bigr),$$

*and $\sigma^2 = 2/(2d + \mu^2)$.* (i) $\mathbb{E}\operatorname{Var}(F \mid \mathfrak{B}) \geq 2\sigma^4 \sum_{B\in\mathcal{Z}} \alpha_B^2$.

(ii) $\operatorname{Var} F \leq 2d^2 \sum_x f(x)^2$.

(iii) *Let $g \geq 0$ be a Lipschitz function on $\mathbb{R}^d$ with compact support and $\int g^2 > 0$. For $n \geq 1$ let $\Lambda_n$ contain $n \operatorname{supp} g$ in a fundamental domain, $f_n(x) = g(x/n)$, let $\mathcal{Z}_n$ contain every block that meets $n \operatorname{supp} g$, and let $\mu = \mu_n \to 0$. Then for the packets $F_n$ of $f_n$,*

$$\liminf_{n\to\infty} \frac{\mathbb{E}\operatorname{Var}(F_n \mid \mathfrak{B}_n)}{n^d \int g^2} \geq 2^{1-d}, \qquad \limsup_{n\to\infty} \frac{\operatorname{Var} F_n}{n^d \int g^2} \leq 2d^2,$$

*so $\mathbb{E}\operatorname{Var}(F_n \mid \mathfrak{B}_n) \geq (2^{-d}d^{-2} - o(1))\operatorname{Var} F_n$.*

*Proof.* (i) No two of the sites $x_B, y_B$, $B \in \mathcal{Z}$, are neighbours: their coordinate sums are even, and a neighbour of a site has a coordinate sum of the other parity. Let $\mathfrak{H} \supseteq \mathfrak{B}$ be generated by $\mathfrak{B}$ and by $\phi(w)$ for every $w$ outside $\{x_B, y_B : B \in \mathcal{Z}\}$. By the law of total variance, $\operatorname{Var}(F \mid \mathfrak{B}) = \mathbb{E}[\operatorname{Var}(F \mid \mathfrak{H}) \mid \mathfrak{B}] + \operatorname{Var}(\mathbb{E}[F \mid \mathfrak{H}] \mid \mathfrak{B})$, so $\mathbb{E}\operatorname{Var}(F \mid \mathfrak{B}) \geq \mathbb{E}\operatorname{Var}(F \mid \mathfrak{H})$. In the exponent of the density, a site $w$ enters through $(d + \frac{\mu^2}{2})\phi(w)^2$ and through $-\phi(w)\phi(w')$ for each of its $2d$ neighbours $w'$. Given $\mathfrak{H}$, the block average fixes $s_B = \phi(x_B) + \phi(y_B)$, and with $u_B = \phi(x_B) - \phi(y_B)$ we have $\phi(x_B)^2 + \phi(y_B)^2 = \frac{1}{2}(s_B^2 + u_B^2)$. Since the free sites have only $\mathfrak{H}$-measurable neighbours, the conditional density of $(u_B)_{B\in\mathcal{Z}}$ is proportional to $\prod_B \exp(-\frac{1}{4}(2d+\mu^2)u_B^2 + c_B u_B)$ with $\mathfrak{H}$-measurable $c_B$: the $u_B$ are conditionally independent

Gaussians of variance $\sigma^2$. A term $(\nabla_\nu\phi(w))^2$ contains at most one free site, and if it contains $x_B$, then $\phi(x_B) = \frac{1}{2}(s_B + u_B)$ shows that it is $\frac{1}{4}u_B^2$ plus a term linear in $u_B$ plus an $\mathfrak{H}$-measurable term; the same holds for $y_B$ with $-u_B$. The terms containing $x_B$ are those with $w = x_B$ and those with $w = x_B - e_\nu$, $d$ of each kind, so

$$F = \sum_{B\in\mathcal{Z}} (\alpha_B u_B^2 + \beta_B u_B) + F_0$$

with $\mathfrak{H}$-measurable $\beta_B$ and $F_0$. Writing $u_B = m_B + v_B$ with $m_B$ the conditional mean, $\alpha_B u_B^2 + \beta_B u_B = \alpha_B v_B^2 + (2\alpha_B m_B + \beta_B)v_B + \text{const}$, and for a centred Gaussian $v$ of variance $\sigma^2$, $\operatorname{Var}(\alpha v^2 + \gamma v) = 2\alpha^2\sigma^4 + \gamma^2\sigma^2$. By conditional independence, $\operatorname{Var}(F \mid \mathfrak{H}) \geq 2\sigma^4 \sum_B \alpha_B^2$.

(ii) For centred jointly Gaussian $X, Y$, $\operatorname{Cov}(:X^2:, :Y^2:) = 2\operatorname{Cov}(X,Y)^2$. With $G_{\nu\rho}(x,y) = \mathbb{E}[\nabla_\nu\phi(x)\nabla_\rho\phi(y)]$,

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{Var} F &= 2\sum_{x,y} f(x)f(y) \sum_{\nu,\rho} G_{\nu\rho}(x,y)^2 \\ &\leq \sum_{x,y} (f(x)^2 + f(y)^2) \sum_{\nu,\rho} G_{\nu\rho}(x,y)^2.\end{aligned}$$

On the dual torus $\Lambda^*$, with $\hat{p}^2 = \sum_\nu |e^{ip_\nu} - 1|^2$,

$$G_{\nu\rho}(x,y) = \frac{1}{|\Lambda|} \sum_{p\in\Lambda^*} \frac{(e^{ip_\nu} - 1)(e^{-ip_\rho} - 1)}{\hat{p}^2 + \mu^2} e^{ip\cdot(x-y)},$$

and by Parseval $\sum_y G_{\nu\rho}(x,y)^2 = |\Lambda|^{-1} \sum_p |e^{ip_\nu} - 1|^2 |e^{ip_\rho} - 1|^2 (\hat{p}^2 + \mu^2)^{-2} \leq 1$, since each factor $|e^{ip_\nu} - 1|^2$ is at most $\hat{p}^2$. The same holds for the sum over $x$, and (ii) follows.

(iii) If $\operatorname{Lip} g = K$, every site entering $\alpha_B$ lies within distance 3 of $2z$, so $|\alpha_B - d\, g(2z/n)| \leq 3dK/n$. Hence $\sum_{B\in\mathcal{Z}_n} \alpha_B^2 \geq \sum_z (d\, g(2z/n) - 3dK/n)_+^2$, the sum running over $z$ with $2z \in n \operatorname{supp} g$, and this is $d^2(n/2)^d \int g^2\,(1 + o(1))$ as a Riemann sum on the grid $(2/n)\mathbb{Z}^d$. Since $\sigma^4 = 4/(2d + \mu_n^2)^2 \to d^{-2}$, (i) gives the first bound. By (ii) and $\sum_x g(x/n)^2 = n^d \int g^2(1 + o(1))$, the second follows. □

For $d = 4$ and the energy density, $\operatorname{Var} F_n$ grows like $(\ell/a)^4$ at a fixed physical size $\ell$ of the packet, and no step of conditioning on block averages removes more than a fraction $1 - 2^{-d}d^{-2} + o(1)$ of it. The reflected norm $C_k(0) = \omega_k(\vartheta(\bar{A}_k)A_k)$, which renormalises the packet in Theorem 10.7, involves the covariance only between the support of $\vartheta f_0$ and that of $f_0$, at a fixed physical distance. The errors of a blocking route have therefore to be measured in that norm; Figure 12 shows the blocks between the reflection plane and the packet.

10.5. **Higher correlations.** Theorem 10.7 controls two renormalised fields at a time, and part (i) of it gives nothing for more: $Z_k$ may diverge while the fields $\Phi_x \circ \Phi_{s_k}$ stay bounded, so a bound on the norm of the renormalised packet as an operator is not available. A reflection positive process with a fixed gap and a two-point function independent of the cutoff can have divergent four-point functions at separated times (Remark 10.17), so no statement about the two-point function alone can replace the following hypothesis on the truncated correlations. In this subsection $\Phi$ is real-valued, as the energy of the plaquettes is; for a complex field the conjugate field has to be adjoined and (T1) imposed on all mixed cumulants. Write $\varphi_k(x) = \Phi_x \circ \Phi_{s_k}$, $\omega_k^T$ for the truncated correlations (joint cumulants) under $\omega_k$, and for $f \in C_c(\mathbb{R}^4)$

$$A_k(f) = \sum_{x\in\mathbb{Z}^4} a_k^4 f(a_k x)(\varphi_k(x) - \omega_k(\varphi_k(x))),$$

so that $A_k = A_k(f_0)$ and $\bar{A}_k(f) = A_k(\bar{f})$. Let $w_k : \mathbb{Z}^4 \to [0,\infty)$ be even functions with $W_k = \sum_x w_k(x) < \infty$, let $r_k > 0$ be amplitude scales, and consider:

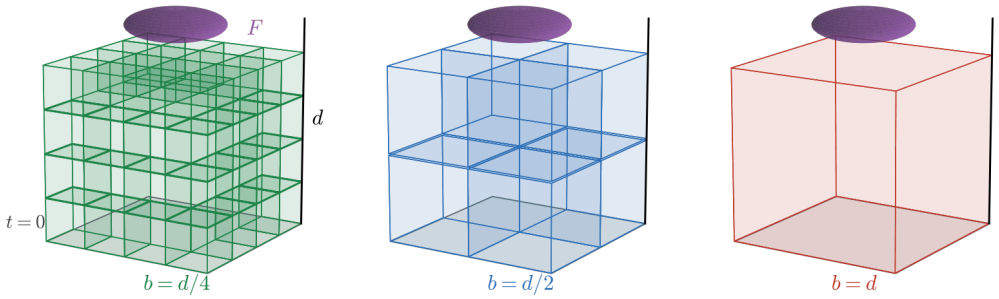



FIGURE 12. Block averages between the reflection plane $t = 0$ and a packet $F$ at physical height $d$, for blocks of side $d/4$, $d/2$ and $d$. By Proposition 10.13 the first conditioning step already leaves a fixed fraction of the ordinary variance of the packet, so the errors of such steps have to be measured in the reflected norm.

(T1) *Tree bounds.* For every $n \geq 2$ there is $K_n$, independent of $k$, with

$$|\omega_k^T(\varphi_k(x_1); \dots; \varphi_k(x_n))| \leq K_n r_k^n \sum_T \prod_{\{i,j\} \in T} w_k(x_i - x_j)$$

for all $x_1, \dots, x_n \in \mathbb{Z}^4$, the sum running over the trees $T$ on $\{1, \dots, n\}$.

(T2) *Saturation.* $C_k(0) \geq c\, r_k^2 a_k^4 W_k$ for a $c > 0$ and every $k$.

(T3) *Physical volume.* $B_* = \sup_k a_k^4 W_k < \infty$.

The amplitude $r_k$ separates the size of the field from the volume over which it is correlated; Remark 10.16 shows why it is needed. For a compact $Q \subset \mathbb{R}^4$ let $|Q|_k = a_k^4 \#\{x \in \mathbb{Z}^4 : a_k x \in Q\}$; for a cube of side $L$ it is at most $(L + a_0)^4$.

**Lemma 10.14.** *Under* (T1)*, for $n \geq 2$ and bounded $f_1, \dots, f_n$ with compact supports, $f_1$ supported in $Q$,*

$$|\omega_k^T(A_k(f_1); \dots; A_k(f_n))| \leq K_n n^{n-2} r_k^n\, |Q|_k\, (a_k^4 W_k)^{n-1} \prod_{j=1}^n \|f_j\|_\infty.$$

*Proof.* Joint cumulants of order $n \geq 2$ are multilinear and do not change when constants are added to the variables, so the left side is at most $a_k^{4n} \sum_{x_1, \dots, x_n} \prod_j |f_j(a_k x_j)|$ times the absolute value of the truncated correlation, the sums being finite. Insert (T1) and fix a tree $T$. With $x_1$ fixed, sum over the other points one at a time, each time over a leaf of what remains of $T$ other than 1; each such sum is at most $W_k$. The remaining sum over $x_1$ has at most $|Q|_k a_k^{-4}$ nonzero terms. There are $n^{n-2}$ trees. □

**Theorem 10.15.** *Assume* (T1)–(T3).

(i) *For $n \geq 2$, $f_j$ as in the lemma,*

$$|\omega_k^T(Z_k A_k(f_1); \dots; Z_k A_k(f_n))| \leq K_n n^{n-2} c^{-n/2}\, B_*^{n/2-1}\, |Q|_k \prod_{j=1}^n \|f_j\|_\infty,$$

*and the moments $\omega_k(\prod_j Z_k A_k(f_j))$ with all $f_j$ supported in a cube $Q$ are bounded by $M_n(Q) \prod_j \|f_j\|_\infty$, with $M_n(Q)$ independent of $k$.*

(ii) *Every sequence of $k$ has a subsequence along which*

$$S_n(f_1,\dots,f_n)=\lim_k \omega_k\Big(\prod_{j=1}^{n} Z_k A_k(f_j)\Big)$$

*exists for all $n$ and all $f_j\in C_c(\mathbb{R}^4)$. Each $S_n$ is symmetric, multilinear, bounded by $M_n(Q)\prod_j\|f_j\|_\infty$ on functions supported in $Q$, hence a distribution on $(\mathbb{R}^4)^n$; it is invariant under all translations of $\mathbb{R}^4$ if the $\omega_k$ are translation invariant, and the kernel $K$ of Theorem 10.7 along the subsequence is $K(y,y')=S_2(\overline{f_0(\cdot-y)}\circ\theta, f_0(\cdot-y'))$, with $\theta$ as in* (iii).

(iii) *Put $S_0=1$, $S_1=0$, and let $\theta$ be the reflection $t\mapsto -t$ of $\mathbb{R}^4$. For every finite family of $c_\alpha\in\mathbb{C}$ and $f_{\alpha,j}\in C_c(\mathbb{R}^4)$ supported in $\{t>0\}$,*

$$\sum_{\alpha,\beta}\bar c_\alpha c_\beta\, S\Big(\prod_j \overline{f_{\alpha,j}}\circ\theta\cdot\prod_j f_{\beta,j}\Big)\ge 0,$$

*where $S$ of a product of $n$ test functions means $S_n$. Hence the Osterwalder–Schrader construction gives a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$ with vacuum $\Omega$ and a dense set of vectors $\Psi(P)$ indexed by polynomials $P$ in the smeared fields at positive times, with $\langle\Psi(P),\Psi(P')\rangle=S(\theta\bar P\cdot P')$; in particular the separated higher correlations of the renormalised fields are finite. The vector $\Psi(P_0)$ of the field smeared by $f_0$ is a unit vector orthogonal to $\Omega$.*

(iv) *Suppose the $\omega_k$ are translation invariant. Then the time translations by $t\ge 0$ define on $\mathcal{H}$ a strongly continuous semigroup $e^{-tH}$ with $H\ge 0$ self-adjoint, and the spatial translations a strongly continuous unitary group commuting with $H$. Moreover there is a dyadic $\sigma>0$ with $C_k(\sigma)\ge\frac12 C_k(0)$ for all large $k$, so the limit of Theorem 10.7 is nontrivial.*

(v) *If $a_k^4W_k\to 0$ along the subsequence, every $S_n$ is given by Wick's rule from $S_2$: the limit is the Gaussian field with covariance $S_2$.*

(vi) *If the $\omega_k$ are translation invariant and the hypothesis of Theorem 10.4 holds, then $0$ is a simple eigenvalue of $H$ and $\sigma(H)\subset\{0\}\cup[m_*,\infty)$ with $m_*=\log(1/\alpha)/(2\ell)$, and $\Omega^\perp\neq 0$.*

*Proof.* (i) By (T2), $Z_k^n=C_k(0)^{-n/2}$ is at most $(c\,r_k^2a_k^4W_k)^{-n/2}$; multiply the lemma by it, which cancels $r_k^n$, and use $(a_k^4W_k)^{n/2-1}\le B_*^{n/2-1}$ by (T3) for $n\ge 2$. A moment is the sum over partitions of $\{1,\dots,n\}$ of the products of the cumulants of the blocks; blocks of size one vanish because $A_k(f)$ is centred, and each block contributes the bound just proved with $|Q|_k\le(L+a_0)^4$ for a cube of side $L$. This gives $M_n(Q)$.

(ii) For each cube $Q_L=[-L,L]^4$, $L\in\mathbb{N}$, the continuous functions supported in $Q_L$ form a separable space under the supremum norm. Choose a countable dense set $\mathcal{F}$ of functions; by (i) the countably many sequences $\omega_k(\prod Z_kA_k(f_j))$, $f_j\in\mathcal{F}$, are bounded, and a diagonal subsequence makes all of them converge. By multilinearity,

$$\begin{aligned}&\Big|\omega_k\Big(\prod_j Z_kA_k(f_j)\Big)-\omega_k\Big(\prod_j Z_kA_k(g_j)\Big)\Big|\\&\qquad\le M_n(Q)\sum_i\|f_i-g_i\|_\infty\prod_{j\neq i}\max(\|f_j\|_\infty,\|g_j\|_\infty)\end{aligned}$$

for functions supported in $Q$, so the limits exist for all $f_j\in C_c(\mathbb{R}^4)$ and obey the same bound. Symmetry and multilinearity pass to the limit. A multilinear form bounded in this way is separately continuous on $C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R}^4)$, so the Schwartz kernel theorem makes it a distribution. For dyadic $y$ and large $k$, $y/a_k\in\mathbb{Z}^4$ and translation invariance of $\omega_k$ and of the flow (Proposition 10.6(i)) give $\omega_k(\prod Z_kA_k(f_j(\cdot-y)))=\omega_k(\prod Z_kA_k(f_j))$. For a real $y$ take dyadic $y_m\to y$; the functions $f_j(\cdot-y_m)$ converge uniformly to $f_j(\cdot-y)$ with supports in one cube, so the bound above carries the invariance to $y$. The formula for $K$ follows from $A_k^y=A_k(f_0(\cdot-y))$ and the argument of (iii) with $n=2$.

(iii) Let $\vartheta$ be the lattice reflection of Appendix F and $\theta_k$ the corresponding reflection of $a_k\mathbb{Z}^4$; it differs from $\theta$ by a translation of length at most $a_k$. Since $\Phi$ is real and $\vartheta$ commutes with the flow, $\vartheta(\bar{A}_k(f)) = A_k(\bar{f}\circ\theta_k)$. Let $P_k = \sum_\beta c_\beta \prod_j Z_k A_k(f_{\beta,j})$ and $R_k = \sum_\alpha \bar{c}_\alpha \prod_j Z_k A_k(\overline{f_{\alpha,j}}\circ\theta)$, so that $\vartheta(\bar{P}_k)$ is $R_k$ with $\theta$ replaced by $\theta_k$. Reflection positivity gives $\omega_k(\vartheta(\bar{P}_k)P_k)\geq 0$. By (i), applied in a cube containing all the supports and their reflections, and by multilinearity, $|\omega_k(\vartheta(\bar{P}_k)P_k) - \omega_k(R_kP_k)|$ is at most a constant independent of $k$ times $\max_{\alpha,j}\|f_{\alpha,j}\circ\theta_k - f_{\alpha,j}\circ\theta\|_\infty$, which tends to zero by uniform continuity, while $\omega_k(R_kP_k)$ tends to the left side of (iii) by (ii). So the limit of the nonnegative numbers is the left side of (iii). The construction of $\mathcal{H}$ is the usual quotient of the polynomials at positive times by the null space of this form [62]. By the same approximation of $\theta$ by $\theta_k$, $\|\Psi(P_0)\|^2 = \lim_k Z_k^2 C_k(0) = 1$, and $\langle\Omega,\Psi(P_0)\rangle = S_1(f_0) = 0$.

(iv) For a polynomial $P$ at positive times let $\tau_tP$ be its time translate by $t\geq 0$, again at positive times. By translation invariance and $\theta\circ\tau_t = \tau_{-t}\circ\theta$, $\langle\Psi(\tau_tP),\Psi(P')\rangle = \langle\Psi(P),\Psi(\tau_tP')\rangle$, and $q_P(t) = \|\Psi(\tau_tP)\|^2 = \langle\Psi(P),\Psi(\tau_{2t}P)\rangle$. If $P$ has degree at most $d$, every partition in (i) of the products in $q_P(t)$ has at most $d$ blocks, each bounded by a multiple of $|Q|_k$ for a cube $Q$ of side $O(1+t)$, so $q_P(t)\leq C_P(1+t)^{4d}$. The Cauchy–Schwarz inequality gives $q_P(t)\leq q_P(0)^{1/2}q_P(2t)^{1/2}$, hence by induction $q_P(t)\leq q_P(0)^{1-2^{-m}}q_P(2^mt)^{2^{-m}}$ for every $m$, and letting $m\to\infty$, $q_P(t)\leq q_P(0)$. So $\tau_t$ maps null vectors to null vectors and extends to a symmetric contraction $\mathsf{T}(t)$ of $\mathcal{H}$; $\mathsf{T}(s)\mathsf{T}(t) = \mathsf{T}(s+t)$, and $\mathsf{T}(t) = \mathsf{T}(t/2)^2\geq 0$. By the bound of (ii) and uniform continuity of the translated test functions, $\|\Psi(\tau_tP) - \Psi(P)\|\to 0$ as $t\to 0$, so the semigroup is strongly continuous on a dense set, hence everywhere, and $\mathsf{T}(t) = e^{-tH}$ with $H\geq 0$ self-adjoint [62]. Spatial translations preserve the form, have the opposite translations as inverses, commute with $\tau_t$, and are strongly continuous by the same argument.

For the ratio let $f_{0,t} = f_0(\cdot - (t,0))$. For dyadic $t>0$ and large $k$, translation invariance gives $\tau_{t/a_k}A_k = A_k(f_{0,t})$, so by (iii)

$$C_k(t) - C_k(0) = \omega_k\big(A_k(\bar{f}_0\circ\theta_k)\,A_k(f_{0,t} - f_0)\big),$$

a covariance of two centred fields. The case $n=2$ of (i) bounds $Z_k^2$ times it by $L_0\|f_{0,t} - f_0\|_\infty$ with $L_0 = (K_2/c)\sup_k|Q|_k\|f_0\|_\infty$, $Q$ a cube containing the supports of $f_0\circ\theta_k$ for all $k$. By uniform continuity of $f_0$ there is a dyadic $\sigma>0$ with $L_0\|f_{0,\sigma} - f_0\|_\infty\leq\frac{1}{2}$; then $C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0)\geq\frac{1}{2}$, and Theorem 10.7(iv) applies.

(v) For $n\geq 3$ the exponent $n/2-1$ in (i) is positive, so with $(a_k^4W_k)^{n/2-1}$ in place of $B_*^{n/2-1}$ the cumulants of order $n\geq 3$ of the renormalised fields tend to zero. The moments are the sums over partitions of products of cumulants, so in the limit only the partitions into pairs remain, which is Wick's rule.

(vi) As in the proof of Theorem 10.4, $\mathbb{T}_k$ has gap at least $\log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k)$ on the complement of $\Omega_k$. For a polynomial $P$ at positive times let $v_k = \Psi_{P_k} - \omega_k(P_k)\Omega_k$ with $P_k$ its lattice version. For dyadic $t$ and large $k$,

$$\omega_k(\vartheta(\bar{P}_k)\tau_{t/a_k}P_k) - |\omega_k(P_k)|^2 = \langle v_k,\mathbb{T}_k^{t/a_k}v_k\rangle\leq e^{-m_*t}\|v_k\|^2,$$

and both sides are finite combinations of moments, which converge by (ii) and the approximation of $\theta$ in (iii). The limit is $\langle v,e^{-tH}v\rangle\leq e^{-m_*t}\|v\|^2$ for $v = \Psi(P) - \langle\Omega,\Psi(P)\rangle\Omega$. These $v$ are dense in $\Omega^\perp$, so the inequality holds on $\Omega^\perp$ for all $t\geq 0$, and the spectral theorem gives the spectral statement as in Theorem 10.4. By (iii), $\Psi(P_0)$ is a unit vector in $\Omega^\perp$. □

Part (iv) shows that the order-two cases of (T1) and (T2) already contain the lower bound on the ratio that Theorem 10.7(iv) needs; they are not harmless combinatorial assumptions, and proving them along the continuum tuning is at least as hard as that lower bound. Part (vi) passes the conditional mass gap of Theorem 10.4 to every polynomial in the smeared fields. Neither part proves Euclidean invariance, independence of the limit

from the subsequence, or the reconstruction of the field operators, for which the growth of $M_n(Q)$ in $n$ would also be needed.

*Remark* 10.16. The amplitude scale cannot be dropped for a bounded field. Suppose $\operatorname{Var}\varphi_k(0) \to 0$, as for the energy of the flowed plaquettes in lattice units when the flowed links approach the identity. Reflection invariance of $\omega_k$, the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality and stationarity give

$$C_k(0) \le \omega_k(|A_k|^2) \le \Big(a_k^4 \sum_x |f_0(a_k x)|\Big)^2 \operatorname{Var}\varphi_k(0) \to 0.$$

With $r_k = 1$, (T2) then forces $a_k^4 W_k \to 0$, and by part (v) the limit is Gaussian. With $r_k^2$ of the order of $\operatorname{Var}\varphi_k(0)$ this is no longer forced. Choosing $r_k$ does not prove (T1) or (T2).

*Remark* 10.17. Let $0 < \epsilon < 1$, $m > 0$, let $\pi$ be the probability measure on $\{-1, 0, 1\}$ with weights $\epsilon/2$, $1-\epsilon$, $\epsilon/2$, and let $P_t = e^{-mt} I + (1 - e^{-mt})\Pi$ on $L^2(\pi)$, where $\Pi f = \pi(f)$ is the projection onto the constants. This is a symmetric Markov semigroup with $P_t \ge 0$ and gap $m$, so its stationary process is reflection positive. For $X(s) = s/\sqrt{\epsilon}$ we have $\pi(X) = \pi(X^3) = 0$, $\pi(X^2) = 1$, $\pi(X^4) = 1/\epsilon$ and $P_t X = e^{-mt} X$, so the two-point function is $e^{-mt}$ for every $\epsilon$, while for $t_1 \le t_2 \le t_3 \le t_4$ and $q_i = e^{-m(t_{i+1} - t_i)}$ the four-point function is $q_3\, \pi\big(X P_{t_2 - t_1}(X P_{t_3 - t_2} X^2)\big) = q_1 q_3 (q_2/\epsilon + 1 - q_2)$, with truncated part $q_1 q_3 (q_2/\epsilon - q_2 - 2q_2^2)$; both diverge as $\epsilon \to 0$. By part (i), no choice of amplitude scales makes (T1)–(T3) hold for this family with constants independent of $\epsilon$.

The hypotheses (T1)–(T3) are uniform cluster estimates for the continuum tuning $\beta_k \to \infty$, and the next proposition shows that they are estimates at a critical point: with the order-two cases alone the lattice gap is at most a fixed multiple of $a_k$, and the tree majorant carries a fixed fraction of its weight at a fixed physical distance. Let $m_k \in [0, \infty]$ be the gap of $\mathbb{T}_k$ on the complement of $\Omega_k$, so that $\|\mathbb{T}_k v\| \le e^{-m_k}\|v\|$ for $v \perp \Omega_k$, and let $t_0 > 0$ be the least time in the support of $f_0$.

**Proposition 10.18.** (i) *For every dyadic $\sigma > 0$ and every large $k$, $C_k(\sigma) \le e^{-m_k \sigma/a_k} C_k(0)$. If $m_k/a_k \to \infty$, every limit of Theorem 10.7 is trivial; this is the case for $\beta_k = \beta$ fixed in the range of Theorem 1.5, where $m_k \ge m_G(\beta)$.*

(ii) *Suppose the $\omega_k$ are translation invariant and* (T1) *for $n = 2$ and* (T2) *hold. Then $m_k \le a_k \log 2/\sigma$ for every large $k$, where $\sigma$ is the dyadic number of Theorem 10.15*(iv)*, which depends only on $K_2/c$ and $f_0$. If also the hypothesis of Theorem 10.4 holds, then $m_* a_k \le m_k \le a_k \log 2/\sigma$, and in particular $m_* \le \log 2/\sigma$.*

(iii) *Under* (T1) *for $n = 2$ and* (T2)*, let $Q$ be a cube containing the support of $f_0$ and $\gamma = c/(K_2 \|f_0\|_\infty^2 \sup_k |Q|_k)$. Then for every $k$*

$$\sum_{z \in \mathbb{Z}^4,\ |z_0| \ge R_k} w_k(z) \ge \gamma\, W_k, \qquad R_k = \frac{2t_0}{a_k} - 1.$$

*If $w_k(z) = e^{-\mu_k |z_0|} u_k(\bar z)$ with $\bar z$ the spatial part of $z$ and $u_k \ge 0$ summable on $\mathbb{Z}^3$, then $\mu_k R_k \le \log(2/\gamma)$, so the physical time decay rate of the majorant is at most $\log(2/\gamma)/(2t_0 - a_k)$.*

*Proof.* (i) In the proof of Theorem 10.7, $C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0) = \langle \Psi_k, \mathbb{T}_k^{\sigma/a_k} \Psi_k \rangle$ with $\Psi_k$ a unit vector orthogonal to $\Omega_k$. The operator $\mathbb{T}_k$ is self-adjoint and fixes $\Omega_k$, so it preserves the complement, and the inequality follows. If $m_k/a_k \to \infty$ then $\rho(\sigma) = 0$ for every dyadic $\sigma > 0$ along every subsequence, and the limit is trivial by Theorem 10.7(iv). At fixed $\beta$ in the range of Theorem 1.5 the gap is at least $m_G(\beta) > 0$ in lattice units, and $a_k \to 0$; the spatial flow does not change the transfer matrix (Proposition 10.6(iv)).

(ii) Theorem 10.15(iv) uses (T1) and (T2) only for $n = 2$, since the exponent $n/2 - 1$ in part (i) vanishes there, and gives $C_k(\sigma) \ge \frac{1}{2} C_k(0)$ for large $k$. With (i), $e^{-m_k \sigma/a_k} \ge \frac{1}{2}$. Under the hypothesis of Theorem 10.4, the proof of that theorem gives $m_k \ge \log(1/\alpha)/(2n_k) \ge m_* a_k$.

(iii) $C_k(0) = \omega_k(A_k(\bar f_0 \circ \theta_k)A_k(f_0))$, a covariance of two centred fields, by the proof of Theorem 10.15(iv). A point $x$ in the support of the first sum has $a_k x_0 \le -t_0 + a_k$, and a point $y$ in the support of the second has $a_k y_0 \ge t_0$, so $|x_0 - y_0| \ge R_k$. By (T1) for $n = 2$,

$$\begin{aligned} C_k(0) &\le K_2 r_k^2 \|f_0\|_\infty^2 \, a_k^8 \sum_{a_k y \in Q} \sum_{|x_0 - y_0| \ge R_k} w_k(x - y) \\ &\le K_2 r_k^2 \|f_0\|_\infty^2 |Q|_k \, a_k^4 \sum_{|z_0| \ge R_k} w_k(z), \end{aligned}$$

and (T2) bounds the left side below by $c\, r_k^2 a_k^4 W_k$. For the product form let $R' = \lceil R_k \rceil$; if $R' \le 0$ there is nothing to prove, and otherwise

$$\frac{\sum_{|j| \ge R'} e^{-\mu_k |j|}}{\sum_{j \in \mathbb{Z}} e^{-\mu_k |j|}} = \frac{2e^{-\mu_k R'}}{1 + e^{-\mu_k}} \le 2e^{-\mu_k R_k},$$

while the factor $\sum_{\bar z} u_k(\bar z)$ cancels. So $2e^{-\mu_k R_k} \ge \gamma$. □

So reflection positivity and decay do not supply (T2): at fixed $\beta$ in the range of Theorem 1.5 the measures are reflection positive with exponential clustering, and $C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0) \to 0$, so no choice of $w_k$, $r_k$ and constants satisfies the order-two cases of (T1) and (T2) together there. For the same reason no estimate whose constants give a lattice gap bounded below, as a convergent strong coupling expansion does [64], can give the tree bounds along the tuning: (T1) and (T2) hold, if at all, only along couplings where the lattice gap closes at least as fast as $a_k$. A mass gap in physical units, which bounds the decay of the two-point function, does not give the constants $K_n$ either. By Theorem 10.15(v) the limit can be non-Gaussian only if $\liminf_k a_k^4 W_k > 0$; for the product majorants of part (iii) the time factor of $W_k$ is $\coth(\mu_k/2) \ge 2/\mu_k$, which is of order $1/a_k$ at least, so the time direction alone is compatible with this. At a fixed physical flow time the flowed fields are smooth on the scale $\sqrt{\tau}$; majorants of product form for them are not proved here.

The order-two cases of (T1) and (T2) say more about the reference vector than part (iv) of Theorem 10.15 records: for a smooth $f_0$ they bound every time difference of the packet, which makes its energy distribution tight with finite moments and gives the ratio with an explicit rate. Recall the spectral measures $\mu_k$ on $[0, \infty]$ of the proof of Theorem 10.7, so that $C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0) = \int e^{-\sigma E} d\mu_k(E)$.

**Proposition 10.19.** *Suppose the $\omega_k$ are translation invariant,* (T1) *holds for $n = 2$ and* (T2) *holds, and $f_0$ has $m \ge 1$ continuous time derivatives. Let $Q$ be a cube containing the supports of $f_0(\cdot - (s, 0))$ for $0 \le s \le m a_0$, and $B_m = (K_2/c) \sup_k |Q|_k \, \|\partial_t^m f_0\|_\infty^2$.*

(i) *$\|(1 - \mathbb{T}_k)^m \Psi_k\|^2 \le B_m a_k^{2m}$ for every $k$, where $\Psi_k = Z_k \Psi_{A_k}$.*

(ii) *$\int \big((1 - e^{-a_k E})/a_k\big)^{2m} d\mu_k(E) \le B_m$ and $\mu_k([\Lambda, \infty]) \le B_m (a_k + \Lambda^{-1})^{2m}$ for $\Lambda > 0$. Every weak limit $\mu$ of the $\mu_k$ satisfies $\mu(\{\infty\}) = 0$ and $\int E^{2m} d\mu(E) \le B_m$. If* (T1)–(T3) *hold, the unit vector $\Psi(P_0)$ of Theorem 10.15*(iii)–(iv) *lies in the domain of $H^m$, with $\|H^m \Psi(P_0)\|^2 \le B_m$.*

(iii) *If $a_k \sqrt{B_1} \le \frac{1}{2}$, then $C_k(\sigma) \ge e^{-2\sqrt{B_1}\sigma} C_k(0)$ for every $\sigma \in a_k \mathbb{Z}_{\ge 0}$, and the gap $m_k$ of Proposition 10.18 satisfies $m_k \le -\log(1 - a_k \sqrt{B_1}) \le 2\sqrt{B_1}\, a_k$.*

*Proof.* (i) Let $D_k f_0 = \sum_{j=0}^m (-1)^j \binom{m}{j} f_0(\cdot - (j a_k, 0))$. By translation invariance $\mathbb{T}_k^j \Psi_{A_k} = \Psi_{\tau_j A_k}$ and $\tau_j A_k = A_k(f_0(\cdot - (j a_k, 0)))$, so $(1 - \mathbb{T}_k)^m \Psi_{A_k} = \Psi_{A_k(D_k f_0)}$, and as in the proof of Theorem 10.15(iv) its squared norm is the covariance $\omega_k(A_k(\overline{D_k f_0} \circ \theta_k) A_k(D_k f_0))$. The function $D_k f_0$ is supported in $Q$ and is an $m$-th difference with step $a_k$, so $\|D_k f_0\|_\infty \le a_k^m \|\partial_t^m f_0\|_\infty$. Lemma 10.14 with $n = 2$ bounds the covariance by $K_2 r_k^2 |Q|_k \, a_k^4 W_k \|D_k f_0\|_\infty^2$, and (T2) bounds $C_k(0) = Z_k^{-2}$ below by $c\, r_k^2 a_k^4 W_k$.

(ii) By the spectral theorem the left side of (i) is $\int (1 - e^{-a_k E})^{2m} d\mu_k$, the integrand being 1 at $E = \infty$. For $E \ge \Lambda$, $(1 - e^{-a_k E})/a_k \ge (1 - e^{-a_k \Lambda})/a_k \ge \Lambda/(1 + a_k \Lambda)$, because $1 - e^{-x} \ge x/(1 + x)$; this gives the tail bound. The set $(\Lambda, \infty]$ is open in $[0, \infty]$, so

$\mu((\Lambda,\infty]) \le \liminf_k \mu_k((\Lambda,\infty]) \le B_m\Lambda^{-2m}$, and $\mu(\{\infty\}) = 0$. For a continuous $\chi$ with $0 \le \chi \le 1$ and support in $[0, L]$, the same inequality gives $E \le (1 + a_k L)(1 - e^{-a_k E})/a_k$ on that support, so $\int \chi E^{2m} d\mu = \lim_k \int \chi E^{2m} d\mu_k \le B_m$; letting $\chi$ increase to 1 gives the moment bound. The vector $\Psi(P_0)$ has $\langle \Psi(P_0), e^{-\sigma H}\Psi(P_0)\rangle = \lim_k C_k(\sigma)/C_k(0) = \int e^{-\sigma E} d\mu$ for dyadic $\sigma > 0$ along the subsequence, so its spectral measure for $H$ is $\mu$.

(iii) By (i) with $m = 1$ and the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality, $\langle \Psi_k, (1 - \mathbb{T}_k)\Psi_k\rangle \le a_k\sqrt{B_1}$, which is the hypothesis of Proposition 10.8(ii) with $C = \sqrt{B_1}$. Since $\Psi_k$ is a unit vector orthogonal to $\Omega_k$, the same quantity is at least $1 - e^{-m_k}$. □

Part (iii) makes Proposition 10.18(ii) explicit: the order-two tree and saturation bounds pin the lattice gap below $2\sqrt{B_1}\, a_k$, a physical mass of at most $2\sqrt{B_1}$, and give the ratio of Theorem 10.7(iv) at every separation. The open input of Theorem 10.7 is therefore implied by these two bounds for one smooth $f_0$; nothing here proves them for the Wilson action.

## 11. The open inputs

This section states the two unproved inputs of Section 10, the cube estimate and the limit, and measures the first: what can be controlled uniformly in the coupling, and what any proof of the cube estimate has to produce.

11.1. **The two open statements.** Theorem 10.4 reduces a continuum mass gap to two statements, neither of which is proved here or, to our knowledge, anywhere else.

(D) *The cube estimate.* There are $\alpha < 1$ and $\ell > 0$ such that $D(n, \alpha)$ holds with $na \le \ell$ along the continuum tuning $\beta = \beta(a) \to \infty$, uniformly in $a$.

(E) *The limit.* The renormalised Schwinger functions converge along $a_k = 2^{-k}a_0$ to Schwinger functions that satisfy the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms and are not those of the vacuum alone.

(D) and (E) together give the mass gap of the continuum theory; the remaining Clay requirements, Euclidean invariance and the local structure of the limit [47], belong to (E). (D) is a statement about a single cube of fixed physical size and a single coupling at each spacing; (E) is the construction problem, on which Bałaban's renormalisation group analysis [5, 6, 7] gives the ultraviolet part in finite volume.

*Remark* 11.1. The following count relates (D) to a correlation length. Suppose that the gauge-fixed field responds to a change of one link on the boundary of a cube through a Poisson kernel with decay length $\xi$ in lattice units. Then the response summed over the cube is of order $\xi$, so $K_c$ is of order $n^3\xi$ and $D(n, \alpha)$ holds once $n \gtrsim \xi/\alpha$, that is, once $\ell \gtrsim \xi a/\alpha$, a fixed multiple of the physical correlation length. The hypothesis is that the gauge-fixed links decorrelate on the scale $\xi$, and it is a statement about the gauge, not about the gauge-invariant observables: the gauge here is built on straight lines, and in gauges of axial type the gauge-fixed variables can fluctuate on all scales while gauge-invariant observables cluster. Propositions 11.2 and 11.3 carry the count out exactly for Gaussian fields, and Proposition 11.3 shows that the quadratic approximation of the forest gauge fluctuates in this way. Where it does, (D) fails in this gauge and has to be posed for block-averaged variables, where it becomes part of the renormalisation group problem. Section 12.1 carries this out in the quadratic approximation.

The count of Remark 11.1 can be carried out exactly for a Gaussian field, the quadratic approximation of the gauge-fixed theory at weak coupling, and shows what (D) asks of the gauge-fixed variables.

**Proposition 11.2.** *Let $d \ge 1$, $b > 0$, $t \ge 0$, let $n \ge 2$ be even and $V = [0, n)^d \cap \mathbb{Z}^d$. Given $\eta \in \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{Z}^d \setminus V}$, let $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$ be the Gaussian law on $\mathbb{R}^V$ with density proportional to*

$$\exp\Big(-\frac{b}{2}\Big[\sum_{\{x,y\}\cap V \ne \emptyset} (\phi_x - \phi_y)^2 + t\sum_{x\in V}\phi_x^2\Big]\Big),$$

*the first sum over nearest-neighbour pairs, with $\phi = \eta$ outside $V$. Define $C_{V,j}$, the classes $c$ (residues modulo two) and $K_c$ as above, with $d_V(\phi,\phi') = \sum_{x\in V}|\phi_x - \phi'_x|$ and $\delta(\eta_j,\eta'_j) = |\eta_j - \eta'_j|$, and put $N_n = (n/2)^d$. Then $K_c = \alpha_n(t)N_n$ for every class $c$, where*

$$\alpha_n(t) = 1 - \frac{t}{n^d}\,\mathbf{1}^{\mathsf T}(t + L_n)^{-1}\mathbf{1}$$

*and $L_n$ is the Dirichlet Laplacian of $V$. In particular:*

(i) *for $t = 0$, $K_c = N_n$ for every $n$ and every $b$, so $D(n,\alpha)$ fails for every $\alpha < 1$;*
(ii) *for $t > 0$, $1 - \alpha_n(t) \ge (5/6)^d\, tn^2/(tn^2 + 10d)$; for $d = 4$, $t = m^2a^2$ and $\ell/2 \le na \le \ell$ this gives $D(n,\alpha)$ with $\alpha = 1 - (5/6)^4(m\ell)^2/((m\ell)^2 + 160)$, uniformly in $a$.*

*Proof.* Let $A = t + L_n$ and $G = A^{-1}$, and let $B$ be the matrix with $B_{xj} = 1$ when $x \in V$ and $j \notin V$ are neighbours. The law $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$ has covariance $b^{-1}G$ and mean $GB\eta$. The matrix $A$ has nonpositive off-diagonal entries and is positive definite, so $G \ge 0$ entrywise. Changing $\eta_j$ by $\Delta$ translates the law by $\Delta\, GB_j$, where $B_j$ is the column of $j$. The coupling by translation gives $W_1^{d_V} \le |\Delta| \sum_x (GB_j)_x$, and the 1-Lipschitz function $\sum_x \phi_x$ gives the reverse inequality, so $C_{V,j} = \mathbf{1}^{\mathsf T}GB_j$. Since $B\mathbf{1} = L_n\mathbf{1}$ (both count the exterior neighbours of each site),

$$\sum_{j\notin V} C_{V,j} = \mathbf{1}^{\mathsf T}GL_n\mathbf{1} = \mathbf{1}^{\mathsf T}\mathbf{1} - t\,\mathbf{1}^{\mathsf T}G\mathbf{1} = n^d\alpha_n(t).$$

The reflection $x_i \mapsto n-1-x_i$ preserves $V$ and the coefficients and, as $n$ is even, exchanges the two residues of the coordinate $x_i$; so the $2^d$ class sums are equal, and each is $n^d\alpha_n(t)/2^d = \alpha_n(t)N_n$. This proves the formula and (i).

For (ii) let $v(i) = (i+1)(n-i)$ for $0 \le i < n$ and $\psi(x) = \prod_i v(x_i)$. The one-dimensional Dirichlet Laplacian maps $v$ to the constant 2, so with $s_1 = \sum_i v(i) = n(n+1)(n+2)/6$ and $s_2 = \sum_i v(i)^2 = n(n+1)(n+2)(n^2+2n+2)/30$,

$$\mathbf{1}^{\mathsf T}\psi = s_1^d, \qquad \psi^{\mathsf T}A\psi = ts_2^d + 2ds_1s_2^{d-1}.$$

By the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality for the form of $A^{-1}$, $\mathbf{1}^{\mathsf T}G\mathbf{1} \ge (\mathbf{1}^{\mathsf T}\psi)^2/\psi^{\mathsf T}A\psi$, hence

$$1 - \alpha_n(t) \ge \Big(\frac{s_1^2}{ns_2}\Big)^d \frac{t}{t + 2ds_1/s_2} \ge \Big(\frac{5}{6}\Big)^d \frac{tn^2}{tn^2 + 10d},$$

since $s_1^2/(ns_2) = \frac{5}{6}(n^2+3n+2)/(n^2+2n+2) \ge \frac{5}{6}$ and $2ds_1/s_2 = 10d/(n^2+2n+2) \le 10d/n^2$. With $d = 4$ and $tn^2 = m^2(na)^2 \ge (m\ell)^2/4$ the last fraction is at least $(m\ell)^2/((m\ell)^2 + 160)$. □

The Gaussian field is not Yang–Mills theory, and the proposition is a benchmark for the condition, not a statement about the Wilson measure. It shows that the averaged cube condition is met at a fixed physical scale by a field with a mass and fails exactly, at every size and every stiffness, for a massless one. Small local fluctuations alone therefore give nothing: in the massless Gaussian field on $\mathbb{Z}^d$, $d \ge 3$, the variance of $\phi_x - \phi_{x+e_1}$ is $1/(db)$, which tends to zero as $b \to \infty$, and still $K_c = N_n$. A proof of (D) along the tuning has to produce in the gauge-fixed variables the loss that the parameter $t$ supplies here, from the Wilson action alone.

The quadratic approximation of the forest gauge itself, with the plaquette action in place of the Laplacian, is no better than the massless field of Proposition 11.2(i).

**Proposition 11.3.** *Let $b > 0$, let $n$ be even and $V$ the cube of Definition 10.1. For real functions $\varphi$ on the links of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ that vanish on $F$, let $(d\varphi)_p$ be the sum of $\varphi$ around the plaquette $p$ with the signs of its orientation. Given $\eta \in \mathbb{R}^{A\setminus V}$, let $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$ be the law on $\mathbb{R}^V$ with density proportional to*

$$\exp\Big(-\frac{b}{2}\sum_{p\cap V\neq\emptyset}(d\varphi)_p^2\Big),$$

*with $\varphi = \eta$ on $A \setminus V$ and $\varphi = 0$ on $F$, and define $C_{V,j}$ and $K_c$ as above with $d_V(\varphi, \varphi') = \sum_{i \in V} |\varphi_i - \varphi'_i|$ and $\delta(\eta_j, \eta'_j) = |\eta_j - \eta'_j|$. Then*

$$\sum_c K_c \geq |V| = 48 N_n,$$

*so $K_c \geq N_n$ for some class $c$, and $D(n, \alpha)$ fails for every $\alpha < 1$, at every $n$ and every $b$.*

*Proof. The laws.* The quadratic form $\sum_{p \cap V \neq \emptyset} (d\varphi)_p^2$ with $\varphi = 0$ outside $V$ vanishes only at $\varphi = 0$: the argument of Corollary 11.12, written additively, gives a function $h$ on the sites with $\varphi_{(x,\mu)} = h(x) - h(x + e_\mu)$, constant outside the box and along the lines of $F$, hence constant. So $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$ is a Gaussian law whose covariance does not depend on $\eta$ and whose mean is $\sum_j \eta_j u_j$ for some vectors $u_j \in \mathbb{R}^V$. Two exteriors that differ in finitely many links give translates of one law by $t = \sum_j (\eta'_j - \eta_j) u_j$; the coupling by translation and the 1-Lipschitz function $\sum_i \operatorname{sign}(t_i) \varphi_i$ show that their distance is $\|t\|_1$. In particular $C_{V,j} = \|u_j\|_1$, and

$$W_1^{d_V}\left(\gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta), \gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta')\right) \leq \sum_j C_{V,j} \, |\eta'_j - \eta_j|.$$

*Lines.* By Lemma 2.2(i) the lines of $F$ are straight, disjoint and cover the sites, and the two ends of an active link $(x, \mu)$ lie on different lines, since the line through $x$ has direction $\sigma(x) \neq \mu$. For a line $\ell$ let $h_\ell$ be the indicator of its sites and $(dh_\ell)_{(x,\mu)} = h_\ell(x) - h_\ell(x + e_\mu)$. Then $dh_\ell$ vanishes on $F$ and around every plaquette, so the density is invariant under $\varphi \mapsto \varphi + dh_\ell$, and $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid dh_\ell)$ is $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid 0)$ translated by the restriction of $dh_\ell$ to $V$. Hence

$$\sum_{i \in V} |(dh_\ell)_i| \leq \sum_{j \in A \setminus V} C_{V,j} \, |(dh_\ell)_j|.$$

Here $|(dh_\ell)_e| = 1$ when exactly one end of $e$ lies on $\ell$ and 0 otherwise, so $\sum_\ell |(dh_\ell)_e| = 2$ for every active link $e$, the sum running over the finitely many lines that meet a link entering the inequality. Summing over these lines gives $2|V| \leq 2 \sum_j C_{V,j} = 2 \sum_c K_c$. □

The proof uses only that gauge transformations constant on the lines of $F$ move the whole cube while changing few boundary links, which is the behaviour of gauges of axial type anticipated in Remark 11.1. The class sums themselves, computed exactly for $n \leq 8$, lie between 1.57 and 11.24 times $N_n$ and increase with $n$. Below the correlation length the theory is weakly coupled, and the quadratic approximation is its leading order there. A proof of (D) along the tuning therefore has to show that the nonperturbative regime reduces the cube coefficients of the forest gauge below $N_n$, or (D) has to be posed for other variables.

*Remark* 11.4. Five other routes stop at (D) or (E), or earlier.

(a) *Disjoint blocks.* The block criterion of Lemma B.3 with a partition into cubes of side $n$ requires, for a link on a face, that its influence on the neighbouring cube be less than one. In the count of Remark 11.1 that influence is of order $\xi$, which grows like $1/a$. Averaging over the $N_n$ translates divides it by the number of translates on whose boundary the link lies, a factor of order $1/n$, and this is why (D) is stated for averaged cubes.

(b) *Rescaling a fixed lattice gap.* Any bound uniform in lattice units, such as those of Theorems 1.1–1.7, gives trivial continuum two-point functions [15]; rescaling it produces no gap.

(c) *Assuming the gap.* Hypothesis R of [15] assumes the gap in physical units together with the limit. Theorem 10.4 replaces the gap part by the cube estimate (D), which concerns one box and one coupling at each spacing.

(d) *Computation.* At a fixed coupling and a fixed small $n$, $D(n, \alpha)$ is a finite set of Kantorovich bounds and could in principle be certified as in Propositions 7.8 and 7.9; for $n = 2$ and SU(2) the block already has 48 links and 144 real variables. (D) asks for it at infinitely many couplings with $n \to \infty$, which no finite computation covers.

(e) *Axioms alone.* Proposition 9.2 shows that positivity, invariance and regularity do not force a gap, and Proposition 9.1 shows that the growth route to rotation invariance is closed for the action density. The infrared input therefore has to be an estimate such as (D).

11.2. **Estimates uniform in the coupling.** Some local quantities of the Wilson measure can be controlled uniformly in $\beta_W$, the volume and the boundary condition, by integrating by parts in a single link. Such estimates hold along every tuning, but they concern local fields in lattice units, and the three results below show how far they are from the open inputs: the force has bounded moments but its centred form is a null vector of the reflected form, the plaquette has fluctuations of order $\beta_W^{-2}$ but this is a single-site variance, and bare links over a fixed physical distance become independent Haar variables.

Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(N)$, write $b = \beta_W$, so that the Wilson weight is $e^{bS}$ with $S = \sum_p N^{-1} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p$, and give $\mathfrak{g}$ the metric $\langle T, R\rangle = -\operatorname{Tr}(TR)$. For a link $e$ let $S_e$ be the sum of the six plaquette terms containing $e$, $X_T$ the derivative along $U_e \mapsto e^{uT}U_e$ at $u = 0$, $\nabla_e$ and $\Delta_e$ the gradient and Laplacian in $U_e$, $q = N^2 - 1$, $c_N = (N^2-1)/N$, and

$$E_e = b|\nabla_e S_e|^2, \qquad W_e = E_e - c_N S_e = b|\nabla_e S_e|^2 + \Delta_e S_e.$$

Below, $\omega$ is a Wilson Gibbs state at $b > 0$: a finite-volume measure in which $e$ is not fixed by the boundary condition, or an infinite-volume state whose conditional law of $U_e$ given the other links is proportional to $e^{bS_e}dU_e$ with $dU_e$ the Haar measure.

**Proposition 11.5.** (i) *For every unit $T \in \mathfrak{g}$, $t \in \mathbb{R}$ and $0 \le \eta < N/12$,*

$$\mathbb{E}_\omega\big[e^{t\sqrt{b}\,X_T S_e} \,\big|\, U_{e^c}\big] \le e^{3t^2/N},$$
$$\mathbb{E}_\omega\big[e^{\eta E_e} \,\big|\, U_{e^c}\big] \le (1 - 12\eta/N)^{-q/2},$$

*so $\mathbb{E}_\omega E_e^m \le m!\,(24/N)^m 2^{q/2}$ for $m \ge 1$, uniformly in $b$, the volume and the boundary condition. Moreover $\mathbb{E}_\omega E_e = c_N \mathbb{E}_\omega S_e$.*

(ii) *For a bounded function $F$ of finitely many links, continuously differentiable in $U_e$, $\mathbb{E}_\omega[W_e F] = -\mathbb{E}_\omega\langle \nabla_e S_e, \nabla_e F\rangle$. In particular $\mathbb{E}_\omega[W_e F] = 0$ if $F$ does not depend on $U_e$, and $\mathbb{E}_\omega[W_e W_f] = 0$ if no plaquette contains both $e$ and $f$.*

(iii) *Let $\omega$ be reflection positive as in Appendix F, and let $A = \sum_e h_e W_e$ be a finite sum over links whose endpoints have times at least 2. Then $\omega(\vartheta(\bar{A})A) = 0$, so $\Psi_A = 0$: in the reconstructed Hilbert space the packets $\sum_e h_e E_e$ and $c_N \sum_e h_e S_e$ define the same vector.*

*Proof.* (i) Along $u \mapsto e^{uT}U_e$ a plaquette term containing $e$ is $N^{-1}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(e^{uT}V)$ or $N^{-1}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ve^{-uT})$ with $V$ unitary, whose second derivative is $N^{-1}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(T^2 e^{\pm uT}V)$. Since $-T^2 \ge 0$ and $\operatorname{Tr}(-T^2) = 1$, $|\operatorname{Tr}(T^2 M)| \le 1$ for unitary $M$, so the second derivative of $S_e$ along the curve is at most $6/N$ in absolute value. Taylor's formula with $u = t/\sqrt{b}$ gives $b\big(S_e(e^{tT/\sqrt{b}}U_e) - S_e(U_e)\big) \ge t\sqrt{b}X_T S_e(U_e) - 3t^2/N$. The conditional density is $e^{bS_e}/Z$ with respect to Haar measure, and the left invariance of Haar measure gives $\mathbb{E}_\omega[e^{b(S_e(e^{tT/\sqrt{b}}U_e)-S_e(U_e))} \mid U_{e^c}] = 1$, which with the Taylor bound proves the first inequality. For the second let $G_0$ be a standard Gaussian vector in $\mathfrak{g}$, independent of $\omega$; then $e^{\eta|Y|^2} = \mathbb{E}e^{\sqrt{2\eta}\langle G_0, Y\rangle}$ for $Y = \sqrt{b}\nabla_e S_e$, and the first inequality in the direction of $G_0$ with $t = \sqrt{2\eta}|G_0|$ gives the bound $\mathbb{E}e^{6\eta|G_0|^2/N} = (1 - 12\eta/N)^{-q/2}$. With $\eta = N/24$ and $x^m \le m!\,\eta^{-m}e^{\eta x}$ the moment bound follows. For the mean, $\sum_A T_A^2 = -c_N I$ in an orthonormal basis gives $\Delta_e S_e = -c_N S_e$, and the integral of the divergence of $e^{bS_e}\nabla_e S_e$ over $G$ vanishes.

(ii) The integral over $U_e$ of the divergence of $e^{bS_e}F\nabla_e S_e$ vanishes, and that divergence is $e^{bS_e}(W_e F + \langle \nabla_e S_e, \nabla_e F\rangle)$; integrate the conditional identity. The function $W_f$ depends only on the links of the plaquettes containing $f$.

(iii) Each $W_e$ in the sum depends on links with times at least 1, so $\vartheta(\bar{A})$ depends only on links with times at most 0, none of which is a link $e$ of the sum. By (ii), $\omega(\vartheta(\bar{A})W_e) = 0$ for each $e$. □

**Proposition 11.6.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$, $b \geq 0$, $\omega$ a Wilson Gibbs state at $b$ and $p$ a plaquette with a link that is not fixed by the boundary condition. Then*

$$\mathrm{Var}_\omega\big(\tfrac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p\big) \geq \frac{1}{2^{19}(1+6b)^2}, \quad \mathbb{E}_\omega\big[1 - \tfrac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p\big] \geq \frac{1}{4b+1}.$$

*Proof.* Let $e$ be the link and identify $\mathrm{SU}(2)$ with the unit quaternions. Given the other links, $U_e = x$ has density proportional to $e^{rx\cdot u}$ with $|u| = 1$ and $0 \leq r \leq 6b$, since the six staples have norm one, and $\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p = x \cdot v$ for a unit vector $v$ fixed by the conditioning. Let $X = x \cdot u$ and $T = 1 - X$; the law of $T$ has density proportional to $e^{-rt}\sqrt{t(2-t)}$ on $[0,2]$. Put $n = 1 + r$. Since $e^{-rt} \leq e^2 e^{-nt}$, the normalisation is at most $e^2 \int_0^\infty \sqrt{2t} e^{-nt} dt = e^2\sqrt{\pi/2}\, n^{-3/2} < 14 n^{-3/2}$. On $I = [\frac{1}{4n}, \frac{1}{2n}]$ the density is at least $\frac{1}{2} n^{-1/2} e^{-1/2}$ and on $J = [\frac{1}{n}, \frac{3}{2n}]$ at least $\frac{1}{2} n^{-1/2} e^{-3/2}$, so $P(T \in I) \geq \frac{1}{224}$ and $P(T \in J) \geq \frac{1}{336}$. With an independent copy $T'$, $\mathrm{Var}\, T = \frac{1}{2}\mathbb{E}(T - T')^2 \geq P(T \in I) P(T \in J)(2n)^{-2} > 2^{-19} n^{-2}$. By symmetry the conditional covariance of $x$ is diagonal in $u$ and $u^\perp$, with eigenvalues $\mathrm{Var}\, X$ and $\mathbb{E}(1 - X^2)/3$; on $I$, $1 - X^2 = T(2-T) \geq \frac{3}{8n}$, so $\mathbb{E}(1-X^2)/3 \geq \frac{1}{1792 n} \geq 2^{-19} n^{-2}$. Hence the conditional variance of $x \cdot v$ is at least $2^{-19}(1+6b)^{-2}$, and so is the variance, by the law of total variance. For the mean, integrating $\frac{d}{dX}\big(e^{rX}(1-X^2)^{3/2}\big)$ over $[-1,1]$ gives $3\mathbb{E}X = r\mathbb{E}(1 - X^2) \leq r(1 - (\mathbb{E}X)^2)$, whence $\mathbb{E}X \leq (\sqrt{9 + 4r^2} - 3)/(2r) \leq 2r/(2r+3)$ for $r > 0$, and $\mathbb{E}[1 - x \cdot v] \geq 1 - \mathbb{E}X \geq 3/(2r+3) \geq 1/(4b+1)$. □

For the blocking statement let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$, $B \geq 4$ an integer and, for a coarse edge $(x, \mu)$, $V_{(x,\mu)} = \prod_{r=0}^{B-1} U_{(Bx + r\hat{\mu}, \mu)}$ the ordered product of the fine links along it.

**Proposition 11.7.** *For every Wilson Gibbs state $\omega$ of $\mathrm{SU}(2)$ at $b > 0$ and every set $\mathcal{E}$ of $K$ coarse edges,*

$$\begin{aligned} \big\| \mathrm{Law}_\omega\big((V_e)_{e\in\mathcal{E}}\big) - m^{\otimes K} \big\|_{\mathrm{TV}} &\leq \frac{K}{2} e^{3b} \Big(\frac{4b}{4b+1}\Big)^{B-3} \\ &\leq \frac{K}{2} \exp\Big(3b - \frac{B-3}{4b+1}\Big), \end{aligned}$$

*where $m$ is the Haar measure. If $F$ is a function of the $V_e$ of a set of coarse edges at positive times, $|F| \leq 1$, and $\epsilon$ is this bound for those edges and their reflections, then $0 \leq \omega(\vartheta(\bar{F}^c)F^c) \leq 6\epsilon$ with $F^c = F - \omega(F)$.*

*Proof.* Select on each coarse edge the fine links with $1 \leq r \leq B - 2$. No plaquette contains two selected links: collinear links do not share a plaquette, parallel coarse edges are $B$ apart, and a plaquette containing a selected link of $(x, \mu)$ has its links in direction $\nu \neq \mu$ at $\mu$-offsets $r, r+1 \in [1, B-1]$ from $Bx$, while coarse edges in direction $\nu$ lie at offsets in $B\mathbb{Z}$. Given the other links, the selected ones are therefore independent, each with density $e^{r_i\, x\cdot u_i}/Z(r_i)$, $0 \leq r_i \leq 6b$. Convolution with such a density acts on the representation of spin $l \geq 1$ by $D^{(l)}(u_i)$ times $I_{l+1}(r_i)/I_1(r_i)$, whose absolute value is at most $I_2(r_i)/I_1(r_i)$ because $I_\nu(r)$ decreases in $\nu \geq 0$, and $I_2(r_i)/I_1(r_i) = \mathbb{E}X \leq 4b/(4b+1)$ by the proof of Proposition 11.6, so it contracts the mean-zero part of $L^2$ by that factor. The density is at most $e^{6b}$ because $Z \geq 1$ by Jensen's inequality, so its distance to 1 in $L^2$ is at most $e^{3b}$. The conditional law of $V_e$ is that of a product of $B - 2$ such independent variables between two fixed ones, so its total variation distance to $m$ is at most $\frac{1}{2}e^{3b}(4b/(4b+1))^{B-3}$, and the coarse edges are conditionally independent. Total variation distance from a product is at most the sum over the factors, and averaging over the conditioning does not increase it. For the last statement, under $m^{\otimes K}$ the covariance vanishes because $F$ and its reflection depend on disjoint edges; replacing $\omega$ by $m^{\otimes K}$ changes $\omega(\vartheta(\bar{F})F)$ by at most $2\epsilon$ and $|\omega(F)|^2$ by at most $4\epsilon$. □

With $B = \ell/a_k$ for a fixed physical length $\ell$ and $b_k = O(\log(1/a_k))$ the bound tends to zero: the bare coarse links of a fixed coarse graph become independent Haar variables, their reflected form has rank one, and a renormalisation $Z_k$ that keeps the reflected norm of $Z_k F^c$ at least $c > 0$ must grow at least like $(c/6\epsilon)^{1/2}$. The renormalised flowed fields of Theorem 10.7 are not bounded functions of bare coarse links, and none of the three propositions bears on the slice ratio, the tree bounds or (D).

11.3. **What the cube estimate requires.** This subsection proves seven facts about $D(n,\alpha)$. It holds at small coupling for every even $n$ above an explicit size (Proposition 11.9), and it survives small perturbations of the action (Proposition 11.10), although gauge-invariant perturbations still need strong coupling at the scale of the cube (Proposition 11.17). It forces the gauge-fixed variables of a cube with trivial exterior to stay a fixed distance from the identity on average (Theorem 11.11, and Proposition 11.13 for SU(2)), so that for every fixed $n$ it fails once $\beta$ is large (Corollary 11.12). And it cannot be obtained from bounds on the conditional law of a single line of links that are uniform in the configuration around the line (Proposition 11.21). For the compact abelian theory with the Villain action it fails at every size once $\beta$ is large (Proposition 11.18). In Section 12.1 the estimate is posed for block averages, where its quadratic approximation holds along the tuning. None of these decides (D) along the continuum tuning, where $n$ grows while $\beta$ grows.[17]

For a finite $V \subset A$ and $j \in A \setminus V$ let $b(V,j)$ be the number of links of $V$ that share a plaquette with $j$, and write $k \sim i$ when two active links share a plaquette.

**Lemma 11.8.** *Suppose that $C_{ee'} \le c_0$ for all active $e, e'$, with $12c_0 < 1$. Then $C_{V,j} \le c_0\, b(V,j)/(1-12c_0)$ for every finite $V \subset A$ and every $j \in A \setminus V$.*

*Proof.* Fix $Q, Q'$ that differ only at $j$, put $d = \delta(Q_j, Q'_j)$, $\mu = \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q)$ and $\nu = \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q')$. The couplings of $\mu$ and $\nu$ form a weakly compact set on which $\pi \mapsto \int d_V \, d\pi$ is continuous, so one of them, $\pi$, minimises it; let $\rho_i = \int \delta(X_i, Y_i)\, d\pi$. Fix $i \in V$. Under $\mu$ the conditional law of $X_i$ given the other links of $V$ is $\gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid X)$, and likewise for $\nu$. Replace $(X_i, Y_i)$ by a pair drawn from an optimal coupling of $\gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid X)$ and $\gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid Y)$, chosen measurably [75, Cor. 5.22], and keep the other coordinates. The new coupling still has marginals $\mu$ and $\nu$, and changing the links in which $X$ and $Y$ differ one at a time gives

$$W_1\big(\gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid X), \gamma_i^F(\cdot \mid Y)\big) \le \sum_{k \in V,\, k \ne i} C_{ik}\, \delta(X_k, Y_k) + C_{ij}\, d.$$

Minimality of $\pi$ therefore gives $\rho_i \le c_0 \sum_{k \in V,\, k \sim i} \rho_k + c_0 [i \sim j]\, d$. Sum over $i \in V$: every $\rho_k$ occurs at most twelve times by Lemma 2.2(iv), so $(1-12c_0)\sum_i \rho_i \le c_0\, b(V,j)\, d$. Since $W_1^{d_V}(\mu,\nu) \le \sum_i \rho_i$, dividing by $d$ proves the lemma. □

**Proposition 11.9.** *Let $n = 2m$ and let $V$ be the cube of Definition 10.1. For every class $c$,*

$$\sum_{j \in c \setminus V} b(V,j) \le 10m^3 - 2m^2,$$

*with equality for three classes. Consequently, if $C_{ee'} \le c_0$ for all $e, e'$ with $12c_0 < 1$, then $D(n,\alpha)$ holds for every $\alpha \in (0,1)$ with*

$$\alpha \ge \hat\alpha_n = \frac{c_0}{1-12c_0}\Big(\frac{20}{n} - \frac{8}{n^2}\Big).$$

*For* SU(2) *and $|\beta_W| < \frac{1}{3}$ this reads $\hat\alpha_n = \frac{|\beta_W|}{1-3|\beta_W|}\big(\frac{5}{n} - \frac{2}{n^2}\big)$, which is below one for every even $n > 5|\beta_W|/(1-3|\beta_W|)$.*

[17] The four statements answer the question of which parts of (D) can be settled with the methods of this paper. The first places (D) in the range where the single-link method already works, the second and third show what any proof of (D) at weak coupling has to produce, and the fourth excludes the most direct one-dimensional route.

*Proof.* Let $j = (y, \mu)$ lie in the class $c$, with $y \equiv r$ modulo two. A link of $V$ that shares a plaquette with $j$ has base point $y + d$ with $d \in \{-1, 0, 1\}^4$ and at most two nonzero coordinates, and the twelve offsets $d$ depend only on $c$. For a fixed offset we count the $y \equiv r$ with $y + d \in [0, n)^4$ and $y \notin [0, n)^4$. In the coordinate $l$ there are $m$ values of $y_l \equiv r_l$ with $y_l + d_l \in [0, n)$, and one of them lies outside $[0, n)$ exactly when $d_l = 1$ and $r_l = 1$ (the value $y_l = -1$) or $d_l = -1$ and $r_l = 0$ (the value $y_l = n$). If $q$ is the number of such coordinates, the count is $m^4 - m^{4-q}(m-1)^q$, that is 0, $m^3$ or $2m^3 - m^2$ for $q = 0, 1, 2$. Summing over the twelve offsets, the class sum is $a_c m^3 - b_c m^2$, where $b_c$ is the number of offsets with $q = 2$ and $a_c$ is the number with $q = 1$ plus twice $b_c$. Reading the offsets from Table 3, the pairs $(a_c, b_c)$ over the 48 classes are $(2, 0)$, $(7, 0)$, $(7, 1)$, $(9, 1)$, $(9, 2)$ and $(10, 2)$ three times each and $(3, 0)$, $(4, 0)$, $(5, 0)$, $(6, 0)$ and $(8, 1)$ six times each. In every case $a_c \le 10$ and $8 - a_c + b_c \ge 0$, so

$$(10m^3 - 2m^2) - (a_c m^3 - b_c m^2) = m^2\big((10 - a_c)m + b_c - 2\big) \ge m^2(8 - a_c + b_c) \ge 0,$$

with equality for the three classes with $(a_c, b_c) = (10, 2)$. By Lemma 11.8, $K_c \le c_0(10m^3 - 2m^2)/(1 - 12c_0)$, and $N_n = m^4$ gives $K_c/N_n \le \hat{\alpha}_n$. For SU(2) the proof of Theorem 1.1 gives $c_0 = |\beta| = |\beta_W|/4$. □

At $\beta_W = \frac{3}{10}$ and $n = 16$, for instance, $\hat{\alpha}_{16} = \frac{117}{128}$, and Theorem 10.2 gives the gap $\log \frac{128}{117}/32$, much weaker than Theorem 1.1. The proposition shows that the cube condition is not empty; it does not extend the range, because the absorption $12c_0 < 1$ is the single-link condition itself.

The cube condition is also stable under small changes of the action, which is what a block renormalisation would need at its last scale, where the effective action is no longer of Wilson form. Let $r \ge 0$ and $\varepsilon \ge 0$, and let $(w_X)$ be real functions on $G^A$ indexed by finite sets $X \subset A$ of diameter at most $r$, with $w_X$ depending only on the links of $X$, such that the family is invariant under the translations by $2\mathbb{Z}^4$, every active link lies in at most $M$ of the sets $X$, every $X$ has at most $s$ links, and

$$|w_X(Q) - w_X(Q')| \le \varepsilon \sum_{i \in X} \delta(Q_i, Q_i')$$

for all $Q, Q'$. Let $\gamma_V^W(\cdot \mid Q)$ be the probability measure with density proportional to $\exp \sum_{X \cap V \ne \emptyset} w_X$ with respect to $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q)$, and define $C_{V,j}^W$, $K_c^W$ and the condition $D^W(n, \alpha)$ as in Definition 10.1, with $\gamma_V^W$ in place of $\gamma_V$.

**Proposition 11.10.** *Let $n$ be even and suppose that $D(n, \alpha)$ holds at $\beta$. Then $D^W(n, \alpha')$ holds with*

$$\alpha' = \alpha\, e^{\Omega}(1 + 2\Omega) + 96\, s\, \Omega, \qquad \Omega = 48\, M\, D\, N_n\, \varepsilon.$$

*In particular $\alpha' < 1$ for all $\varepsilon$ below an explicit $\varepsilon_0(n, \alpha, M, s) > 0$.*

*Proof.* The cube has $|V| = 48N_n$ links, so $d_V$ has diameter $\Delta_V = 48N_nD$. For fixed exterior links put $u = \sum_{X \cap V \ne \emptyset} w_X$ as a function on $G^V$. Each link of $V$ lies in at most $M$ sets $X$, so $u$ is $M\varepsilon$-Lipschitz for $d_V$ and its oscillation is at most $M\varepsilon\Delta_V = \Omega$; we normalise $u$ so that $\sup u = 0$, which does not change the tilted measures, and put $h = e^u$, so that $e^{-\Omega} \le h \le 1$ and $h$ is $M\varepsilon$-Lipschitz.

*A common tilt.* Let $\mu, \nu$ be probability measures on $G^V$ and $\mu_h = h\mu/\mu(h)$, $\nu_h = h\nu/\nu(h)$. Let $f$ be 1-Lipschitz for $d_V$; subtracting a constant we may take $|f| \le \Delta_V$. Then $fh$ is $(1 + \Delta_V M\varepsilon)$-Lipschitz, $|\nu(fh)| \le \Delta_V \nu(h)$, $|\mu(h) - \nu(h)| \le M\varepsilon W_1^{d_V}(\mu, \nu)$ and $\mu(h) \ge e^{-\Omega}$, so

$$\begin{aligned} \mu_h(f) - \nu_h(f) &= \frac{\mu(fh) - \nu(fh)}{\mu(h)} + \nu(fh)\,\frac{\nu(h) - \mu(h)}{\mu(h)\nu(h)} \\ &\le e^{\Omega}(1 + 2\Omega)\, W_1^{d_V}(\mu, \nu), \end{aligned}$$

since $\Delta_V M\varepsilon = \Omega$. By Kantorovich duality $W_1^{d_V}(\mu_h, \nu_h) \le e^{\Omega}(1 + 2\Omega) W_1^{d_V}(\mu, \nu)$.

*Two tilts.* If $u'$ is another weight with $|u-u'|\le\eta$, the density of $\nu_{h'}$ with respect to $\nu_h$ lies in $[e^{-2\eta},e^{2\eta}]$, so the total variation distance of the two is at most $1-e^{-2\eta}\le 2\eta$, and $W_1^{d_V}(\nu_h,\nu_{h'})\le 2\eta\Delta_V$.

*The coefficients.* Let $Q,Q'$ differ only at $j\notin V$, with $\delta=\delta(Q_j,Q'_j)$, and let $u,u'$ be the weights for the two exteriors. They differ only through the sets $X$ that contain $j$ and meet $V$; if there are $m_j$ of them, $|u-u'|\le m_j\varepsilon\delta$. With $\mu=\gamma_V(\cdot\mid Q)$ and $\nu=\gamma_V(\cdot\mid Q')$, the triangle inequality and the two steps give

$$C^W_{V,j}\le e^{\Omega}(1+2\Omega)\,C_{V,j}+2\Delta_V\,m_j\,\varepsilon.$$

The pairs $(X,j)$ with $j\in X\setminus V$ and $X\cap V\neq\emptyset$ number at most $s$ times the number of sets meeting $V$, hence at most $sM|V|$. Summing over $j\in c\setminus V$,

$$K^W_c\le e^{\Omega}(1+2\Omega)\,\alpha N_n+2\Delta_V sM|V|\varepsilon=\big(\alpha e^{\Omega}(1+2\Omega)+96\,s\,\Omega\big)N_n.$$

The family is invariant under $2\mathbb{Z}^4$, so the coefficients are, and this is $D^W(n,\alpha')$. □

The admissible perturbation is of order $1/N_n=(2/n)^4$, so the proposition is useful in a box of a fixed number of lattice spacings, which is how a renormalisation argument would use it: after enough block steps that the cube of physical size $\ell$ has become a cube of fixed side, the effective action has to lie within $\varepsilon_0$ of an action that satisfies the condition there. Whether the effective actions along the tuning do so is not decided here, and that is where the problem lies: at the scale where the blocked theory is strongly coupled enough for a condition of this kind, the running coupling is of order one, which is outside the range of the existing ultraviolet analysis. The proposition shows only that the condition itself is not the obstacle.

The next theorem uses the configuration in which every link outside $V$ is the identity. Write $\gamma^1_V=\gamma_V(\cdot\mid 1)$ and

$$\varepsilon_V(\beta)=\frac{1}{|V|}\sum_{i\in V}\int\delta(1,Q_i)\,d\gamma^1_V(Q)$$

for the mean distance of the gauge-fixed variables of the cube from the identity. Recall that $\delta$ is bi-invariant of diameter $D$.

**Theorem 11.11.** *Let $n$ be even, $V$ the cube of Definition 10.1, and suppose that $D(n,\alpha)$ holds at $\beta$. Then*

$$\varepsilon_V(\beta)\ge\frac{(1-\alpha)\,D}{3}.$$

*Proof. A flat configuration.* By Lemma 2.2(i) and the period two of $\sigma$, the sixteen residues modulo two fall into eight pairs $\{r,r+e_{\sigma(r)}\}$, the residues met by one line of $F$. The eight residues 0010, 0011, 0100, 0110, 1001, 1011, 1100, 1101 form four of these pairs. Choose $z,w\in G$ with $\delta(z,w)=D$, put $g(x)=w$ if $x$ is congruent to one of those eight residues and $g(x)=z$ otherwise, and let $Q^g_{(x,\mu)}=g(x)g(x+e_\mu)^{-1}$ for every link of $\mathbb{Z}^4$. Then $g$ is constant on every line of $F$, so $Q^g$ equals 1 on $F$, every plaquette variable of $Q^g$ is 1, and $Q^g$ has period two. By bi-invariance $\delta(1,Q^g_{(x,\mu)})=\delta(g(x+e_\mu),g(x))$, which is $D$ when $x$ and $x+e_\mu$ receive different values and 0 otherwise; from Table 3 the first case occurs for exactly 32 of the 48 classes. Let $\delta_c$ be the common value of $\delta(1,Q^g_e)$ for $e$ in the class $c$, so that $\sum_c\delta_c=32D$.

*Gauge covariance.* Let $\Phi(Q)_{(x,\mu)}=g(x)Q_{(x,\mu)}g(x+e_\mu)^{-1}$ on $G^V$. The gauge transformation by $g$ maps the configuration equal to $Q_V$ on $V$ and to 1 elsewhere to the one equal to $\Phi(Q_V)$ on $V$ and to $Q^g$ elsewhere; it leaves every plaquette trace unchanged and every link of $F$ equal to 1, and $\Phi$ preserves Haar measure. Hence $\gamma_V(\cdot\mid Q^g)=\Phi_*\gamma^1_V$.

*Upper bound.* Only the finitely many links outside $V$ that share a plaquette with $V$ enter $\gamma_V$. Changing them one at a time from 1 to $Q^g$ and applying the definition of $C_{V,j}$ at each

step,

$$W_1^{d_V}(\gamma_V^1, \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g)) \le \sum_{j \in A \setminus V} C_{V,j}\, \delta(1, Q_j^g) = \sum_c \delta_c K_c \le \alpha N_n \sum_c \delta_c = 32\,\alpha D N_n.$$

*Lower bound.* The function $f(Q) = -\sum_{i \in V} \delta(Q_i, Q_i^g)$ is 1-Lipschitz for $d_V$. By gauge covariance and bi-invariance, $\int f\, d\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g) = -\int \sum_i \delta(Q_i, 1)\, d\gamma_V^1 = -|V|\varepsilon_V$, and by the triangle inequality $\int f\, d\gamma_V^1 \le -\sum_i \delta(1, Q_i^g) + |V|\varepsilon_V$. Every class has $N_n$ links in $V$, so $\sum_i \delta(1, Q_i^g) = 32 D N_n$ and

$$W_1^{d_V}(\gamma_V^1, \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g)) \ge 32 D N_n - 2|V|\varepsilon_V.$$

With $|V| = 48 N_n$ the two bounds give $96 N_n \varepsilon_V \ge 32(1-\alpha) D N_n$. □

**Corollary 11.12.** *For every even $n$ and every $\alpha < 1$ there is $\beta_0(n, \alpha)$ such that $D(n, \alpha)$ fails at every $\beta \ge \beta_0(n, \alpha)$. In particular, if $D(n_k, \alpha)$ holds at couplings $\beta_k \to \infty$, then $n_k \to \infty$.*

*Proof.* For $\beta > 0$, $\gamma_V^1$ has density proportional to $e^{-N\beta S}$ with respect to Haar measure, where $S = \sum_{p \cap V \neq \emptyset} (N - \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_p^F)$ is continuous and nonnegative on $G^V$ and vanishes exactly when $Q_p^F = 1$ for every plaquette $p$ that meets $V$. We show that this forces $Q_V = 1$. The other plaquettes have all their links equal to 1, so every plaquette variable is 1; since the plaquettes of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ fill every closed lattice path, there is a function $h$ on the sites with $Q_{(x,\mu)} = h(x) h(x + e_\mu)^{-1}$ on every link, and $h$ takes equal values at the two ends of every link on which $Q = 1$. Every link with base point outside $[0, n)^4$ is such a link. From a site with a coordinate at least $n$ one can move in every positive direction along links of this kind, and from a site with a negative coordinate $x_\nu$ one can move in the positive directions other than $\nu$ until another coordinate reaches $n$; so $h$ is constant on the sites outside the box. Every line of $F$ leaves the box, and $h$ is constant along it, so $h$ is constant and $Q_V = 1$.

Let $U$ be a neighbourhood of 1 in $G^V$, $s = \min_{G^V \setminus U} S > 0$, and $U' \subset U$ a neighbourhood of 1 on which $S < s/2$. Then $\gamma_V^1(G^V \setminus U) \le e^{-N\beta s} / (|U'| e^{-N\beta s/2})$, which tends to zero, so $\varepsilon_V(\beta) \to 0$ as $\beta \to \infty$, and Theorem 11.11 excludes $D(n, \alpha)$ once $\varepsilon_V(\beta) < (1-\alpha) D/3$. □

For SU(2) the constant of Theorem 11.11 can be improved: a flat configuration with four values instead of two moves every class of active links, and the means of the gauge-fixed links are scalar.

**Proposition 11.13.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ with the chordal metric, let $n$ be even, $V$ the cube of Definition 10.1, and suppose that $D(n, \alpha)$ holds at $\beta$. Then*

$$\frac{1}{|V|} \sum_{i \in V} \Big| \int \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_i\, d\gamma_V^1 \Big| \le 2\alpha,$$

$$\frac{1}{|V|} \sum_{i \in V} \int \delta(1, Q_i)^2\, d\gamma_V^1 \ge 2(1-\alpha),$$

*and $\varepsilon_V(\beta) \ge 1 - \alpha$.*

*Proof.* Write $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ for the Euclidean product of quaternions; then $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} q = 2\langle q, 1 \rangle$ and $\delta(p, q) = |p - q|$.

*Four colours.* Split the sixteen residues modulo two into the sets

$$X_1 = \{0000, 1000, 0111, 1111\},$$
$$X_2 = \{0001, 0101, 1010, 1110\},$$
$$X_3 = \{0010, 0011, 1100, 1101\},$$
$$X_4 = \{0100, 0110, 1001, 1011\}.$$

Each is the union of two of the eight pairs $\{r, r+e_{\sigma(r)}\}$, and Table 3 shows that $r$ and $r+e_\mu$ lie in different sets for every residue $r$ and every $\mu \neq \sigma(r)$. (The eight residues used in the proof of Theorem 11.11 form $X_3 \cup X_4$.) Let

$$z_1 = (\mathbf{i}+\mathbf{j}+\mathbf{k})/\sqrt{3}, \quad z_2 = (\mathbf{i}-\mathbf{j}-\mathbf{k})/\sqrt{3},$$
$$z_3 = (-\mathbf{i}+\mathbf{j}-\mathbf{k})/\sqrt{3}, \quad z_4 = (-\mathbf{i}-\mathbf{j}+\mathbf{k})/\sqrt{3},$$

unit quaternions with $\langle z_k, z_l\rangle = -\frac{1}{3}$ for $k \neq l$, so that $\delta(z_k, z_l) = d_* = (8/3)^{1/2}$. Put $g(x) = z_k$ when the residue of $x$ lies in $X_k$, and $Q^g_{(x,\mu)} = g(x)g(x+e_\mu)^{-1}$. As in the proof of Theorem 11.11, $Q^g$ equals 1 on $F$, every plaquette variable of $Q^g$ is 1, and $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g) = \Phi_*\gamma_V^1$ with $\Phi(Q)_{(x,\mu)} = g(x)Q_{(x,\mu)}g(x+e_\mu)^{-1}$; now $\delta(1, Q^g_e) = d_*$ for every active link $e$.

*Upper bound.* Changing the exterior links one at a time,

$$W_1^{d_V}(\gamma_V^1, \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g)) \le d_* \sum_c K_c \le 48\,\alpha\, d_* N_n = \alpha\, d_* |V|.$$

*Lower bound.* Conjugating every link of $V$ by one unit quaternion leaves the exterior 1, the links of $F$, Haar measure and every plaquette trace unchanged, so it preserves $\gamma_V^1$. The mean $m_i = \int Q_i\, d\gamma_V^1$, taken in the space of quaternions, therefore commutes with every unit quaternion, and $m_i = a_i 1$ with $a_i = \frac{1}{2}\int \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} Q_i\, d\gamma_V^1$ real. Since $\Phi$ acts on each link by a fixed left and right multiplication, the mean of $Q_i$ under $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g)$ is $a_i Q_i^g$. Choose unit quaternions $w_i$ with $\langle w_i, a_i Q_i^g - a_i 1\rangle = |a_i|\,|Q_i^g - 1|$. The function $f(Q) = \sum_{i\in V}\langle w_i, Q_i\rangle$ is 1-Lipschitz for $d_V$, and Kantorovich duality gives

$$W_1^{d_V}(\gamma_V^1, \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g)) \ge \sum_{i\in V} |a_i|\,\delta(1, Q_i^g) = d_* \sum_{i\in V} |a_i|.$$

*Conclusion.* Comparing the two bounds, $\sum_i |a_i| \le \alpha|V|$, which is the first inequality. Since $\delta(1,q)^2 = 2 - 2\langle q, 1\rangle$, $\int \delta(1,Q_i)^2\, d\gamma_V^1 = 2(1-a_i) \ge 2(1-|a_i|)$, and averaging gives the second. As $\delta \le 2$, $\delta \ge \delta^2/2$, and the bound on $\varepsilon_V$ follows. □

The four colours need nothing from SU(2) except four elements whose pairwise quotients are conjugate, and every compact simple group contains such elements. For a metric that comes from a representation the bound then compares the cube with Haar measure.

**Proposition 11.14.** *Let $G$ be a compact simple group, $\rho$ a nontrivial irreducible unitary representation of $G$ of dimension $d$, and $\delta(p,q) = \kappa^{-1/2}\|\rho(p) - \rho(q)\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$ for some $\kappa > 0$. Let $n$ be even, $V$ the cube of Definition 10.1, and suppose that $D(n,\alpha)$ holds at $\beta$. Then*

$$\frac{1}{|V|}\sum_{i\in V}\Big|\int \operatorname{Tr}\rho(Q_i)\, d\gamma_V^1\Big| \le \alpha\, d,$$

$$\frac{1}{|V|}\sum_{i\in V}\int \delta(1,Q_i)^2\, d\gamma_V^1 \ge (1-\alpha)\int_G \delta(1,q)^2\, dq,$$

*where $dq$ is Haar measure, and $\varepsilon_V(\beta) \ge (1-\alpha)D/2$.*

*Proof. Four elements.* Let $\varphi\colon \mathrm{SU}(2) \to G$ be the homomorphism of the SU(2) subgroup of a root, and $z_1, \dots, z_4$ the tetrahedral quaternions of Proposition 11.13. For $k \neq l$ the quaternion $z_k z_l^{-1}$ has real part $\langle z_k, z_l\rangle = -\frac{1}{3}$; unit quaternions with equal real parts are conjugate in SU(2), so the twelve elements $\varphi(z_k z_l^{-1})$ are conjugate in $G$, and by bi-invariance $\delta(\varphi(z_k), \varphi(z_l)) = d_*$ for all $k \neq l$, with one number $d_*$. If $d_* = 0$, then $\varphi(z_k z_l^{-1})$ lies in $\ker\rho$, a proper normal subgroup of the simple group $G$ and therefore central; it then commutes with $\varphi(\mathrm{SU}(2))$, so it is central there, and $z_k z_l^{-1}$ lies in $\{\pm 1\}\ker\varphi \subset \{\pm 1\}$, which its real part $-\frac{1}{3}$ excludes. So $d_* > 0$.

*The two bounds.* Put $g(x) = \varphi(z_k)$ when the residue of $x$ lies in $X_k$. The proof of Proposition 11.13 applies word for word: $Q^g$ equals 1 on $F$ and on every plaquette, $\delta(1, Q^g_e) = d_*$ on every active link, and $W_1^{d_V}(\gamma_V^1, \gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g)) \le \alpha d_* |V|$. Simultaneous conjugation of the links of $V$ preserves $\gamma_V^1$, so the mean $\int \rho(Q_i)\, d\gamma_V^1$ commutes with $\rho(G)$, and by Schur's lemma

it is $c_i I$ with $c_i = d^{-1}\int \operatorname{Tr}\rho(Q_i)\,d\gamma_V^1$. Its mean under $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g)$ is $c_i\rho(Q_i^g)$. With matrices $W_i$ of Hilbert–Schmidt norm $\kappa^{-1/2}$ chosen so that $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(W_i^* c_i(\rho(Q_i^g)-I)) = |c_i|\,\delta(1,Q_i^g)$, the function $f(Q) = \sum_i \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(W_i^*\rho(Q_i))$ is 1-Lipschitz for $d_V$, and Kantorovich duality gives $W_1^{d_V} \ge d_*\sum_i |c_i|$. Hence $\sum_i |c_i| \le \alpha|V|$, the first inequality.

*Comparison with Haar measure.* Since $\kappa\,\delta(1,q)^2 = 2d - 2\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}\rho(q)$ and $\int_G \operatorname{Tr}\rho(q)\,dq = 0$ for a nontrivial irreducible $\rho$, $\int_G \delta(1,q)^2 dq = 2d/\kappa$, while $\int \delta(1,Q_i)^2 d\gamma_V^1 = 2d(1-\operatorname{Re} c_i)/\kappa \ge 2d(1-|c_i|)/\kappa$. Averaging gives the second inequality. Finally $\kappa D^2 \le 4d$, because $\|\rho(p) - \rho(q)\|_{\mathrm{HS}} \le 2\sqrt{d}$, so $\delta \ge \delta^2/D$ gives $\varepsilon_V \ge 2d(1-\alpha)/(\kappa D) \ge (1-\alpha)D/2$. □

For SU($N$) with the Hilbert–Schmidt distance this improves the constant $\frac{1}{3}$ of Theorem 11.11 to $\frac{1}{2}$, and for SU(3), where $D^2 = 9$ and the Haar mean of $\delta^2$ is 6, to $\frac{2}{3}$: in a cube with the identity outside, $D(n,\alpha)$ leaves the gauge-fixed links at least the fraction $1-\alpha$ of the disorder of independent Haar-distributed links.

The size $\beta_0(n,\alpha)$ in Corollary 11.12 comes from a compactness argument. For SU(2) it can be made explicit, and then reads as a lower bound on the side of any cube that satisfies the condition.

**Proposition 11.15.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ with the chordal metric, so that $D = 2$, let $b = \beta_W \ge \frac{1}{9}$, let $n \ge 2$ be even and put $L(b) = 1 + \log 24 + \frac{3}{2}\log(9b)$. Then*

$$\frac{1}{|V|}\sum_{e\in V}\int \delta(1,Q_e)^2\,d\gamma_V^1 \le \frac{n^2(n+2)(2n+1)\,L(b)}{b},$$

*so $\varepsilon_V(\beta)^2$ is at most the same quantity. Consequently, if $D(n,\alpha)$ holds at $b$, then*

$$n^4 \ge \frac{2(1-\alpha)\,b}{5\,L(b)}.$$

*Proof.* Put $m = n/2$. Under $\gamma_V^1$ every link outside $V$ equals 1: the links of $F$ always, the others by the choice of exterior. A plaquette that does not meet $V$ therefore has plaquette variable 1.

*Links as loops.* Let $e = (x,\mu) \in V$, $y = x + e_\mu$, $\sigma = \sigma(x)$ and $\tau = \sigma(y)$. The directions $\sigma, \tau, \mu$ are distinct: $\sigma \ne \mu$ because $e$ is active; $\tau \ne \mu$ because otherwise the line of $F$ through $y$ would contain $x$, and the lines of $F$ are disjoint; and $\tau \ne \sigma$ by Table 3, in which $\sigma(x+e_\mu) \ne \sigma(x)$ whenever $\mu \ne \sigma(x)$. Since $0 \le x_\sigma < n$, one of $n - x_\sigma$ and $x_\sigma + 1$ is at most $m$; call it $s$ and let $\epsilon = \pm 1$ be the sign for which $x' = x + s\epsilon e_\sigma$ has $\sigma$-coordinate outside $[0,n)$. Choose $t \le m$ and $\epsilon'$ in the same way for $y$ and $\tau$ (note $y_\tau = x_\tau$). Let $R_1$ be the $s$ plaquettes of the rectangle with corners $x$, $x'$, $x' + e_\mu$, $y$ in the plane $\{\sigma,\mu\}$, and $R_2$ the $st$ plaquettes of the rectangle with corners $y$, $x' + e_\mu$, $x' + e_\mu + t\epsilon' e_\tau$, $y + t\epsilon' e_\tau$ in the plane $\{\sigma,\tau\}$. The union $R(e) = R_1 \cup R_2$ is a disc, and its boundary runs from $x$ along the line of $F$ through $x$ to $x'$, then to $x' + e_\mu$, along $e_\tau$ to $x' + e_\mu + t\epsilon' e_\tau$, along $e_\sigma$ to $y + t\epsilon' e_\tau$, back along the line of $F$ through $y$ to $y$, and over $e$ to $x$. The links of the first and fifth pieces lie in $F$. The links of the second and third pieces have base points with $\sigma$-coordinate $x'_\sigma \notin [0,n)$, and those of the fourth have base points with $\tau$-coordinate outside $[0,n)$; none of them lies in $V$. So the holonomy of the boundary of $R(e)$ is $Q_e^{\pm 1}$. Adding the plaquettes of a disc one at a time along its boundary shows that this holonomy is a product of conjugates of the plaquette variables $(Q_p^F)^{\pm 1}$, $p \in R(e)$, one for each plaquette. By bi-invariance and the triangle inequality,

$$\delta(1,Q_e) \le \sum_{p\in R(e)} \delta(1,Q_p^F), \qquad |R(e)| = s(t+1) \le m(m+1).$$

*Multiplicity.* If a plaquette $p$ lies in $R_2(e)$, its plane is $\{\sigma,\tau\}$, $\mu$ is one of the two other directions, and the base point of $p$ is $y + ae_\sigma + ce_\tau$ with $-m \le a, c \le m-1$. Given $p$, there are two ways to name the directions of its plane, two choices of $\mu$ and $(2m)^2$ of $(a,c)$, and they determine $y$, hence $e$; so $p$ lies in at most $16m^2$ of the sets $R_2(e)$. Likewise $p \in R_1(e)$

forces its plane to be $\{\sigma,\mu\}$ and its base point to be $x+ae_\sigma$ with $-m\le a\le m-1$, which leaves at most $4m$ links $e$. Every plaquette therefore lies in at most $16m^2+4m=4n^2+2n$ of the discs $R(e)$.

*The energy.* For the chordal metric $\delta(1,q)^2=2-\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}q$. Let $S=\sum_{p\cap V\neq\emptyset}\delta(1,Q_p^F)^2$; then $\gamma_V^1$ has density $e^{-bS/2}/Z$ with $Z=\int e^{-bS/2}$, the integral over $\mathrm{SU}(2)^V$ with Haar measure. The function $t\mapsto\log\int e^{-tS}$ is convex and vanishes at $t=0$, so its derivative at $t=b/2$, which is $-\int S\,d\gamma_V^1$, is at least $2\log Z/b$. A plaquette that meets $V$ contains at most three links of $V$ and the other links are 1, so $\delta(1,Q_p^F)^2\le 3\sum_{e\in p\cap V}\delta(1,Q_e)^2$; every link lies in six plaquettes, so $S\le 18\sum_{e\in V}\delta(1,Q_e)^2$ and $Z\ge I^{|V|}$ with $I=\int e^{-9b\,\delta(1,q)^2}dq$. The chordal distance is at most the geodesic one, and the geodesic ball of radius $r=(9b)^{-1/2}\le 1$ has measure greater than $r^3/24$ (proof of Proposition 11.21), so $I\ge e^{-1}(9b)^{-3/2}/24$ and

$$\int S\,d\gamma_V^1\le\frac{2|V|\,L(b)}{b}.$$

*Conclusion.* The Cauchy–Schwarz inequality inside each disc squares the loop bound:

$$\begin{aligned}\delta(1,Q_e)^2&\le|R(e)|\sum_{p\in R(e)}\delta(1,Q_p^F)^2\\&\le m(m+1)\sum_{p\in R(e)}\delta(1,Q_p^F)^2.\end{aligned}$$

Summing over $e\in V$ and using the multiplicity,

$$\sum_{e\in V}\delta(1,Q_e)^2\le m(m+1)(4n^2+2n)\,S=\frac{n^2(n+2)(2n+1)}{2}\,S,$$

and integrating against $\gamma_V^1$ gives the first bound; the bound on $\varepsilon_V$ follows by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality. If $D(n,\alpha)$ holds, Proposition 11.13 gives $2(1-\alpha)\le n^2(n+2)(2n+1)L(b)/b$, and $(n+2)(2n+1)\le 5n^2$ for $n\ge 2$. □

The loops and their multiplicity use nothing of $\mathrm{SU}(2)$ but the bi-invariance of $\delta$, and the energy uses only the form of the action and the measure of small balls. The bound therefore holds for every $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, with the same power of $n$.

**Proposition 11.16.** *Let $G=\mathrm{SU}(N)$, $N\ge 2$, with the weight $\exp(\frac{b}{N}\sum_p\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}Q_p)$, $b=\beta_W\ge N/9$, and the Hilbert–Schmidt distance $\delta(p,q)=\|p-q\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$. Let $n\ge 2$ be even and put*

$$L_N(b)=1+\frac{N^2-1}{2}\log(81\pi^2 b)+N(N-1)\log\frac{12}{11}.$$

*Then*

$$\frac{1}{|V|}\sum_{e\in V}\int\delta(1,Q_e)^2\,d\gamma_V^1\le\frac{N\,n^2(n+2)(2n+1)\,L_N(b)}{b}.$$

*Consequently, if $D(n,\alpha)$ holds at $b$, then*

$$n^4\ge\frac{2(1-\alpha)\,b}{5\,L_N(b)}.$$

*Proof. Loops.* The discs $R(e)$ of the proof of Proposition 11.15 and the bound $4n^2+2n$ on their multiplicity do not depend on the group, and the loop bound uses only bi-invariance and the triangle inequality. With $S=\sum_{p\cap V\neq\emptyset}\delta(1,Q_p^F)^2$ the same Cauchy–Schwarz step gives $\sum_{e\in V}\delta(1,Q_e)^2\le\frac12 n^2(n+2)(2n+1)\,S$.

*The energy.* Since $\delta(1,q)^2=2N-2\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}q$, the measure $\gamma_V^1$ has density $e^{-bS/(2N)}/Z$ with respect to Haar measure. As in the proof of Proposition 11.15, the convexity of $t\mapsto\log\int e^{-tS}$ gives $\int S\,d\gamma_V^1\le 2N\log(1/Z)/b$, and $S\le 18\sum_{e\in V}\delta(1,Q_e)^2$ gives $Z\ge I^{|V|}$ with $I=\int e^{-9b\,\delta(1,q)^2/N}dq$.

*Small balls.* Give $\mathfrak{su}(N)$ the inner product $\mathrm{Tr}(X^*Y)$ and $\mathrm{SU}(N)$ the corresponding bi-invariant metric, of volume $v_N$. In exponential coordinates the Riemannian measure is $j(X)\,dX$, where $dX$ is Lebesgue measure and

$$j(X) = \Big|\det \frac{1 - e^{-\operatorname{ad} X}}{\operatorname{ad} X}\Big| = \prod_{k<l} \Big(\frac{\sin(\varphi_{kl}/2)}{\varphi_{kl}/2}\Big)^2$$

if $X$ has eigenvalues $i\theta_1, \dots, i\theta_N$ and $\varphi_{kl} = \theta_k - \theta_l$ [42, Ch. II, Thm. 1.7]; in particular $j \le 1$. Every $q \in \mathrm{SU}(N)$ is conjugate to a diagonal matrix with entries $e^{i\psi_k}$, $-\pi \le \psi_k < \pi$; then $\sum_k \psi_k = 2\pi k_0$ with $|k_0| \le N/2$, and changing $|k_0|$ of the $\psi_k$ by $\mp 2\pi$ gives angles $\theta_k$ with sum zero and $|\theta_k| \le 3\pi$. So $q = e^X$ with $X \in \mathfrak{su}(N)$ and $\|X\|_{\mathrm{HS}} \le 3\pi\sqrt{N}$, and $v_N \le \omega_{N^2-1}(3\pi\sqrt{N})^{N^2-1}$, where $\omega_k$ is the volume of the unit ball of $\mathbb{R}^k$. Now let $\|X\|_{\mathrm{HS}} \le r \le 1$. The eigenvalues have $|\theta_k| \le 1 < \pi$, so exp is injective on this ball; $\delta(1, e^X)^2 = \sum_k |e^{i\theta_k} - 1|^2 \le \|X\|_{\mathrm{HS}}^2$; and $|\varphi_{kl}|/2 \le (\theta_k^2 + \theta_l^2)^{1/2}/\sqrt{2} \le 2^{-1/2}$, so each factor of $j(X)$ is at least $(1 - \frac{1}{12})^2$ because $\sin x/x \ge 1 - x^2/6$. Dividing by $v_N$, the Haar measure of $\{q : \delta(1,q) \le r\}$ is at least

$$\Big(\frac{11}{12}\Big)^{N(N-1)} \frac{\omega_{N^2-1} r^{N^2-1}}{v_N} \ge \Big(\frac{11}{12}\Big)^{N(N-1)} \Big(\frac{r}{3\pi\sqrt{N}}\Big)^{N^2-1}.$$

With $r = (N/9b)^{1/2} \le 1$ this gives $I \ge e^{-1}$ times the right-hand side, and since $3\pi\sqrt{N}/r = 9\pi\sqrt{b}$, $\log(1/I) \le L_N(b)$. Hence $\int S\, d\gamma_V^1 \le 2N|V|L_N(b)/b$, and the first bound follows from the loops.

*Conclusion.* Proposition 11.14 with the defining representation and $\kappa = 1$, for which the Haar mean of $\delta(1,q)^2$ is $2N$, gives $2N(1-\alpha) \le N\, n^2(n+2)(2n+1)L_N(b)/b$ when $D(n,\alpha)$ holds, and $(n+2)(2n+1) \le 5n^2$. □

For every $N$, a cube on which the condition holds therefore has side at least of order $(\beta_W/\log\beta_W)^{1/4}$, with a constant that depends on $N$ only through $L_N$, which grows like $\frac{N^2}{2}\log\beta_W$.

The cube condition is a statement about strong coupling at its own scale, and this persists under the perturbations of Proposition 11.10 when they respect the gauge. Call $(w_X)$ *gauge invariant* if $w_X(Q^h) = w_X(Q)$ for every function $h$ on the sites that is constant on every line of $F$, where $Q^h_{(x,\mu)} = h(x)Q_{(x,\mu)}h(x+e_\mu)^{-1}$. Such transformations keep the links of $F$ equal to 1, so they act on $G^A$, and the restriction to the gauge of an action invariant under all gauge transformations is gauge invariant in this sense. Write $\varepsilon_V^W$ for $\varepsilon_V$ with $\gamma_V^W(\cdot \mid 1)$ in place of $\gamma_V^1$.

**Proposition 11.17.** *Let $(w_X)$ be as in Proposition 11.10 and gauge invariant, let $n = 2m$, and suppose that $D^W(n,\alpha)$ holds.*

(i) $\varepsilon_V^W \ge (1-\alpha)D/3$.

(ii) *If $\eta \ge 0$, $0 \le \kappa \le 1$, and the event that $\delta(1, Q_p^F) \le \eta$ for every plaquette $p$ that meets $V$ has probability at least $1-\kappa$ under $\gamma_V^W(\cdot \mid 1)$, then*

$$m(m+1)\,\eta + \kappa D \ge \frac{(1-\alpha)D}{3}.$$

*Proof.* (i) The proof of Theorem 11.11 uses the action only through the identity $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid Q^g) = \Phi_*\gamma_V^1$ and through the coefficients $C_{V,j}$. The function $g$ of that proof is constant on every line of $F$, so the gauge transformation by $g$ leaves every $w_X$ unchanged, as it leaves every plaquette trace, and the same identity holds for $\gamma_V^W$. Only finitely many links outside $V$ enter $\gamma_V^W$, because the sets $X$ have bounded diameter, so the upper bound holds with $C_{V,j}^W$ and $K_c^W$ in place of $C_{V,j}$ and $K_c$; the lower bound is unchanged.

(ii) Under $\gamma_V^W(\cdot \mid 1)$ every link outside $V$ equals 1, so a plaquette that does not meet $V$ has variable 1. The loop bound of the proof of Proposition 11.15, which uses only the

bi-invariance of $\delta$, gives $\delta(1,Q_e)\le\sum_{p\in R(e)}\delta(1,Q_p^F)\le m(m+1)\eta$ for every $e\in V$ on the event of the statement, and $\delta(1,Q_e)\le D$ off it. Averaging over $e\in V$ and integrating, $\varepsilon_V^W\le m(m+1)\eta+\kappa D$, and (i) completes the proof. □

In the small-field region of a gauge-covariant block renormalisation the blocked plaquette variables lie within a distance $\eta$ that tends to zero with the running coupling, and large fields have small probability $\kappa$. If $\kappa<(1-\alpha)/3$, part (ii) allows the cube condition on the blocked lattice only when $m(m+1)\ge x$, where $x=((1-\alpha)/3-\kappa)D/\eta$, so the side must grow like $\eta^{-1/2}$. On such a cube $N_n=m^4\ge x^2/4$, and since $\alpha'\ge\alpha+96s\Omega$, Proposition 11.10 gives $\alpha'<1$ only for

$$\begin{aligned}\varepsilon&<\frac{1-\alpha}{4608\,sMD\,N_n}\\&\le\frac{(1-\alpha)\,\eta^2}{1152\,sMD^3\big((1-\alpha)/3-\kappa\big)^2},\end{aligned}$$

which is of order $\eta^2$. At a fixed side the condition is therefore a statement about strong coupling, and a renormalisation argument has to carry the blocked theory out of the small-field regime before the condition can be checked. That passage, at a running coupling of order one, is the step that remains open.

The next statement shows that the cube condition separates a theory with a massless photon from the expected behaviour of $\mathrm{SU}(N)$: for the compact abelian theory in its Coulomb phase it fails at every scale. Let $G=\mathrm{U}(1)$ with the chordal metric, $D=2$, and replace the Wilson weight by the Villain weight

$$\varphi_\beta(\theta)=\sum_{k\in\mathbb{Z}}e^{-\beta(\theta+2\pi k)^2/2},$$

so that the measure of a box $\Lambda$ has density proportional to $\prod_{p\in P(\Lambda)}\varphi_\beta(\theta_p)$, where $e^{i\theta_p}$ is the plaquette variable. Define $\gamma^F$, $C_{V,j}$, $K_c$ and $D(n,\alpha)$ as before with $\varphi_\beta$ in place of the Wilson weight.

**Proposition 11.18.** *There is $\beta_0$ such that for the Villain theory at every $\beta>\beta_0$ the condition $D(n,\alpha)$ fails for every even $n\ge2$ and every $\alpha<1$. In particular, for couplings $\beta_k\to\infty$ and any even $n_k$, the hypothesis of Theorem 10.4 fails for this theory.*

*Proof.* Lemma 3.1, Proposition 3.2(i)–(iii) and (v), Lemma B.1, Corollary B.2 and Lemma B.4 use the Wilson weight only as a positive continuous class function of the plaquette variable, with one exception: the Doeblin bound in Lemma B.4(a), which for the Villain weight reads that each single-link density is at least $(\min\varphi_\beta/\max\varphi_\beta)^6>0$ times its maximum. Suppose that $D(n,\alpha)$ holds. As in the proof of Theorem 10.2, the limit $\omega(O)=\lim W_\Lambda(O)$ of the measures of boxes with free boundary conditions then exists along every sequence of boxes exhausting $\mathbb{Z}^4$, and for gauge-invariant local $O,O'$ with $O$ Lipschitz in each link,

$$|\operatorname{Cov}_\omega(O,O')|\le\|O'\|_\infty L_O\,\frac{D(1+c_ne^{\lambda\rho_n})}{1-\theta}\,|S_{O'}|\,e^{-\lambda\operatorname{dist}(O,O')}$$

for every $\lambda>0$ with $\theta=\alpha e^{\lambda\rho_n}<1$, where $L_O$ is a Lipschitz constant of $O$ and $S_{O'}$ the support of $O'$.

Put $\Psi_p=\varphi_\beta'(\theta_p)/\varphi_\beta(\theta_p)$; up to the factor $-\mathbf{i}$ this is the lattice field strength of Fröhlich and Spencer [36, Sect. 2] for the Villain action. It is real, odd and smooth in $\theta_p$, so it is gauge invariant, local and Lipschitz in each of its four links, with constants that do not depend on $p$, and $\omega(\Psi_p)=0$ by the symmetry $\theta\mapsto-\theta$. The bound above gives $\sum_{p'}|\omega(\Psi_p\Psi_{p'})|<\infty$, the sum over the plaquettes $p'$ parallel to $p$. The state of [36] is the limit of the same free-boundary measures over boxes, which is $\omega$. Fröhlich and Spencer prove, for $\beta$ larger than some $\beta_0$, that the Fourier transform of the two-plaquette function of the field strength

is discontinuous at zero momentum, so that this sum is infinite [36, Sect. 2]; see also [41]. This contradiction proves the first statement, and the second follows because $\beta_k > \beta_0$ for all large $k$. □

At large $\beta$ the plaquette variables of the abelian theory are Gaussian to leading order, as are those of $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, and every property of the action used in this paper (compactness, locality, positivity and smoothness of the weight, reflection positivity, the forest gauge) is shared by the two theories. A proof of (D) along the continuum tuning therefore has to use the non-abelian structure of $G$; Proposition 11.18 holds at every cube size, so letting the side grow with $\beta$, which Corollary 11.12 already requires, does not remove the need. Fröhlich and Spencer indicate how their result extends to the Wilson action without giving the details [36, Sect. 2], so the proposition is stated for the Villain action only.

*Remark* 11.19. The proof loses the area of a disc, of order $n^2$, in passing from plaquettes to links, and on loops that loss is of the right order. On the periodic lattice $(\mathbb{Z}/L\mathbb{Z})^4$ with $L$ even and coordinates $0 \le x_j < L$, let $\phi = 4\pi/L^2$, $q(\theta) = \cos\theta + \mathbf{i}\sin\theta$, and put $U_{(x,2)} = q(\phi x_1)$, $U_{(x,1)} = q(-\phi L x_2)$ when $x_1 = L-1$, and $U = 1$ on every other link. Every plaquette of the plane $\{1,2\}$ equals $q(\phi)$, including those on the seam $x_1 = L-1$ and at the corner $x_1 = x_2 = L-1$, where the angle is $\phi - 4\pi$; all other plaquettes equal 1. So every plaquette variable lies within $\phi$ of the identity, while the boundary of the square $[0, L/2]^2$ of the plane $\{1,2\}$ has holonomy $q(\phi L^2/4) = -1$, at the largest possible distance $D = 2$, against the bound $\phi L^2/4 = \pi$ given by the disc. Every staple sum of this configuration is parallel to its link, so it is a stationary point of the Wilson action, and gradient flow [55] does not change it. Plaquette variables within $O(n^{-2})$ of the identity therefore do not force loops of length $n$ near the identity, and an argument of the kind above that places gauge-fixed links near the identity needs plaquette bounds of order $o(n^{-2})$.

Up to the factor $L(b)^{1/2}$ the rate $b^{-1/2}$ of Proposition 11.15 is the right one, and the lower bound below holds for every $n$ and every exterior.

**Proposition 11.20.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ with the chordal metric and $b = \beta_W > 0$. For every Gibbs specification of the gauge-fixed theory, every active link $e$ and every configuration of the other links, the conditional law of $Q_e$ satisfies*

$$\int \delta(1, Q_e)\, d\mu_e \ge \frac{1}{9\max(6b,1)^{1/2}}.$$

*In particular $\varepsilon_V(\beta) \ge \frac{1}{9}\max(6b,1)^{-1/2}$ for every $n$; at every fixed $n$, $\varepsilon_V(\beta)$ lies between constant multiples of $b^{-1/2}$ and $(L(b)/b)^{1/2}$.*

*Proof.* Write $\langle\cdot,\cdot\rangle$ for the Euclidean product of quaternions, so that $\mathrm{Re}\,\mathrm{Tr}\, q = 2\langle q, 1\rangle$. The six plaquettes that contain $e$ contribute $\exp(b\langle Q_e, W_p\rangle)$ to the conditional density, with $|W_p| = 1$; so $\mu_e$ has density $e^{\langle u,v\rangle}/Z(|v|)$ with respect to normalised Haar measure, for some $v$ with $a = |v| \le 6b$. Put $a' = \max(a,1)$ and $\eta = a'^{-1/2} \le 1$. On the geodesic ball of radius $\eta$ about $v/|v|$ the exponent is at least $a(1-\eta^2/2) \ge a - \frac{1}{2}$, and that ball has measure greater than $\eta^3/24$ (proof of Proposition 11.21); hence $Z(a) \ge e^{a-1/2}\eta^3/24$ and the density is at most $24e^{1/2}a'^{3/2}$ (for $a < 1$ directly, since $Z \ge 1$ by Jensen's inequality). A chordal ball of radius $r$ is a geodesic ball of radius $\theta$ with $2\sin(\theta/2) = r$, so $\theta \le \pi r/2$, and its measure is $(\theta - \sin\theta\cos\theta)/\pi \le 2\theta^3/(3\pi) \le \pi^2 r^3/12$. With $r = \frac{2}{9}a'^{-1/2}$,

$$\mu_e\big(\delta(1,Q_e) < r\big) \le 24e^{1/2}a'^{3/2}\,\frac{\pi^2 r^3}{12} = 2e^{1/2}\pi^2\Big(\frac{2}{9}\Big)^3 < \frac{1}{2},$$

so the mean of $\delta(1,Q_e)$ is at least $r/2 = \frac{1}{9}a'^{-1/2}$. Averaging over $e \in V$ and over the configuration gives the bound on $\varepsilon_V$. □

Along the continuum tuning Theorem 11.11 says the following. If (D) holds, then in a cube of fixed physical size $\ell$ with the identity outside, the forest-gauge variables stay on

average at distance at least $(1-\alpha)D/3$ from the identity, and at least $1-\alpha$ for SU(2), at every spacing. This is not a contradiction: $n=\ell/a$ grows like $1/a$, while asymptotic freedom makes $\beta(a)$ grow only like $\log(1/a)$, and the corollary concerns fixed $n$. The size bound of Proposition 11.15 is likewise met along the tuning, since its right side grows only like $\log(1/a)$. It turns the hypothesis of Remark 11.1, that the gauge-fixed links decorrelate on the scale of the cube, into a necessary condition: (D) requires the forest-gauge variables to be disordered at a fixed physical scale. For gauge-invariant observables of a massive theory that disorder is clustering; for the gauge-fixed variables it is not proved.

The last statement concerns the following strategy: control the conditional law of one line of links, given everything else, uniformly in the configuration around it, and assemble the cube from lines. Fix a site $x$, let $s=\sigma(x)$ and $\mu\neq s$, and let $c_k=(x+ke_s,\mu)$, $k\in\mathbb{Z}$. All $c_k$ are active, since $\sigma$ is constant along the line through $x$.

**Proposition 11.21.** *Let $G=\mathrm{SU}(2)$, identified with the unit quaternions, and $b=\beta_W\geq 1$. There is a configuration of the active links outside $\{c_k\}$, independent of $b$, for which the conditional law of $(Q_{c_k})_k$ has a ten-step transfer operator, similar to a positive self-adjoint operator $K_b$ on $L^2(S^3)$ with simple top eigenvalue $\Lambda_b$, whose gap satisfies*

$$0<1-\frac{\Lambda_{b,1}}{\Lambda_b}\leq e^{20}\,24^{10}\,b^{15}\,e^{-b/1280},$$

*where $\Lambda_{b,1}$ is the next point of the spectrum.*

*Proof. The interactions.* By Lemma 2.2(iii), $c_k$ lies in two plaquettes of the plane $\{\mu,s\}$, which contain $c_{k-1}$ or $c_{k+1}$, the link $(x+ke_s,s)$ or $(x+(k-1)e_s,s)$ of $F$, and an active twist link of direction $s$; and in four plaquettes of the planes $\{\mu,t\}$ and $\{\mu,\rho\}$, each containing $c_k$, one link of $F$ and two active links not on the line. The four plaquettes at $c_k$ lie in the hyperplane of $s$-coordinate $x_s+k$, so these plaquettes at different $k$ share no link; two plaquettes through $c_k$ share no other link; and their links have directions other than $s$, so they are not twists. Set every twist to 1; then the plaquette at $x+ke_s$ in the plane $\{\mu,s\}$ contributes $b\langle q_k,q_{k+1}\rangle$ to the exponent, with $q_k=Q_{c_k}$. In each of the four other plaquettes at $c_k$ set one of its two links to 1 and the other to $X$; after a cyclic rotation and possibly an inversion the plaquette variable is $q_kX^{\pm1}$ or $q_k^{-1}X^{\pm1}$, and since $\mathrm{Re}(q\bar u)=\mathrm{Re}(\bar q u)=\langle q,u\rangle$ for unit quaternions, $X$ can be chosen so that the plaquette contributes $b\langle q_k,u\rangle$ for any prescribed unit vector $u$. Every other active link is set to 1. Four unit vectors add up to any vector of length at most 4 (two copies each of $t\pm(1-|t|^2)^{1/2}\nu$ with $t=v/4$ and $\nu\perp t$ a unit vector), so the conditional density of the line is proportional to $\exp\bigl(b\sum_k\langle q_k,q_{k+1}\rangle+\sum_k\langle h_k,q_k\rangle\bigr)$ for any fields $h_k$ with $|h_k|\leq 4b$.

*The fields.* Let $a=\frac12$, $c=\frac{\sqrt3}{2}$, let $e_1,\dots,e_4$ be the standard basis of $\mathbb{R}^4$, and let $r_k$ have period ten with $(r_0,\dots,r_9)=a(e_1,-e_1,e_2,-e_2,e_3,-e_3,e_3,-e_2,e_2,-e_1)$. Put $h_k=b(2r_k-r_{k-1}-r_{k+1})$, so $|h_k|\leq 4ab=2b$, and the configuration is independent of $b$ because $h_k/b$ is. With $v_k=q_k-r_k$ and $|q_k|=1$, $|r_k|=a$, summation by parts gives, over $0\leq k\leq 9$,

$$\frac12\sum_k|v_{k+1}-v_k|^2=\sum_k\bigl(1-\langle q_k,q_{k+1}\rangle\bigr)-\frac1b\sum_k\langle h_k,q_k\rangle+\frac12\sum_k|r_{k+1}-r_k|^2+B(q_0)-B(q_{10}),$$

with $B(q)=\langle q,r_0-r_9\rangle$. The boundary terms only conjugate the ten-step transfer kernel by a multiplication operator, so up to similarity it is

$$K_b(x,y)=\int_{(S^3)^9}\exp\Bigl(-\frac{b}{2}\sum_{k=0}^{9}|v_{k+1}-v_k|^2\Bigr)dq_1\cdots dq_9,\qquad q_0=x,\ q_{10}=y,$$

with normalised Haar measure. The sequence $r_0,\dots,r_{10}$ is a palindrome, so $K_b=B_bB_b^*$ for the five-step kernel $B_b$; $K_b$ is compact, positive and self-adjoint with a continuous positive kernel, its top eigenvalue $\Lambda_b$ is simple, and its eigenfunction $\psi_b>0$ is even under the reflection $x_4\mapsto -x_4$, which commutes with $K_b$.

*A barrier.* Let $E = \frac{1}{2}\sum_{k=0}^{9} |v_{k+1} - v_k|^2$ and suppose that $(q_0)_4 \geq 0 \geq (q_{10})_4$ and $E \leq \frac{1}{1280}$. Put $\Delta = (20E)^{1/2} \leq \frac{1}{8}$ and $w = v_0$; by Cauchy–Schwarz $|w - v_k| \leq \Delta$ for all $k$, and $0 \leq w_4 \leq \Delta$ because the $r_k$ have no fourth coordinate. From $|v_k + r_k| = 1$, $||w+r_k|^2 - 1| \leq \Delta(2+\Delta) =: \eta$ for $0 \leq k \leq 5$. The pairs $r_k = \pm a e_l$ give $|w_l| \leq \eta/(2a) = \eta$ for $l = 1, 2, 3$ and $|w|^2 \geq \frac{3}{4} - \eta$, so $\frac{3}{4} \leq 3\eta^2 + \Delta^2 + \eta \leq 3(\frac{17}{64})^2 + \frac{1}{64} + \frac{17}{64} = \frac{2019}{4096}$, a contradiction. Hence $K_b(x, y) \leq e^{-b/1280}$ whenever $x_4 \geq 0 \geq y_4$.

*The top eigenvalue.* Let $\epsilon = b^{-1/2}$. The geodesic ball of radius $\epsilon \leq 1$ in $S^3$ has normalised measure $\frac{2}{\pi}\int_0^\epsilon \sin^2\theta \, d\theta \geq \frac{8\epsilon^3}{3\pi^3} > \frac{\epsilon^3}{24}$. If each $q_k$ lies in the ball of radius $\epsilon$ about $r_k + c e_4$, then $|v_k - c e_4| \leq \epsilon$ and $E \leq 20\epsilon^2$, so the integrand is at least $e^{-20}$. Testing $K_b$ on the normalised indicator of the ball about $r_0 + c e_4$ gives $\Lambda_b \geq e^{-20}(\epsilon^3/24)^{10} = e^{-20} 24^{-10} b^{-15}$.

*The gap.* Let $\phi(x) = \operatorname{sign}(x_4)\psi_b(x)$, a unit vector orthogonal to $\psi_b$. Then

$$\Lambda_b - \langle \phi, K_b \phi \rangle = 4 \int_{x_4 > 0 > y_4} \psi_b(x) K_b(x, y) \psi_b(y) \, dx \, dy \leq e^{-b/1280},$$

because $\int_{x_4>0} \psi_b \leq \frac{1}{2}$ by Cauchy–Schwarz. By the variational principle $\Lambda_{b,1} \geq \langle \phi, K_b \phi \rangle$, and dividing by the lower bound on $\Lambda_b$ proves the estimate; the gap is positive because $\Lambda_b$ is simple. □

The exterior of Proposition 11.21 is legal at every coupling, so a bound on the conditional law of single lines that is uniform in the exterior cannot be better than $e^{-b/1280}$ up to powers of $b$, and an argument of this kind cannot give (D) along the tuning. A proof of (D) has to use what such a bound discards: the joint resampling of the transverse links inside the cube, which the averaged coefficients $C_{V,j}$ retain, or the smallness of the probability of such exteriors under the Wilson measure.

## 12. Block averages

Proposition 11.3 locates the failure of (D) in the quadratic approximation: gauge transformations constant on the lines of $F$ move the whole cube and change few links outside it. This section takes up the programme of the report [53] of the third author, which keeps the cube condition but changes the gauge and conditions the cube on block averages of the field, as in Bałaban's renormalisation group [5, 6]. The natural block averages of the line field leave one class of lines invisible and fail at every size (Proposition 12.1). In a gauge whose fixed links are trees inside blocks of side two, the averages over whole blocks remove every zero mode, the constrained quadratic form has a gap that does not depend on the volume (Theorem 12.4), and the constrained cube condition holds at every coupling once the cube is large (Theorem 12.7). Integrating out one scale bounds the cube coefficients by the constrained ones plus those of the averages (Corollary 12.10), and the averages carry at least the coarse quadratic form at every scale (Proposition 12.8). For the group-valued links themselves, the straight paths between block roots satisfy a coercivity bound for all fields but do not compose, a continuous covariant map cannot treat the transverse positions alike, and a cut-off of Bałaban's averaging operation is coercive for all fields and agrees with the block averages to first order (Section 12.2). It composes across all scales on fields of small curvature for every compact group (Section 12.3), and under the SU(2) Wilson measure the fields that are not small form clusters of vanishing physical size (Section 12.4).

12.1. **Block-constrained cubes.** In this subsection everything concerns the quadratic approximation: real fields $\varphi$ on links, $(d\varphi)_p$ the signed sum around the plaquette $p$, and $(dh)_{(x,\mu)} = h(x) - h(x + e_\mu)$ for a function $h$ on sites.

**Proposition 12.1** ([53])**.** *In the setting of Proposition 11.3, condition the cube in addition on any family of the face averages*

$$V^{\mathrm{face}}_{y,\mu}(\varphi) = \frac{1}{8}\sum_{x} \big(\varphi_{(x,\mu)} + \varphi_{(x+e_\mu,\mu)}\big),$$

*where $x$ runs over the eight sites of the block $2y+\{0,1\}^4$ with $x_\mu = 2y_\mu$. Then $\sum_{c\in C_I} K_c \geq 12N_n$ for the twelve classes*

$$C_I = \{(0111,\mu),(1111,\mu),(0111+e_\mu,\mu),(1111+e_\mu,\mu) : \mu = 1,2,3\},$$

*written as residue of the base and direction. Hence $K_c \geq N_n$ for some class, and the constrained condition fails for every $\alpha < 1$, at every even $n$ and every $b$.*

*Proof.* By Table 3, $\sigma(0111) = \sigma(1111) = 0$, so the lines of $F$ through the sites with $x_1, x_2, x_3$ odd have direction 0; call them invisible. Let $\ell$ be one of them and $h_\ell$ its indicator. The sum of $dh_\ell$ along a path of length two from $x$ is $h_\ell(x) - h_\ell(x+2e_\mu)$. For $\mu \neq 0$ both end points have even $\mu$-coordinate and are off $\ell$; for $\mu = 0$ they have the same transverse coordinates and are both on $\ell$ or both off it. So $dh_\ell$ changes no face average, and the translation argument of Proposition 11.3 applies to the constrained laws: $\sum_{i\in V} |(dh_\ell)_i| \leq \sum_{j\notin V} C_{V,j} |(dh_\ell)_j|$. An active link $e = (x,\mu)$ has $|(dh_\ell)_e| = 1$ for at most one invisible $\ell$, since its two ends lie on different lines and both cannot be invisible (for $\mu \neq 0$ they differ in the coordinate $\mu$, and for $\mu = 0$ the link would lie in $F$). It has one such $\ell$ exactly when its base or its end has residue 0111 or 1111, which by Table 3 are the classes of $C_I$: the six classes with base residue 0111 or 1111 and direction $\mu \neq 0$, and the six with base residue $r + e_\mu$, $r \in \{0111, 1111\}$, whose directions $\mu$ differ from $\sigma(r+e_\mu)$ (for instance $\sigma(0011) = 3 \neq 1$). Summing over the invisible lines gives $12N_n \leq \sum_{c\in C_I} K_c$. □

**Definition 12.2.** The blocks are $B(y) = 2y + \{0,1\}^4$, $y \in \mathbb{Z}^4$, and $o = x \bmod 2$ is the offset of a site. A link $(x,\mu)$ is a *tree link* if $o_\mu = 0$ and $o_\nu = 0$ for every $\nu > \mu$, and *active* otherwise; fields vanish on tree links. For a coarse link $(y,\mu)$ the *block average* is

$$V_{y,\mu}(\varphi) = \frac{1}{16} \sum_{x\in B(y)} \big(\varphi_{(x,\mu)} + \varphi_{(x+e_\mu,\mu)}\big),$$

the mean of $\varphi$ summed along the sixteen paths of length two in the direction $\mu$ that start in $B(y)$.

**Lemma 12.3.** (i) *The fifteen tree links of a block form a spanning tree of its sixteen sites. Each block carries 49 active links: the 17 active links inside it, with $o_\mu = 0$, and the 32 links with $o_\mu = 1$, which join $B(y)$ to $B(y+e_\mu)$.*

(ii) *If $dh$ vanishes on the tree links, $h$ is constant on every block, and $V_{y,\mu}(\varphi + dh) = V_{y,\mu}(\varphi) + h_{B(y)} - h_{B(y+e_\mu)}$.*

(iii) *With $S^\mu_y = \sum_{x\in B(y),\, o_\mu = 0} \varphi_{(x,\mu)}$,*

$$V_{y,\mu}(\varphi) = \frac{1}{8} \sum_{x\in B(y),\, o_\mu = 1} \varphi_{(x,\mu)} + \frac{1}{16}\big(S^\mu_y + S^\mu_{y+e_\mu}\big).$$

*Proof.* (i) A tree link of direction $\mu$ has $o_\mu = 0$ and stays in its block; there are $2^\mu$ of them for each $\mu$, fifteen in all. From any site, the tree links of direction 3 lead to $o_3 = 0$, then those of direction 2 to $o_2 = 0$, and so on to the corner, so the tree links connect the sixteen sites, and fifteen edges connecting sixteen vertices form a tree. Of the 64 links with base in the block, the 32 with $o_\mu = 0$ stay inside it. (ii) $h$ is constant along the edges of a spanning tree. The path of length two from $x \in B(y)$ ends at $x + 2e_\mu \in B(y+e_\mu)$, and the sum of $dh$ along it is $h(x) - h(x+2e_\mu)$. (iii) The path from $x$ consists of $(x,\mu)$ and $(x+e_\mu,\mu)$; a link with $o_\mu = 1$ is the second link of one path and the first of another, and the links of $S^\mu_{y+e_\mu}$ are the second links of the paths that start with $o_\mu = 1$. □

By (ii) the residual gauge freedom is the coarse gauge group, which acts on the block averages as on the links of the coarse lattice. Let $W$ be a set of blocks and let $\Phi_W$ be the space of finitely supported real $\varphi$ on the active links with base in $\bigcup W$, with $V_{y,\mu}(\varphi) = 0$ for every $y \in W$ and every $\mu$. Write $Q(\varphi) = \sum_p (d\varphi)^2_p$ over all plaquettes, $\varphi$ being zero off its support.

**Theorem 12.4.** *For every set of blocks $W$ and every $\varphi \in \Phi_W$,*

$$\sum_e \varphi_e^2 \le 52\, Q(\varphi).$$

*Proof. Inside a block.* Let $e = (x, \mu)$ be an active link with $o_\mu = 0$, and let $\nu_1 > \cdots > \nu_k$ be the directions above $\mu$ in which $o$ equals one; $1 \le k \le 3$. Put $x_0 = x$ and $x_i = x_{i-1} - e_{\nu_i}$. The plaquette $p_i$ at $x_i$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu_i\}$ has the links $(x_i, \mu)$, $(x_{i-1}, \mu)$ and the tree links $(x_i, \nu_i)$, $(x_i + e_\mu, \nu_i)$, whose offsets vanish in $\nu_i$ and above it; and $(x_k, \mu)$ is a tree link. Hence $\varphi_e = \pm(d\varphi)_{p_1} \pm \cdots \pm (d\varphi)_{p_k}$ and $\varphi_e^2 \le k \sum_i (d\varphi)_{p_i}^2$. The plaquette at $x'$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ is used only by the links $(x' + e_\nu + \sum_{\rho \in R} e_\rho, \mu)$ with $R \subset \{\nu + 1, \dots, 3\}$, each with $k = c + 1 + |R|$, where $c$ is the number of ones of the offset of $x'$ strictly between $\mu$ and $\nu$. Its total weight $2^{3-\nu}(c+1) + (3-\nu)2^{2-\nu}$ is at most 8, the value at $\mu = 0$, $\nu = 1$. So the sum $I$ of $\varphi_e^2$ over the active links inside the blocks is at most $8Q_{\mathrm{in}}$, where $Q_{\mathrm{in}}$ is the sum over the plaquettes inside a block.

*Between blocks.* Fix $y \in W$ and $\mu$, and label the eight links $(x, \mu)$, $x \in B(y)$, $o_\mu = 1$, by the transverse offset $a \in \{0,1\}^3$. If $a$ and $a'$ differ in the coordinate $\nu$, with $o_\nu = 0$ at $a$, the plaquette at $x$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ contains these two links, $(x, \nu)$ in $B(y)$ and $(x + e_\mu, \nu)$ in $B(y + e_\mu)$, the last two inside their blocks. So $\varphi_a - \varphi_{a'} = \pm(d\varphi)_p \pm \psi \pm \psi'$ with $\psi, \psi'$ inside blocks, and these twelve face plaquettes correspond to the twelve edges of the cube $\{0,1\}^3$. By Lemma 12.3(iii) and $V_{y,\mu}(\varphi) = 0$, the mean of the $\varphi_a$ is $m = -(S^\mu_y + S^\mu_{y+e_\mu})/16$, so $8m^2 \le \frac{1}{2}$ times the sum of the squares of the sixteen links of $S^\mu_y$ and $S^\mu_{y+e_\mu}$. The Laplacian of the graph $\{0,1\}^3$ has smallest nonzero eigenvalue 2, so

$$\begin{aligned}\sum_a \varphi_a^2 &= 8m^2 + \sum_a (\varphi_a - m)^2 \\ &\le 8m^2 + \frac{3}{2} \sum_{\text{edges}} \big((d\varphi)_p^2 + \psi^2 + \psi'^2\big).\end{aligned}$$

Summed over $y \in W$ and $\mu$, a link $(z, \nu)$ inside a block occurs as $\psi$ or $\psi'$ once for each $\mu \ne \nu$ (as $\psi$ if $o_\mu = 1$, as $\psi'$ of the face of the block below if $o_\mu = 0$) and in two of the sums $S^\nu$, so it receives weight at most $3 \cdot \frac{3}{2} + 2 \cdot \frac{1}{2} = \frac{11}{2}$. The face plaquettes are distinct and lie in no block, so the links between blocks contribute at most $\frac{3}{2} Q_{\mathrm{face}} + \frac{11}{2} I$, and

$$\sum_e \varphi_e^2 \le \frac{13}{2} I + \frac{3}{2} Q_{\mathrm{face}} \le 52\, Q_{\mathrm{in}} + \frac{3}{2} Q_{\mathrm{face}} \le 52\, Q(\varphi). \qquad \square$$

With $W$ all blocks the bound extends to $\ell^2$, so the block-constrained quadratic form on $\mathbb{Z}^4$ has a spectral gap at least $\frac{1}{52}$; it removes in particular the four flat connections that are zero modes of the unconstrained form. In the Bloch decomposition the exact gap is $0.10748776948684\ldots$, attained at the momentum $(0, \pi, \pi, \pi)$, a floating-point value computed in [53] and reproduced in the archive; the theorem does not use it. The cube conditions now take the following form. Let $n$ be even, $V$ the active links with base in $[0, n)^4$, $W$ its blocks, and for an exterior $\eta$ and values $v = (v_{y,\mu})_{y \in W}$ let $\gamma^{\mathrm{c}}_V(\cdot \mid \eta, v)$ be the law on $\mathbb{R}^V$ with density proportional to $\exp(-\frac{b}{2} \sum_{p \cap V \ne \emptyset} (d\varphi)_p^2)$ on the affine set $\{V_{y,\mu}(\varphi) = v_{y,\mu}\}$, with $\varphi = \eta$ off $V$. Define $C^{\mathrm{c}}_{V,j}$, $K^{\mathrm{c}}_c$ and $D_{\mathrm{c}}(n, \alpha)$ as $C_{V,j}$, $K_c$ and $D(n, \alpha)$, with $v$ held fixed and the 49 classes of active links modulo two.

**Lemma 12.5.** *Let $H \ge 0$ be symmetric on $\mathbb{R}^m$ with $\|H\| \le h$, let $B : \mathbb{R}^m \to \mathbb{R}^k$ with $BB^\top \ge \beta > 0$ and $\langle x, Hx \rangle \ge a|x|^2$ on $\ker B$, and $s > 0$. Then $K = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} H & sB^\top \\ sB & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ is invertible, and the solution of $K(x, y) = (f, g)$ has $|x| \le (|f| + h|x_1|)/a + |x_1|$ with $|x_1| \le |g|/(s\sqrt{\beta})$, and $|y| \le (|f| + h|x|)/(s\sqrt{\beta})$.*

*Proof.* Put $x_1 = B^\top (BB^\top)^{-1} g/s$, so $sBx_1 = g$ and $|x_1| \le |g|/(s\sqrt{\beta})$. On $\ker B$ the compression of $H$ is at least $a$, so there is a unique $x_0 \in \ker B$ with $Hx_0 - f + Hx_1 \perp \ker B$, and $a|x_0| \le |f| + h|x_1|$. Then $f - H(x_0 + x_1)$ lies in $(\ker B)^\perp = \operatorname{ran} B^\top$, and

$y = (BB^{\top})^{-1}B(f - Hx)/s$ solves $sB^{\top}y = f - Hx$. For $f = g = 0$ the construction gives zero, so $K$ is injective. □

**Lemma 12.6** (Combes–Thomas [27])**.** *Let $K$ be an invertible symmetric matrix indexed by a finite set $X$, with $\|K^{-1}\| \le M_0$ and $\sum_b |K_{ab}| \le S$ for every $a$, and let $d : X \to \mathbb{R}$ satisfy $|d(a) - d(b)| \le 1$ whenever $K_{ab} \neq 0$. If $(e^{\lambda} - 1)SM_0 \le \frac{1}{2}$, then $\|e^{\lambda d}K^{-1}e^{-\lambda d}\| \le 2M_0$.*

*Proof.* $e^{\lambda d}Ke^{-\lambda d} = K + E$ with $|E_{ab}| \le (e^{\lambda} - 1)|K_{ab}|$, so $\|E\| \le (e^{\lambda} - 1)S$ by the Schur test, $\|K^{-1}E\| \le \frac{1}{2}$, and $(K + E)^{-1} = (1 + K^{-1}E)^{-1}K^{-1}$ has norm at most $2M_0$. □

**Theorem 12.7.** *For every $b > 0$, every even $n$ and every exterior link $j$:*

(i) *$\gamma^{\mathrm{c}}_V(\cdot \mid \eta, v)$ is a Gaussian law whose covariance depends on neither $\eta$ nor $v$ and whose mean is affine in $(\eta, v)$, and $C^{\mathrm{c}}_{V,j} = \|u_j\|_1$, where $u_j \in \mathbb{R}^V$ is the change of the mean when $\eta_j$ increases by one; $u_j$ does not depend on $b$;*

(ii) *$\sum_{e \in V} e^{2\lambda_0 d(e)} u_j(e)^2 \le 3500^2$ and $\|u_j\|_1 \le 10^{14}$, where $\lambda_0 = 2.4 \cdot 10^{-5}$ and $d(e)$ is the $\ell^{\infty}$ distance between the midpoints of $e$ and $j$;*

(iii) *$D_{\mathrm{c}}(n, \alpha)$ holds for every $\alpha \in (0, 1)$ and every even $n \ge 2 \cdot 10^{15}/\alpha$, at every $b > 0$.*

*Proof.* (i) Let $H$ be the matrix of $\sum_{p \cap V \neq \emptyset} (d\varphi)_p^2$ on $\mathbb{R}^V$ and $B$ that of the averages $V_{y,\mu}$, $y \in W$, restricted to $V$. By Theorem 12.4 with this $W$, $H \ge \frac{1}{52}$ on $\ker B$, so the density is that of a non-degenerate Gaussian on the affine set, its covariance is $b^{-1}$ times the inverse of $H$ on $\ker B$, and its mean $m$ minimises the quadratic form on the affine set. The mean is affine in $(\eta, v)$, and two exteriors that differ at $j$ give translates by $u_j$, which minimises $Q(u + \delta_j)$ subject to $Bu = g$, $g$ being minus the coefficients of $j$ in the averages. The translation argument of Proposition 11.3 gives $C^{\mathrm{c}}_{V,j} = \|u_j\|_1$.

(ii) The pair $(u_j, y)$, with $y$ the Lagrange multipliers, solves $K(u_j, y) = (f, sg)$ with $K$ as in Lemma 12.5, $s = 96$ and $f = -\sum_{p \ni j} (d\delta_j)_p \, d_p|_V$, where $d_p|_V$ is the row of the plaquette $p$ restricted to $V$. Each link lies in six plaquettes of four links, so the row sums of $|H|$ are at most 24 and $h \le 24$; $|f| \le 6\sqrt{3}$; and $|g| \le \frac{1}{16}$, since an exterior link enters at most one average of $W$, with weight $\frac{1}{16}$. By Lemma 12.3(iii) each average has squared norm at least $8 \cdot \frac{1}{64} = \frac{1}{8}$, two averages share links only if they are $(y, \mu)$ and $(y \pm e_\mu, \mu)$, and then their inner product is at most $8 \cdot \frac{1}{256} = \frac{1}{32}$; so $BB^{\top} \ge \frac{1}{16}$ by Gershgorin's theorem. With $a = \frac{1}{52}$, Lemma 12.5 gives $\|K^{-1}\| \le M_0 = 105$. The rows of $K$ have absolute sums at most $S = \max(24 + \frac{96}{8}, 96 \cdot 2) = 192$, because an average has eight coefficients $\frac{1}{8}$ and sixteen of $\frac{1}{16}$ and a link enters averages with total weight at most $\frac{1}{8}$. Index the rows of $B$ by the centre $2y + \frac{1}{2}(1, 1, 1, 1) + e_\mu$ of the two blocks of the average and put $d$ equal to the $\ell^{\infty}$ distance to the midpoint of $j$. Links of one plaquette, and an average and its links, are within distance one, so Lemma 12.6 applies with $\lambda = \log(1 + 1/40320) > \lambda_0$, and

$$\sum_e e^{2\lambda d(e)} u_j(e)^2 \le \big(2M_0 e^{\lambda}(|f| + s|g|)\big)^2 \le 3500^2,$$

since $f$ and $g$ live at distance at most one from $j$. At most $4(64k^3 + 16k)$ links have their base at $\ell^{\infty}$ distance $k \ge 1$ from the base of $j$, and their midpoints are at distance at least $k - 1$, so Cauchy–Schwarz gives

$$\|u_j\|_1^2 \le 3500^2 \cdot 4e^{2\lambda}\Big(1 + \sum_{k \ge 1} (64k^3 + 16k) e^{-2\lambda k}\Big) \le (10^{14})^2.$$

(iii) $C^{\mathrm{c}}_{V_x,j} = 0$ unless $j$ shares a plaquette with $V_x$ or enters an average of $V_x$, which forces the base $z$ of $j$ into $x + [-1, n + 1]^4$, while $z \notin x + [0, n)^4$ when $j \notin V_x$. For each coordinate at most $\frac{n}{2} + 2$ even $x_i$ satisfy the first condition and exactly $\frac{n}{2}$ the second, so

$$K^{\mathrm{c}}_c \le \Big(\Big(\frac{n}{2} + 2\Big)^4 - \Big(\frac{n}{2}\Big)^4\Big) 10^{14} \le \frac{17}{n}\, 10^{14} N_n$$

for $n \ge 10^4$, which is at most $\alpha N_n$ when $n \ge 2 \cdot 10^{15}/\alpha$. □

The constants are crude. The computations of [53] give $C^{\mathrm{c}}_{V,j} \le 12.48$ at $n = 4$, and an exact face expansion $K^{\mathrm{c}}_c/N_n = a_c/n + O(n^{-2})$ with $\max_c a_c = 61.18$, so that $D_{\mathrm{c}}(n, 0.95)$ first holds at $n = 64$; they are floating-point values, reproduced in the archive for $n \le 4$, and the theorem does not use them. The coefficients are large because the constrained responses obey no maximum principle: an exterior link changes the curvature of up to six plaquettes, and keeping the curvature small moves a dozen links inside the cube with alternating signs. Re-weighting the classes does not help much: if $\sum_{j \in c \setminus V} \sum_{c'} w_{c'} C^{c'}_{V,j} \le \alpha N_n w_c$ for positive weights $w$, where $C^{c'}_{V,j}$ is the part of $\|u_j\|_1$ on the links of the class $c'$, then $\alpha N_n$ is at least the spectral radius of the non-negative matrix of these sums, hence at least $\min_c K^{\mathrm{c}}_c$, by the Collatz–Wielandt inequality [53].

The block averages can be integrated out one scale at a time. For a field $v$ on the coarse links put $Q_1(v) = \sum_P (dv)_P^2$ over the plaquettes $P$ of the coarse lattice, and write $V(\varphi) = (V_{y,\mu}(\varphi))_{y,\mu}$. The averages of averages are formed in the same way on the coarse lattice, and $V^{(k)}$, $Q_k$ denote the $k$-fold averages and the plaquette form of the lattice of spacing $2^k$.

**Proposition 12.8.** *Let $\varphi$ be a finitely supported field on $\mathbb{Z}^4$ that vanishes on the tree links.*

(i) *For the coarse plaquette $P$ at $y$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$, $16\,(dV(\varphi))_P$ is the sum over $x \in B(y)$ of the curvatures of the squares of side two spanned by $x$, $x+2e_\mu$, $x+2e_\nu$, and every plaquette of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ lies in exactly four of these squares. Hence $Q_1(V(\varphi)) \le Q(\varphi)$, and $Q_k(V^{(k)}(\varphi)) \le Q(\varphi)$ for every $k \ge 1$.*

(ii) *For every finitely supported $v$ on the coarse links, the field $\varphi^*(v)$ equal to $v_{y,\mu}$ on the eight links $(x, \mu)$, $x \in B(y)$, $o_\mu = 1$, and to zero on the other links, vanishes on the tree links, has $V(\varphi^*(v)) = v$ and $Q(\varphi^*(v)) = 4\,Q_1(v)$.*

(iii) *The effective form $S_1(v) = \inf\{Q(\varphi) : V(\varphi) = v\}$ satisfies $Q_1 \le S_1 \le 4\,Q_1$, and $S_k(w) = \inf\{Q(\varphi) : V^{(k)}(\varphi) = w\} \ge Q_k(w)$ for every $k$, the infima over finitely supported fields that vanish on the tree links.*

(iv) *For every $k$, every set $W$ of blocks of the lattice of spacing $2^k$ and every $w$ in the space $\Phi_W$ of that lattice, $\sum_e w_e^2 \le 52\,S_k(w)$.*

*Proof.* (i) The path of length two from $x \in B(y)$ in the direction $\mu$ ends at $x+2e_\mu \in B(y+e_\mu)$, at the same offset, and so on around the square; so the four averages of $(dV)_P$ pair the sixteen paths into sixteen closed squares, and the sum of $\varphi$ around a square is the sum of the curvatures of its four plaquettes. A plaquette at $z$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ lies in the square from $x$ exactly when $z - x \in \{0,1\}e_\mu + \{0,1\}e_\nu$, which gives four points $x$, each in one block. By Cauchy–Schwarz, $(dV)_P^2 \le \frac{1}{16} \sum_x \ell_x^2 \le \frac{1}{4} \sum_x \sum_{p \subset \square_x} (d\varphi)_p^2$, where $\ell_x$ is the curvature of the square from $x$; summing over $P$ gives $Q_1(V(\varphi)) \le Q(\varphi)$. The argument uses neither the tree links nor the spacing, so it applies on every lattice, and induction gives the bound for $V^{(k)}$.

(ii) The tree links have $o_\mu = 0$. By Lemma 12.3(iii) the average of $\varphi^*$ is $\frac{1}{8} \cdot 8 v_{y,\mu}$. A plaquette inside a block has only links with $o_\mu = 0$ in its direction $\mu$, and so vanishes. A plaquette at $x$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ with $o_\mu = 1$, $o_\nu = 0$ has the two links $(x, \mu)$, $(x + e_\nu, \mu)$ of the same block, both equal to $v_{y,\mu}$, and two links with offset zero in the direction $\nu$; its curvature vanishes, and so does that of the plaquettes with $o_\mu = 0$, $o_\nu = 1$. If $o_\mu = o_\nu = 1$, its four links carry $v_{y,\mu}$, $v_{y+e_\mu,\nu}$, $v_{y+e_\nu,\mu}$, $v_{y,\nu}$, so its curvature is $(dv)_P$, and there are four such plaquettes for each $P$.

(iii) The lower bound is (i) and the upper bound is (ii); for $S_k$ apply (i) to the $k$-fold averages.

(iv) Theorem 12.4 holds on every lattice, so $\sum_e w_e^2 \le 52\,Q_k(w) \le 52\,S_k(w)$ by (iii). □

In the Bloch decomposition the eigenvalues of $S_1$ relative to $Q_1$ fill $[1, 4]$: they tend to one as the momentum tends to zero and equal four at $(\pi, \pi, 0, 0)$, a floating-point computation reproduced in the archive. So at this order the averages carry the coarse quadratic form

with no loss at long wavelengths; the coupling does not run here, and its running is the order-$g^2$ effect of Remark 12.11(c). Part (iv) is a gap for the averages at every scale, with the constant of Theorem 12.4; it does not give the localisation of Theorem 12.7(ii) for $S_k$, since $S_k$ is not a nearest-neighbour form.

**Lemma 12.9.** *Let $(X, d_X)$ and $(Y, d_Y)$ be Polish spaces, $\rho, \rho'$ Borel probability measures on $Y$, and $\kappa, \kappa'$ probability kernels from $Y$ to $X$, all with finite first moments. If $W_1(\kappa(\cdot \mid v), \kappa'(\cdot \mid v)) \le \varepsilon$ and $W_1(\kappa'(\cdot \mid v), \kappa'(\cdot \mid v')) \le d_Y(v, v')$ for all $v, v'$, then the mixtures $\pi = \int \kappa(\cdot \mid v)\, \rho(dv)$ and $\pi' = \int \kappa'(\cdot \mid v)\, \rho'(dv)$ satisfy*

$$W_1(\pi, \pi') \le \varepsilon + W_1^{d_Y}(\rho, \rho').$$

*Proof.* Let $F$ be 1-Lipschitz on $X$ and $\kappa F(v) = \int F\, d\kappa(\cdot \mid v)$. Then $\int F\, d\pi - \int F\, d\pi' = \int (\kappa F - \kappa' F)\, d\rho + \big(\int \kappa' F\, d\rho - \int \kappa' F\, d\rho'\big)$. The first term is at most $\varepsilon$. The function $\kappa' F$ is 1-Lipschitz for $d_Y$, so the second is at most $W_1^{d_Y}(\rho, \rho')$. The Kantorovich–Rubinstein duality gives the claim. □

A law $\gamma$ on $\mathbb{R}^V$ *decomposes along the averages* if $\gamma(\cdot \mid \eta) = \int \gamma_V^{\mathrm{c}}(\cdot \mid \eta, v)\, \rho_V(dv \mid \eta)$, with $\rho_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$ the law of $(V_{y,\mu})_{y \in W}$. Every law with density proportional to $\exp(-\frac{b}{2} \sum_{p \cap V \neq \emptyset} (d\varphi)_p^2)\, g(V(\varphi))$, on a set cut out by conditions on the averages, decomposes in this way, because Lebesgue measure disintegrates along the fibres of a surjective linear map into multiples of Lebesgue measure on the fibres. Here $g$ can carry any action of the averages, in particular a coarse gauge fixing and a coarse effective action, which is the form a law takes after the fine scale has been integrated out.

**Corollary 12.10.** *Let $r_w \in \mathbb{R}^V$ minimise $\sum_{p \cap V \neq \emptyset} (d\varphi)_p^2$, with zero exterior, subject to $V_{y',\mu'}(r_w) = \delta_{w,(y',\mu')}$ for all $(y', \mu')$, $y' \in W$; put $L_w = \|r_w\|_1$ and $d_L(v, v') = \sum_w L_w |v_w - v'_w|$. For every law that decomposes along the averages,*

$$C_{V,j} \le C_{V,j}^{\mathrm{c}} + C_{V,j}^{\rho}, \qquad C_{V,j}^{\rho} = \sup \frac{W_1^{d_L}(\rho_V(\cdot \mid \eta), \rho_V(\cdot \mid \eta'))}{|\eta_j - \eta'_j|},$$

*the supremum over exteriors that differ only at $j$, and $L_w \le 4 \cdot 10^{14}$. Hence $K_c \le K_c^{\mathrm{c}} + K_c^{\rho}$ with $K_c^{\rho} = \sum_{j \in c \setminus V} C_{V,j}^{\rho}$, and if $K_c^{\rho} \le \frac{\alpha}{2} N_n$ for every class and $n \ge 4 \cdot 10^{15}/\alpha$, then $D(n, \alpha)$ holds for the law, with the 49 classes of active links.*

*Proof.* Apply Lemma 12.9 with $\kappa = \gamma_V^{\mathrm{c}}(\cdot \mid \eta, \cdot)$, $\kappa' = \gamma_V^{\mathrm{c}}(\cdot \mid \eta', \cdot)$, $\rho = \rho_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$, $\rho' = \rho_V(\cdot \mid \eta')$. The first condition holds with $\varepsilon = C_{V,j}^{\mathrm{c}} |\eta_j - \eta'_j|$. By Theorem 12.7(i) the laws $\gamma_V^{\mathrm{c}}(\cdot \mid \eta', v)$ and $\gamma_V^{\mathrm{c}}(\cdot \mid \eta', v')$ are translates by $\sum_w (v'_w - v_w) r_w$, so their distance is at most $d_L(v, v')$. For the bound on $L_w$, the pair $(r_w, y)$ solves $K(r_w, y) = (0, s\, e_w)$ with $K$ as in the proof of Theorem 12.7. Measure $d$ from the centre of the row $w$; Lemma 12.6 gives $\sum_e e^{2\lambda d(e)} r_w(e)^2 \le (2M_0 s)^2 = 20160^2$. With $z_0 = 2y + e_\mu$ for $w = (y, \mu)$, a link whose base is at distance $k$ from $z_0$ has its midpoint at distance at least $k - 1$ from the centre, and the count in that proof gives $L_w^2 \le 20160^2 \cdot 4e^{2\lambda}(1 + \sum_{k \ge 1} (64k^3 + 16k) e^{-2\lambda k}) \le (4 \cdot 10^{14})^2$. Summing over the translates as in Definition 10.1 gives $K_c \le K_c^{\mathrm{c}} + K_c^{\rho}$, and Theorem 12.7(iii) with $\alpha/2$ in place of $\alpha$ gives $K_c^{\mathrm{c}} \le \frac{\alpha}{2} N_n$. □

The responses are much smaller than the bound: in floating point, $\max_w L_w$ is 23.8, 44.1 and 50.9 for the block $(m, m, m, m)$, $m = \lfloor n/4 \rfloor$, of the cubes $n = 4$, 6, 8. Since Theorem 12.7 controls the first term at every coupling, the corollary reduces $D(n, \alpha)$ for a law that decomposes along the averages to the cube condition $K_c^{\rho}$ for its averages, a problem of the same form one scale up, in the metric $d_L$. Iterating it needs the localisation of Theorem 12.7(ii) for $S_k$ and ends in a cube condition for the coarsest averages, which is where a gap has to come from: the quadratic approximation describes a massless field and has none. The corollary is one step of the composition of Remark 12.11(a), not its conclusion.

*Remark* 12.11. Theorem 12.7 is the weak-coupling half of the constrained route at leading order, and Theorem 10.4 cannot use it as it stands. Four steps remain, each an open problem.

(a) *Composition.* $D_{\mathrm{c}}$ holds the block averages fixed. A gap in physical units needs a theorem that combines the constrained conditions at all scales with a cube condition for the coarsest averages, in the place of Theorem 10.4. Corollary 12.10 is one step of it, and Proposition 12.8(iv) gives the gap at every scale; the localisation of $S_k$ uniformly in $k$ and a cube condition for the coarsest averages are open.

(b) *Beyond the quadratic approximation.* For the Wilson measure the block averages are products of group elements along paths, their level sets are curved, and the Bakry–Émery tensor of Section 6 is negative at large fields; Theorem 12.4 controls only the small fields, and the large fields have to be split off as in Bałaban's analysis [7]. For the straight paths between block roots the group-valued estimate holds for all fields (Theorem 12.13), but that map does not compose across scales (Proposition 12.16), and for every compact connected group no continuous covariant map treats the transverse positions of a block alike (Proposition 12.17). The cut-off average of Theorem 12.19 is coercive for all fields and agrees with the averages to first order, with constants for one step; on torus-valued fields of small curvature it composes (Theorem 12.21), and for every compact group it composes on fields whose curvature is small at every scale with a small sum (Theorem 12.25); under the Wilson measure the remaining large fields form microscopic clusters (Corollary 12.28), but the conditional estimate needed near them is open.

(c) *Second order.* Let $b_0 = 11N/(48\pi^2)$ for $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, $t = 2b_0 \log 2$, and let $g_m^{-2} = g_*^{-2} + tm$ be the one-loop coupling $m$ steps above a matching scale. Comparison with integrals gives $\sum_{m \le M} g_m^2 = t^{-1} \log M + O(1)$ and $\sum_m g_m^4 \le \pi^2/(6t^2)$ [53]. A loss $1 + cg_m^2$ per step therefore compounds to a power of $M$, and a step from one scale to the next has to be exact at order $g^2$, with that term absorbed into the running coupling and the normalisation of the field, and remainders of order $g^4$.

(d) *Crossover and existence.* The passage from weak coupling to the strong-coupling range of Section 4–8 and the existence of the limit, (E), are untouched.

The renormalisation group needed for (a) and (b) is the ultraviolet half of (E), so the constrained route places both residues on one construction.

12.2. **Path blocks for the group-valued links.** Remark 12.11(b) asks for estimates on the actual group-valued links. They can be proved for a coarser block map, the straight path between block roots, and this map exhibits the second half of the difficulty: it does not compose across scales. A topological argument shows why no continuous map that treats the transverse positions alike can take its place.

Let $G \subset \mathrm{U}(r)$ be a compact matrix group, $\delta(A, B) = \|A - B\|_{\mathrm{HS}}$, which is invariant under left and right multiplication, and work on the periodic lattice of side $2L$ with the block tree of Definition 12.2, all fifteen tree links of each block equal to $I$. Write $\mathcal{B}$ for the number of blocks. The *path map* is

$$V^{\mathrm{p}}_{y,\mu}(U) = U_{2y+e_\mu,\mu},$$

the product along the straight path from $2y$ to $2y + 2e_\mu$, whose first link is a tree link; it transforms as a link under the gauge transformations at the block roots. Fixing $V^{\mathrm{p}} = v$ fixes four of the 49 active links of each block, so the fibre is $G^{45\mathcal{B}}$, and the Wilson law in the tree gauge restricts to it with product Haar measure as reference, since the tree gauge has unit Jacobian. The *reconstruction* $R(v)$ puts $R_{2y+o,\mu} = v_{y,\mu}$ if $o_\mu = 1$ and $R_{2y+o,\mu} = I$ otherwise. For $U$ in the fibre of $v$ put

$$D_v(U)^2 = \sum_e \delta(U_e, R_e(v))^2, \qquad Q(U) = \sum_p \delta(U_p, I)^2,$$

the first sum having zero terms on the tree and path links, and let $Q_1(v) = \sum_P \delta(v_P, I)^2$ on the coarse lattice.

**Lemma 12.12.** *For vectors $z_a$ of a real Hilbert space indexed by $a \in \{0,1\}^3$, with $z_0 = 0$,*

$$\sum_a \|z_a\|^2 \le \frac{3+\sqrt{7}}{2} \sum_{\{a,a'\}} \|z_a - z_{a'}\|^2 \le 3 \sum_{\{a,a'\}} \|z_a - z_{a'}\|^2,$$

*the sums on the right over the twelve edges of the cube.*

*Proof.* It suffices to treat real numbers. The right side is $\langle z, L_0 z\rangle$, where $L_0$ is the Laplacian of the cube with the vertex 0 deleted, and the claim is that its least eigenvalue is $3-\sqrt{7}$. The permutations of the coordinates commute with $L_0$. On the functions $f_k$ of the level $k = |a|$, $L_0$ acts by $f_1 \mapsto 3f_1 - 2f_2$, $f_2 \mapsto 3f_2 - 2f_1 - f_3$, $f_3 \mapsto 3f_3 - 3f_2$, whose characteristic polynomial in $t = 3 - \lambda$ is $t^3 - 7t$; the eigenvalues are 3 and $3 \pm \sqrt{7}$. On the functions of levels one and two whose sum over each level vanishes, indexed by the coordinate that is one at level one and zero at level two, $L_0$ acts by the matrix $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ 1 & 3 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, with eigenvalues 2 and 4; at level three these functions vanish. The two spaces have dimensions 3 and 4 and span $\mathbb{R}^7$. Finally $1/(3-\sqrt{7}) = (3+\sqrt{7})/2 < 3$.[18] □

**Theorem 12.13.** *For every $G \subset \mathrm{U}(r)$, every $L \ge 1$, every $v$ and every $U$ in the fibre of $v$,*

$$D_v(U)^2 \le 224\, Q(U).$$

*Proof.* Let $I_0$ be the sum of $\delta(U_e, I)^2$ over the active links inside the blocks and $J_0$ the sum of $\delta(U_e, v_{y,\mu})^2$ over the links that leave $B(y)$ in the direction $\mu$, so $D_v^2 = I_0 + J_0$. For an active link inside a block, the chain of plaquettes in the proof of Theorem 12.4 applies to group elements: each plaquette of the chain has its two transverse links on the tree, so the holonomy is the product of two consecutive links of the chain, and invariance of $\delta$ with the triangle inequality gives $\delta(U_e, I)^2 \le k \sum_i \delta(U_{p_i}, I)^2$ with $k \le 3$. The loads are those of that proof, so $I_0 \le 8 Q_{\mathrm{in}}$. Fix $y, \mu$ and label the eight links leaving $B(y)$ by the transverse offset $a \in \{0,1\}^3$; the link $a = 0$ is the path link and equals $v_{y,\mu}$. For a transverse edge $\{a, a'\}$ the face plaquette has holonomy $U_a \psi' U_{a'}^{-1} \psi^{-1}$ with $\psi, \psi'$ links inside the two blocks, so $\delta(U_a, U_{a'}) \le \delta(U_p, I) + \delta(\psi, I) + \delta(\psi', I)$. Lemma 12.12 with $z_a = U_a - v_{y,\mu}$ in the real Hilbert–Schmidt space and Cauchy–Schwarz bound the eight terms by 9 times the sum of the three squares over the twelve edges. Each face plaquette occurs once, and each link inside a block occurs once for each of the three directions other than its own, as in the proof of Theorem 12.4. Hence $J_0 \le 9 Q_{\mathrm{face}} + 27 I_0$ and $D_v^2 \le 28 I_0 + 9 Q_{\mathrm{face}} \le 224\, Q$. □

The bound holds for all fields, with no small-field condition and no logarithmic chart; Theorem 12.4 is its linearisation for the averages, with the better constant 52.

**Proposition 12.14.** *$Q_1(V^{\mathrm{p}}(U)) \le 4Q(U)$, $Q(R(v)) = 4Q_1(v)$ and $Q(U) \le 8Q_1(v) + 48 D_v(U)^2$ for $U$ in the fibre of $v$; if $Q_1(v) = 0$, then $Q(U) \le 24 D_v(U)^2$.*

*Proof.* The holonomy of a coarse plaquette is that of the square of side two at $2y$, a product of four conjugated fine plaquette holonomies, so $\delta(v_P, I) \le \sum_{p \subset P} \delta(U_p, I)$; these squares tile each coordinate plane, which gives the first bound. In $R(v)$ only the plaquettes with offset one in both directions carry holonomy, equal to that of the coarse plaquette, four for each $P$. For any plaquette, telescoping gives $\delta(U_p, R_p) \le \sum_{e \in p} \delta(U_e, R_e)$, so $\delta(U_p, I)^2 \le 2\delta(R_p, I)^2 + 8 \sum_{e \in p} \delta(U_e, R_e)^2$, and each link lies in six plaquettes. If $Q_1(v) = 0$, every $R_p$ is $I$ and the factor 2 is not needed. □

Let $m = 45\mathcal{B}$, let the action be $\lambda Q$ with $\lambda \ge 0$ (for $\mathrm{SU}(N)$, $\lambda = \beta/(2N)$ up to a constant), and put

$$z_G(t) = \int_G e^{-t\delta(g,I)^2} dg, \qquad Z_\lambda(v) = \int_{G^m} e^{-\lambda Q(U)} dU,$$

[18] The constant $(3+\sqrt{7})/2$ is attained by a function of the level $|a|$ alone, so it is the best constant in the lemma.

with normalised Haar measures, the integral over the fibre of $v$.

**Theorem 12.15.** *For every $v$,*

$$e^{-8\lambda Q_1(v)} z_G(48\lambda)^m \le Z_\lambda(v) \le e^{-\lambda Q_1(v)/8} z_G(\lambda/448)^m,$$

*and if $Q_1(v) = 0$, then $z_G(24\lambda)^m \le Z_\lambda(v) \le z_G(\lambda/224)^m$. Let $A_\lambda = z_G(\lambda/448)/z_G(24\lambda)$. Under the conditional law at such a $v$,*

$$\mathbb{E}\, e^{\lambda D_v^2/448} \le A_\lambda^m, \qquad \mathbb{E}\, \delta(U_e, I)^2 \le \frac{20160}{\lambda} \log A_\lambda$$

*for each link $e$ when $v \equiv I$, and $A_\lambda \to 10752^{q/2}$ as $\lambda \to \infty$ if $G$ has dimension $q \ge 1$.*

*Proof.* By Theorem 12.13 and Proposition 12.14, $Q \ge \frac{1}{2}(D_v^2/224 + Q_1/4)$ and $Q \le 8Q_1 + 48D_v^2$. Each term of $D_v^2$ involves one free link, and right multiplication by $R_e(v)^{-1}$ preserves Haar measure, so $\int e^{-tD_v^2} dU = z_G(t)^m$; this gives the two bounds, and the flat case is the same with $Q \le 24D_v^2$. Next, $-\lambda Q + \lambda D_v^2/448 \le -\lambda D_v^2/448$, and integration with the lower bound gives the exponential moment; Jensen's inequality gives $\mathbb{E}D_v^2 \le (448m/\lambda)\log A_\lambda$. When $v \equiv I$ the law is invariant under translation by blocks, so the $\mathcal{B}$ links of each of the 45 classes have equal expectations, and $448 \cdot 45 = 20160$. Finally, in exponential coordinates $\delta(e^X, I)^2 = \|X\|^2 + O(\|X\|^4)$ and the Haar density is smooth and positive at 0, while $\delta(\cdot, I)$ is bounded below away from $I$; so $z_G(t) \sim c_G t^{-q/2}$, and the ratio at $\lambda/448$ and $24\lambda$ tends to $(24 \cdot 448)^{q/2}$. □

So the fluctuations of the free links around a flat path field are of order $\lambda^{-1/2}$ uniformly in the volume, for the group variables themselves. The path map cannot be iterated, however, and this is where it differs from the averages. Write $V^{\mathrm{p},k}$ for the $k$-fold path map, the straight path of length $s = 2^k$, and $Q_k$ for the plaquette energy of the lattice of spacing $s$.

**Proposition 12.16.** *On the periodic lattice of side $3s$, $s = 2^k$, there are* SU(2) *fields in the tree gauge with*

$$\frac{Q(U)}{Q_k(V^{\mathrm{p},k}(U))} = s \sin^2 \frac{\pi}{2s} \le \frac{\pi^2}{4s}.$$

*For the averages, by contrast, $Q_k(V^{(k)}(\varphi)) \le Q(\varphi)$ for every $k$ in the quadratic approximation (Proposition 12.8(i)).*

*Proof.* Let $T = \mathrm{diag}(i\pi/2, -i\pi/2)$. Put the $s/2$ links in the direction 0 at $(j, 0, 0, 0)$, $j$ odd, $j < s$, equal to $e^{2T/s}$ and all other links equal to $I$. These links have offset one in the direction 0, so the tree gauge holds, and the links at even $j$ are tree links. The path from 0 to $se_0$ carries $e^T$ and every other path carries $I$, so one coarse link is $e^T$, and it lies in six coarse plaquettes, each with $\delta^2 = \|e^T - I\|_{\mathrm{HS}}^2 = 4$: $Q_k = 24$. No fine plaquette contains two of the changed links, since the two links of a plaquette in the direction 0 differ in a transverse coordinate, so there are $3s$ nonzero fine plaquettes, each with $\delta^2 = 8\sin^2(\pi/2s)$, and $Q = 24s\sin^2(\pi/2s)$. Gauge covariance of the path map makes the ratio gauge invariant. □

A field concentrated on one thin path carries a coarse curvature of order one at a fine cost of order $1/s$. In the averages it is one transverse position among $s^3$ and enters with the weight $s^{-3}$, which is why the averages compose and the paths do not. The two properties needed for Remark 12.11(a) and (b) are therefore held by two different maps: the paths give a global estimate for the group-valued links on fibres that do not compose, and the averages compose on linear fibres that exist only in the quadratic approximation.

A block map with both properties cannot treat the transverse positions alike and be continuous, for any compact connected gauge group. Let $s = 2^k$ and let $V$ be a map of the links with both ends in $B(y) \cup B(y + e_\mu)$, blocks of side $s$, to $G$. Call it *covariant* if $V(U^h) = h_1 V(U) h_2^{-1}$ for every gauge transformation $h$ equal to $h_1$ on $B(y)$ and to $h_2$ on $B(y + e_\mu)$, and *normalised* if $V(I) = I$. The path map and its iterates are covariant, normalised and continuous. Let $T$ be the set of the $s^3$ links in the direction $\mu$ from $B(y)$ to

$B(y+e_\mu)$, and for $u \in G^T$ let $U(u)$ carry $u_t$ on the link $t \in T$ and $I$ on every other link (Figure 13). Let $S \subset G$ be a maximal torus, of dimension $\ell$; a basis of the kernel of its exponential map identifies $S$ with $(\mathbb{R}/2\pi\mathbb{Z})^\ell$ and its first homology with $\mathbb{Z}^\ell$.

**Proposition 12.17.** *Let $G \subset \mathrm{U}(r)$ be a compact connected Lie group of positive dimension, let $V$ be covariant and normalised, and let $F(u) = V(U(u))$ be continuous on $G^T$. Then $F$ maps $S^T$ into $S$, and the integer matrices $W_t$ by which the maps $u_t \mapsto F(u)$, $u_t \in S$, $u_{t'} = I$ for $t' \neq t$, act on $H_1(S) = \mathbb{Z}^\ell$ satisfy*

$$\sum_{t \in T} W_t = I_\ell .$$

*Hence some $W_t \neq 0$, so that the map $u_t \mapsto V(U(u))$ on fields equal to $I$ off the link $t$ is not homotopic to a constant on $S$, and, if $|T| \geq 2$, no transitive group of permutations of $T$ leaves $F$ invariant. For $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$, $\ell = 1$, the $W_t$ are integers adding up to one, and some field equal to $I$ off one link of $T$ has $V = -I$.*

*Proof.* The gauge transformation equal to $g$ on $B(y) \cup B(y+e_\mu)$ maps $U(u)$ to $U(gug^{-1})$, since the links equal to $I$ stay $I$, and the one equal to $g$ on $B(y)$ and to $I$ on $B(y+e_\mu)$ maps it to $U(gu)$. So $F(gug^{-1}) = gF(u)g^{-1}$ and $F(gu) = gF(u)$, and with $F(I) = I$ the second gives $F(g,\dots,g) = g$. If every $u_t$ lies in $S$, every $g \in S$ fixes $u$ under conjugation, so $F(u)$ commutes with $S$; in a compact connected Lie group a maximal torus is its own centraliser [42], so $F(u) \in S$. Therefore $F$ restricts to a continuous map $f : S^T \to S$. The first homology of $S^T$ is $\bigoplus_{t \in T} \mathbb{Z}^\ell$, the $t$-th summand coming from the inclusion of the $t$-th factor with the identity elsewhere, so $f$ acts on it by $(x_t)_t \mapsto \sum_t W_t x_t$. The diagonal map $S \to S^T$ acts by $x \mapsto (x,\dots,x)$, and $f$ composed with it is the identity of $S$ because $F(g,\dots,g) = g$. Hence $\sum_t W_t = I_\ell$. If all $W_t$ vanished the sum would vanish, and a map of tori that is homotopic to a constant acts by zero on homology. A transitive permutation group preserving $F$ would make all $W_t$ equal to one matrix $W$, and $|T|\,W = I_\ell$ has no integer solution for $|T| \geq 2$. For $\mathrm{SU}(2)$, $S$ is a circle through $-I$, and a loop of nonzero degree in a circle is onto. □

For the path map, $W_t$ is the identity at the position of the path and zero elsewhere. Averages of the path holonomies weigh the positions alike, so by the proposition they have no continuous covariant extension to all of $G^T$, for $\mathrm{SU}(N)$ and for every compact simple group. Bałaban's averages are defined only on fields whose plaquettes are small, and the large fields are split off [5, 7]. A block map with both properties for all fields is therefore discontinuous or, like the path map, not invariant under the transverse symmetries of the block. Theorem 12.19 below gives a continuous one whose departure from the symmetry is confined to large fields.[19]

The proposition leaves room for a map that treats the positions alike to first order and breaks the symmetry only where the field is large. For a coarse link $(y,\mu)$ and $x \in B(y)$ put

$$P_x = U_{x,\mu} U_{x+e_\mu,\mu},$$

the product along the straight path of length two from $x$ to $x+2e_\mu$. In the tree gauge it is the parallel transport from $2y$ to $2y+2e_\mu$ through $x$ and $x+2e_\mu$, it transforms as a link under the gauge transformations at the block roots, and $P_{2y} = V^{\mathrm{p}}_{y,\mu}$, since the first link of that path is a tree link. Let $\mathfrak{g}$ be the Lie algebra of $G$, $\|X\|$ the Hilbert–Schmidt norm and $\log$ the principal logarithm of unitary matrices without the eigenvalue $-1$.

**Lemma 12.18.** *If $g$ is unitary and $\delta(g,I) \leq 1$, then $\|\log g\| \leq \frac{\pi}{3}\,\delta(g,I)$. If $X$ is skew-Hermitian, then $\delta(e^X, I) \leq \|X\|$.*

[19] That spheres and tori carry no continuous symmetric mean goes back to Aumann [2] and Eckmann [33]; the proof above is their homology argument in gauge-covariant form, with the links of the slice $T$ as the arguments of the mean and a maximal torus in place of the circle.

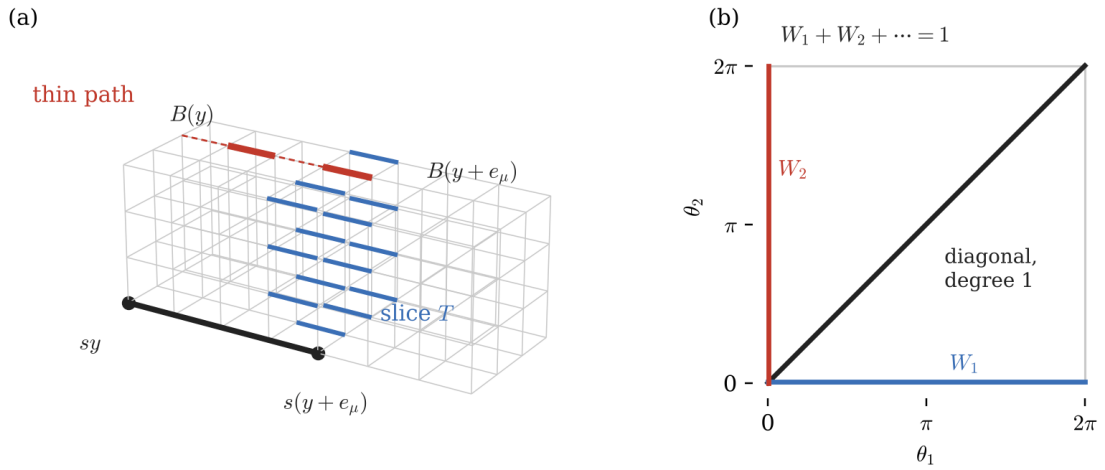



FIGURE 13. (a) Two adjacent blocks $B(y)$, $B(y+e_\mu)$ of side $s=4$, drawn in three of the four dimensions. The black segment is the straight path between the roots, the coarse link of the path map. The blue links form the slice $T$ of Proposition 12.17. The red links carry the field of Proposition 12.16: a path whose holonomy is that of a coarse link of order one, at a fine energy of order $1/s$. (b) For SU(2), two coordinates of the torus $(\mathbb{R}/2\pi\mathbb{Z})^T$ of slice fields with values in a maximal torus. The diagonal is pure gauge and is sent to a loop of degree one, so the degrees $W_t$ of the coordinate loops add up to one.

*Proof.* Let $e^{i\theta_j}$, $|\theta_j| \le \pi$, be the eigenvalues of $g$. Then $\delta(g,I)^2 = \sum_j 4\sin^2(\theta_j/2)$ and $\|\log g\|^2 = \sum_j \theta_j^2$. Each term of the first sum is at most 1, so $|\theta_j| \le \pi/3$, and $\theta/(2\sin(\theta/2))$ increases on $(0,\pi)$ and equals $\pi/3$ at $\theta = \pi/3$. The second statement is $|e^{i\theta}-1| \le |\theta|$ for the eigenvalues of $X$. □

Let $\rho_G \in (0,1]$ be such that $\log g \in \mathfrak{g}$ for every $g \in G$ with $\delta(g,I) \le \rho_G$.[20] Let $\phi(t) = \min\{1, \max\{0, 2-2t\}\}$, which equals 1 on $[0,\frac12]$ and 0 on $[1,\infty)$, put

$$\chi_{y,\mu}(U) = \phi\Big(\rho_G^{-1} \max_{x\in B(y)} \delta(P_x, P_{2y})\Big),$$

and define the *cut-off average*

$$V^\sharp_{y,\mu}(U) = P_{2y} \exp\Big(\frac{\chi_{y,\mu}(U)}{16} \sum_{x\in B(y)} \log(P_{2y}^{-1} P_x)\Big), \tag{12.1}$$

the exponential factor being $I$ when $\chi_{y,\mu}(U) = 0$ (Figure 14). When every path is close to the straight one it is the average of the sixteen paths taken in the chart at $P_{2y}$; when some path is far from it, it is the path map.

**Theorem 12.19.** *For every compact $G \subset \mathrm{U}(r)$ the cut-off average is continuous, covariant and normalised, and the following hold, with $c = \pi/3$.*

(i) *If $\delta(P_x, P_{2y}) \le \rho_G/2$ for every $x \in B(y)$, then $V^\sharp_{y,\mu}(U) = P_{2y}\exp(\frac{1}{16}\sum_x \log(P_{2y}^{-1}P_x))$. For $\varphi$ with values in $\mathfrak{g}$, vanishing on the tree links,*

$$V^\sharp_{y,\mu}(e^{t\varphi}) = I + t\,V_{y,\mu}(\varphi) + O(t^2),$$

[20] The exponential map of $G$ is a diffeomorphism from a ball of $\mathfrak{g}$ of operator-norm radius less than $\pi$ onto a neighbourhood $N$ of $I$ in $G$, on which it inverts the principal logarithm, and $N$ contains $\{g \in G : \delta(g,I) \le \rho\}$ for small $\rho > 0$. For $\mathrm{U}(r)$ one may take $\rho_G = 1$. For $\mathrm{SU}(N)$ one may take $\rho_G = \min\{1, 5/\sqrt{N}\}$: by Lemma 12.18 the trace of $\log g$ has modulus at most $\sqrt{N}\,\pi\rho_G/3 < 2\pi$, and it lies in $2\pi i\mathbb{Z}$. Some restriction is needed: on the circle $\{\mathrm{diag}(z, z^7)\} \subset \mathrm{U}(2)$ the point $z = e^{2\pi i/7}$ has $\delta(g,I) < 1$ but $\log g \notin \mathfrak{g}$.

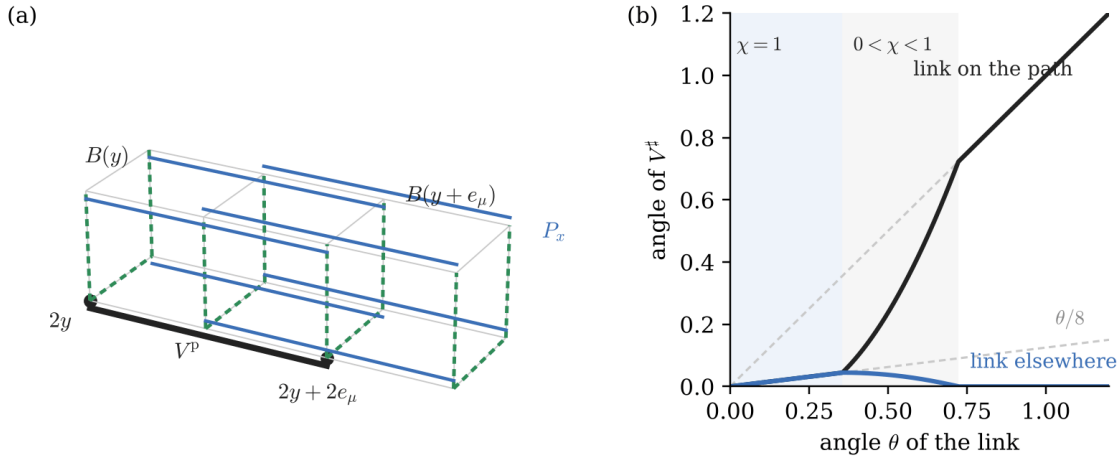



FIGURE 14. (a) A block $B(y)$ of side two and the next block in the direction $\mu$, drawn in three of the four dimensions. Green dashed: the tree links, equal to $I$. Blue: the paths $P_x$ of length two from the sites of $B(y)$, each joining $2y$ to $2y + 2e_\mu$ through the trees; black: the straight path $P_{2y}$, the coarse link of the path map. The cut-off average is the mean of the sixteen paths in the chart at $P_{2y}$ while every path is close to it. (b) For SU(2) and one link $e^{\theta X}$, $X = \mathrm{diag}(i, -i)$, the angle of $V^\sharp$ when the link lies on the straight path (black) or at another transverse position (blue), with $\rho_G = 1$. Both equal $\theta/8$, the block average, while $\chi = 1$; past the cut-off they are the path map, $\theta$ and 0, so the slice windings are 1 and 0.

*with $V_{y,\mu}$ the block average of Definition 12.2.*

(ii) *For every field $U$ in the tree gauge,*

$$\sum_{y,\mu} \sum_{x \in B(y)} \delta(P_x, P_{2y})^2 \le 896\, Q(U),$$

$$\sum_{y,\mu} \delta(V^\sharp_{y,\mu}(U), V^{\mathrm{p}}_{y,\mu}(U))^2 \le 56c^2\, Q(U),$$

$$\sum_{e} \delta(U_e, R_e(V^\sharp(U)))^2 \le (448 + 896c^2)\, Q(U),$$

$$Q_1(V^\sharp(U)) \le (8 + 2688c^2)\, Q(U),$$

*and $448 + 896c^2 < 1431$, $8 + 2688c^2 < 2956$.*

(iii) *In the setting of Proposition 12.17 with $s = 2$, $W_t$ is the identity at the position of the straight path and 0 at the seven others.*

(iv) *If $U$ equals $I$ except on one link from $B(y)$ to $B(y + e_\mu)$, where it equals $g$ with $\delta(g, I) \le \rho_G/2$, then $V^\sharp_{y,\mu}(U) = \exp(\frac{1}{8} \log g)$, at each of the eight transverse positions of the link; the path map gives $g$ at one position and $I$ at the seven others.*

*Proof.* Write $P = P_{2y}$, $v_x = P^{-1} P_x$ and $m = \max_x \delta(v_x, I) = \max_x \delta(P_x, P)$. Where $m < \rho_G$, every $\log v_x$ lies in $\mathfrak{g}$, depends continuously on $U$ by Lemma 12.18, which keeps the eigenvalues of $v_x$ away from $-1$, and the exponent of (12.1) lies in $\mathfrak{g}$, so $V^\sharp \in G$. Where $m \ge \rho_G$, $V^\sharp = P$. As $m$ increases to $\rho_G$ the exponent has norm at most $\chi c \rho_G \to 0$, so $V^\sharp$ is continuous. Let $h$ be a gauge transformation equal to $h_1$ on $B(y)$ and to $h_2$ on $B(y + e_\mu)$. The middle point $x + e_\mu$ of each path lies in one of the two blocks, so $P_x \mapsto h_1 P_x h_2^{-1}$ and $v_x \mapsto h_2 v_x h_2^{-1}$; $\delta$ is invariant and log is equivariant under unitary conjugation, so $\chi$ is unchanged and $V^\sharp \mapsto h_1 V^\sharp h_2^{-1}$. At $U = I$ every $v_x$ is $I$, so $V^\sharp(I) = I$.

(i) The first statement is $\chi = 1$. If $U = e^{t\varphi}$ with $\varphi = 0$ on the tree, then $P = I + t\varphi_{2y+e_\mu,\mu} + O(t^2)$ and $\log v_x = t(\varphi_{x,\mu} + \varphi_{x+e_\mu,\mu} - \varphi_{2y+e_\mu,\mu}) + O(t^2)$, and for small $t$ the condition of the first statement holds. The mean over the sixteen $x$ is $t(V_{y,\mu}(\varphi) - \varphi_{2y+e_\mu,\mu}) + O(t^2)$, since $\varphi_{2y,\mu} = 0$, and multiplying by $P$ gives the claim.

(ii) In the tree gauge $P = v_{y,\mu} := V^{\mathrm{P}}_{y,\mu}(U)$. If $o_\mu = 0$, then $U_{x+e_\mu,\mu}$ is the link leaving $B(y)$ at the transverse offset of $x$, and invariance of $\delta$ with the triangle inequality gives $\delta(P_x, P) \le \delta(U_{x,\mu}, I) + \delta(U_{x+e_\mu,\mu}, v_{y,\mu})$; if $o_\mu = 1$, the roles of the two links are exchanged. Each link leaving a block in the direction $\mu$ occurs for two sites $x$ of that block, and each link in the direction $\mu$ with $o_\mu = 0$ occurs once for the block containing it and once for the block before it. With $(a+b)^2 \le 2a^2 + 2b^2$ and the notation of the proof of Theorem 12.13, the sum is at most $2(2I_0 + 2J_0) = 4D_v^2 \le 896Q$. Next, if $\chi > 0$, Lemma 12.18 and the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality give

$$\begin{aligned}\delta(V^\sharp, P) &\le \Big\| \frac{\chi}{16} \sum_x \log v_x \Big\| \le \frac{c}{16} \sum_x \delta(v_x, I) \\ &\le \frac{c}{4} \Big( \sum_x \delta(P_x, P)^2 \Big)^{1/2},\end{aligned}$$

and the second bound follows from the first, $896c^2/16 = 56c^2$. The reconstruction $R(V^\sharp)$ agrees with $R(v)$ on the links with $o_\mu = 0$, and on the eight links with $o_\mu = 1$ of each block and direction $\delta(U_e, V^\sharp)^2 \le 2\delta(U_e, v)^2 + 2\delta(V^\sharp, v)^2$; so the third sum is at most $2D_v^2 + 16 \cdot 56c^2 Q \le (448 + 896c^2)Q$. Finally, write $V^\sharp = vM$. Removing the four factors $M$ from the holonomy of a coarse plaquette one at a time changes $\delta(\cdot, I)$ by at most $\delta(M, I)$ each time, so $\delta(V_P^\sharp, I)^2 \le 2\delta(v_P, I)^2 + 8 \sum_{\ell \in P} \delta(M_\ell, I)^2$. Each coarse link lies in six coarse plaquettes, so $Q_1(V^\sharp) \le 2Q_1(v) + 48 \cdot 56c^2 Q$, and $Q_1(v) \le 4Q$ by Proposition 12.14. The numerical bounds use $c^2 < 1.0967$.

(iii) For $s = 2$ the slice $T$ consists of the eight links leaving $B(y)$, and the links inside the blocks are $I$, so $P_x = u_a$ for the transverse offset $a$ of $x$, two sites for each $a$. Let $t$ be a position other than the straight path and $u_{t'} = I$ for $t' \ne t$. Then $P = I$, two of the $v_x$ equal $u_t$ and the others $I$, so $F(u) = \exp(\frac{1}{8}\chi \log u_t)$ with $\chi = \phi(\delta(u_t, I)/\rho_G)$. On $S$ the maps $u_t \mapsto \exp(\frac{\lambda}{8}\chi \log u_t)$, $0 \le \lambda \le 1$, are continuous by the argument above and take values in $S$, since $\log u_t$ commutes with $S$ and the centraliser of a maximal torus in $\mathfrak{g}$ is its Lie algebra; they join $F$ to the constant $I$, so $W_t = 0$. By Proposition 12.17 the $W_t$ add up to the identity, which is therefore the matrix at the straight path.

(iv) At the straight path, $P_x = g$ for the two sites with transverse offset 0 and $P_x = I$ for the others, so $V^\sharp = g \exp(-\frac{14}{16} \log g) = \exp(\frac{1}{8} \log g)$; at another position, $P = I$ and two of the $P_x$ equal $g$, so $V^\sharp = \exp(\frac{2}{16} \log g)$. □

The small-field part of (12.1) is Bałaban's averaging operation [6]; the cut-off extends it to all fields with the bounds of (ii). The theorem shows how far Proposition 12.17 reaches. The cut-off average is continuous, covariant and coercive for every field, and it agrees with the block averages to first order. Its slice windings are those of the path map, as the proposition demands of any such map, but the departure from the transverse symmetry happens only where some path differs from the straight one by more than $\rho_G/2$. Below that the field of a single link enters with the weight $\frac{1}{8}$ of the averages, whichever position it occupies.

What the theorem does not give is composition. The constants of (ii) are those of one step, and iterating them gives a factor that grows exponentially in the number of steps; on its large-field branch the map is the path map, for which Proposition 12.16 rules out any bound uniform in that number. Whether the $k$-fold cut-off average obeys $Q_k(V^{\sharp,k}(U)) \le C\, Q(U)$ and the corresponding coercivity bound with $C$ independent of $k$ is open for general fields; it is the form in which Remark 12.11(b) remains. Section 12.3 proves it, with $C = 1.001$, for fields with values in a maximal torus whose curvature stays small at every scale, and

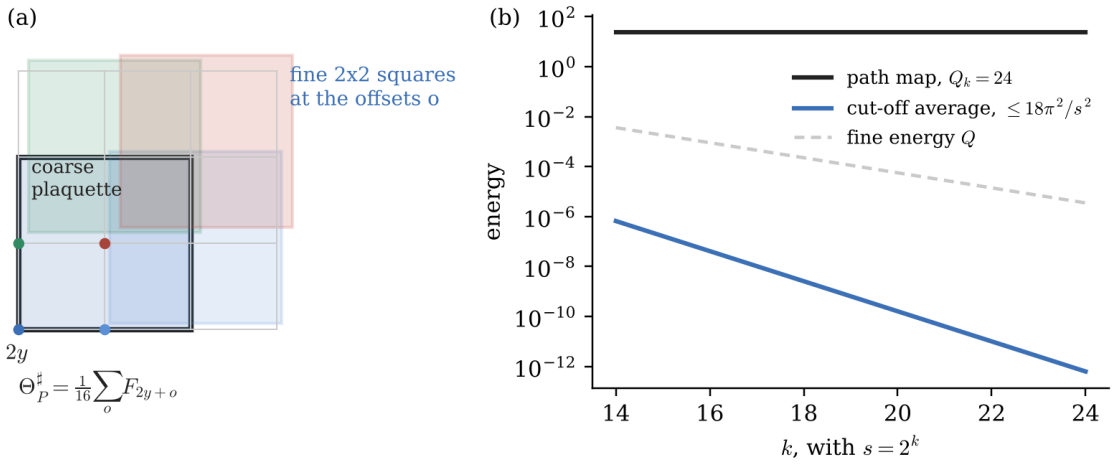



FIGURE 15. (a) In the torus, the coarse plaquette of the cut-off average is the mean of the fluxes $F_{2y+o}$ of the sixteen fine squares of side two at the offsets $o$ (four of them drawn), whatever the gauge of the coarse links (Lemma 12.20). (b) For the thin-path fields of Proposition 12.16, the coarse energy after $k$ steps: 24 for the path map, at most $18\pi^2/s^2$ for the cut-off average (Corollary 12.22); the fine energy is about $6\pi^2/s$.

with $C = e^{12060\sigma}$ for fields of any compact group whose curvatures at the successive scales are small with sum $\sigma$.

12.3. **Composition across scales.** This subsection proves that the cut-off average composes across all scales on fields with values in a maximal torus whose curvature stays small, which includes the thin paths that defeat the path map, and then that it composes for every compact group on fields whose curvature is small, with a summable loss over the scales.

Let $S$ be a maximal torus of $G \subset \mathrm{U}(r)$ and $\mathfrak{s}$ its Lie algebra. The exponential maps $\mathfrak{s}$ onto $S$, and its kernel $\Lambda$ consists of diagonalisable matrices with eigenvalues in $2\pi i\mathbb{Z}$, so every nonzero element of $\Lambda$ has norm at least $2\pi$. For an $S$-valued field with $\delta(U_p, I) \leq \rho_G$ on every plaquette put $\Theta_p = \log U_p$; it lies in $\mathfrak{g}$, commutes with $S$, and so lies in $\mathfrak{s}$. For a fine site $x$ and a coordinate plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ let $\square_x$ be the square of side two at $x$ in that plane and $F_x = \sum_{p \subset \square_x} \Theta_p$, the sum of its four plaquettes, oriented as the square. Put

$$\eta_G = \rho_G/12.$$

The $k$-fold cut-off average is defined by putting the coarse field back into the tree gauge, by an $S$-valued gauge transformation, before each step. The tree gauge fixes such a transformation up to one that is constant on blocks, under which $V^\sharp$ is covariant, so the coarse plaquette holonomies $U_P^{(j)}$ of the $j$-th iterate $U^{(j)}$ are well defined; we write $\Theta_P^{(j)} = \log U_P^{(j)}$ when $\delta(U_P^{(j)}, I) \leq \rho_G$.

**Lemma 12.20.** *Let $U$ be an $S$-valued field in the tree gauge with $\|\Theta_p\| \leq \eta_G$ for every plaquette. Then $\chi_{y,\mu}(U) = 1$ for every coarse link, and the coarse plaquette $P$ at $y$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ has*

$$V^\sharp(U)_P = \exp \bar{F}_P, \qquad \bar{F}_P = \frac{1}{16} \sum_{o \in \{0,1\}^4} F_{2y+o},$$

*with $\|\bar{F}_P\| \leq 4 \max_p \|\Theta_p\|$, so that $\log V^\sharp(U)_P = \bar{F}_P$.*

*Proof.* Let $\eta = \max_p \|\Theta_p\|$. Fix $(y, \mu)$ and $x = 2y + o$. The tree path $\tau$ from $2y$ to $x$ sets the coordinates of $o$ one at a time in increasing order, so it has at most four edges, at most three of them transverse to $\mu$. In the tree gauge its links are $I$, so $P_{2y}^{-1} P_x$ is the holonomy of the loop $\tau$, then the straight path from $x$ to $x + 2e_\mu$, then $\tau + 2e_\mu$ backwards,

then the straight path from $2y + 2e_\mu$ back to $2y$. This loop is the boundary of the surface swept by the transverse edges of $\tau$ along two steps in the direction $\mu$: at most six distinct plaquettes, each with coefficient $\pm 1$. The group is abelian, so $P_{2y}^{-1} P_x = \exp d_x$ with $d_x$ the signed sum of their $\Theta_p$, and $\|d_x\| \le 6\eta \le \rho_G/2$. By Lemma 12.18, $\delta(P_x, P_{2y}) \le \rho_G/2$, so $\chi = 1$, and since the eigenvalues of $d_x$ have modulus at most $\frac{1}{2}$, $\log(P_{2y}^{-1} P_x) = d_x$. Hence $V^{\sharp}_{y,\mu} = \exp(X_{y,\mu} + \bar{d}_{y,\mu})$, where $X_{y,\mu} \in \mathfrak{s}$ is any logarithm of $P_{2y}$ and $\bar{d}_{y,\mu}$ is the mean of the $d_x$.

Let the sides of $P$ be the coarse links $\ell$ with signs $\epsilon_\ell$, and write $d_{o,\ell}$ for the $d_x$ of the side $\ell$ at the offset $o$. For each $o$ the four straight paths of length two at the offset $o$ of the four sides bound the square $\square_{2y+o}$, so

$$Y_o = \sum_\ell \epsilon_\ell (X_\ell + d_{o,\ell}) - F_{2y+o} \in \Lambda.$$

Since $d_{0,\ell} = 0$, $\|Y_o - Y_0\| \le 4 \cdot 6\eta + 8\eta = 32\eta \le \frac{8}{3} < 2\pi$, so $Y_o = Y_0$ for every $o$. Averaging over $o$ gives $\sum_\ell \epsilon_\ell (X_\ell + \bar{d}_\ell) = \bar{F}_P + Y_0$, and $\exp Y_0 = I$. Finally $\|\bar{F}_P\| \le \max_o \|F_{2y+o}\| \le 4\eta < \pi/3$, so $\bar{F}_P$ is the principal logarithm. □

**Theorem 12.21.** *Let $U$ be an $S$-valued field in the tree gauge on the periodic lattice of side divisible by $2^k$, with $\delta(U_p, I) \le \rho_G$ on every plaquette, and put $\eta_0 = \max_p \|\Theta_p\|$, $A = \sum_p \|\Theta_p\|$. Suppose that*

$$\max_P \|\Theta_P^{(j)}\| \le \eta_G \quad \text{for } 0 \le j < k, \tag{12.2}$$

*which holds in particular if $\eta_0 A \le \eta_G^2$. Then the cut-off is inactive at every step, $\Theta^{(j+1)} = \bar{F}(\Theta^{(j)})$, and for $j < k$*

$$\sum_P \|\Theta_P^{(j+1)}\|^2 \le \sum_P \|\Theta_P^{(j)}\|^2, \qquad \sum_P \|\Theta_P^{(j+1)}\| \le \frac{1}{4} \sum_P \|\Theta_P^{(j)}\|,$$
$$\max_P \|\Theta_P^{(j+1)}\| \le 4 \max_P \|\Theta_P^{(j)}\|.$$

*Consequently*

$$Q_k(V^{\sharp,k}(U)) \le \sum_p \|\Theta_p\|^2 \le 1.001\, Q(U),$$
$$Q_k(V^{\sharp,k}(U)) \le 16^{-k} A^2.$$

*Proof.* The first assertions follow from Lemma 12.20 by induction, the $S$-valued gauge fixing between steps leaving the plaquette holonomies unchanged. The coarse plaquettes $P$ in a plane together with the offsets $o$ are in bijection with the fine squares $\square_x$ in that plane, $x = 2y + o$, and a fine plaquette lies in four such squares. With $\|\bar{F}_P\|^2 \le \frac{1}{16} \sum_o \|F_{2y+o}\|^2$ and $\|F_x\|^2 \le 4 \sum_{p \subset \square_x} \|\Theta_p\|^2$ this gives $\sum_P \|\bar{F}_P\|^2 \le \frac{1}{16} \cdot 4 \cdot 4 \sum_p \|\Theta_p\|^2$; the same count without Cauchy–Schwarz gives the factor $\frac{1}{4}$ in the second inequality, and the third is $\|F_x\| \le 4\eta$.

For the sufficient condition, let $\eta_j$ and $A_j$ be the maximum and the sum of $\|\Theta_P^{(j)}\|$. While (12.2) holds up to $j - 1$, the inequalities give $\eta_j \le 4^j \eta_0$ and $\eta_j \le A_j \le 4^{-j} A$. The product of the two bounds is $\eta_0 A \le \eta_G^2$, so the smaller one is at most $\eta_G$, and (12.2) holds at $j$.

Finally $\delta(\exp \Theta, I) \le \|\Theta\|$ (Lemma 12.18), so $Q_k(V^{\sharp,k}(U)) \le \sum_P \|\Theta_P^{(k)}\|^2$, which is at most both $\sum_p \|\Theta_p\|^2$ and $\eta_k A_k \le A_k^2 \le 16^{-k} A^2$. The eigenvalues of each $\Theta_p$ are $i\theta$ with $|\theta| \le \eta_0 \le \eta_G \le \frac{1}{12}$, since $\eta_0^2 \le \eta_0 A$ in the sufficient condition and $\eta_0 \le \eta_G$ is the case $j = 0$ of (12.2); and $\theta^2 \le 1.001 \cdot 4 \sin^2(\theta/2)$ there, which gives $\sum_p \|\Theta_p\|^2 \le 1.001\, Q(U)$. □

**Corollary 12.22.** *For $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ and the fields of Proposition 12.16 with $s = 2^k \geq 2^{14}$,*

$$Q_k(V^{\sharp,k}(U)) \leq \frac{18\pi^2}{s^2} \leq \frac{4}{s}\,Q(U),$$
$$Q_k(V^{\mathrm{p},k}(U)) = 24 \geq \frac{4s}{\pi^2}\,Q(U).$$

*Proof.* Here $\rho_G = 1$ and $S$ is the diagonal torus. The $3s$ nonzero plaquettes have $\Theta_p = \pm 2T/s$, of norm $\sqrt{2}\pi/s$, so $\eta_0 A = 6\pi^2/s \leq \frac{1}{144}$ when $s \geq 864\pi^2$, which holds for $s \geq 2^{14}$, and $A^2 = 18\pi^2$. Proposition 12.16 gives $Q(U) = 24s\sin^2(\pi/2s)$, which lies between $(6\pi^2/s)(1 - \pi^2/(12s^2))$ and $6\pi^2/s$. □

So on torus-valued fields of small curvature the cut-off average behaves like the linear averages: the curvature is averaged over the sixteen offsets at every step, the energy never increases, and a thin path is spread out and contracted instead of being carried to the coarse lattice (Figure 15).

For general fields the paths do not commute, and the logarithms carry commutators from the second order on. The next two lemmas bound these commutators by the square of the local curvature. The same composition then holds for every compact group, with a loss of at most $1 + O(\eta_j)$ at scale $j$.

**Lemma 12.23.** *Let $Z_1, \dots, Z_n \in \mathfrak{g}$ with $r = \sum_i \|Z_i\| \leq \min\{\frac{1}{4}, \rho_G\}$, and let $g = e^{Z_1} \cdots e^{Z_n}$. Then $\delta(g, I) \leq r$, $\log g \in \mathfrak{g}$, and*

$$\Big\| \log g - \sum_i Z_i \Big\| \leq 1.6\, r^2.$$

*Proof.* The distance $\delta$ is invariant under multiplication by unitary matrices on either side, so $\delta(g, I) \leq \sum_i \delta(e^{Z_i}, I) \leq r$ by Lemma 12.18, and $\log g \in \mathfrak{g}$ by the choice of $\rho_G$. Expanding the exponentials, $g - I - \sum_i Z_i$ is a sum of products of at least two factors. Since the Hilbert–Schmidt norm is submultiplicative, its norm is at most $e^r - 1 - r \leq \frac{1}{2} r^2 e^r \leq 0.643\, r^2$, and $M = g - I$ has $\|M\| \leq e^r - 1 \leq 1.137\, r \leq 0.285$. The operator norm of $M$ is smaller than 1. The principal logarithm is holomorphic on the disc $|z - 1| < 1$, which contains the spectrum of $g$, so it is given there by its power series, $\log g = \sum_{k \geq 1} (-1)^{k+1} M^k / k$. Hence

$$\|\log g - M\| \leq \frac{\|M\|^2}{2(1 - \|M\|)} \leq 0.905\, r^2,$$

and the two bounds add up to less than $1.6\, r^2$. □

Let $U$ be a $G$-valued field in the tree gauge with $\delta(U_p, I) \leq \rho_G$, and put $\Theta_p = \log U_p$. A change of base point conjugates $\Theta_p$ and does not change its norm. Let $P$ be a coarse plaquette at $y$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$. Its sides are $\ell_1 = (y, \mu)$, $\ell_2 = (y + e_\mu, \nu)$, $\ell_3 = (y + e_\nu, \mu)$ and $\ell_4 = (y, \nu)$, with initial points $y_i$. For an offset $o \in \{0, 1\}^4$ let $P_{i,o}$ be the path product of $\ell_i$ through $2y_i + o$, and put

$$K_{P,o} = P_{1,o} P_{2,o} P_{3,o}^{-1} P_{4,o}^{-1}, \qquad \bar{F}_P = \frac{1}{16} \sum_o \log K_{P,o}.$$

The tree segments between consecutive sides cancel. Hence $K_{P,o}$ is the holonomy of the square $\square_{2y+o}$, carried to $2y$ along the tree. In a torus, $\log K_{P,o} = F_{2y+o}$, and $\bar{F}_P$ is the mean of Lemma 12.20. Let $\sigma_{P,o}$ be the sum of $\|\Theta_p\|$ over the four plaquettes of $\square_{2y+o}$.

**Lemma 12.24.** *Let $U$ be a $G$-valued field in the tree gauge with $\delta(U_p, I) \leq \rho_G$ and $\|\Theta_p\| \leq \eta \leq \rho_G/1000$ for every plaquette. Then $\chi_{y,\mu}(U) = 1$ for every coarse link. Every coarse plaquette has $\delta(V^\sharp(U)_P, I) \leq 0.03\, \rho_G$ and*

$$\|\log V^\sharp(U)_P - \bar{F}_P\| \leq 3.2\, r_P^2,$$
$$\|\bar{F}_P\| \leq \frac{1 + 6.4\eta}{16} \sum_o \sigma_{P,o}, \tag{12.3}$$

*with $r_P \le 28.26\,\eta$ defined in the proof. Let $E$, $A$ be the sum of $\|\Theta_p\|^2$ and of $\|\Theta_p\|$, and let $E'$, $A'$, $\eta'$ be the sum of squares, the sum and the maximum of $\|\log V^\sharp(U)_P\|$. Then*

$$\sqrt{E'} \le (1+6030\eta)\sqrt{E}, \qquad A' \le (1+9147\eta)\frac{A}{4},$$
$$\eta' \le 4(1+647\eta)\,\eta.$$

*Proof. Paths.* Fix a coarse link $(y,\mu)$ and $x = 2y + o$. As in the proof of Lemma 12.20, $P_{2y}^{-1}P_x$ is the holonomy of a loop bounding a surface of at most six plaquettes, swept by the transverse edges of the tree path. Build the surface one plaquette at a time. This writes the holonomy as a product of at most six factors $hU_p^{\pm1}h^{-1} = \exp(\pm h\Theta_p h^{-1})$. Let $\sigma_{(y,\mu),o} \le 6\eta$ be the sum of their $\|\Theta_p\|$. By Lemma 12.23, $\delta(P_x, P_{2y}) \le 6\eta \le \rho_G/2$, so $\chi = 1$. The logarithm $D_{(y,\mu),o} = \log(P_{2y}^{-1}P_x)$ lies in $\mathfrak{g}$, with

$$\|D_{(y,\mu),o}\| \le (1+9.6\eta)\,\sigma_{(y,\mu),o}.$$

In the same way $K_{P,o}$ is a product of four such factors, so $\|\log K_{P,o}\| \le (1+6.4\eta)\sigma_{P,o}$. Averaging over $o$ gives the second inequality of (12.3).

*The plaquette.* Write $D_{i,o}$ for $D_{\ell_i,o}$. Then $P_{i,o} = P_{i,0}e^{D_{i,o}}$ and $D_{i,0} = 0$, and $V_{\ell_i}^\sharp = P_{i,0}e^{m_i}$ with $m_i = \frac{1}{16}\sum_o D_{i,o}$. The paths and $V^\sharp$ transform as links under gauge transformations constant on blocks. These transformations preserve the tree gauge and conjugate $D_{i,o}$, $m_i$, $K_{P,o}$ and $V_P^\sharp$ by fixed elements. Choose one with $P_{1,0} = P_{2,0} = P_{3,0} = I$. Then $P_{4,0} = K_{P,0}^{-1}$, and with $c = \log K_{P,0}$,

$$V_P^\sharp = e^{m_1}e^{m_2}e^{-m_3}e^{-m_4}e^{c},$$
$$K_{P,o} = e^{D_{1,o}}e^{D_{2,o}}e^{-D_{3,o}}e^{-D_{4,o}}e^{c}.$$

Put $r_P = \sum_i \max_o\|D_{i,o}\| + \|c\|$. Since $\|m_i\| \le \max_o\|D_{i,o}\|$, the five exponents in each product have norms adding up to at most $r_P$, and

$$r_P \le 24(1+9.6\eta)\eta + 4(1+6.4\eta)\eta \le 28.26\,\eta.$$

Lemma 12.23 gives $\delta(V_P^\sharp, I) \le r_P \le 0.03\,\rho_G$ and

$$\log V_P^\sharp = m_1 + m_2 - m_3 - m_4 + c + R,$$
$$\log K_{P,o} = D_{1,o} + D_{2,o} - D_{3,o} - D_{4,o} + c + R_o,$$

with $\|R\|, \|R_o\| \le 1.6\,r_P^2$. Average the second line over $o$ and subtract it from the first; since $m_i$ is the mean of the $D_{i,o}$, this is the first inequality of (12.3).

*Sums.* Each fine plaquette lies in four squares $\square_x$, and the pairs $(P,o)$ are in bijection with these squares. The second inequality of (12.3) and Cauchy–Schwarz therefore give $\sum_P\|\bar F_P\|^2 \le (1+6.4\eta)^2E$; without Cauchy–Schwarz they give $\sum_P\|\bar F_P\| \le (1+6.4\eta)A/4$. For the remainders, let $\mathcal{U}_\ell$ be the set of plaquettes of the surfaces of the side $\ell = (y,\mu)$ for all sixteen offsets. These lie in planes $\{\mu,\alpha\}$, $\alpha \ne \mu$, at $\mu$-positions $2y_\mu$, $2y_\mu+1$, $2y_\mu+2$, and there are at most 36 of them. A plaquette lies in $\mathcal{U}_\ell$ for at most four coarse links. With $m'_\ell = \sum_{p\in\mathcal{U}_\ell}\|\Theta_p\|$,

$$r_P \le 1.0096\Big(\sum_{\ell\subset P} m'_\ell + \sigma_{P,0}\Big).$$

A coarse link is a side of six coarse plaquettes, and a plaquette lies in $\square_{2y}$ for at most one coarse plaquette. Therefore

$$\sum_P r_P \le 1.0096\,(6\cdot 4A + A) \le 25.24\,A,$$
$$\sum_P r_P^2 \le 1.0096^2\cdot 5\,(6\cdot 36\cdot 4\,E + 4E) \le 4424\,E.$$

Hence, with $r_P \le 28.26\,\eta$,

$$\sum_P 3.2\,r_P^2 \le 3.2\cdot 28.26\cdot 25.24\,\eta A \le 2283\,\eta A,$$

$$\Big(\sum_P \big(3.2\,r_P^2\big)^2\Big)^{1/2} \le 3.2\cdot 28.26\,\eta\,(4424\,E)^{1/2} \le 6015\,\eta\sqrt{E}.$$

The triangle inequality, for the Euclidean norm over $P$ in the first case, gives $\sqrt{E'} \le (1+6.4\eta+6015\eta)\sqrt{E}$ and $A' \le (1+6.4\eta)A/4 + 2283\,\eta A$. For the maximum, $\eta' \le (1+6.4\eta)4\eta + 3.2\,(28.26\,\eta)^2 \le 4(1+647\eta)\eta$. □

For a $G$-valued field, the $k$-fold cut-off average is defined as before, with $G$-valued gauge transformations. The tree gauge fixes them up to transformations constant on blocks, under which $V^\sharp$ is covariant. These transformations conjugate the plaquette holonomies and leave the norms $\|\Theta_P^{(j)}\|$ unchanged.

**Theorem 12.25.** *Let $G \subset \mathrm{U}(r)$ be compact and let $U$ be a $G$-valued field on the periodic lattice of side divisible by $2^k$, with $\delta(U_p, I) \le \rho_G$ on every plaquette. Let $\eta_j$, $A_j$, $E_j$ be the maximum, the sum and the sum of squares of $\|\Theta_P^{(j)}\|$ over the plaquettes of the $j$-th iterate.*

(i) *If $\eta_j \le \rho_G/1000$ for $0 \le j < k$, the cut-off is inactive at every step. With $\sigma = \sum_{j<k}\eta_j$,*

$$E_k \le e^{12060\sigma} E_0, \qquad A_k \le e^{9147\sigma} 4^{-k} A_0,$$
$$\eta_k \le e^{647\sigma} 4^k \eta_0.$$

(ii) *If $\eta_0 A_0 \le 2\cdot 10^{-10}\rho_G^2$, then (i) applies for every $k$ with $\sigma \le 7.25\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0}$, and*

$$Q_k(V^{\sharp,k}(U)) \le e^{8.8\cdot 10^4\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0}} E_0 \le 1.0001\, e^{8.8\cdot 10^4\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0}}\, Q(U),$$
$$Q_k(V^{\sharp,k}(U)) \le e^2\, 16^{-k} A_0^2.$$

*Proof.* (i) Apply Lemma 12.24 at each step to the field in the tree gauge; the gauge fixing does not change the norms. The lemma gives $\delta(U_P^{(j+1)}, I) \le \rho_G$, so $\Theta^{(j+1)}$ is defined, and with $1+t \le e^t$ the three inequalities of the lemma multiply over the steps.

(ii) Suppose that for $i < j$ we have $\eta_i \le \rho_G/1000$ and $\sum_{i<j}\eta_i \le 7.25\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0} \le 1/9747$. Then (i) gives $A_j \le e\,4^{-j}A_0$ and $\eta_j \le e\,4^j\eta_0$, and $\eta_j \le A_j$. So $\eta_j \le e\min\{4^j\eta_0, 4^{-j}A_0\} \le e\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0} \le \rho_G/1000$. Let $i_*$ be the last index with $4^{i_*}\eta_0 \le 4^{-i_*}A_0$. The terms of $\min\{4^i\eta_0, 4^{-i}A_0\}$ increase by the factor 4 up to $i_*$ and decrease by the factor 4 after it. The terms at $i_*$ and $i_*+1$ are at most $\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0}$, so the sum over all $i$ is at most $\frac{8}{3}\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0}$, and $\sum_{i\le j}\eta_i \le \frac{8e}{3}\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0} \le 7.25\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0}$. This completes the induction. Then $E_k \le e^{12060\cdot 7.25\sqrt{\eta_0 A_0}} E_0$. By Lemma 12.18, $Q_k(V^{\sharp,k}(U)) \le E_k$, and $E_k \le \eta_k A_k \le A_k^2 \le e^2\,16^{-k}A_0^2$. Finally the eigenvalues $i\theta$ of each $\Theta_p$ have $|\theta| \le \eta_0 \le \sqrt{\eta_0 A_0} < 10^{-4}$, and $\theta^2 \le 1.0001\cdot 4\sin^2(\theta/2)$ there. □

For a torus Theorem 12.21 is sharper, and its hypothesis is weaker; the content of Theorem 12.25 is the non-abelian case. Neither theorem gives the supremum over boundary conditions in (D). Theorem 12.19 has the constants of one step. Theorems 12.21 and 12.25 need the curvature to be small at every scale: in Theorem 12.25 the losses $e^{6030\eta_j}$ must have a bounded product, and a field whose curvature is smooth on a scale $\ell$ grows by a factor four per step until the coarse spacing reaches $\ell$. The large fields, where the cut-off is active, and the Wilson measure itself are outside both; Section 12.4 shows where the large fields lie under that measure.

12.4. **Large fields under the Wilson measure.** Theorem 12.25 needs every plaquette to be small. This subsection shows that, under the SU(2) Wilson measure, the plaquettes that are not small form clusters of microscopic size, and that the cut-off average departs

from the average only next to them. It also shows that such plaquettes are present along the one-loop tuning, so the composition has to pass through them.

Let $\Lambda_L = (\mathbb{Z}/L\mathbb{Z})^4$ with $L = 2^m \geq 4$, and let $\mu_L$ be the SU(2) Wilson measure on $\Lambda_L$, with density proportional to $e^{-\beta_W S(U)}$ with respect to product Haar measure, where

$$S(U) = \sum_p s_p, \qquad s_p = 1 - \tfrac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} U_p = \tfrac{1}{4}\,\delta(U_p, I)^2.$$

This is the Wilson measure of Section 3 on the torus, without gauge fixing; it has $4L^4$ links and $6L^4$ plaquettes. For $0 < \rho \leq 1$ call a plaquette *bad* if $\delta(U_p, I) > \rho$. The closed unit cube $\mathcal{C}_x = x + [0,1]^4$ contains 24 plaquettes. Let $B_x$ be the event that one of them is bad. A plaquette lies in exactly four unit cubes, one for each choice of the two transverse coordinates of the cube's corner.

**Lemma 12.26.** *Let $Z_L$ be the normalising constant of $\mu_L$ and $C_0 = \frac{1}{2} + \frac{2}{3}\log(24\pi^3)$. For $\beta_W \geq 1$,*

$$-\log Z_L \leq 6L^4(\log \beta_W + C_0), \qquad \mathbb{E}_{\mu_L} S \leq 6L^4\,\frac{\log \beta_W + C_0}{\beta_W}.$$

*Proof.* Write $U = \cos\theta\, I + \sin\theta\, J$ with $0 \leq \theta \leq \pi$ and $J^2 = -I$. The angle $\theta$ of $g^{-1}h$ is a bi-invariant distance, and under Haar measure $\theta$ has density $\frac{2}{\pi}\sin^2\theta$. Put $r = (4\sqrt{\beta_W})^{-1}$. If every link has angle at most $r$, every plaquette has angle at most $4r \leq 1$ and $s_p \leq (4r)^2/2 = 1/(2\beta_W)$, so $S \leq 3L^4$. Each link angle is at most $r$ with probability

$$\frac{2}{\pi}\int_0^r \sin^2 t\, dt \geq \frac{8r^3}{3\pi^3} = \frac{1}{24\pi^3\beta_W^{3/2}},$$

by $\sin t \geq 2t/\pi$. Hence $Z_L \geq e^{-3L^4}(24\pi^3\beta_W^{3/2})^{-4L^4}$, which is the first bound. The function $F(b) = -\log Z_L$ at the coupling $b$ is concave with $F(0) = 0$ and $F'(b) = \mathbb{E}S$, so $bF'(b) \leq F(b)$, which is the second. □

**Theorem 12.27.** *For $\beta_W \geq 1$, $0 < \rho \leq 1$ and every set $A$ of unit cubes,*

$$\mu_L\Big(\bigcap_{x\in A} B_x\Big) \leq q^{|A|},$$

$$q = q_\rho(\beta_W) = \min\{1, \exp\big(6(\log\beta_W + C_0) - \beta_W\rho^2/16\big)\}.$$

*Proof.* The measure $\mu_L$ is reflection positive in every hyperplane through sites [64]: the plaquettes are either in the hyperplane or on one side of it, so conditionally on the links in the hyperplane the weight factors into two mirror images, and reflection preserves Haar measure and $\operatorname{Tr} U_p$. On a torus of side $2^m$ this gives the chessboard estimate for functions of the links of closed unit cubes [35], [20, Section 5.3]:

$$\mu_L\Big(\bigcap_{x\in A} B_x\Big) \leq \mu_L\Big(\bigcap_{x\in\Lambda_L} B_x\Big)^{|A|/L^4},$$

since the reflection of $B_x$ into another cube is the event $B_y$ of that cube. If every cube is bad, there are at least $L^4/4$ bad plaquettes, so $S \geq \rho^2 L^4/16$ and the event has unnormalised weight at most $e^{-\beta_W\rho^2 L^4/16}$. Dividing by $Z_L$ and using Lemma 12.26 gives the bound. □

**Corollary 12.28.** *Join two unit cubes when their corners are at $\ell^\infty$ distance one on the torus. For an integer $r \geq 1$,*

$$\mu_L\{\text{some connected set of } r \text{ bad cubes}\} \leq L^4(6400\,q)^r.$$

*Hence, on a torus of fixed physical side $La$, if $a \to 0$ along $L = 2^m$ and $\beta_W(a) \to \infty$, the physical diameters of all connected clusters of bad cubes tend to 0 in probability, for every fixed $\rho$.*

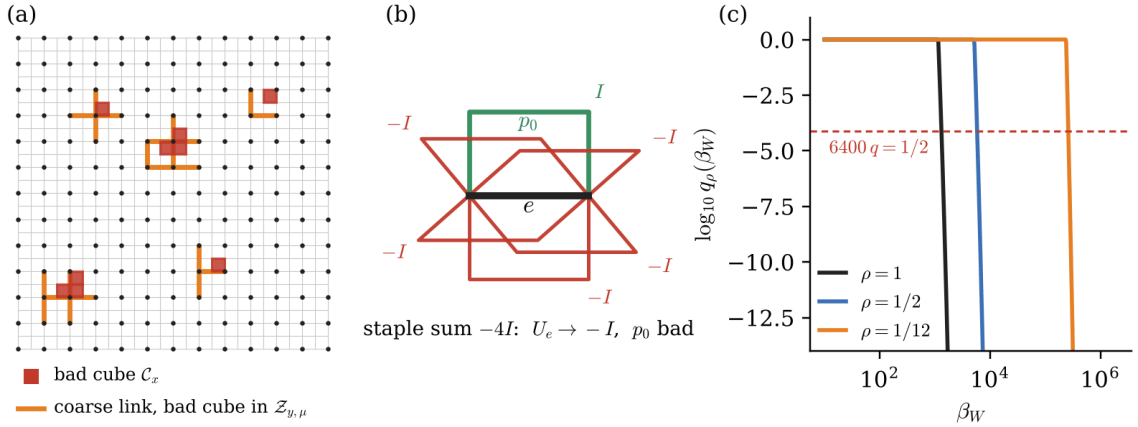



FIGURE 16. Large fields under the SU(2) Wilson measure. (a) A plane section of the lattice: bad unit cubes (red) form clusters, and the cut-off average can differ from the path average only on coarse links (orange) whose 24 cubes $\mathcal{Z}_{y,\mu}$ meet a bad cube (Corollary 12.29). (b) The frustrated exterior of a link $e$: the staple of $p_0$ is $I$ and the other five staples are $-I$, so $U_e$ is driven to $-I$ and $p_0$ is bad. (c) The weight $q_\rho(\beta_W)$ of Theorem 12.27 for three values of $\rho$; below the dashed line the cluster bound of Corollary 12.28 is summable.

*Proof.* A connected set of $r$ cubes containing a given cube is recovered from a walk of length $2(r-1)$ around a spanning tree, and each cube has 80 neighbours, so there are at most $80^{2(r-1)} \le 6400^r$ such sets. Apply Theorem 12.27 and sum over the $L^4$ roots. A cluster of physical diameter at least $R$ contains a connected set of $\lceil R/a \rceil$ cubes, and once $6400\,q \le \frac{1}{2}$ the bound is at most $(La/a)^4 2^{-R/a} \to 0$. □

The bad cubes control where the cut-off average differs from the average. For a coarse link $(y,\mu)$ let $\mathcal{Z}_{y,\mu}$ be the 24 unit cubes with corners $2y + te_\mu + w$, $t \in \{0,1,2\}$, $w \in \{0,1\}^4$, $w_\mu = 0$ (Figure 16).

**Corollary 12.29.** *Let $\rho = \frac{1}{12}$. If no cube of $\mathcal{Z}_{y,\mu}$ is bad, then $\chi_{y,\mu}(U) = 1$ in the tree gauge, and $V^\sharp_{y,\mu}$ is the average of the sixteen paths in the chart at $P_{2y}$. A bad cube lies in $\mathcal{Z}_{y,\mu}$ for at most eight coarse links, so the expected fraction of coarse links with $\chi < 1$ is at most $4.5 \cdot 10^5\,(\log \beta_W + C_0)/\beta_W$. Along the limits of Corollary 12.28, with probability tending to one these links lie within physical distance $2a$ of clusters of bad cubes of physical diameter less than any fixed $R > 0$.*

*Proof.* As in the proof of Lemma 12.24, $P_{2y}^{-1} P_x$ is a product of at most six conjugates of plaquette holonomies or their inverses. These plaquettes lie in planes $\{\mu,\alpha\}$ with corners $2y + te_\mu + w$ as above, and a plaquette lies in the unit cube at its corner. So $\delta(P_x, P_{2y}) \le 6\rho = \frac{1}{2}$, and $\chi = 1$. A cube with corner $z$ lies in $\mathcal{Z}_{y,\mu}$ only if $z_\mu - 2y_\mu \in \{0,1,2\}$ and $z_\alpha - 2y_\alpha \in \{0,1\}$ for $\alpha \ne \mu$, which leaves at most two coarse links in each direction. There are $L^4/4$ coarse links, the number of bad cubes is at most four times the number of bad plaquettes, and a bad plaquette has $s_p > \rho^2/4$, so by Lemma 12.26 the expected fraction is at most $4 \cdot 8 \cdot 4 \cdot 24 \cdot 144\,(\log \beta_W + C_0)/\beta_W$. The last assertion is Corollary 12.28. □

Small plaquettes everywhere, which Theorem 12.25 assumes, are nevertheless improbable along the one-loop tuning. For SU(2), $\beta_W = 4g^{-2}$, and the one-loop coupling of Remark 12.11(c) at spacing $a = 1/L$ gives $\beta_W = 8b_0 \log L + O(1) = \frac{11}{3\pi^2} \log L + O(1)$.

**Proposition 12.30.** *Let $0 < \rho \le 1$, $v_* = \frac{2}{\pi} \int_{\arccos(3/4)}^{\pi/3} \sin^2 t\,dt$ and $p = v_* e^{-3\beta_W}$. Conditionally on all other links, a plaquette through a link $e$ is bad with probability at least $p$.*

*Hence*

$$\mu_L\{\text{no plaquette is bad}\} \le e^{-\lfloor L/3\rfloor^4 p},$$

*which tends to* 0 *when* $\beta_W \le B\log L + O(1)$ *with* $B < 4/3$*, in particular along the one-loop tuning.*

*Proof.* Identify SU(2) with the unit quaternions. Conditionally on the other links, $U_e$ has density proportional to $e^{\kappa\, h\cdot u}$ with $0 \le \kappa \le 6\beta_W$ and $|h| = 1$, the six staples contributing at most $\beta_W$ each. The plaquette holonomy is $U_e$ or its inverse multiplied by a fixed element, so it has a density of the same form. Writing the density as a superposition of indicators of caps centred at $h$, the probability of a cap about $I$ is largest when $h = I$, and for $h = I$ it increases with $\kappa$, because its derivative is the covariance of an increasing function of $\operatorname{Tr} U$ with $\frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Tr} U$. So the probability of being bad is at least that of the angle exceeding $\arccos(1-\rho^2/4) \le \arccos(3/4)$ under the density proportional to $e^{6\beta_W\cos t}\sin^2 t$, which is at least $p$: bound the numerator from below on $[\arccos(3/4), \pi/3]$, where $\cos t \ge \frac{1}{2}$, and the denominator by $e^{6\beta_W}\pi/2$.

Let $M = \lfloor L/3\rfloor$. Choose the links in direction 0 at the sites $3z$, $z \in \{0,\dots,M-1\}^4$, and their plaquettes in the plane $\{0,1\}$. No chosen plaquette contains another chosen link. Removing one chosen link at a time therefore bounds the probability that all chosen plaquettes are good by $(1-p)^{M^4}$. With $\beta_W = B\log L + O(1)$ the exponent is of order $L^{4-3B}$. □

The joint bound of Theorem 12.27 is not a conditional one, and (D) needs a supremum over boundary conditions. The two differ genuinely. Fix a link $e$ and a plaquette $p_0$ through it. Put all links on the six staples of $e$ at $I$, except the middle links of the five staples other than that of $p_0$, which are $-I$. Then the conditional density of $U_e$ is proportional to $e^{-2\beta_W \operatorname{Tr} U_e}$, and $p_0$, whose holonomy is $U_e^{\pm 1}$, is bad with conditional probability tending to 1 as $\beta_W \to \infty$, for every $\rho < 2\sqrt{2}$. Nearby exteriors behave the same way. So the clusters of Corollary 12.28 are small in probability, but the boundary response of a cube to a frustrated exterior is not small, and the composition near the bad clusters and the conditional estimate in (D) remain open.

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This paper rests on the work of many earlier scientists. Lattice gauge theory is due to Wilson [77] and its Hamiltonian form to Kogut and Susskind [51]; reflection positivity and the reconstruction of the transfer matrix to Osterwalder and Schrader [62, 63], and their lattice form, with the first proof of a gap at strong coupling, to Osterwalder and Seiler [64, 68]. The uniqueness method is Dobrushin's [29, 30, 31], the curvature method is that of Bakry and Émery [3, 4] in the form of Shen, Zhu and Zhu [69], the gauge fixing on a forest is Creutz's [26], and the curvature of Lie groups is Milnor's [60]; the localisation estimate of Section 12.1 is that of Combes and Thomas [27]. The analysis of the single-link law uses results of Barta [9], Biernacki and Krzyż [19], McShane [59], Stein and Weiss [72] and Watson [76], and the continuum problem is the one formulated by Jaffe and Witten [47] and studied by Bałaban [5, 6, 7]. The Yang–Mills manuscripts of Sussman and collaborators [73, 74] were read in the preparation of Section 9.

## Declarations

**Data and code availability.** The proofs are analytic except for the evaluations in Propositions 7.8 and 7.9 and Lemma 8.3 and the numerical bounds of Lemma 5.5, which are computations in interval arithmetic with rigorous error bounds. The programs of these steps, in Python with python-flint (FLINT and Arb) and a C kernel for products of Taylor polynomials, their outputs and the list of certified boxes are in the repository `https://github.com/creelie/4Y-M`, release v4.8.0, together with a Lean 4 certificate of the line field and independent exact or numerical checks of the other finite statements.

The computations, the checks and parts of the drafting were done with AI assistance (Claude Opus 5.5, Claude Fable 5.1, GPT-6.1 Sol Ultra and GPT-6 Astra Ultra) under the direction of Deep Bhattacharjee. The combination of the forest gauge with the sharp quarter behind Theorem 1.1 was first assembled by Anaxia, the reasoning engine of the BLLM system [12, 13]; the line field, the free-boundary limit, the ceiling, the curvature bound, the SU(3) part, the plaquette blocks and the certified constants are the authors' own. All three authors approved the final text.

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## Appendix A. The line field

Table 3 lists, for each residue class of $x$ modulo two, the direction $\sigma(x)$ and the permutation $\pi_x(\mu) = \sigma(x + e_\mu)$. In every row $\pi_x$ fixes $\sigma(x)$ and is a three-cycle on the other directions, which is the condition of Lemma 2.1.

Table 3. The line field: $x$ modulo two (digits $x_0x_1x_2x_3$), the direction $\sigma(x)$ and the values $\sigma(x + e_\mu)$ for $\mu = 0, 1, 2, 3$.

| $x$ | $\sigma(x)$ | $\mu = 0$ | $\mu = 1$ | $\mu = 2$ | $\mu = 3$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0000 | 0 | 0 | 2 | 3 | 1 |
| 1000 | 0 | 0 | 3 | 1 | 2 |
| 0100 | 2 | 3 | 0 | 2 | 1 |
| 1100 | 3 | 2 | 0 | 1 | 3 |
| 0010 | 3 | 1 | 2 | 0 | 3 |
| 1010 | 1 | 3 | 1 | 0 | 2 |
| 0110 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 2 | 0 |
| 1110 | 1 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 0 |
| 0001 | 1 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 0 |
| 1001 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 2 | 0 |
| 0101 | 1 | 3 | 1 | 0 | 2 |
| 1101 | 3 | 1 | 2 | 0 | 3 |
| 0011 | 3 | 2 | 0 | 1 | 3 |
| 1011 | 2 | 3 | 0 | 2 | 1 |
| 0111 | 0 | 0 | 3 | 1 | 2 |
| 1111 | 0 | 0 | 2 | 3 | 1 |

## Appendix B. The comparison lemma

Let $(G, \delta)$ be a compact group with a bi-invariant metric of diameter $D$, $\Omega = G^A$, and $C_{ee'}$ the coefficients of Section 3, with row and column sums at most $\alpha < 1$ and $C_{ee'} = 0$ unless $e, e'$ share a plaquette, so that $|e - e'| \le 1$ for the distance of link midpoints. Fix $\lambda > 0$ with $\theta = \alpha e^{\lambda} < 1$.

**Lemma B.1.** *Let $S \subset A$, possibly infinite, and let $\mu_1, \mu_2$ be probability measures on $\Omega$ invariant under $\gamma_e^F$ for every $e \notin S$. Let $T \subset A \setminus S$ be finite, $w_b = e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(b,T)}$, and suppose $\sum_{z\in S} w_z < \infty$. There is a coupling of $\mu_1, \mu_2$ whose link distances $\varrho(b) = \mathbb{E}\,\delta(\sigma_b, \sigma'_b)$ satisfy*

$$\sum_{b\notin S} w_b \varrho(b) \le \frac{\theta D}{1-\theta} \sum_{z\in S} w_z.$$

*If $S = \emptyset$ then $\mu_1 = \mu_2$.*

*Proof.* The couplings form a weakly compact set and $\Psi(\pi) = \sum_b w_b \mathbb{E}_\pi \delta(\sigma_b, \sigma'_b)$ is weakly continuous because $\sum_b w_b < \infty$; let $\pi^*$ be a minimiser. For $e \notin S$ replace the pair $(\sigma_e, \sigma'_e)$ by a sample of an optimal coupling of $\gamma_e^F(\cdot \mid \sigma)$ and $\gamma_e^F(\cdot \mid \sigma')$, chosen measurably [75, Cor. 5.22]. Both $\mu_i$ are invariant, so the result is again a coupling, and changing the finitely many links that enter $\gamma_e^F$ one at a time gives $W_1 \le \sum_{e'} C_{ee'} \delta(\sigma_{e'}, \sigma'_{e'})$. Minimality gives $\varrho(e) \le \sum_{e'} C_{ee'} \varrho(e')$. Multiply by $w_e$ and sum over $e \notin S$; where $C_{ee'} \neq 0$, $w_e \le e^{\lambda} w_{e'}$, so

$$\sum_{e \notin S} w_e \varrho(e) \le \theta \Big[ \sum_{e' \notin S} w_{e'} \varrho(e') + \sum_{z \in S} w_z \varrho(z) \Big],$$

all sums are finite, and $\varrho \le D$ on $S$. If $S = \emptyset$, $\varrho \equiv 0$. □

**Corollary B.2.** *Let $\mu$ be the Gibbs measure of $\gamma^F$, $F$ a local function with support $S_F$, $L_F$-Lipschitz in each link, and $H$ bounded with finite support $S_H$ disjoint from $S_F$. Then*

$$|\operatorname{Cov}_\mu(F, H)| \le \|H\|_\infty L_F \frac{\theta D}{1-\theta} |S_H| \, e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(S_F, S_H)}.$$

*Proof.* Condition on the links of $S_H$ [50, Ch. 3]; the conditional measures $\mu^\sigma = \mu(\cdot \mid \sigma_{S_H})$ are invariant under $\gamma_e^F$ for $e \notin S_H$. Lemma B.1 with $S = S_H$ and $T = S_F$, for which $w_b = 1$ on $S_F$ and $w_z \le e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(S_F, S_H)}$ on $S_H$, gives $|\mu^\sigma(F) - \mu^{\sigma'}(F)| \le L_F \sum_{b \in S_F} \varrho(b) \le L_F \frac{\theta D}{1-\theta} |S_H| e^{-\lambda \operatorname{dist}(S_F, S_H)}$ for any two boundary values. Since $H$ depends only on $\sigma_{S_H}$, $\operatorname{Cov}_\mu(F, H) = \iint H(\sigma)(\mu^\sigma(F) - \mu^{\sigma'}(F)) \, d\mu(\sigma) \, d\mu(\sigma')$, and the bound follows. □

**Lemma B.3.** *Let the blocks partition $A$, let $C_{Bj}$ be the block coefficients of Section 5, with $\sum_B C_{Bj} \le \alpha < 1$ for every $j$ and $C_{Bj} = 0$ unless every link of $B$ lies within distance 2 of $j$, and fix $\lambda > 0$ with $\theta = \alpha e^{2\lambda} < 1$. Let $S \subset A$ be a union of blocks and let $\mu_1, \mu_2$ be invariant under $\gamma_B^{\mathcal{B}}$ for every block $B \not\subset S$. With $T$, $w_b$ as in Lemma B.1 and $\sum_{z \in S} w_z < \infty$, there is a coupling with $\sum_{b \notin S} w_b \varrho(b) \le \frac{\theta D}{1-\theta} \sum_{z \in S} w_z$, and $\mu_1 = \mu_2$ if $S = \emptyset$.*

*Proof.* Take a minimiser $\pi^*$ of $\Psi$ as before. For a block $B \not\subset S$ replace $(\sigma_B, \sigma'_B)$ by an optimal coupling, for the metric $d$, of the two block laws; it is again a coupling, and changing the boundary links one at a time bounds the expected new $d$-distance by $\sum_j C_{Bj} \varrho(j)$. Put $\bar{w}_B = \max_{i \in B} w_i$. Minimality gives

$$\sum_{i \in B} w_i \varrho(i) \le \bar{w}_B \sum_j C_{Bj} \varrho(j),$$

and $\bar{w}_B \le e^{2\lambda} w_j$ whenever $C_{Bj} \neq 0$. Summing over the blocks outside $S$ and using the column sums,

$$\sum_{b \notin S} w_b \varrho(b) \le \theta \Big[ \sum_{j \notin S} w_j \varrho(j) + \sum_{z \in S} w_z \varrho(z) \Big],$$

which gives the claim as in Lemma B.1. □

**Lemma B.4.** *Let $n \ge 2$ be even, let $V_x$, $x \in 2\mathbb{Z}^4$, be the translates of Section 10, and suppose that $D(n, \alpha)$ holds.*

(a) *If a probability measure $\mu$ on $G^A$ is invariant under $\gamma_e^F$ for every $e$ in a finite set $V$, it is invariant under $\gamma_V$.*

(b) *Fix $\lambda > 0$ with $\theta = \alpha e^{\lambda \rho_n} < 1$. Let $S \subset A$, and let $\mu_1, \mu_2$ be invariant under $\gamma_{V_x}$ for every $x$ with $V_x \cap S = \emptyset$. With $T$, $w_b$ as in Lemma B.1 and $\sum_{z \in S} w_z < \infty$, there is a coupling with*

$$\sum_{b \notin S} w_b \varrho(b) \le \frac{D(1 + c_n e^{\lambda \rho_n})}{1 - \theta} \sum_{z \in S} w_z,$$

*and $\mu_1 = \mu_2$ if $S = \emptyset$.*

*Proof.* (a) Let $\nu_\eta$ be the conditional law of $Q_V$ given the links $\eta$ outside $V$. For bounded $f$ on $G^V$ and bounded $g$ of $\eta$, $\gamma_e^F(fg) = g\,\gamma_e^F f$ for $e \in V$, so invariance gives $\int g(\eta)(\nu_\eta(\gamma_e^F f) - \nu_\eta(f))\,d\mu = 0$ for all $g$; taking $f$ in a countable dense set of continuous functions, $\nu_\eta$ is invariant under every $\gamma_e^F(\cdot \mid \cdot, \eta)$, $e \in V$, for $\mu$-almost every $\eta$. So is $\gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$, whose conditional laws of single links are the $\gamma_e^F$. The composition $P_\eta$ of the kernels $\gamma_e^F$, $e \in V$, in a fixed order has a density with respect to Haar measure on $G^V$ bounded below by a positive constant, because each single-link density is at least $e^{-12N^2\beta}$ times its maximum over the group. A Markov kernel with such a lower bound has at most one invariant probability measure (Doeblin's condition), so $\nu_\eta = \gamma_V(\cdot \mid \eta)$.

(b) Let $\pi^*$ minimise $\Psi$ as in Lemma B.1 and call $x$ admissible if $V_x \cap S = \emptyset$. For admissible $x$ replace $(\sigma_{V_x}, \sigma'_{V_x})$ by an optimal coupling, for $d_{V_x}$, of the two block laws; both $\mu_i$ are invariant, so the result is a coupling, and changing the boundary links one at a time bounds the new expected $d_{V_x}$-distance by $\sum_j C_{V_x,j}\,\varrho(j)$. With $\bar w_x = \max_{i \in V_x} w_i$, minimality gives

$$\sum_{i \in V_x} w_i \varrho(i) \le \bar w_x \sum_{j \notin V_x} C_{V_x,j}\,\varrho(j),$$

and $\bar w_x \le e^{\lambda \rho_n} w_j$ whenever $C_{V_x,j} \neq 0$. Let $S'$ be the set of links outside $S$ that lie in a translate meeting $S$; each is within distance $\rho_n$ of a link of $S$, so $\sum_{i \in S'} w_i \le c_n e^{\lambda \rho_n} \sum_{z \in S} w_z$. A link outside $S \cup S'$ lies in $N_n$ translates, all admissible. Summing over admissible $x$ and using $\sum_{x:\, j \notin V_x} C_{V_x,j} = K_{c(j)} \le \alpha N_n$,

$$N_n \sum_{i \notin S \cup S'} w_i \varrho(i) \le \theta N_n \Big[ \sum_{i \notin S \cup S'} w_i \varrho(i) + \sum_{i \in S \cup S'} w_i \varrho(i) \Big].$$

All sums are finite and $\varrho \le D$, so $\sum_{i \notin S \cup S'} w_i \varrho(i) \le \frac{\theta D}{1-\theta}(1 + c_n e^{\lambda \rho_n}) \sum_{z \in S} w_z$; adding $\sum_{i \in S'} w_i \varrho(i) \le D c_n e^{\lambda \rho_n} \sum_{z \in S} w_z$ gives the bound. If $S = \emptyset$ then $S' = \emptyset$ and $\varrho \equiv 0$. □

The covariance bound of Corollary B.2 follows from part (b) in the same way, with $\theta D/(1-\theta)$ replaced by $D(1 + c_n e^{\lambda \rho_n})/(1-\theta)$, since the conditional measures $\mu^\sigma$ there are invariant under $\gamma_{V_x}$ for $V_x \cap S_H = \emptyset$ by part (a).

## Appendix C. The plaquette blocks

Table 4 lists the block plaquettes of Section 5 modulo $2\mathbb{Z}^4$: the plaquette at $x$ in the plane $\{\mu, \nu\}$ is a block plaquette exactly when $x$ modulo two and $\{\mu, \nu\}$ appear in the table. Eight lie in the plane $\{0, 1\}$ and eight in $\{2, 3\}$; together they contain the 48 active links of a cell of side two, each once.

Table 4. The sixteen block plaquettes modulo two: the base point $x$ (digits $x_0x_1x_2x_3$ modulo two) and the plane.

| $x$ | plane | $x$ | plane |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0000 | $\{0,1\}$ | 0000 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 0001 | $\{0,1\}$ | 0011 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 0010 | $\{0,1\}$ | 0100 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 0011 | $\{0,1\}$ | 0111 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 1100 | $\{0,1\}$ | 1000 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 1101 | $\{0,1\}$ | 1011 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 1110 | $\{0,1\}$ | 1100 | $\{2,3\}$ |
| 1111 | $\{0,1\}$ | 1111 | $\{2,3\}$ |

In closed form, the plaquette at $x$ in $\{0, 1\}$ is a block plaquette when $x_0 \equiv x_1$ and the plaquette at $x$ in $\{2, 3\}$ when $x_2 \equiv x_3$; the blocks do not depend on the line field beyond the fact that every plaquette contains one fixed link. The bounds of Lemma 5.5 are evaluated

in ball arithmetic at 120 bits: the series of $Z_0$ and of its first three derivatives in $s = r^2$ is summed to forty terms, and the tail is bounded for $s \le 5$ by twice the first omitted term $(5/4)^{40}40^3/(40!\,41!)$, because consecutive terms decrease by a factor below one half. The constants of (5.2) and $\alpha$ are then evaluated at a given $\beta_W$ from exact input.

For SU(3) the bounds of Lemma 8.3 are evaluated on the 841 boxes of side $\frac{3}{16}$ at $r = \frac{3}{2}$ and the 784 boxes of side $\frac{19}{100}$ at $r = \frac{38}{25}$ with the moments of Appendix E, and the constants of (8.2) and $\alpha_3$ are evaluated from these bounds and the cover of Proposition 7.8 or Proposition 7.9 in ball arithmetic at 120 bits. The cover of Proposition 7.9 is computed as in Appendix E with $r = \frac{38}{25}$ and the threshold 1.03.

## Appendix D. The blocks of Lemma 6.2

*Diagonal blocks.* Let $w_a = e^{i\phi}$. On the diagonal part, $f_p = -\cos\phi\,(y_1 + y_2 - y_3 - y_4)^2$ and $c_p = 2(y_1y_4 - y_1y_2 + y_2y_3 - y_3y_4)$, so

$$\mathcal{F} = \sum_i \alpha_i y_i^2 + \cos\phi\,(y_1 + y_2 - y_3 - y_4)^2 \\ - \tfrac{9}{5}(y_1y_4 - y_1y_2 + y_2y_3 - y_3y_4)$$

with $y_k = 0$ and weights $\alpha_{k\pm1} = \frac{21}{10}$, $\alpha_{k+2} = \frac{5}{4}$. It is affine in $\cos\phi$, so positivity at $\cos\phi = \pm1$ suffices. For $k = 1$ and $\cos\phi = 1$ the matrix in $(y_2, y_3, y_4)$ is

$$\begin{pmatrix} \frac{31}{10} & -\frac{19}{10} & -1 \\ -\frac{19}{10} & \frac{9}{4} & \frac{19}{10} \\ -1 & \frac{19}{10} & \frac{31}{10} \end{pmatrix},$$

and Table 5 lists the leading principal minors for every position; all are positive.

Table 5. Leading principal minors of the diagonal blocks of Lemma 6.2.

| Fixed link | $\cos\phi = 1$ | | | $\cos\phi = -1$ | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $e_1$, $e_4$ | $\frac{31}{10}$, | $\frac{673}{200}$, | $\frac{8421}{2000}$ | $\frac{11}{10}$, | $\frac{53}{200}$, | $\frac{21}{2000}$ |
| $e_2$ | $\frac{31}{10}$, | $\frac{861}{100}$, | $\frac{8421}{2000}$ | $\frac{11}{10}$, | $\frac{21}{100}$, | $\frac{21}{2000}$ |
| $e_3$ | $\frac{9}{4}$, | $\frac{673}{200}$, | $\frac{8421}{2000}$ | $\frac{1}{4}$, | $\frac{53}{200}$, | $\frac{21}{2000}$ |

*Pair blocks.* Let $w_a = e^{i(\chi+\vartheta)}$ and $w_b = e^{i(\chi-\vartheta)}$. The terms of $f_p$ carry $w_a + \bar{w}_b = 2\cos\chi\, e^{i\vartheta}$ or its conjugate, and $c_p$ carries $w_a\bar{w}_b = e^{2i\vartheta}$, so the Hermitian matrix $M(m,\vartheta)$ of $\mathcal{F}$, $m = \cos\chi$, is affine in $m$ with $M(-1,\vartheta) = M(1,\vartheta+\pi)$, and $m = 1$ suffices. For the fixed link $e_2$, in the variables $(z_1, z_3, z_4)$ and with $c = \cos\vartheta$,

$$M = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{21}{5} + 2c & -2e^{i\vartheta} & -\frac{9}{5} - 2e^{i\vartheta} \\ -2e^{-i\vartheta} & \frac{21}{5} + 2c & \frac{9}{5} + 2e^{-i\vartheta} \\ -\frac{9}{5} - 2e^{-i\vartheta} & \frac{9}{5} + 2e^{i\vartheta} & \frac{5}{2} + 2c \end{pmatrix}.$$

With $u = \cos^2(\vartheta/2) \in [0,1]$ its leading principal minors are

$$\tfrac{20u+11}{5}, \quad \tfrac{(20u+1)(20u+21)}{25}, \quad \tfrac{400u(40u^2-23u+4)+21}{250},$$

and $40u^2 - 23u + 4$ has negative discriminant $529 - 640$. The other positions give the same determinant and the leading minors $\frac{20u+11}{5}$ or $\frac{8u+1}{2}$ and $\frac{800u^2-180u+53}{50}$, whose discriminant $32400 - 169600$ is negative. Every block is positive definite.

The inequality is not tight. In floating point the least eigenvalue of the whole form over $W \in \mathrm{U}(N)$, $N \le 4$, is 0.0149, which is also the least eigenvalue of the exact blocks; this slack is what the choice of the weights $\frac{21}{10}$, $\frac{5}{4}$, $\frac{9}{10}$ trades against the constant $\frac{29}{2}$.

## Appendix E. The certified computation

*Truncation.* For a corner $b$ of a box the moments of Lemma 7.6 are derivatives of $Z$ at $(b,\bar b)$. The truncated series is $\mathbb{E}_H[A_t(UD)B_t(\bar U D')]$ with $A_t$ the part of $\sum_\lambda c_\lambda s_\lambda(UD)$ over partitions with $\lambda_1-\lambda_3\le 34$ and $\lambda_3\le 11$, and $B_t$ likewise. Every omitted partition has $|\lambda|>34$, because $3\cdot 12>34$, and the omitted part is at most $T(\|D\|)=\sum_{n>34}(\frac32\|D\|)^n/n!$ in modulus. On the polydisc $|D_{ij}-b_{ij}|\le\rho$, $\|D\|\le\|b\|+3\rho$, and Cauchy's estimate bounds the $\alpha$-th derivative of the omitted part by $\alpha!\rho^{-|\alpha|}T(\|b\|+3\rho)$. The derivatives of the full exponential are at most $2^{-|\alpha|}e^{v/2}$ with $v=\sum_k|b_k|$, since $|\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)|\le\sum_k|b_k|$ for diagonal $b$. With $\varepsilon_\alpha=2^{|\alpha|}\alpha!\rho^{-|\alpha|}T(\|b\|+3\rho)$ the truncated moment differs from the true one by at most $\varepsilon_\alpha e^{v/2}+(e^{v/2}+\varepsilon_\alpha)\varepsilon_\beta$, and $\rho$ is chosen to minimise $\rho^{-6}T$. The largest error bound of an unnormalised moment at any corner is $1.7\times10^{-11}$.

*Weight zero.* Conjugation by the diagonal torus $T$ preserves Haar measure and $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Ub)$ for diagonal $b$, and multiplies $u_{ij}$ by $t_it_j^{-1}$; a moment of a monomial on which $T$ acts by a nontrivial character is therefore 0, and only 8278 of the 134596 monomials of degree at most six have the trivial character. The functions $\operatorname{Tr}(X)$, $e_2(X)$, $\det X$ of $X=DD'^{\top}$ and $\det D$, $\det D'$ are invariant under the same action on the variables, so after these are formed in the full ring of Taylor polynomials of degree six in the 18 variables, the series is computed in the subring of weight-zero monomials.

*Rounding.* The truncated series is a Taylor polynomial of total degree six in the 36 real directions of $(D-b,D'-\bar b)$, computed in double precision. Every operation is repeated on absolute values and carries an operation count $n$, so that the computed coefficient differs from the exact one by at most $\gamma_n=nu/(1-nu)$, $u=2^{-53}$, times the absolute-value coefficient [43, Sec. 3.1]. With $C$ in $2^{-30}\mathbb{Z}$, the polynomials $2^{31}q_h$, $X_a(2^{31}q_h)$, $12\cdot2^{31}(\varphi_h+\Delta q_h)$ and $12\cdot2^{31}\langle\nabla\varphi_{F_k},\nabla q_h\rangle$ for the coordinate vectors $h$ have coefficients in $\mathbb{Z}[i]$, and every partial sum in their computation is bounded, through the same operations on absolute values, by less than $2^{50}$; they are therefore computed exactly. Normalisation by $Z$, the products with the corner coordinates, the quadratic forms and their error matrices are formed with the same bookkeeping, and the largest eigenvalues are bounded in ball arithmetic [48].

*Separation.* The functional $c$ of a discarded box is the dual solution of a linear program for the gauge of the centre of the box with respect to a $72\times72$ grid of $T$. Only the final inequality is used: $\max_T\ell$ is bounded by its maximum over a $512\times512$ grid plus $\frac12 H\delta^2/2$, with $\delta=2\pi/512$ and $H=|c_1|+|c_2|+2|c_3|$ a bound for its Hessian on the torus, and the inequality is checked with relative margin $10^{-12}$.

## Appendix F. The transfer matrix

This appendix recalls the Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction for the lattice [62, 63, 64] in the form used for the gaps, following our earlier paper [14].

Let $\omega$ be a state on the gauge-invariant local functions of $\mathbb{Z}^4$ that is invariant under translations and the hypercubic group and reflection positive for reflections in planes through sites and in planes bisecting links; by Proposition 3.2(iii)–(iv) and its analogues in the other theorems, the states of this paper are of this kind. The reconstruction gives a Hilbert space with a vector $\Omega$, a map $F\mapsto\Psi_F$ with dense range, and a self-adjoint $\mathbb{T}$ with $0\le\mathbb{T}\le1$, $\mathbb{T}\Omega=\Omega$ and $\langle\Psi_F,\mathbb{T}^t\Psi_H\rangle=\omega(\vartheta(\bar F)\tau_tH)$, where $\vartheta$ is the time reflection and $\tau_t$ the time translation.[21]

**Proposition F.1.** *For $m>0$ the following are equivalent:*

(a) *the spectrum of $\mathbb{T}$ on $\Omega^\perp$ lies in $[0,e^{-m}]$;*

[21] $\Psi_F$ is the class of $F$ in the completion of the positive-time local functions for the form $\langle F,H\rangle=\omega(\vartheta(\bar F)H)$, which is positive semidefinite by reflection positivity. Since $|\omega(\vartheta(\bar F)F)|\le\omega(|F|^2)$ by the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality and the invariance of $\omega$ under $\vartheta$, functions that are close in $L^2(\omega)$ give close vectors.

(b) *for every $F$ in a class of gauge-invariant local functions supported at times in a bounded interval and dense in $L^2(\omega)$ on each such support, there is $C_F < \infty$ with $0 \le \omega(\vartheta(\bar F)\tau_t F) - |\omega(F)|^2 \le C_F e^{-mt}$ for all $t \ge 0$.*

*Under* (a) *one may take $C_F = \|F\|_\infty^2$ for every bounded $F$.*

*Proof.* If (a) holds, then

$$\omega(\vartheta(\bar F)\tau_t F) - |\omega(F)|^2 = \langle \Psi'_F, \mathbb{T}^t \Psi'_F \rangle$$

with $\Psi'_F = \Psi_F - \langle \Omega, \Psi_F\rangle \Omega \in \Omega^\perp$; this number lies in $[0, e^{-mt}\|\Psi_F\|^2]$, and $\|\Psi_F\|^2 \le \|F\|_\infty^2$. Conversely, let $\sigma$ be the spectral measure of $\mathbb{T}$ at $\Psi'_F$ and let $\delta > 0$. Then

$$\sigma\big((e^{-m+\delta}, 1]\big) e^{(-m+\delta)t} \le C_F e^{-mt}$$

for all $t$, so $\sigma((e^{-m+\delta}, 1]) = 0$. The spectral projection of $(e^{-m}, 1]$ restricted to $\Omega^\perp$ therefore annihilates the vectors $\Psi'_F$ of the class, which are dense by the footnote above, and it vanishes. □

## Appendix G. Spectral measures and Laplace transforms

This appendix collects the facts on spectral measures that the continuum step uses, with proofs.

**Lemma G.1.** *Let $T$ be a self-adjoint operator on a Hilbert space with $0 \le T \le 1$ and let $\psi$ be a unit vector. There is a unique probability measure $\nu$ on $[0,1]$ with $\langle \psi, h(T)\psi\rangle = \int h\, d\nu$ for every bounded Borel function $h$ on $[0,1]$. If $T\psi' = \psi'$ implies $\langle \psi', \psi\rangle = 0$, then $\nu(\{1\}) = 0$. If $\mu$ is the image of $\nu$ under $\lambda \mapsto -c^{-1}\log\lambda \in [0,\infty]$ for some $c > 0$, then $\langle \psi, T^{\sigma/c}\psi\rangle = \int_{[0,\infty]} e^{-\sigma E} d\mu(E)$ for $\sigma > 0$, with the integrand 0 at $E = \infty$.*

*Proof.* The spectral theorem [65, Sec. VII.2] gives the measure $\nu$, carried by the spectrum of $T$, which lies in $[0,1]$; uniqueness holds because the moments $\int \lambda^n d\nu = \langle \psi, T^n\psi\rangle$ determine a measure on a compact interval, polynomials being dense in $C[0,1]$. The spectral projection $P = \mathbf{1}_{\{1\}}(T)$ projects onto the eigenvectors of $T$ with eigenvalue 1, so $\nu(\{1\}) = \|P\psi\|^2 = \langle P\psi, \psi\rangle = 0$ under the hypothesis. The last identity is the change of variables $\lambda^{\sigma/c} = e^{-\sigma E}$ for $\lambda = e^{-cE}$, with $\lambda = 0$ corresponding to $E = \infty$. □

**Lemma G.2.** *Every sequence of probability measures on a compact metric space $K$ has a subsequence that converges weakly, that is, against every continuous function, to a probability measure on $K$.*

*Proof.* $C(K)$ is separable; let $(h_j)$ be dense. The numbers $\int h_j\, d\mu_k$ are bounded by $\|h_j\|_\infty$, so a diagonal subsequence makes all of them converge. By density the limit $\Lambda(h) = \lim \int h\, d\mu_k$ exists for every $h \in C(K)$; $\Lambda$ is linear, positive and $\Lambda(1) = 1$, so by the Riesz representation theorem it is integration against a probability measure. □

**Lemma G.3.** *Let $\mu$ be a probability measure on $[0,\infty]$ and $\rho(\sigma) = \int e^{-\sigma E} d\mu(E)$ for $\sigma > 0$.*

(a) *$\rho$ is nonincreasing and log-convex: $\rho(\sigma)^2 \le \rho(\sigma - s)\rho(\sigma + s)$ for $0 < s < \sigma$.*
(b) *$\rho(\sigma) > 0$ for one $\sigma > 0$ if and only if $\mu([0,\infty)) > 0$, and then $\rho(\sigma) > 0$ for every $\sigma > 0$.*
(c) *$\rho(\sigma) \to \mu([0,\infty))$ as $\sigma \downarrow 0$.*
(d) *If $\mu$ is carried by $[m,\infty]$, then $\rho(\sigma) \le e^{-m\sigma}$.*
(e) *For $M > 0$, $\mu([0,M]) \ge \rho(\sigma) - e^{-\sigma M}$.*
(f) *If $\mu_k \to \mu$ weakly on $[0,\infty]$, then $\int e^{-\sigma E} d\mu_k \to \rho(\sigma)$ for every $\sigma > 0$.*

*Proof.* (a) The integrand decreases in $\sigma$. By the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality,

$$\Big(\int e^{-\sigma E} d\mu\Big)^2 \le \int e^{-(\sigma-s)E} d\mu \int e^{-(\sigma+s)E} d\mu.$$

(b) The integrand is positive exactly on $[0,\infty)$. (c) The integrand increases to $\mathbf{1}_{[0,\infty)}$ as $\sigma \downarrow 0$, and monotone convergence applies. (d) The integrand is at most $e^{-m\sigma}$ on $[m,\infty]$.

(e) Split the integral at $M$: it is at most $\mu([0,M]) + e^{-\sigma M}$. (f) For $\sigma > 0$ the function $E \mapsto e^{-\sigma E}$, extended by 0 at $\infty$, is continuous on $[0,\infty]$. □

By (b) and (e), a lower bound $\rho(\sigma) \geq c > 0$ at one $\sigma$ places mass at least $c/2$ on the bounded interval $[0, \sigma^{-1}\log(2/c)]$; for the measures $\mu_k$ of Theorem 10.7 a bound uniform in $k$ therefore makes them tight on $[0,\infty)$ with a fixed fraction of their mass.

## Appendix H. The character expansion

Let $G$ be a compact connected Lie group with normalised Haar measure $dU$. For an irreducible unitary representation $\rho_\lambda$ of dimension $d_\lambda$ write $\chi_\lambda = \operatorname{Tr}\rho_\lambda$. The characters form an orthonormal basis of the square-integrable class functions (Peter–Weyl and Schur orthogonality [22, Chs. 2–4]).

**Lemma H.1.** *Let $w \in L^1(G)$ be a class function with $w(U^{-1}) = w(U)$, and put*

$$\hat{c}_\lambda = d_\lambda^{-1} \int w\,\chi_\lambda\,dU.$$

*Then $\int w(U)\rho_\lambda(U)\,dU = \hat{c}_\lambda I$, and $\int w(U)\chi_\lambda(U^{-1}V)\,dU = \hat{c}_\lambda \chi_\lambda(V)$.*

*Proof.* $M = \int w(U)\rho_\lambda(U)dU$ commutes with every $\rho_\lambda(V)$, since $w(VUV^{-1}) = w(U)$ and Haar measure is invariant; by Schur's lemma $M = cI$, and taking traces gives $c = \hat{c}_\lambda$. Then $\int w(U)\chi_\lambda(U^{-1}V)dU = \operatorname{Tr}(\int w(U)\rho_\lambda(U^{-1})dU\,\rho_\lambda(V))$, and the substitution $U \mapsto U^{-1}$ with $w(U^{-1}) = w(U)$ turns the integral into $M$. □

**Lemma H.2.** *Let $G = \mathrm{SU}(N)$ and $\beta > 0$, and let*

$$w_\beta(U) = e^{\frac{\beta}{N}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}U} \Big/ \int e^{\frac{\beta}{N}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}V} dV.$$

*Then $\hat{c}_\lambda(\beta) = d_\lambda^{-1}\int w_\beta\chi_\lambda\,dU$ is real, $0 \leq \hat{c}_\lambda(\beta) \leq 1$, and $\hat{c}_\lambda(\beta) < 1$ for $\lambda \neq 0$. Moreover*

$$\hat{c}_\lambda(\beta) = 1 - \frac{N\,C_2(\lambda)}{\beta} + O(\beta^{-2}) \qquad (\beta \to \infty),$$

*where $-\sum_a \rho_\lambda(T_a)^2 = 2C_2(\lambda)I$ for a basis $(T_a)$ of $\mathfrak{su}(N)$ orthonormal for $|X|^2 = -\operatorname{Tr}X^2$, so that $C_2 = (N^2-1)/(2N)$ on the fundamental representation.*

*Proof.* Since $w_\beta(\bar{U}) = w_\beta(U)$ and $\chi_\lambda(\bar{U}) = \overline{\chi_\lambda(U)}$, and complex conjugation preserves Haar measure, $\int w_\beta\chi_\lambda = \int w_\beta\bar{\chi}_\lambda$, which is the complex conjugate of the left side; so $\hat{c}_\lambda$ is real. Next, $w_\beta$ is a multiple of $\exp(\frac{\beta}{2N}(\chi_{\mathrm{F}} + \bar{\chi}_{\mathrm{F}})) = \sum_m \frac{1}{m!}(\frac{\beta}{2N})^m(\chi_{\mathrm{F}} + \bar{\chi}_{\mathrm{F}})^m$, and each power is the character of a representation, hence a sum of irreducible characters with nonnegative integer coefficients. By orthonormality $\int w_\beta\bar{\chi}_\lambda \geq 0$, so $\hat{c}_\lambda \geq 0$. As $|\chi_\lambda(U)| \leq d_\lambda$, with $\operatorname{Re}\chi_\lambda(U) = d_\lambda$ only where $\rho_\lambda(U) = I$, a proper closed subgroup when $\lambda \neq 0$ and so a Haar null set, and $w_\beta > 0$ everywhere, $\hat{c}_\lambda = d_\lambda^{-1}\int w_\beta \operatorname{Re}\chi_\lambda < 1$ for $\lambda \neq 0$.

For the expansion, $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}U \leq N$ with equality only at $U = I$, so outside a neighbourhood $\{U = e^X : |X| < \delta\}$ both integrals $\int e^{\frac{\beta}{N}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}U}\chi_\lambda$ and $\int e^{\frac{\beta}{N}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}U}$ are smaller than their values near $I$ by a factor $e^{-c\beta}$. Near $I$ write $U = e^X$; the Haar density in these coordinates is $j(X) = 1 + O(|X|^2)$, even in $X$. For antihermitian $X$, $\operatorname{Tr}X^3$ is imaginary, so

$$\tfrac{1}{N}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}e^X = 1 - \tfrac{1}{2N}|X|^2 + r(X), \qquad 0 \leq r(X) \leq C|X|^4,$$

and $d_\lambda^{-1}\chi_\lambda(e^X) = 1 + d_\lambda^{-1}\operatorname{Tr}\rho_\lambda(X) + \frac{1}{2d_\lambda}\operatorname{Tr}\rho_\lambda(X)^2 + c_3(X) + O(|X|^4)$, with $c_3$ cubic and $\operatorname{Tr}\rho_\lambda(X) = 0$, since $\mathfrak{su}(N)$ is perfect. Let $\langle\cdot\rangle$ denote the average against the Gaussian weight $e^{-\beta|X|^2/(2N)}$, under which the coordinates $x_a$ of $X = \sum x_a T_a$ are independent with variance

$N/\beta$. With $h = j\, e^{\beta r}$,

$$\hat{c}_\lambda(\beta) = \frac{\langle d_\lambda^{-1}\chi_\lambda(e^X)\, h\rangle}{\langle h\rangle} + O(e^{-c\beta}) \\ = 1 + \frac{\langle \frac{1}{2d_\lambda}\operatorname{Tr}\rho_\lambda(X)^2\, h\rangle}{\langle h\rangle} + \frac{\langle (c_3(X) + O(|X|^4))h\rangle}{\langle h\rangle},$$

the averages being taken over $|X| < \delta$. Under $\langle\cdot\rangle$, $|X|^{2m}$ has mean of order $\beta^{-m}$ and $\beta|r(X)| \le C\beta|X|^4$ has mean of order $\beta^{-1}$, so $h = 1 + O(\beta^{-1})$ in every moment. The weight $h$ is even in $X$, since $\operatorname{Tr} X^k$ is imaginary for odd $k$ and $j$ is even, so the odd term $c_3$ contributes nothing; the quartic remainder and the correlation of the quadratic term with $h-1$ contribute $O(\beta^{-2})$. Finally $\langle \operatorname{Tr}\rho_\lambda(X)^2\rangle = \frac{N}{\beta}\sum_a \operatorname{Tr}\rho_\lambda(T_a)^2 = -\frac{2NC_2(\lambda)d_\lambda}{\beta}$, which gives the expansion. For SU(2) and the representation of spin $j$ the integrals are explicit, $\hat{c}_j(\beta) = I_{2j+1}(\beta)/I_1(\beta)$ with the modified Bessel functions $I_n$, in agreement with $C_2 = j(j+1)$. □

## Appendix I. The single-link law of SU(2)

This appendix proves the sharp quarter, $W_1(\nu_b, \nu_{b'}) \le \frac{1}{4}|b - b'|$ for the one-link law of SU(2), which Theorems 1.1 and 1.3 use, and the exact value at $b = 0$, which Theorem 1.2 uses. The argument is that of our earlier paper [14]; it is given in full so that the present paper is self-contained.

I.1. **The von Mises–Fisher law.** Identify SU(2) with the unit quaternions, that is with the unit sphere $S^3 \subset \mathbb{R}^4$, so that $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr} U = 2x_0(U)$ and $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(UV) = 2\langle u, \bar{v}\rangle$ for the Euclidean inner product of $\mathbb{R}^4$ and quaternion conjugation $v \mapsto \bar{v}$. Fix a link $e$ and the field off $e$. Every plaquette through $e$ can be rotated cyclically so that its trace reads $\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Q_e A_p)$ with $A_p \in \mathrm{SU}(2)$, the staple of $e$ in $p$. The action therefore depends on $Q_e$ only through

$$N\beta \sum_{p \ni e} \operatorname{Re}\operatorname{Tr}(Q_e A_p) = \langle x, b\rangle, \qquad b = 4\beta \sum_{p \ni e} \bar{A}_p \in \mathbb{R}^4,$$

with $x = Q_e \in S^3$. Since there are six staples, each of norm one,

$$\kappa := |b| \le y := 24|\beta|. \tag{I.1}$$

The conditional law of $Q_e$ is the von Mises–Fisher law[22]

$$\nu_b(dx) = Z(\kappa)^{-1} e^{\langle x, b\rangle}\, \sigma(dx) \tag{I.2}$$

on the unit sphere, with $\sigma$ the normalised surface measure. We use coordinates in which $b = \kappa e_1$. The density of $t = x_1$ is proportional to $(1-t^2)^{1/2}e^{\kappa t}$ on $[-1, 1]$, so $Z(\kappa) = 2I_1(\kappa)/\kappa$ with the modified Bessel function $I_1$, normalised so that $Z(0) = 1$.

**Lemma I.1.** *For every $\kappa \ge 0$ the law $\nu_b$ on the unit sphere $S^3$ satisfies the Poincaré inequality $\operatorname{Var}_{\nu_b}(g) \le \frac{1}{3}\int |\nabla g|^2 d\nu_b$, and the constant $\frac{1}{3}$ is attained at $\kappa = 0$.*

*Proof.* In the polar angle $\theta \in (0, \pi)$ from $e_1$ the generator of the reversible diffusion of $\nu_b$ is $L = \partial_\theta^2 + b(\theta)\partial_\theta + \sin^{-2}\theta\, \Delta_{S^2}$ with $b(\theta) = 2\cot\theta - \kappa\sin\theta$. On spherical harmonics of degree $\ell$ on $S^2$ it acts as a Sturm–Liouville operator $L_\ell$ with potential $\ell(\ell+1)\sin^{-2}\theta$. A ground state comparison of Barta's type [9] with the trial function $\psi = \sin\theta\, e^{a\kappa\cos\theta}$ gives $-L_1\psi \ge 3\psi$ for $a = -\frac{1}{5}$, and the same trial function with $a = -\frac{2}{5}$ gives the bound 3 for the derivatives of zonal eigenfunctions; Appendix J carries out both computations. Hence every

[22] On the sphere $S^{p-1} \subset \mathbb{R}^p$ the von Mises–Fisher law with mean direction $\mu$ and concentration $\kappa$ has density proportional to $e^{\kappa\langle x,\mu\rangle}$ with respect to the surface measure, and its normalising constant is $(2\pi)^{p/2} I_{p/2-1}(\kappa)/\kappa^{p/2-1}$; it is the maximum entropy law with prescribed mean resultant, and it plays on the sphere the role of the Gaussian in $\mathbb{R}^p$. For $p = 4$ the Bessel index is 1. The mean resultant length $\mathbb{E}\langle x, \mu\rangle = I_{p/2}(\kappa)/I_{p/2-1}(\kappa)$ is the function $A$ of Lemma I.2. See Mardia and Jupp [58], Ch. 9, for these facts and for the tangent-normal decomposition used in Appendix J.

nonzero eigenvalue of $-L$ is at least 3. At $\kappa = 0$ the first eigenvalue of the Laplacian of the unit $S^3$ is 3. □

I.2. **Moments.** Let $A(\kappa) = \mathbb{E}_{\nu_b} x_1 = Z'(\kappa)/Z(\kappa) = I_2(\kappa)/I_1(\kappa)$.

**Lemma I.2.** *For every $\kappa > 0$, in coordinates with $b = \kappa e_1$,*

(i) $\mathbb{E}x_2^2 = \mathbb{E}x_3^2 = \mathbb{E}x_4^2 = A/\kappa$, $\mathbb{E}(1 - x_1^2) = 3A/\kappa$, *the covariance matrix of $x$ is* $\operatorname{diag}(A', A/\kappa, A/\kappa, A/\kappa)$, *and* $A' = 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa$;

(ii) $\dfrac{\kappa}{2 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 4}} \le A(\kappa) \le \dfrac{\kappa}{1 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 9}}$;

(iii) $A' \le A/\kappa \le \big(1 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 9}\big)^{-1} \le \frac{1}{4}$;

(iv) $A(\kappa) \ge \kappa / \big(\frac{3}{2} + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 25/4}\big)$.

*Proof.* (i) Integrating by parts against $\frac{d}{dt}(1-t^2)^{3/2} = -3t(1-t^2)^{1/2}$ gives $\kappa\,\mathbb{E}(1-x_1^2) = 3\mathbb{E}x_1$, and the three coordinates $x_2, x_3, x_4$ are exchangeable under $\nu_b$, with $\sum_i x_i^2 = 1$. The off-diagonal covariances vanish by the reflections $x_i \mapsto -x_i$, $i \ge 2$, and $A' = \operatorname{Var} x_1$ because $A = (\log Z)'$. (ii) By (i), $A$ solves the Riccati equation $A' = 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa$ with $A(\kappa) = \kappa/4 + O(\kappa^3)$. Appendix J shows that the left side of (ii) is a subsolution and the right side a supersolution of this equation, with the same behaviour at 0, and concludes by comparison. (iii) The middle inequality is (ii). For the first, put $s = \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 4}$. By (ii), $4A/\kappa \ge 4/(2+s)$ and $1 - A^2 \le 1 - \kappa^2/(2+s)^2$, and

$$1 - \frac{\kappa^2}{(2+s)^2} \le \frac{4}{2+s} \iff (2+s)^2 - \kappa^2 \le 4(2+s)$$
$$\iff s^2 - \kappa^2 \le 4,$$

which holds with equality. So $A' = 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa \le A/\kappa$. (iv) is the comparison of (ii) with a third barrier, which improves the lower bound of (ii); it is carried out in the same appendix. □

I.3. **The Lipschitz rate of the family.** Let $\delta$ be the chordal metric $\delta(x, x') = |x - x'|$ on $S^3$ and $W_1$ the Kantorovich distance for $\delta$. For $c \in \mathbb{R}^4$ and a unit vector $h \in \mathbb{R}^4$ put

$$L(c, h) = \sup_g \operatorname{Cov}_{\nu_c}\big(g, \langle h, x\rangle\big), \tag{I.3}$$

the supremum over 1-Lipschitz functions $g$ for $\delta$. Since $\frac{d}{dt}\nu_{c+th}(g) = \operatorname{Cov}_{\nu_{c+th}}(g, \langle h, x\rangle)$, the Kantorovich–Rubinstein duality gives, for all $b, b'$,

$$W_1(\nu_b, \nu_{b'}) \le |b - b'| \sup_{c \in [b, b']} L\Big(c, \frac{b' - b}{|b' - b|}\Big). \tag{I.4}$$

By rotation invariance $L(c, h)$ depends only on $\kappa = |c|$ and on the angle $\varphi$ between $h$ and $c^\perp$, and we write $L(\kappa, \varphi)$.

**Lemma I.3.** *For all $c$ and $h$, $L(c, h) \le 1/(2\sqrt{3})$. Moreover:*

(i) *at $c = 0$, $L(0, h) = \frac{1}{4}$ for every $h$;*

(ii) *if $h \perp c$, then $L(c, h) = \mathbb{E}_{\nu_c} x_2^2 = A(\kappa)/\kappa \le \frac{1}{4}$;*

(iii) *if $\kappa \ge \sqrt{88}/3 \approx 3.127$, then $L(c, h) \le \frac{1}{4}$ for every $h$.*

*Proof.* A 1-Lipschitz function for $\delta$ is 1-Lipschitz for the geodesic distance, which is larger, so $|\nabla g| \le 1$ almost everywhere, and Lemma I.1 gives $\operatorname{Var} g \le \frac{1}{3}$. By Lemma I.2(i), (iii) the largest eigenvalue of the covariance of $x$ is $A/\kappa \le \frac{1}{4}$, so $\operatorname{Var}\langle h, x\rangle \le A/\kappa$. The Cauchy–Schwarz inequality gives

$$L(c, h) \le \big(\tfrac{1}{3} A/\kappa\big)^{1/2} \le \Big(3\big(1 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 9}\big)\Big)^{-1/2} \le \frac{1}{2\sqrt{3}}. \tag{I.5}$$

(i) and (ii) are reflection arguments. Let $R$ be the reflection in the hyperplane $h^\perp$, and suppose $\nu_c$ is $R$-invariant, which is the case when $c = 0$ or $h \perp c$. Then $\mathbb{E}\langle h, x\rangle = 0$ and

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{Cov}(g, \langle h, x\rangle) &= \mathbb{E}\big[(g(x) - g(Rx))\langle h, x\rangle;\ \langle h, x\rangle > 0\big] \\ &\le \mathbb{E}\big[2\langle h, x\rangle^2;\ \langle h, x\rangle > 0\big] = \mathbb{E}\langle h, x\rangle^2,\end{aligned}$$

since $\delta(x, Rx) = 2|\langle h, x\rangle|$. Equality holds for $g = \langle h, x\rangle$, which is 1-Lipschitz. At $c = 0$, $\mathbb{E}\langle h, x\rangle^2 = \frac{1}{4}$; for $h \perp c$, $\mathbb{E}\langle h, x\rangle^2 = A/\kappa$. (iii) By (I.5), $L \le \frac{1}{4}$ as soon as $1 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 9} \ge \frac{16}{3}$, that is $\kappa^2 \ge \frac{88}{9}$. □

The reflection settles the directions $h \perp c$ and the point $c = 0$; for an oblique $h$ the reflection no longer preserves $\nu_c$, and the Cauchy–Schwarz bound (I.5) is too weak for $\kappa < \sqrt{88}/3$. The next theorem closes this case.

**Theorem I.4** (The sharp quarter)**.** *For every $c \in \mathbb{R}^4$ and every unit vector $h \in \mathbb{R}^4$,*

$$L(c, h) \le \tfrac{1}{4},$$

*with equality at $c = 0$. Equivalently, $W_1(\nu_b, \nu_{b'}) \le \frac{1}{4}|b - b'|$ for all $b, b' \in \mathbb{R}^4$, and the constant $\frac{1}{4}$ is the best possible.*

The equivalence is (I.4) in one direction and the derivative formula above it in the other; the sharpness is Lemma I.3(i). The metric matters.[23] The proof has four steps. A Lipschitz function on $S^3$ extends to the unit ball $B \subset \mathbb{R}^4$, and Green's formula in $B$ bounds the covariance by a negative Sobolev norm of the density (Lemma I.5). This norm splits into a zonal and a transverse part, both explicit series in modified Bessel functions (Lemma I.6). The transverse part is at most $\frac{1}{4}$ because a certain power series has nonnegative coefficients (Proposition I.8), and the zonal part is at most $\frac{1}{4}$ by a Riccati comparison (Proposition I.9).

I.4. **Harmonic extension.** Let $\sigma$ be the normalised surface measure of $S^3$ and $H_k$ the space of spherical harmonics of degree $k$, the restrictions to $S^3$ of harmonic homogeneous polynomials of degree $k$ on $\mathbb{R}^4$. The spaces $H_k$ are orthogonal in $L^2(\sigma)$ and span it; we write $u_k$ for the component of $u$ in $H_k$, and for $u$ with $\int u\, d\sigma = 0$ we put

$$\mathcal{Q}(u) = \sum_{k \ge 1} \frac{1}{k}\, \|u_k\|^2_{L^2(\sigma)}. \tag{I.6}$$

This is $\langle u, \Lambda^{-1} u\rangle$ for the Dirichlet-to-Neumann operator $\Lambda$ of $B$, which acts on $H_k$ as multiplication by $k$.

**Lemma I.5.** *Let $u$ be a real-analytic function on $S^3$ with $\int u\, d\sigma = 0$ and let $g$ be 1-Lipschitz for the chordal metric. Then*

$$\int_{S^3} g\, u\, d\sigma \le \tfrac{1}{2}\, \mathcal{Q}(u)^{1/2}.$$

*Proof.* The chordal metric is the Euclidean metric of $\mathbb{R}^4$ restricted to $S^3$, so McShane's extension $G(y) = \inf_{x \in S^3}(g(x) + |x - y|)$ is 1-Lipschitz on $\mathbb{R}^4$ and equals $g$ on $S^3$ [59]; by Rademacher's theorem $|\nabla G| \le 1$ almost everywhere. Let $\psi = \sum_{k \ge 1} k^{-1} r^k u_k(\omega)$ in polar coordinates $y = r\omega$. Each term is a harmonic polynomial, the series converges with all derivatives on the closed ball because $u$ is real-analytic,[24] and $\partial_r \psi = u$ on $S^3$. Green's formula for the Lipschitz function $G$ and the smooth harmonic function $\psi$ reads

[23] In the geodesic metric of $S^3$ the statement is false already at $c = 0$: the function $\arcsin x_2$ is geodesically 1-Lipschitz and its covariance with $x_2$ under the uniform law is $\frac{8}{9\pi} \approx 0.283 > \frac{1}{4}$. A proof therefore has to use that the chordal distance between two points is shorter than their geodesic distance, that is, it has to see the sphere from the ball it bounds. The proof below does exactly this: it extends a chordally Lipschitz function to the ball and integrates by parts there.

[24] For real-analytic $u$ the norms $\|u_k\|$ decay geometrically in $k$, and the supremum of a function in $H_k$ is at most $(\dim H_k)^{1/2} = k + 1$ times its $L^2(\sigma)$ norm, so the series for $\psi$ and for each of its derivatives converge uniformly on $\bar{B}$.

$\int_{S^3} G\,\partial_r\psi\,dS = \int_B \nabla G\cdot\nabla\psi\,dy$. With $|S^3| = 2\pi^2$ and $|B| = \pi^2/2$ the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality gives

$$\int g\,u\,d\sigma = \frac{1}{2\pi^2}\int_B \nabla G\cdot\nabla\psi\,dy \le \frac{|B|^{1/2}}{2\pi^2}\Big(\int_B |\nabla\psi|^2 dy\Big)^{1/2}.$$

Green's formula once more gives $\int_B |\nabla\psi|^2 = \int_{S^3}\psi\,\partial_r\psi\,dS = 2\pi^2\sum_k k^{-1}\|u_k\|^2 = 2\pi^2\mathcal{Q}(u)$, and the right side becomes $\frac12\mathcal{Q}(u)^{1/2}$. □

The lemma is a form of Thomson's principle. By Kantorovich–Rubinstein duality, $\sup_g \int gu\,d\sigma$ is the least cost of a flow in $\mathbb{R}^4$ that carries the positive part of $u\,d\sigma$ to its negative part, the cost being the total length travelled by the mass.[25] The harmonic field $\nabla\psi$ is one such flow, through the interior of the ball, and the lemma computes its cost. At $c = 0$ the flow is optimal: for $u = \langle h, x\rangle$ one has $\psi = \langle h, y\rangle$, the field $\nabla\psi = h$ is constant, the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality is an equality, and $\mathcal{Q}(u) = \|u\|^2 = \frac14$.

I.5. **Spectral decomposition.** Fix $c = \kappa e_1$ with $\kappa > 0$ and write $h = \cos\varphi\,e_1 + \sin\varphi\,e_2$, which is no loss of generality by rotation invariance. Let $\rho = d\nu_c/d\sigma = e^{\kappa x_1}/Z(\kappa)$, $Z(\kappa) = \int e^{\kappa x_1}d\sigma = 2I_1(\kappa)/\kappa$, and

$$u = \big(\langle h, x\rangle - \mathbb{E}_{\nu_c}\langle h, x\rangle\big)\rho,$$

so that $\mathrm{Cov}_{\nu_c}(g, \langle h, x\rangle) = \int gu\,d\sigma$ and $\int u\,d\sigma = 0$. Let $U_n$ be the Chebyshev polynomials of the second kind and put

$$d_n(\kappa) = \frac{(n+1)\,I_{n+1}(\kappa)}{I_1(\kappa)}, \qquad n \ge 0. \tag{I.7}$$

**Lemma I.6.** *With this notation*

$$\mathcal{Q}(u) = \cos^2\varphi\,\mathcal{Q}_z(\kappa) + \sin^2\varphi\,\mathcal{Q}_x(\kappa),$$

*where*

$$\mathcal{Q}_z = \sum_{n\ge1}\frac{d_n'(\kappa)^2}{n}, \qquad \mathcal{Q}_x = \frac{1}{3\kappa^2}\sum_{n\ge1}(n+2)\,d_n(\kappa)^2.$$

*Proof.* The functions $U_n(x_1)$, $n \ge 0$, are the zonal harmonics: $U_n(x_1) \in H_n$, and they are orthonormal in $L^2(\sigma)$ (Appendix K). The expansion $e^{\kappa t} = \frac{2}{\kappa}\sum_n (n+1)I_{n+1}(\kappa)U_n(t)$ of the same appendix gives $\rho = \sum_n d_n(\kappa)U_n(x_1)$, with $d_0 = 1$.

Write $u = \cos\varphi\,u_z + \sin\varphi\,u_x$ with $u_z = (x_1 - A)\rho$ and $u_x = x_2\rho$; here $\mathbb{E}_{\nu_c}x_1 = A$ and $\mathbb{E}_{\nu_c}x_2 = 0$. The reflection $x_2 \mapsto -x_2$ maps each $H_k$ to itself, fixes $u_z$ and reverses $u_x$, so the components of $u_z$ and $u_x$ in each $H_k$ are orthogonal and the cross term in $\mathcal{Q}(u)$ vanishes.

Since $A = Z'/Z$, we have $u_z = \partial_\kappa\rho = \sum_n d_n'(\kappa)U_n(x_1)$, and the component of $u_z$ in $H_n$ is $d_n'U_n(x_1)$, of norm $|d_n'|$. This gives $\mathcal{Q}_z$.

For $u_x$, let $y(t) = \cos t\,e_1 + \sin t\,e_2$. The law $\nu_{\kappa y(t)}$ has density $\rho_t = e^{\kappa\langle y(t),x\rangle}/Z(\kappa) = \sum_n d_n(\kappa)U_n(\langle y(t), x\rangle)$, and $\partial_t\rho_t|_{t=0} = \kappa x_2\rho$. The function $U_n(\langle y(t), x\rangle)$ lies in $H_n$ for every $t$, hence so does its derivative $x_2U_n'(x_1)$ at $t = 0$, and the component of $u_x$ in $H_n$ is $\kappa^{-1}d_nx_2U_n'(x_1)$. Its norm follows from the eigenvalue $n(n+2)$ of the Laplacian of $S^3$ on $H_n$. For $f = U_n(x_1)$,

$$\begin{aligned} n(n+2) = n(n+2)\|f\|^2 &= \int |\nabla_{S^3}f|^2 d\sigma \\ &= \int U_n'(x_1)^2(1-x_1^2)\,d\sigma, \end{aligned}$$

[25] This is the Beckmann formulation of the transport problem with cost $|x-y|$: the optimal cost equals the least $\int|V|$ over vector measures $V$ on $\mathbb{R}^4$ with divergence $u\,d\sigma$. Restricting the flow to the closed ball does not change the infimum, since projecting onto $\bar B$ shortens paths. The gradient $\nabla\psi$ on $B$ is one admissible flow. It minimises the energy $\int|V|^2$ rather than the cost $\int|V|$, and the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality converts one into the other at the price of the factor $|B|^{1/2}$.

since the tangential gradient of $x_1$ has squared length $1-x_1^2$. Given $x_1$, the point $(x_2,x_3,x_4)$ is uniform on the sphere of radius $(1-x_1^2)^{1/2}$, so $\mathbb{E}[x_2^2 \mid x_1] = \frac{1}{3}(1-x_1^2)$ and $\|x_2 U_n'(x_1)\|^2 = \frac{1}{3}n(n+2)$. Summing $n^{-1}\kappa^{-2}d_n^2 \cdot \frac{1}{3}n(n+2)$ over $n \geq 1$ gives $\mathcal{Q}_x$. □

By Lemmas I.5 and I.6,

$$L(\kappa,\varphi) \leq \tfrac{1}{2}\max\big(\mathcal{Q}_z(\kappa),\mathcal{Q}_x(\kappa)\big)^{1/2}, \tag{I.8}$$

and Theorem I.4 follows once both parts are at most $\frac{1}{4}$. Both are $\frac{1}{4}$ at $\kappa = 0$, by continuity from the values $d_1 \sim \kappa/2$, $d_1' \to \frac{1}{2}$ and $d_n = O(\kappa^n)$.

I.6. **Three Bessel sums.** The series of Lemma I.6 reduce to closed forms. Write $I_j$ for $I_j(\kappa)$.

**Lemma I.7.** *For every $\kappa > 0$,*

$$\sum_{j\geq 1} j^2 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa}{4}\, I_1(2\kappa), \qquad \sum_{j\geq 1} j^3 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa^2}{4}(I_0^2 + I_1^2),$$
$$I_1(2\kappa) = 2\sum_{j\geq 1} I_{j-1} I_j.$$

The first and third identities follow from Parseval's formula for $e^{\kappa\cos\theta} = \sum_{j\in\mathbb{Z}} I_j e^{ij\theta}$, and the second from the recurrences of $I_j$ by telescoping; Appendix K gives the proofs.

I.7. **The transverse part.**

**Proposition I.8.** *$\mathcal{Q}_x(\kappa) \leq \frac{1}{4}$ for every $\kappa \geq 0$.*

*Proof.* By (I.7), $\mathcal{Q}_x = (3\kappa^2 I_1^2)^{-1}\sum_{j\geq 2} j^2(j+1)I_j^2$, and the sum equals $\sum_{j\geq 1}(j^3+j^2)I_j^2 - 2I_1^2$. By Lemma I.7, $\mathcal{Q}_x \leq \frac{1}{4}$ is equivalent to

$$\mathcal{D}(\kappa) := (8+2\kappa^2)I_1^2 - \kappa^2 I_0^2 - \kappa I_1(2\kappa) \geq 0. \tag{I.9}$$

Each term is an entire function of $\kappa$ that is even after the factor $\kappa^2$ is removed, so $\mathcal{D}(\kappa) = \sum_{n\geq 0}\mathcal{D}_n\kappa^{2n}$. Lemma K.2 of Appendix K computes the coefficients: $\mathcal{D}_0 = \mathcal{D}_1 = 0$, and for $n = m+1 \geq 2$

$$\mathcal{D}_n = \frac{N_m}{4^m\, m!\,(m+1)!\,(m+1)(m+2)},$$

with

$$N_m = \binom{2m}{m}\big(4(2m+1) + (m-1)(m+1)(m+2)\big) - 4^m(m+1)(m+2).$$

The numerator $N_m$ vanishes for $m = 0,1,2$ and is positive for $m \geq 3$ (Lemma K.2). So every coefficient of $\mathcal{D}$ is nonnegative and $\mathcal{D} \geq 0$. □

The first nonzero coefficient is $\mathcal{D}_4 = \frac{1}{2304}$, so $\frac{1}{4} - \mathcal{Q}_x = \mathcal{D}/(12\kappa^2 I_1^2)$ is of order $\kappa^4$ at 0: the transverse part leaves the value $\frac{1}{4}$ very slowly, which is why no estimate that loses a constant can prove the proposition.

I.8. **The zonal part.** Let $A = I_2/I_1$ as before, so that $d_1 = 2A$ and, by Lemma I.2(i), $A' = 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa$.

**Proposition I.9.** *For $0 < \kappa \leq \sqrt{88}/3$,*

$$\mathcal{Q}_z(\kappa) \leq \frac{1}{4} + 4A'^2 + \frac{A^2}{4} - \frac{A}{2\kappa} - \frac{2A^2}{\kappa^2} < \frac{1}{4}.$$

*Proof. The higher modes.* With $r_\nu = I_{\nu+1}/I_\nu$ the recurrence $I'_\nu = I_{\nu+1} + \frac{\nu}{\kappa} I_\nu$ gives

$$\frac{d'_n}{d_n} = \frac{I'_{n+1}}{I_{n+1}} - \frac{I'_1}{I_1} = \frac{n}{\kappa} + r_{n+1} - r_1.$$

By Lemma K.3 of Appendix K, $r_{n+1} \le r_1$, and $r_1 = A \le \kappa/4$ by Lemma I.2(iii). Hence $-n/\kappa \le n/\kappa - \kappa/4 \le d'_n/d_n \le n/\kappa$ for $n \ge 2$ and $\kappa^2 \le 16$, so $d'^2_n \le n^2 d_n^2/\kappa^2$. With $d'_1 = 2A'$,

$$\mathcal{Q}_z \le 4A'^2 + \frac{1}{\kappa^2} \sum_{n\ge 2} n\, d_n^2 = 4A'^2 + \frac{S_3 - S_2 - 4I_2^2}{\kappa^2 I_1^2},$$

where $S_2 = \sum_{j\ge1} j^2 I_j^2$ and $S_3 = \sum_{j\ge1} j^3 I_j^2$; the second form uses $n\, d_n^2 I_1^2 = (j-1) j^2 I_j^2$ with $j = n+1$.

*The closed form.* The recurrences $I_0 - I_2 = \frac{2}{\kappa} I_1$ and $I_1 - I_3 = \frac{4}{\kappa} I_2$ give $I_0/I_1 = 2/\kappa + A$ and $I_2 I_3/I_1^2 = A - 4A^2/\kappa$. By Lemma I.7, $S_3/(\kappa^2 I_1^2) = \frac14 (2/\kappa + A)^2 + \frac14$, and, keeping three terms of the third identity,

$$\frac{S_2}{\kappa^2 I_1^2} \ge \frac{I_0 I_1 + I_1 I_2 + I_2 I_3}{2\kappa I_1^2} = \frac{1}{2\kappa}\Big(\frac{2}{\kappa} + 3A - \frac{4A^2}{\kappa}\Big).$$

Collecting terms, $\mathcal{Q}_z \le \frac14 + 4A'^2 + T(A)$ with $T(a) = \frac{a^2}{4} - \frac{a}{2\kappa} - \frac{2a^2}{\kappa^2}$, which is the first inequality.

*The barrier.* Let $s = \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 25/4}$ and $A_\flat = \kappa/(\frac32 + s)$. By Lemma I.2(iv), $A_\flat \le A \le \kappa/4$. The function $a \mapsto 1 - a^2 - 3a/\kappa$ decreases on $a \ge 0$, and $A' \ge 0$ because $A' = \operatorname{Var} x_1$, so $0 \le A' \le \alpha := 1 - A_\flat^2 - 3A_\flat/\kappa$. For $\kappa^2 \le 12$ the quadratic $T$ decreases on $[0, \kappa/4]$, since

$$T(a) - T(a') = (a' - a)\, \frac{2\kappa - (a + a')(\kappa^2 - 8)}{4\kappa^2}$$

and $(a + a')(\kappa^2 - 8) \le \frac{\kappa}{2}(\kappa^2 - 8) \le 2\kappa$ there. So $\mathcal{Q}_z \le \frac14 + 4\alpha^2 + T(A_\flat)$. With $\kappa^2 = s^2 - \frac{25}{4}$ and $A_\flat/\kappa = 2/(2s+3)$ both terms are rational in $s$: $\alpha = 16/(2s+3)^2$, and

$$4\alpha^2 + T(A_\flat) = \frac{(2s-5)\, p(s)}{4(2s+3)^4}, \qquad p(s) = 8s^3 + 28s^2 - 98s - 695. \tag{I.10}$$

For $0 < \kappa \le \sqrt{88}/3$ we have $\frac52 < s \le \sqrt{577}/6 < 4.004$. On $s \ge \frac52$ the cubic $p$ increases, since $p'(s) = 24s^2 + 56s - 98 > 0$, and $p(4.004) < -120$. So the right side of (I.10) is negative. □

I.9. **Proof of Theorem I.4.** At $c = 0$ the theorem is Lemma I.3(i), and for $|c| \ge \sqrt{88}/3$ it is Lemma I.3(iii). For $0 < |c| < \sqrt{88}/3$, Propositions I.8 and I.9 give $\mathcal{Q}_x, \mathcal{Q}_z \le \frac14$, and (I.8) gives $L \le \frac14$. □

## Appendix J. Computations for the single-link law

J.1. **Barta's inequality.** Let $\rho(\theta) = \sin^2\theta\, e^{\kappa\cos\theta}$ on $(0,\pi)$, let $V$ be a continuous potential, and let

$$T = -\rho^{-1}\partial_\theta\, \rho\, \partial_\theta + V.$$

If $\psi > 0$ is smooth on $(0,\pi)$ with $\rho\psi^2 = O(\sin^4\theta)$ at the end points and $T\psi \ge \lambda_0 \psi$, then

$$\int (|h'|^2 + V h^2)\rho\, d\theta \ge \lambda_0 \int h^2 \rho\, d\theta$$

for every smooth $h$ vanishing to first order at 0 and $\pi$. Indeed, writing $h = \psi u$ and integrating by parts, the boundary terms $\rho\psi\psi' u^2$ vanish and

$$\int (|h'|^2 + V h^2)\rho = \int \rho\psi^2 |u'|^2 + \int \frac{T\psi}{\psi}\, h^2 \rho \;\ge\; \lambda_0 \int h^2 \rho.$$

This is the inequality of Barta [9] in the form of a ground state transformation.

J.2. **The computations of Lemma I.1.** The generator of the reversible diffusion of $\nu_b$ on $S^3$ is $L = \Delta_{S^3} + \kappa \nabla x_1 \cdot \nabla$. In the polar angle $\theta$ from $e_1$ the round metric is $d\theta^2 + \sin^2\theta\, g_{S^2}$, so $\Delta_{S^3} = \partial_\theta^2 + 2\cot\theta\,\partial_\theta + \sin^{-2}\theta\,\Delta_{S^2}$, and $\nabla x_1 \cdot \nabla = -\sin\theta\,\partial_\theta$. On $h(\theta)Y_\ell$ with a spherical harmonic $Y_\ell$ of degree $\ell$ on $S^2$ the operator acts as $L_\ell = \partial_\theta^2 + b\,\partial_\theta - \ell(\ell+1)\sin^{-2}\theta$, $b = 2\cot\theta - \kappa\sin\theta = \rho'/\rho$, so $-L_\ell = T$ with $V = \ell(\ell+1)\sin^{-2}\theta$.

*Degree* $\ell \geq 1$. Take $\psi = \sin\theta\, e^{a\kappa\cos\theta}$. Then $\psi'/\psi = \cot\theta - a\kappa\sin\theta$ and $\psi''/\psi = (\psi'/\psi)^2 + (\psi'/\psi)'$, and a short computation gives

$$\frac{-L_1\psi}{\psi} = 3 + (1+5a)\kappa\cos\theta - a(1+a)\kappa^2\sin^2\theta.$$

For $a = -\frac{1}{5}$ this is $3 + \frac{4}{25}\kappa^2\sin^2\theta \geq 3$. Since $V = \ell(\ell+1)\sin^{-2}\theta \geq 2\sin^{-2}\theta$ for $\ell \geq 1$, Barta's inequality gives $-L_\ell \geq 3$ on every sector with $\ell \geq 1$.

*Degree* $\ell = 0$. Let $g(\theta)$ be a zonal eigenfunction, $-L_0 g = \lambda g$, $g$ not constant, so that $g'(0) = g'(\pi) = 0$. Differentiating $g'' + bg' = -\lambda g$ gives, for $h = g'$,

$$-(h'' + bh') - b'h = \lambda h, \qquad -b' = \frac{2}{\sin^2\theta} + \kappa\cos\theta,$$

so $h$ is an eigenfunction of $T$ with $V = 2\sin^{-2}\theta + \kappa\cos\theta$, with eigenvalue $\lambda$, and $h \not\equiv 0$ vanishes at both ends. With the same $\psi$,

$$\frac{T\psi}{\psi} = 3 + (2+5a)\kappa\cos\theta - a(1+a)\kappa^2\sin^2\theta,$$

which for $a = -\frac{2}{5}$ is $3 + \frac{6}{25}\kappa^2\sin^2\theta \geq 3$. Barta's inequality applied to $h$ gives $\lambda \geq 3$. Together with the case $\ell \geq 1$ every nonzero eigenvalue of $-L$ is at least 3, which is Lemma I.1; the spectrum is discrete because $S^3$ is compact and the drift is smooth.

J.3. **Moments.** The density of $t = x_1$ under $\nu_b$ is proportional to $(1-t^2)^{1/2}e^{\kappa t}$. For every smooth $\phi$ on $[-1,1]$,

$$\frac{d}{dt}\Big[(1-t^2)^{3/2}e^{\kappa t}\Big] = (1-t^2)^{1/2}e^{\kappa t}\big(\kappa(1-t^2) - 3t\big),$$

and integration by parts gives $\mathbb{E}[\phi'(t)(1-t^2)] = \mathbb{E}\big[\phi(t)\big(3t - \kappa(1-t^2)\big)\big]$. With $\phi = 1$ this is $\kappa\mathbb{E}(1-x_1^2) = 3\mathbb{E}x_1$, the identity of Lemma I.2(i). With $\phi = t^k$ it gives the recursion

$$m_{k+2} = m_k - \frac{k+3}{\kappa}\,m_{k+1} + \frac{k}{\kappa}\,m_{k-1}, \qquad m_k = \mathbb{E}x_1^k,$$

from $m_0 = 1$ and $m_1 = A$; all polynomial moments of $\nu_b$ are rational in $\kappa$ and $A(\kappa)$.[26]

J.4. **The Riccati barriers.** By Lemma I.2(i), $A$ solves $A' = \mathcal{F}(\kappa, A) := 1 - A^2 - 3A/\kappa$ on $(0,\infty)$, and $A(\kappa) = \frac{\kappa}{4} - \frac{\kappa^3}{96} + O(\kappa^5)$ from the series of $I_1$ and $I_2$. Let $s = \sqrt{\kappa^2+4}$, $u = \sqrt{\kappa^2+9}$, $\phi_- = \kappa/(2+s)$ and $\phi_+ = \kappa/(1+u)$. Direct differentiation gives

$$\phi_-' - \mathcal{F}(\kappa,\phi_-) = -\frac{\kappa^2}{s(s+2)^2} \leq 0,$$

$$\phi_+' - \mathcal{F}(\kappa,\phi_+) = \frac{(u-3)^2}{u(1+u)^2} \geq 0,$$

[26]For instance $m_2 = 1 - 3A/\kappa$, $m_3 = A - 3/\kappa + 12A/\kappa^2$ and $m_4 = m_2 - 5m_3/\kappa + 2A/\kappa$. The joint moments with $x_2, x_3, x_4$ follow from exchangeability: $\mathbb{E}[\phi(x_1)x_2^2] = \frac{1}{3}\mathbb{E}[\phi(x_1)(1-x_1^2)]$.

and $\phi_\pm = \frac{\kappa}{4} + O(\kappa^3)$.[27] The comparison is singular at 0 because of the term $3A/\kappa$, and we carry it out with an integrating factor. Let $D = A - \phi_-$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} D' &= \mathcal{F}(\kappa, A) - \mathcal{F}(\kappa, \phi_-) - (\phi_-' - \mathcal{F}(\kappa, \phi_-)) \\ &= -\Big(A + \phi_- + \frac{3}{\kappa}\Big) D + R, \end{aligned}$$

with $R = \kappa^2/(s(s+2)^2) \geq 0$. Put $\mu(\kappa) = \kappa^3 \exp \int_0^\kappa (A + \phi_-)$. Then $(\mu D)' = \mu R \geq 0$, and $\mu D = O(\kappa^6) \to 0$ as $\kappa \to 0$, so $\mu D \geq 0$ and $A \geq \phi_-$. The same argument with $D = \phi_+ - A$ and $R = (u-3)^2/(u(1+u)^2)$ gives $A \leq \phi_+$. This is Lemma I.2(ii).

For (iv) let $s = \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 25/4}$ and $\phi_\flat = \kappa/(\frac{3}{2} + s)$. Since $s^2 - \frac{9}{4} = \kappa^2 + 4$, the same differentiation gives

$$\phi_\flat' - \mathcal{F}(\kappa, \phi_\flat) = -\frac{5\,(s - \frac{5}{2})}{2\,s\,(\frac{3}{2} + s)^2} \leq 0,$$

so $\phi_\flat$ is a subsolution, and $\phi_\flat = \frac{\kappa}{4} - \frac{\kappa^3}{80} + O(\kappa^5)$.[28] Hence $A - \phi_\flat = \frac{\kappa^3}{480} + O(\kappa^5)$, and the integrating-factor argument above, with $D = A - \phi_\flat$, $R = \frac{5(s-5/2)}{2s(3/2+s)^2} \geq 0$ and $\mu = \kappa^3 \exp \int_0^\kappa (A + \phi_\flat)$, gives $\mu D = O(\kappa^6)$ at 0, $(\mu D)' = \mu R \geq 0$, and so $A \geq \phi_\flat$. Since $\frac{3}{2} + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 25/4} < 2 + \sqrt{\kappa^2 + 4}$ for $\kappa > 0$, this improves the lower bound of (ii).

## Appendix K. Bessel functions

This appendix proves the auxiliary statements used in Appendix I for Theorem I.4. Throughout, $I_j = I_j(\kappa)$ with $\kappa > 0$, and $I_{-j} = I_j$ for integers $j$. We use the series

$$I_\nu(\kappa) = \sum_{i \geq 0} \frac{(\kappa/2)^{2i+\nu}}{i!\,(i+\nu)!},$$

the integral $I_j(\kappa) = \pi^{-1} \int_0^\pi e^{\kappa \cos\theta} \cos j\theta \, d\theta$, the Fourier series $e^{\kappa\cos\theta} = \sum_{j \in \mathbb{Z}} I_j e^{ij\theta}$ and the recurrences

$$I_{j-1} - I_{j+1} = \frac{2j}{\kappa} I_j, \quad I_j' = I_{j+1} + \frac{j}{\kappa} I_j, \tag{K.1}$$

all of which are in Watson's treatise [76], §§3.7, 3.71, 2.22. All series below converge absolutely, because $0 < I_j \leq (\kappa/2)^j e^\kappa / j!$.

K.1. **Zonal harmonics.** Under $\sigma$ the coordinate $x_1$ has the density $\frac{2}{\pi}(1-t^2)^{1/2}$ on $[-1,1]$, the area of the two-sphere $\{x_1 = t\}$ being proportional to $1 - t^2$ and its normal speed to $(1-t^2)^{-1/2}$. The Chebyshev polynomials $U_n(\cos\theta) = \sin((n+1)\theta)/\sin\theta$ satisfy

$$\int U_n U_m \, d\sigma = \frac{2}{\pi} \int_0^\pi \sin((n+1)\theta) \sin((m+1)\theta)\, d\theta = \delta_{nm},$$

and $U_n = C_n^{(1)}$ is the Gegenbauer polynomial of index $\frac{4-2}{2} = 1$, so $U_n(\langle y, x\rangle)$ is the zonal harmonic of degree $n$ on $S^3$ with pole $y$: $|x|^n U_n(\langle y, x\rangle/|x|)$ is a harmonic polynomial on $\mathbb{R}^4$ [72], Ch. IV, §2.

**Lemma K.1.** *$e^{\kappa t} = \frac{2}{\kappa} \sum_{n \geq 0} (n+1) I_{n+1}(\kappa)\, U_n(t)$ in $L^2\big(\frac{2}{\pi}(1-t^2)^{1/2} dt\big)$, and uniformly on $[-1,1]$.*

[27] For the first identity write $\phi_- = (s-2)/\kappa$, which follows from $s^2 - 4 = \kappa^2$; then $\phi_-' = (\kappa^2/s - s + 2)/\kappa^2$ and $1 - \phi_-^2 - 3\phi_-/\kappa = (\kappa^2 - (s-2)^2 - 3(s-2))/\kappa^2$, and the difference simplifies with $s^2 = \kappa^2 + 4$. The second is the same computation with $\phi_+ = \kappa(u-1)/(u^2-1) = \kappa(u-1)/(\kappa^2+8)$ in place of $\phi_-$ and $u^2 = \kappa^2 + 9$ in place of $s^2 = \kappa^2 + 4$. After clearing the denominator $\kappa^2(1+u)^2$ the numerator becomes $\kappa^2(u-3)^2/u$, which is the stated residual.

[28] With $\phi_\flat = \kappa(s - \frac{3}{2})/(\kappa^2 + 4)$ one has $\phi_\flat' = (\frac{3}{2}s + \frac{25}{4})/(s(\frac{3}{2} + s)^2)$, using $ds/d\kappa = \kappa/s$; and $\mathcal{F}(\kappa, \phi_\flat) = 1 - \phi_\flat^2 - 3/(\frac{3}{2} + s)$. Clearing the denominator $s(\frac{3}{2} + s)^2$ and replacing $\kappa^2$ by $s^2 - \frac{25}{4}$ leaves $-\frac{5}{2}s + \frac{25}{4}$ in the numerator, which is the stated residual. The expansion follows from $s = \frac{5}{2} + \frac{\kappa^2}{5} + O(\kappa^4)$.

*Proof.* With $t = \cos\theta$ and $2\sin\theta\sin((n+1)\theta) = \cos n\theta - \cos(n+2)\theta$, the $n$-th coefficient is

$$\frac{2}{\pi}\int_0^\pi e^{\kappa\cos\theta}\sin((n+1)\theta)\sin\theta\,d\theta = I_n - I_{n+2} = \frac{2(n+1)}{\kappa}I_{n+1},$$

by (K.1). Since $|U_n| \le n+1$ and $I_{n+1}$ decays factorially, the series converges uniformly. □

K.2. **Proof of Lemma I.7.** Let $F(\theta) = e^{\kappa\cos\theta} = \sum_j I_j e^{ij\theta}$. Then

$$F'(\theta) = -\kappa\sin\theta\,F(\theta) = \sum_j ijI_j e^{ij\theta},$$

and Parseval's formula gives

$$\sum_{j\in\mathbb{Z}} j^2 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa^2}{2\pi}\int_0^{2\pi}\sin^2\theta\,e^{2\kappa\cos\theta}d\theta = \frac{\kappa^2}{2}(I_0(2\kappa) - I_2(2\kappa)) = \frac{\kappa}{2}I_1(2\kappa),$$

the last step by (K.1) at the argument $2\kappa$. Halving gives the first identity. The coefficient of $e^{i\theta}$ in $F^2 = e^{2\kappa\cos\theta}$ is $I_1(2\kappa) = \sum_{j\in\mathbb{Z}} I_j I_{1-j}$, and the terms with $j \le 0$ repeat those with $j \ge 1$; this is the third identity.

For the second, $jI_j = \frac{\kappa}{2}(I_{j-1} - I_{j+1})$ by (K.1), so

$$\sum_{j\ge1} j^3 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa^2}{4}\sum_{j\ge1} j(I_{j-1}^2 + I_{j+1}^2 - 2I_{j-1}I_{j+1}).$$

Shifting indices and telescoping,

$$\textstyle\sum_{j\ge1} j(I_{j-1}^2 + I_{j+1}^2) = I_0^2 + \sum_{m\ge1} 2mI_m^2,$$
$$\textstyle\sum_{m\ge1} 2mI_m^2 = \kappa\sum_{m\ge1}(I_{m-1}I_m - I_mI_{m+1}) = \kappa I_0 I_1.$$

For the mixed term write $j = \frac{1}{2}((j-1)+(j+1))$ and apply (K.1) to $(j-1)I_{j-1}$ and to $(j+1)I_{j+1}$, using $I_{-1} = I_1$ at $j = 1$:

$$jI_{j-1}I_{j+1} = \frac{\kappa}{4}[(I_{j-1}I_j - I_jI_{j+1}) + (I_{j-2}I_{j+1} - I_{j-1}I_{j+2})].$$

Both brackets telescope, to $I_0I_1$ and to $I_{-1}I_2 = I_1I_2$, so $\sum_{j\ge1} jI_{j-1}I_{j+1} = \frac{\kappa}{4}(I_0I_1 + I_1I_2)$. Altogether

$$\sum_{j\ge1} j^3 I_j^2 = \frac{\kappa^2}{4}\Big(I_0^2 + \frac{\kappa}{2}I_1(I_0 - I_2)\Big) = \frac{\kappa^2}{4}(I_0^2 + I_1^2). \qquad \square$$

K.3. **The coefficients of $\mathcal{D}$.**

**Lemma K.2.** *Write $\mathcal{D}(\kappa) = \sum_{n\ge0}\mathcal{D}_n\kappa^{2n}$ for the function of (I.9). Then $\mathcal{D}_0 = \mathcal{D}_1 = 0$, and for $m \ge 1$*

$$\mathcal{D}_{m+1} = \frac{N_m}{4^m\,m!\,(m+1)!\,(m+1)(m+2)},$$

*with $N_m = \binom{2m}{m}(4(2m+1) + (m-1)(m+1)(m+2)) - 4^m(m+1)(m+2)$. Moreover $N_m = 0$ for $m \le 2$ and $N_m > 0$ for $m \ge 3$.*

*Proof. The coefficients.* Multiplying the series of $I_0$ and $I_1$ and collecting powers,

$$I_0^2 = \sum_{m\ge0}\alpha_m\kappa^{2m}, \qquad I_1^2 = \sum_{m\ge0}\beta_m\kappa^{2m+2},$$
$$\kappa I_1(2\kappa) = \sum_{m\ge0}\frac{\kappa^{2m+2}}{m!\,(m+1)!},$$

where

$$\alpha_m = \frac{1}{4^m}\sum_{i=0}^{m}\frac{1}{i!^2(m-i)!^2},$$
$$\beta_m = \frac{1}{4^{m+1}}\sum_{i=0}^{m}\frac{1}{i!\,(i+1)!\,(m-i)!\,(m-i+1)!}.$$

By Vandermonde's identity, $\sum_i \binom{m}{i}^2 = \binom{2m}{m}$ and $\sum_i \binom{m}{i}\binom{m+2}{i+1} = \binom{2m+2}{m+1}$, so

$$\alpha_m = \frac{\binom{2m}{m}}{4^m\, m!^2}, \qquad \beta_m = \frac{\binom{2m+2}{m+1}}{4^{m+1} m!\,(m+2)!}.$$

The coefficient of $\kappa^{2m+2}$ in $\mathcal{D}$ is $\mathcal{D}_{m+1} = 8\beta_m + 2\beta_{m-1} - \alpha_m - 1/(m!(m+1)!)$, with $\beta_{-1} = 0$; for $m = 0$ it is $\frac{8}{4} - 1 - 1 = 0$, and $\mathcal{D}_0 = 0$ because every term of $\mathcal{D}$ is $O(\kappa^2)$. For $m \geq 1$ put $\Delta = 4^m\, m!\,(m+1)!\,(m+1)(m+2)$ and $b = \binom{2m}{m}$. With $\binom{2m+2}{m+1} = \frac{2(2m+1)}{m+1} b$,

$$8\beta_m = \frac{4(2m+1)\,b}{\Delta}, \qquad \alpha_m = \frac{(m+1)^2(m+2)\,b}{\Delta},$$
$$2\beta_{m-1} = \frac{2m(m+1)(m+2)\,b}{\Delta},$$
$$\frac{1}{m!(m+1)!} = \frac{4^m(m+1)(m+2)}{\Delta},$$

and $2m - (m+1) = m - 1$ gives $\mathcal{D}_{m+1} = N_m/\Delta$.

*The sign.* Directly, $N_0 = N_1 = N_2 = 0$ $(2-2,\ 24-24,\ 192-192)$, $N_3 = 80$, $N_4 = 1140$ and $N_5 = 10416$. For $m \geq 6$ we first show $16^m \leq 4m\binom{2m}{m}^2$ for $m \geq 1$ by induction: it is an equality at $m = 1$, and $(m+1)\binom{2m+2}{m+1} = 2(2m+1)\binom{2m}{m}$ gives

$$4(m+1)\binom{2m+2}{m+1}^2 = \frac{16(2m+1)^2}{m+1}\binom{2m}{m}^2$$
$$\geq \frac{16(2m+1)^2}{4m(m+1)}16^m \geq 16^{m+1}.$$

Since $(m-1)^2 \geq 4m$ for $m \geq 6$, it follows that $\binom{2m}{m}^2(m-1)^2 \geq 16^m$, that is $\binom{2m}{m}(m-1) \geq 4^m$, and

$$N_m = \Big(\binom{2m}{m}(m-1) - 4^m\Big)(m+1)(m+2)$$
$$+ 4(2m+1)\binom{2m}{m} > 0.$$

□

K.4. **Monotonicity of Bessel ratios.**

**Lemma K.3.** *For $n \geq 1$ and $\kappa > 0$, $I_{n+2}(\kappa)/I_{n+1}(\kappa) \leq I_2(\kappa)/I_1(\kappa)$.*

*Proof.* We use a lemma of Biernacki and Krzyż [19]: if $f = \sum a_j x^j$ and $g = \sum b_j x^j$ have positive coefficients and $a_j/b_j$ is nonincreasing in $j$, then $f/g$ is nonincreasing on $x > 0$. Indeed

$$f'g - fg' = \sum_{i,j}(i-j)a_i b_j x^{i+j-1}$$
$$= \frac{1}{2}\sum_{i,j}(i-j)b_i b_j\Big(\frac{a_i}{b_i} - \frac{a_j}{b_j}\Big)x^{i+j-1} \leq 0.$$

Take $x = \kappa^2$, $f = I_{n+1}(\kappa)/\kappa^{n+1}$ and $g = I_1(\kappa)/\kappa$. Then $a_j/b_j = 2^{-n}(j+1)!/(j+n+1)!$ decreases in $j$, so $I_{n+1}/(\kappa^n I_1)$ is nonincreasing in $\kappa$. Its logarithmic derivative is, by the second recurrence of (K.1),

$$\frac{n+1}{\kappa} + \frac{I_{n+2}}{I_{n+1}} - \frac{n}{\kappa} - \frac{1}{\kappa} - \frac{I_2}{I_1} = \frac{I_{n+2}}{I_{n+1}} - \frac{I_2}{I_1} \le 0.$$

□

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